

Fate's Edge

Amaranthine Worldbook

The Northern Shores and the Lands Beyond

Version 1.0

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NICHOLAS A. GASPER

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Part I

The World & Its Ways

Chapter 1

The Amaranthine Sea

The Amaranthine Sea lies at the heart of the known world, a salt expanse ringed by marble quays, vineyard hills, and smoke-blue mountains. For millennia it has served as the circulatory system of trade, faith, and conquest. Tides are subtle, but seasonal winds and river-feeds set the rhythm of commerce, pilgrimage, and war.

Unlike the dry southern coasts of distant lands, the wind patterns here reverse: the hot, arid air of the Sahel belt is pushed south, leaving the northern and eastern shores with ample rainfall and the southern shores as temperate grasslands. Thus the lands around the Amaranthine are lush and productive—olive groves in Ecktoria, wheat fields in Acasia, horse pastures on the Vilikari steppe.

North of the Amaranthine rise the Aelerian mountains, a spine of stone that separates the mild coastal lowlands from the colder northern reaches. Beyond those peaks lie the Violet Steppe and the Mistlands, where the Direwood presses against the fog-hung border. To the east, the Dolmis Sea (a dark inland basin) connects to the Amaranthine through the Astroegro Straits, guarded by the towers of Thepyrgos. The Aberderrin Sea, farther north, is a cold, wave-lashed expanse that borders both the Linn homelands and the Valewood.

A people without a single homeland, the Sidhi are a diaspora born from the ancient cities of Ashaan and Galanina. Their ships carry spice, silk, and secrets across every sea, and their enclaves thrive in Zakov, Kahfagia, and the port-towns of the Dolmis. Feared as pirates and respected as intermediaries, the Sidhi speak a dozen tongues and honor bargains with a blade if necessary. They are the frame through which many distant shores are glimpsed, though those shores lie beyond the scope of this book.

Chapter 2

Travel & Navigation

2.1 Core Travel Procedure

For each leg of a journey, draw 3–4 cards using the decks for your destination and controlling authority.

- ♠ from the destination deck: sets the scene (place).
- ♥ from the destination deck: introduces the local actor or faction.
- ♣ from the Wilds (general hazards) or destination (if strongly policed): brings pressure.
- ♦ from the authority that gates the route: papers, escorts, rights, or exceptions.

Set a travel clock by the highest rank:

- 2–5 $\Rightarrow$ 4 segments
- 6–10 $\Rightarrow$ 6 segments
- J/Q/K $\Rightarrow$ 8 segments
- A $\Rightarrow$ 10 segments

On success, advance to the next leg; on failure, mark delay, debt, or diversion and resolve a consequence in the fiction.

2.2 Mode Rules

2.2.1 Sea Legs

(Amaranthine/Dolmis/Aberderrin). If Theona or Valewood 9s show up anywhere in the seed, add an omission or taboo to the leg (a missing step, an unsaid name).

2.2.2 Passes & Underways

(Aeler). Any A may convert a surface route to an under-route. ♦ from Aeler always codifies outcomes—no roll—for sealed doors, breath time, and escorted segments.

2.2.3 Rivers

Bridges, booms, and law in Ecktoria/Viterra; reed-mazes and bell-lines in Mistlands/Linn waters.

2.2.4 Frontier Blends

When origin and destination disagree on law, draw two $\diamond$ (one from each law) and choose which you will be judged by at the end of the leg.

2.3 Regional Routes

2.3.1 Amaranthine Coastway

Kahfagia $\rightarrow$ Ecktoria $\rightarrow$ Acasia $\rightarrow$ Marcott (Vhasia) $\rightarrow$ Fairport (Viterra).

- Draw $\spadesuit+\heartsuit$ from the port you are entering.
- Draw $\clubsuit$ from the Wilds (gales, quarantine, harbor booms).
- Draw $\diamond$ from the port's deck (permits, berths), or Kahfagia if convoy/lantern law applies.

Silkstrand is Acasia's sole metropolis and a major trading hub; even land caravans risk the marches to reach it.

2.3.2 Astroegro Straits

Thepyrgos controls the hinge between seas via sentinel islands in the straits.

- Draw $\spadesuit+\heartsuit$ and $\clubsuit$ from Thepyrgos (stairs, boom, synod).
- Draw $\diamond$ from Thepyrgos (harbor pass, crane allotment).
- Switch to Dolmis/Amaranthine modules once the boom is lowered.

2.3.3 Dolmis Circuits

Fairport (Viterra) $\rightarrow$ Theona (Three Greens) $\rightarrow$ Ubral fjords $\rightarrow$ Aelinnel west shore $\rightarrow$ Zakov (north coast).

- $\spadesuit+\heartsuit$ from destination; $\clubsuit$ from Linn or the Wilds; $\diamond$ from Theona when island custom matters.
- Zakov: Draw $\spadesuit+\heartsuit$ from Zakov deck; $\clubsuit$ from Zakov or Linn; $\diamond$ from Zakov (harbor-green, corsair charter).

2.3.4 Aelerian Passes & Underways

Vhasia/Viterra/Ubral south slopes $\rightarrow$ Aeler gates $\rightarrow$ Mistlands.

- $\spadesuit+\heartsuit$ and $\clubsuit$ from Aeler; $\diamond$ from Aeler (Underway pass, Key-Writ, Breath time).

2.3.5 Shadow Corridors

Thin Shore (Valewood east coast): risky misted corridor north-south toward Zakov.

- $\spadesuit$ from Valewood, $\heartsuit$ from Mistlands (or Valewood), $\clubsuit$ from Mistlands (wraiths, bell-line failures), $\diamond$ from either Mistlands (Ward-salt, Lantern Writ) or Valewood (Way-cord, Truce-bough) depending on which law you invoke.
- *Rule of 9s*: any 9 in the seed adds an omission.

Green Gate hops (Aelinnel): tide-timed arches.

- $\spadesuit+\clubsuit$ from Aelinnel (tides, geasa), $\diamond$ from Aelinnel (Tide-path Key, Host-rights).

2.3.6 River Roads

Belworth: forms the boundary between Vhasia and Viterra. Twin ports at the mouth (Marcott and Fairport); at mid-reach Tarlington Falls requires lift/portage up to the plateau town. The Lence joins here from Vhasia. Use Viterra for east-bank audits/bridges, Vhasia for west-bank politics.

Yloka: raids run down from the north into the Aberderrin and Dolmis—overlay Linn ♣ and draw destination for ♠+♥.

Acasian rivers: hazardous but profitable approaches to Silkstrand; use Acasia ♣ (feuds/levies/curse) and ♦ (condotta, bridge rights).

2.3.7 Steppe Frontiers

Ykrul ↔ Vilikari ↔ Ecktoria/Acasia borders ↔ Black Banner territories.

- ♠ from the road you ride (Wolf Road or Foedus Stone), ♥ from the counterpart (envoys, comitatus), ♣ from Wilds or frontier decks (rasputitsa, hostage protocol, foedus recall), ♦ from either Ykrul (paiza, remounts) or Vilikari (foedus seal, bench-right).
- Black Banner: Draw ♠ from Ykrul/Vilikari decks (shared territory), ♥ from Black Banner, ♣ from Wilds or frontier decks, ♦ from Ykrul/Vilikari/Black Banner.

2.4 Gateways & Control Points

Gate	Deck	Diamond Source	Typical Leverage
Kassamira (Kahfagia)	Kahfagia	Kahfagia	Convoy letter; lantern-law warrant; pilotage token
Ecktoria Capital Port	Ecktoria	Ecktoria	Berth priority; coin-house credit; procession permit
Silkstrand	Acasia	Acasia	Exchange floor; condotta; watergate priority
Marcott	Vhasia	Vhasia	Letters patent; safeconduct; fairground precedence
Fairport	Viterra	Viterra	Customs seal; ferry priority; Dawn escort
Tarlington Falls	Viterra	Viterra	Lift priority; bridge/portage pass; County Thing
Thepyrgos (boom)	Thepyrgos	Thepyrgos	Harbor pass; crane allotment; Synod indulgence
High-Mist Pass	Aeler	Aeler	Underway pass; Key-Writ; Breath time allotment
Payden's Port	Mistlands	Mistlands	Lantern writ; ward-salt; wraith indemnity
Thin Shore (Valewood)	Valewood	Valewood/Mistlands	Way-cord; dew-mirror; lantern writ
Green Gate (Aelinnel)	Aelinnel	Aelinnel	Tide-path key; host-right bough; salt license
Ubral Passes	Ubral	Aeler/Ubral	Vurim pass-ring; hill-fort shelter writ; guide's bribe
Thing-holm (Linn)	Linn	Linn	Thing ruling; harbor-green; escort writ
Foedus Stone (March)	Vilikari	Vilikari/Ykrul	Foedus renewal; remount allotment; hostage treaty
Zakov Roadstead	Zakov	Zakov	Harbor-green chit; corsair charter; pilot token
Black Banner Camps	Black Banner	Black Banner/Ykrul/Vilikari	Safe-conduct; remount chit; clan truce

Table 2.1: Gateway Control Points

2.5 Overlay: Gatekeepers (Zakov Roadstead & Harbour Quarters)

Draw **one** micro-card each time you *enter*, *shift wharfs*, or *depart* Zakov. Combine with the normal seed.

Zakov Gatekeepers Micro-Cards (draw 1)

1. **Bureaucrat Quirk** — stamps only at *eighth bell*; night filings need a *Night Magistrate* countersign.
2. **Required Stamp** — *Harbor-Green* chit for boom passage this tide; without it, DV +1 on all port checks.
3. **Preferred Gratuity** — figs or lamp oil; wrong gift offends, marking 1 *Exposure* on your port reputation.
4. **Audit Trap** — “contraband tallies”; if carrying *bell-metal* or *dyestuffs*, start a 4-seg *Inspection* clock.
5. **Local Courtesy** — speak the *Dock Oath* (short pledge not to knife on planks) or suffer *Desperate* position in brawls.
6. **Shortcut Rumor** — *Smuggler’s Ladder* on the sea wall; spend a ◇ (*Ladder Map*) to skip one queue.
7. **Pilot’s Privilege** — a *Pilot Token* bumps you ahead on boom lift; otherwise pay tow or lose 1 segment.
8. **Silent Court** — the *Black Bishop* is sitting tonight; legal ♣ escalate by +1 SB if you contest a ruling.

2.6 Special Rules & Taboos

2.6.1 Theona / Valewood 9s

Whenever a 9 appears in a seed involving Theona or Valewood, add an omission: a missing step, an unsaid name, an unseen guest. If the 9 is a ◇, you may break the taboo once—someone will come to collect.

2.6.2 Aeler Aces

An A can rewire routes beneath the mountains. You may swap your ♠ to Aeler (keeping the other seed cards) and continue under-vault procedures.

2.6.3 Echoing Omens

Any A adds a motif you can echo later (ash on the wind, a bell heard underground, a landmark that returns elsewhere). Make the world feel like it remembers.

2.7 Worked Itineraries

2.7.1 West-to-East Coastal Haul (Kahfagia → Viterra)

Leg 1: Kassamira → Ecktoria Seed:

Ecktoria ♠ (Aqueduct arcades), Ecktoria ♥ (Coin-house factor), Wilds ♣ (gale), Kahfagia ◇ (convoy letter).

Clock: 6. Read: cross under coin-house eyes with convoy priority; bad weather strains schedules.

Leg 2: Ecktoria → Silkstrand Seed:

Acasia ♠ (Three-Queens Bridge), Acasia ♥ (Dyers' Guildmistress), Acasia ♣ (loom strike), Acasia ♦ (Exchange pass).

Clock: 6–8 depending on unrest.

Leg 3: Silkstrand → Marcott Seed:

Vhasia ♠ (Pont-du-Tithe), Vhasia ♥ (Parlement clerk), Vhasia ♣ (coin rumor), Vhasia ♦ (letters patent).

Leg 4: Marcott → Fairport Seed:

Viterra ♠ (Fairport tideworks), Viterra ♥ (shipwright), Linn ♣ (boom lifts), Viterra ♦ (customs seal).

Clock: 6.

2.7.2 Acasia → Mistlands (Forgotten Pass + Under-Gate)

Leg 1: Silkstrand → Aeler Gate Seed:

Aeler ♠ (Avalanche gallery), Aeler ♥ (Geometer), Aeler ♣ (Engineer requisition), Aeler ♦ (Underway Pass).

Leg 2: Gate → Mistlands Seed:

Mistlands ♠ (Bell-Line levee), Mistlands ♥ (Bell-warden), Mistlands ♣ (wraith crossing), Mistlands ♦ (Ward-salt).

2.7.3 Thin Shore → Zakov Corridor

Leg 1: Payden's Port → Thin Shore Seed:

Valewood ♠ (Green lane), Mistlands ♥ (Protectorate clerk), Mistlands ♣ (bell failure), Mistlands ♦ (Lantern writ).

Leg 2: Thin Shore transit Seed:

Valewood ♠ (Unfound stile), Valewood ♥ (Path-warden), Valewood ♣ (Sweet wind), Valewood ♦ (Way-cord).

Rule of 9s applies.

2.7.4 Frontier Mediation (Ykrul ↔ Vilikari)

Leg: Foedus Stone parley Seed:

Vilikari ♠ (Foedus Stone), Ykrul ♥ (Noyan envoy), Wilds ♣ (rasputitsa), Vilikari ♦ (Foedus Renewal).

Blend: also draw a Ykrul ♦ (Paiza). Choose which law saves your schedule.

2.7.5 Worked Itinerary: Thin Shore → Zakov → Theona (Corsair Jobs)

Leg 1: Payden's Port → Thin Shore (Shadow Corridor) Seed:

Valewood ♠ (Green lane / Unfound stile); Mistlands ♥ (Protectorate clerk); Mistlands ♣ (bell-line failure); Mistlands ♦ (Lantern Writ).

Clock: 6. *Rule of 9s*: any 9 adds an omission.

Leg 2: Thin Shore Transit (Skirting toward Zakov) Seed:

Valewood ♠ (Sea-mist arcade); Valewood ♥ (Path-warden); Valewood ♣ (Sweet wind); Valewood ♦ (Way-cord).

Clock: 6. *Note*: spending *Way-cord* negates one *Sweet wind* lie.

Leg 3: Approach to Zakov (Roadstead & Booms) Seed:

Zakov ♠ (Boomhouse or Red Wharf); Zakov ♥ (Pilot-Matron or Night Magistrate); Zakov ♣ (Boom Drop or Customs Sweep); Zakov ♦ (Harbor-Green Chit or Pilot Token).

Clock: 6–8 (apply the Gatekeepers overlay draw on arrival). If a 9 shows: *Missing Ninth*—remove one critical step/name until paid in favors.

Leg 4: Corsair Job Inside Zakov (Pick 1) A) Lift a Hull from Drydock Four:

Zakov ♠ (Drydock Four); Zakov ♥ (Corsair Quartermaster); Zakov ♣ (Admiralty Audit); Zakov ♦ (Shipwright's Lien Release).

Goal: tow a seized hull at night; *Lien Release* avoids bond but flips a debt later.

B) Court the Black Bishop for Indulgence:

Zakov ♠ (Black Bell Tower); Zakov ♥ (Black Bishop); Zakov ♣ (Bounty Proclamation); Zakov ♦ (Magistrate's Hush).

Goal: seal a case/docket so a rival can't use it. Hook: rumor must be paid (coin or gossip).

C) Smuggler's Ladder Run:

Zakov ♠ (Lantern Ladder); Zakov ♥ (Lampman); Zakov ♣ (Informant Flip); Zakov ♦ (Smuggler's Ladder Map).

Goal: bypass boom eyes with a wall-stair. Complication: your tip was sold twice.

Leg 5: Zakov → Theona (Isles & Moot) Seed:

Theona ♠ (Uncounted Bridge); Theona ♥ (Matron of Wells or Moot Envoy); Linn ♣ (fogfall raids); Theona ♦ (Moot Token).

Clock: 6–8. Taboo: do *not* count the steps aloud; breaking it imposes *Controlled* on all isle bargains this scene.

Leg 6: Theona Contract (Pick 1) A) Raid-Truce at the Skerries:

Theona ♠ (Tide caves); Theona ♥ (Isle Moot Envoy); Theona ♣ (Muster drum); Theona ♦ (Raid-truce Ribbon).

Goal: secure safe passage window; failure triggers a Linn muster clock.

B) Deliver the Ledger Shard:

Theona ♠ (Well-yard); Theona ♥ (Matron of Wells); Zakov ♣ (Debt Call follows you); Theona ♦ (Sanctuary Night).

Goal: hide a Zakov debt long enough to copy data; sanctuary buys time.

2.7.6 Steppe Passage: Black Banner Territory

Leg: Foedus Stone → Black Banner Camp Seed:

Ykrul/Vilikari ♠ (Wolf Road milepost or Foedus Stone); Black Banner ♥ (Clan Elder or War Captain); Wilds ♣ (Rasputitsa or Remount Sickness); Black Banner ♦ (Safe-conduct or Remount Chit).

Clock: 6–8. Complication: Foedus recall may invalidate your papers.

Leg: Black Banner Camp → Ykrul Territory Seed:

Ykrul ♠ (Winter camp ring or Khagan's way-station); Ykrul ♥ (Khatun of the Ring or Noyan envoy); Frontier ♣ (Hostage protocol or Feud spark); Ykrul ♦ (Paiza tablet or Foedus seal).

Clock: 6–8. *Note*: Choose which law applies—Black Banner customs or Ykrul traditions.

2.8 Pace, Clocks, and Consequences

- Road/river leg: 6-segment clock; +2 segments if crossing a law boundary (new passports, new prayers).
- Sea strait/mountain pass: 8-segment clock; −2 segments if you spend a $\diamond$ that codifies priority (pilotage, pass, convoy).
- Shadow corridor: 6-segment clock; on any A, add a free omen to echo later.
- Failure defaults: delay (lose time; an enemy advances), diversion (alternate route; new $\clubsuit$), or debt (promise, fine, or favor owed to the authority that controls the gate).

SB Note. Re-rolling 1s does *not* erase their SB; any new 1s on the re-roll add more SB.

2.9 Story Beat (SB) Menus

2.9.1 Universal SB Spend Menu

- **1 SB** — Shave time/position: add +1 segment to the current clock *or* drop Position one step *or* impose a small fee/toll *or* mark 1 step of *Asset Exposure*.
- **2 SB** — Escalate the pressure: upgrade the active $\clubsuit$ (e.g., “inspection” → “seizure attempt”) *or* force a *choice of Diamonds* (pick which law you’ll be judged by) *or* tick a relevant *Front* by 1.
- **3 SB** — Lock a gate/taboo: close a route (boom drops; pass closes) until a named $\diamond$ is spent *or* invoke a regional taboo (Theona/Valewood 9s; oath backlash) with teeth *or* auto-trigger a *Debt Flip* on a Diamond already in play.
- **4+ SB** — Reshape the leg: rewrite the route (Aeler under-way reroute; sea lane reversal), start a *new* 4–6 segment complication clock *and* tick a *Front* by +1; demand immediate payment on a Patron/Asset Exposure (lose it if refused).

End-of-leg conversion (optional): Unspent SB convert to *world motion* at a rate of **3 SB** → **tick 1 Front** (GM choice).

2.9.2 Sea (Amaranthine/Dolmis/Aberderrin)

- **1 SB:** Fogfall nips visibility; DV +1 for the next pilotage check.
- **2 SB:** Boom shifts; pilot required (spend a *pilotage* $\diamond$ or delay +2 segments).
- **3 SB:** Lantern-law change mid-leg; choose: pay fine *or* reroute clock +2 *or* spend *Convoy Letter*.
- **4 SB:** Squall wall: split the convoy; lose an escort unless *Moot token* or *Escort* Diamond is spent.

2.9.3 Passes & Underways (Aeler)

- **1 SB:** White wind; breath-time check (mark Fatigue or slow +1 segment).
- **2 SB:** Engineer requisition; surrender cargo slot *or* coin *or* DV +1 until the gate.
- **3 SB:** Under-audit; must go below (swap $\spadesuit$ to Aeler) unless you spend *Key-Writ*.
- **4 SB:** Cave-in detour adds a fresh 4-segment clock unless *Underway Pass* is spent.

2.9.4 Rivers (Belworth & friends)

- **1 SB:** Sandbar drift; portage a beat or pay for a tow.
- **2 SB:** Lift strike at Tarlington; need *Bridge/Portage Pass* or delay +2 segments.
- **3 SB:** Cross-mouth embargo (Marcott/Fairport); choose which harbor’s law applies (draw/commit its $\diamond$).
- **4 SB:** Ice-break or flood surge; split cargo (random item at risk) unless an *Escort Diamond* is spent.

2.9.5 Shadow Corridors (Valewood/Mistlands)

- **1 SB:** Bell-line stutter; next guidance roll at Disadvantage (or DV +1).
- **2 SB:** Omission manifests; something necessary is “missing” until *Ward-salt* or *Way-cord* is spent.
- **3 SB:** Host-law claims you as *host/guest*; accept a service clock or pay with a memory (lose a minor Contact until end of leg).
- **4 SB:** Wraith procession crosses your path; create a 6-segment *Don’t Look Back* clock; spending *Lantern Writ* downgrades it to 4.

2.9.6 Steppe Frontiers (Ykrul/Vilikari/Black Banner)

- **1 SB:** Remount fatigue; lose 1 “fresh mount” use or slow +1 segment.
- **2 SB:** Hostage protocol; must place/accept a token-kin until the next gate (or spend *Safe-hostage*).
- **3 SB:** Foedus recall; your papers conflict—pick Ykrul *Paiza* or Vilikari *Foedus Seal* and offend the other.
- **4 SB:** Muster checkpoint; disarm unless traveling under *Standard Protection* or *Khagan’s Writ*.
- **Black Banner Specific:** Clan feud erupts; choose sides or pay double tolls.

2.9.7 Ports & Forums (Marcott, Fairport, Silkstrand, Thepyrgos, Zakov)

- **1 SB:** Clerk error; pay a “stamp” fee or answer questions (DV +1).
- **2 SB:** Rival petition; they jump the queue unless you spend a Warrant/Letters $\diamond$.
- **3 SB:** Audit cascade; open a new 4-segment *Inspection* clock tied to cargo/ledger.
- **4 SB:** Edict flare; convert today’s $\clubsuit$ into a temporary “law” everyone must obey or take on a *Debt Flip*.
- **Zakov Specific:** Silent Court ruling; legal $\clubsuit$ escalate by +1 SB.

2.9.8 Diamond & Exposure Interactions

- **2 SB:** Flip any $\diamond$ spent this leg: its *Debt Flip* is collected now (not later).
- **2 SB:** Mark 1 step on a named Asset/Patron’s *Exposure* track.
- **3 SB:** Downgrade an *Intricate* success to *Detailed* (remove the flourish or DV 1 benefit).
- **4 SB:** Seize or suspend a visible Diamond’s benefit until another is played (e.g., convoy letter overridden by emergency edict).

Part II

The Northern Shore

Chapter 3

Kahfagia

The Empire of Wakes and Storm-Flags. Kahfagia is a maritime power whose strength lies not in territory but in control of the sea lanes. The Lantern-Law, administered by the Admiral of Lantern-Law, governs every beacon, boom, and berth. Pilots carry mirrors that speak in code, and the spice auctions of Kassamira set prices across the Amaranthine. To sail under Kahfagia's protection is to move with the tide; to defy it is to find the beacons turned against you.

3.1 Kahfagia — “The Creole Thalassocracy”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Every mirror is a blade, every beacon a promise. The sea obeys when we move the lights — but the spiders weave in the mirror-towers.*

Admiral of Lantern-Law (Elite): “Every mirror is a blade, every beacon a promise. The sea obeys when we move the lights — and woe to the fool who rows against them. Yet I have seen the reflection move before the hand that holds it. The tides are not the only ones with secrets.”

Dockside Factor (Commoner): “The pilots see farther than kings. A gesture in lantern-code can open ports, or close them. Keep your debts paid, and your lamps trimmed. And if a grey-robed stranger offers to adjust your mirror for free — say no. The Lethai-ar have long memories, and longer webs.”

Genre / Mood: Creole thalassocracy, signal-and-lane politics, eldritch tide, secret infiltration.

Starting Location: The Lantern Pier admiralty chapel, where votive ships hang from the ceiling and brine drips from the icon of a drowned saint. A sea-notary unlocks a salt-stained reliquary and produces a chart with gilt edges. “Fetch the contraband bell from the corsair galleass *Santa Dolorosa* before moonrise — or the harbour names you accomplices. And watch for silk threads on the bollards. The Spider's children are everywhere.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Kahfagia is the Creole child of Oshiira and the Vilikari — a thalassocracy where Oshiiran ledgers meet Vilikari tide-law. The Admiralty of Lantern-Law rules not by armies but by light, yet the real power flows through a tangled web of oligarchic families, each with their own spies, their own private navies, and their own seat on the Shadow Council. Above them all floats a central Admiralty fleet, charged with protecting the beacon monopoly — and with watching the watchers.

But the oligarchs are not the only players. Unseen, the Lethai-ar of Inaea have been infiltrating the mirror-towers for decades. A factor's trusted secretary, a harbour master's silent wife, a pilot's apprentice with too-still eyes — they weave their webs not for coin, but for *control*. They do not seek to destroy Kahfagia. They seek to *own* it, strand by strand, until the entire thalassocracy hums to the rhythm of the Spider's mercy.

What you notice first: The constant chime of bell-buoys. The smell of salt, tar, and burnt oil from a thousand lanterns. The way everyone — admiral to dockhand — glances at the tide clock before speaking. And the faint, almost invisible silk threads tied around the bollards of the wealthiest piers.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never argue with a Mirror-Keeper about where the channel lies. If they say the safe water moved, it moved. Your chart is already kindling. And if the Mirror-Keeper smiles too widely, check the back of their neck for a spider's brand.

Regional Mood: The Lantern's Vigil & The Spider's Web

Power is visible here — literally. Every night, a thousand lamps burn along the channels, each a statement of control. To dim a light is to declare bankruptcy. To move a beacon is to declare war. Commodores sit in their mirror-towers, watching reflections, while tide-clocks tick down to the next auction, the next inspection, the next quiet murder.

But beneath the visible power, another war is fought in whispers. The Lethai-ar agents of Inaea have spent a generation infiltrating the oligarchic families. A young heir who suddenly displays uncanny negotiating skill may not be talented — they may be *woven*. A Mirror-Keeper whose beacons never fail may be receiving guidance from a source that does not appear on any chart. The Spider's web is patient. It does not break the thalassocracy; it *guides* it.

Prominent NPCs of Kahfagia

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Admiral Zafira	Commander of Lantern-Law	Keep the beacon monopoly intact	She has never lost a ship to the reefs. Her charts are said to be drawn in water.

Mirza al-Qasr	Mirror-Keeper of the Pointe	Control the tides through light	Her face is never seen—only reflected. Some say she has no shadow.
Ximena	Dockside Factor (commoner exemplar)	Profit from every cargo, legal or not	She keeps a ledger in lemon juice; heat reveals the truth.
Captain Rodrigo	Privateer with a crooked letter of marque	Raid the corsair fleet and pay off his crew	His ship flies three flags; the one he lowers last is the one that matters.
Sister Anabel	Healer of the Hospitallers of the Salted Veil (Temple of Light)	Tend the sick without asking payment	Her grey robes are said to be woven from old debts. They never stain.
Notary Farid	Admiralty magistrate	Resolve disputes before they reach the harbour master	He carries a water-clock in his sleeve to measure the shifting of legal moods.
The Veiled Harpist	Lethai-ar infiltrator (secret)	Woven the oligarchs, strand by strand	No one knows her face. She plays only in mirror-lit rooms, and her music leaves threads of silk in the listeners’ hair.

The Oligarchic Houses (Shadow Council)

The true rulers of Kahfagia are not the Admiralty alone, but the **Shadow Council** of seven oligarchic families. Each controls a monopoly (spice, salt, silk, timber, pitch, shipbuilding, or intelligence). Each maintains its own private navy and network of spies. Each vies for the empty seat left by the family that the Lethai-ar have already *woven* into silence.

- **House al-Kassam (Spice):** Oldest, proudest, most vulnerable. The Lethai-ar have already

replaced the family steward.

- **House Carrasco (Salt):** Ruthless pragmatists; they suspect infiltration but cannot prove it.
- **House Mirat (Silk):** Secret allies of the Lethai-ar — they trade webs for influence.
- **House del Puerto (Shipbuilding):** Neutral; they build for anyone who pays.
- **House Henares (Timber):** Deeply indebted to the Admiralty; the Lethai-ar are slowly buying their notes.
- **House de la Vela (Intelligence):** The Admiralty’s own spy network — and already compromised.
- **The Empty Chair:** Once held by House Morat, now vacant. The other houses whisper that the Morats were not destroyed — they were *rewoven*.

Secret Faction: The Silk Vigil (Lethai-ar Infiltrators)

Agents of Inaea, the Spider’s children have spent a generation worming into Kahfagia’s elite. They do not steal or sabotage — they *guide*. A decision that benefits House Carrasco is subtly nudged toward the Lethai-ar’s long-term goal: a unified thalassocracy that answers not to the Admiralty, but to the Web.

Signs of Infiltration:

- A factor’s handwriting becomes unnaturally precise, the loops forming faint eight-shapes.
- A Mirror-Keeper’s reflections show the same face in every tower — a woman with chestnut-brown skin and eyes like polished jet.
- A ship that should have foundered instead limps to port, its crew speaking of a grey-robed passenger who vanished before docking.

Mechanical Hook: Once per session, a PC may roll Wits + Lore (DV 4) to notice a silken thread in an official’s collar or a spider’s brand on a dockhand’s wrist. On success, they identify a Lethai-ar agent. On failure, the agent becomes aware of their scrutiny — and the Web tightens.

Names of Kahfagia

Inspired by the sea-faring republics of the western coast, blended with Oshiiran and Vilikari influences: liquid consonants, soft vowels, and surnames that denote a port, a ship, or a founding ancestor.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Safir	Zafira	al-Kassam	<i>the Lantern</i>
Idris	Ximena	del Puerto	<i>Tide-Keeper</i>
Farid	Layla	de la Vela	<i>the Unlit</i>
Jabir	Aisha	Carrasco	<i>Mirror-Eye</i>
Rodrigo	Salma	Mirat	<i>Bell-Born</i>
Tarik	Nura	Henares	<i>Ash-Sails</i>

Spades — Places (Littoral/Lane/Law)

2. **Tidal Mudflat** — Hidden plank-way at low water; smugglers’ shortcut. *At ebb, the planks rise like the ribs of a drowned whale.* ‘[STEALTH]’

3. **Salt-Scar Pier** — Behind dawn spice auctions; where fortunes wash ashore. *Auditors check the salt-scars — white crust that proves cargo was cleaned, not stolen.* ‘[TRADE]’
4. **Reedbelt Creeks** — Smuggler paths where tax boats won’t follow. *A hanged man’s boots hang from a piling; those who pass tug their collars.* ‘[STEALTH]’
5. **Breakwater Gap** — Under repair; cutters slip at dusk through the works. *The stone is still loose. A wrong step, and the sea claims another toll.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
6. **Dredged Channel** — Fresh with temporary beacons; tomorrow’s safe water. *The buoys are painted yellow — the colour of “maybe.”* ‘[TRAVEL]’
7. **River Sluice** — Tide-gate and boom-chain; access controlled by rope and writ. *The chain has a notch where a slaver’s ship tried to flee. It still drips oil.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
8. **Cutter Yard** — Narrow-keel vessels; apprentices work night shifts. *They sing old work songs — the kind that skip the ninth beat.* ‘[LABOR]’
9. **Lantern Alley** — Fog-lane where beacons migrate with the tide. *Follow the lights. Two blinks means you’re expected. Three? You’re prey.* ‘[WEATHER]’
10. **Admiralty Quay** — Bonded warehouses under seal; law walks the decks. *The seal on the door changes with the tide. Today it’s a serpent eating its tail.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- J **Red Shoal** — Quiet water, loud reputations; where deals are made. *Old barges moored together; a floating court with no bailiff.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
- Q **Mirror Tower** — Pilot station that certifies safe water — today. *The mirror at the top shows not the sea, but the face of the last captain who argued.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
- K **Kassamira Port** — Presidial; auctions at dawn, courts by noon. *The auctioneer’s gavel is wrapped in a page torn from a debtor’s ledger.* ‘[TRADE]’
- A **The Pointe** — Strait of storm-lights and wreckers’ tales. *On still nights, you can hear the drowned singing the names of those who owe.* ‘[DEATH]’

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Tide-Runner** — Bell and rope; knows every tide-table by heart. *“The table says high water at noon. The moon lies. Trust my rope.”* ‘[TRAVEL]’
3. **Pilot’s Apprentice** — Perfect memory for shoals; tomorrow’s navigator. *Touches a brass talisman before every sounding. No one knows why.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
4. **Lantern Clerk** — Knows which lights moved, and why; keeper of the shifts. *Docks with a ledger that smells of smoke. Adds a surcharge for “recent adjustments.”* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
5. **Oshiiran Factor** — Two ledgers; one for Kahfagia, one for truth. *The left ledger records bribes as “conciliation fees.” The right one is never shown.* ‘[TRADE]’
6. **Dock-Syndic** — Makes queues vanish; power in the pause. *He never raises his voice. The harbour master listens anyway.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
7. **Lantern Advocate** — “Jurisdiction moves like tide”; law in flux. *She carries a water-clock in her sleeve to measure the shifting of legal moods.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
8. **Privateer Captain** — “Crooked” letter of convoy; profit in the margins. *Her ship flies three flags; the one she lowers last is the one that matters.* ‘[COMBAT]’
9. **Thalassoi Sergeant** — Shore leave but still on duty; marine precision. *A tattoo of a lighthouse on his forearm; the light is his wife’s name.* ‘[COMBAT]’
10. **Admiralty Magistrate** — Rules fast, travels faster; justice in a hurry. *She once sentenced a man to the galleys and boarded the ship before he did.* ‘[JUSTICE]’

- J **Dredging Foreman** — Channel follows their purse; water reshaped. *His crew are ex-criminals; he pays them in salt pork and absolution.* ‘[LABOR]’
- Q **Mirror-Keeper (Elite)** — Commodore’s confidante; places beacons that bind. *Their faces are never seen — only reflected. Some say they have none.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- K **Kahfagian Commodore** — Off the books but on the water; shadow admiral. *His flagship is a fishing smack. Its nets drag up letters of marque.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- A **Admiral of Red Shoal** — Offers wine, figs — once. Price in stories. *She pours the first cup herself. If she pours a second, you’ve already agreed.* ‘[LEGEND]’

Clubs — Complications/Threats

(Entries unchanged except for the addition of a new threat: **Web Unravelled** – a Lethai-ar agent is exposed, and the oligarchs turn on each other.)

2. **Early Tide** — Turns two bells early; grounding risk rises like the sea. ‘[WEATHER]’ *Someone bribed the tide-clerk — or the moon is angry.*
 3. **Smothering Fog** — Sound travels, sight does not; navigation by ear alone. ‘[WEATHER]’ *You hear oars. Then you don’t. Then they’re behind you.*
 4. **Boom Slam** — Harbour chain slams shut; wrong side means delay or danger. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The chain’s links are inscribed with names of debtors. Each one rattles differently.*
 5. **Light Shift** — Beacons change mid-approach; your lane just moved. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *Someone paid the Lantern Clerk. Find out who — or drift into the reefs.*
 6. **Pilot Strike** — No escorts available; average unpaid, risk assumed. ‘[LABOR]’ *The pilots sit in their guildhall, drinking tea, watching ships founder.*
 7. **Customs Inspection** — Ladder audits cargo and crew; delays bite deep. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The inspector has a silver tooth. He smiles when he sees a manifest.*
 8. **Reef-Runners** — Corsair skiffs circle with boarding hooks; steel in the spray. ‘[COMBAT]’ *Their leader wears a Mirror-Keeper’s badge — stolen or earned, you cannot tell.*
 9. **Jurisdiction Flip** — Lantern-law shifts; your writ no longer bites. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The tide turned. So did the magistrate. Your safe-conduct is now kindling.*
 10. **Fire Risk** — Alchemical cargo aboard; quarantine if anything spills. ‘[DISASTER]’ *A single spark and the whole quay becomes a crater. The factor wants you to know this.*
- J **Quartermaster Betrayal** — Tide-tables sold to rival; route compromised. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The betrayal is written in lemon juice; heat reveals the name.*
- Q **Yellow Flag** — Port quarantine; deadlines rot on the hook. ‘[DEATH]’ *The flag is dyed with turmeric and something else — something that smells sweet.*
- K **Fleet Redeploy** — “Safe” corridor becomes parade ground; chaos in formation. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *Admirals play chess with real ships, and you are a pawn.*
- A **Black Squall (at the Pointe)** — Scatters ships and stories alike. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *This is no natural storm. The water hisses. Something below is waking.*
- + **Web Unravelled** — A Lethai-ar agent is exposed. The oligarchs turn on each other, accusing every rival of being a spider. ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *Silk threads appear on every doorknob. No one trusts their shadow.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

(Unchanged; the existing rewards work well for a thalassocracy.)

2. **Mooring Chit** — Skip the Mooring Roll once; harbour favours you. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The chit is a dried seahorse shell. Keep it away from salt.*
 3. **Pilotage Token** — One certified escort through a bad channel. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The pilot who accepts it must touch your shoulder before speaking.*
 4. **Fee Waiver** — Cargo cleared today; ledger smiles included. ‘[TRADE]’ *The clerk stamps it twice — once for the crown, once for the Hollow.*
 5. **Safe-Conduct** — Along specific beacons lane; law walks with you. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The commodore’s seal is warm. It cools as the exit nears.*
 6. **Salvage Rights** — On named quay or reach; flotsam becomes fortune. ‘[TRADE]’ *You must name each piece before touching it. The wrong word forfeits the claim.*
 7. **Warehouse Access** — Bonded storage; seal prize before rivals sniff. ‘[TRADE]’ *The key is a bronze finger. It fits only one lock — and breaks after use.*
 8. **Lantern Code** — Tonight’s signals revealed; navigation advantage. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *Three quick flashes: safe passage. One long, two short: the Admiralty is watching.*
 9. **Dredging Grant** — You decide where next channel runs; reshape the sea. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The dredgers are convicts. They work faster if you promise a name in their favour.*
 10. **Letter of Marque** — Convoy protection for one season; legal blades. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The ink is mixed with gunpowder. It smokes slightly when read.*
- J **Admiralty Judgment** — Precedent travels with you; law bends. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The case number is burned into a leather tag. Tag it to a belt loop.*
- Q **Mirror Warrant** — Legal right to post a beacon; redraw the map. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The Mirror-Keeper’s seal, still warm. The channel you mark becomes law — until challenged.*
- K **Spice Share** — Stake in Kassamira auction floor; profit in pepper. ‘[TRADE]’ *The share is a peppercorn sealed in wax. Bite it to test authenticity.*
- A **Lantern License** — Temporary authority to redefine the lane. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The harbour master spits when he hands it over. Use it wisely — or not at all.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/rights/priority) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **sea & signal** motifs — beacons that migrate, tides that remember, law that flows like water. If a King or Ace of Spades appears, also echo **web motifs** — silk threads on a bollard, a reflection that holds too long, the faint smell of spiced tea (the Lethai-ar are near).

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Pilot’s Mirror:** Kahfagia’s strength is not its fleet but its monopoly on light and lane. To post a beacon is to redraw the map. Any character with a Mirror Warrant may permanently move a beacon or buoy (GM sets a 4-segment clock). For the duration of that clock, all

navigation rolls on that lane are at +1 Position for the party and -1 Position for rivals.

- **Lantern-Law Privilege:** While flying an Admiralty flag or carrying a valid Lantern License, your ship may pass through chain-booms and customs points at +1 Position. The first time in a session you invoke this privilege, the GM gains 1 SB (the Admiralty is watching).
- **Oligarchic Favour (Leverage Track):** Instead of tracking coin debts, track *Favour* with the great families (al-Kassam, Carrasco, Mirat, etc.). Favour 1–3 gives you access to private docks, early auction warnings, and off-the-books pilots. Favour 4+ lets you call in a family to block a rival’s safe-conduct or raise a false alarm on their ship.
- **The Web’s Patience (Secret Clock [6]):** Tracks the Lethai-ar infiltration of the Shadow Council. The clock ticks when the party helps a Lethai-ar agent, exposes a rival house’s secrets, or ignores a silken thread. At 3, the Harpist’s name appears on a dockmaster’s manifest. At 6, the Empty Chair is filled — and the new house head bows to a grey-robed stranger. The party may reduce the clock by exposing an agent or by warning an oligarch (costs Favour 2).
- **Western Reach Rumours:** Once per port visit, a character may roll Wits + Lore (DV 3) to hear a rumour from a captain returned from beyond the mirror. On success, the GM reveals one of the six rumours (see below) as a foreshadowing hook or a clue for an ongoing arc.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Lantern Bearer** — The Traveler. *A light that never goes out; a promise that never sinks.*
 - **The Mirror-King** — The Witness. *Reflections that remember every lie, every promise, every cargo.*
 - **The Tide Father** — Khemesh. *The pressure beneath the keel; the debt that the sea collects at ebb.*
 - **The Spider’s Daughter** — Inaea (secret). *The web that binds the oligarchs, strand by patient strand.*
 - **The Unlit** — Ikasha. *The ninth lamp that is never lit; the safe harbour that exists only in rumour.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Saint Alvaro of the Lantern (The Traveler):** The Admiralty’s mirror-towers double as wayshrines for the Saint of Lost Channels. Sailors who light a candle before a voyage and whisper a destination to the mirror claim the tide will not turn against them before they reach it. The Mirror-Keepers charge a fee for this service — payable in salt, not silver.
- **The Silken Coup (Inaea):** The Lethai-ar call their infiltration the *Genteel Harvest*. They do not conquer; they adopt. An oligarch who accepts a grey-robed advisor finds that their children are betrothed to shadow-kin, their ledgers are copied in disappearing ink, and their mirror-tower shows only the face they wish to see — not the one that watches them sleep.
- **The Tide-Sworn Compact (The Admiral of Sealed Tides):** A small but influential order of notaries based in Kassamira Port. They adjudicate disputes over beacon rights, cargo claims, and pilotage fees. Their judgments are always delivered in triplicate, and they accept no bribes — only binding oaths. Those who lie before a Covenant judge find that their next three voyages are plagued by contrary winds.
- **The Hospitallers of the Salted Veil (The Bitter Root):** A hospice on Deadman’s Quay is run by grey-robed healers of the Order. They ask no payment, but they never forget a face. It is said that if you accept their care, you owe a favour to the sea itself — and the sea always

collects. Smugglers leave small offerings of fresh water on the pier to stay in the Order’s good graces.

- **The Ninth:** In any lantern-lit scene, the ninth lamp lit in a room reveals a threshold. The wise stop at eight. Those who light the ninth are said to see a figure standing on the water outside the window — waiting.

Kahfagia Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Wake:** Toss a crust over your shoulder before entering a new channel. Ignore the first *Smothering Fog* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Turn the Lantern:** Spin the binnacle lamp once counter-clockwise. Cancel *Boom Slam* or take –1 die on your next pilot check (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Deep:** Whisper a true name into a lead line. Gain +1 Effect against corsairs for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Tide Court. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Cut the Thread:** If you find a silk thread on your bollard, cut it with a silver knife. Negate the next *Web’s Patience* tick. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

(Unchanged; see earlier table.)

Western Reach Rumours (d6, fast hooks)

1. A harbour where bells toll under water; cargo *must* be named aloud.
2. A spice that stops bleeding — until moonrise.
3. A mirror-reef that reflects storms from a week ahead.
4. A pilotage guild that uses birds, not beacons.
5. A fleet that sails by *shadow* cast on fog.
6. A court that weighs debts in *breath*, not coin.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Sail + Wits):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Wake Surge*.
- **Cut the Lane (Pilot + Tactics):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a beacon is under your colour, +1 die.
- **Weather the Squall (Resolve + Sail):** On a hit in *Black Squall*, you pick who drifts; on a miss, the Keeper does.

Boss Seeds (Sea & Signal / Web & Silk)

- **The Mirror-Keeper of Kassamira (signal tyrant)** — *Phases:* Audit → Blacklist → Light Embargo. *Cracks:* rival beacon logs, Tide Court precedent, stolen codebook.
- **Corsair-Chaplain of the Pointe (relic raider)** — *Phases:* Charm → Board → Bell-Wake. *Cracks:* sanctified boom, cofradía oath, drowned-saint tithe.
- **The Veiled Harpist (Spider’s Daughter)** — *Phases:* Whisper → Weave → Harvest. *Cracks:* speak a true name of a Lethai-ar agent, cut a strand of the Web with silver, or remind an oligarch of a debt older than the Spider’s memory.

Patronage & Power

In Kahfagia, power flows through control of the sea lanes themselves — and through the silken threads that bind the oligarchs to the Spider's will. The maritime oligarchs have built their empire not through conquest of territory but through mastery of navigation and the quiet manipulation of debt. Every beacon, every channel marker, every mirror-light is both a navigational aid and a legal instrument. But behind every mirror, a grey-robed woman watches. And she is very, very patient.

For the GM: Kahfagian patronage revolves around access — to channels, to cargo, to legal protection. Rewards often take the form of pilotage tokens, safe-conducts, or salvage rights. But the secret war of the Lethai-ar adds a new layer: players may be hired to expose an agent, to protect an oligarch from being "woven," or even to ally with the Spider's children for a share of the Harvest. Use the **Web's Patience** clock to track the infiltration; let players decide whether to slow it, accelerate it, or ride it to power.

Chapter 4

Ecktoria

Marble & Fire. Once the furnace of the Utaran Imperium, Ecktoria remains a palimpsest of power—old stones bearing new banners, old laws written under fresh seals. Its marble forums and coin-houses still echo with imperial precedent, yet the Black Banners march on its purse, and rival dukes stage processions that collide at every bridge. The Everflame burns in every basilica, judging truth and debt alike.

4.1 Ecktoria — “Marble Fire”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The flame remembers. The marble judges. The ledger never sleeps.*

Grand Magistrate (Elite): “The law here is written not in books but in marble and flame. Every edict carries the weight of centuries, and every judgment echoes in the very stones of the Forum. But the Forum has grown quiet of late. The patricians no longer listen.”

Ferrymaster (Commoner): “I’ve seen the city burn three times and rise again like a phoenix made of stone. The marble remembers, the bells tell the truth, and the fire judges all — especially those who think coin can buy clean hands. But this time the fire isn’t burning. It’s *smiling*. The rich have stopped looking at the flames. They only look at each other.”

Genre / Mood: Imperial decay, mercantile noir, flame-lit judgment, Renaissance decadence — a city walled off from its own rot, where the wealthy dance while the poor cough ash.

Starting Location: The Coin-House floor, marble cracked with soot lines, where votive candles burn beside melted icons. A factor with smoke-singed ledgers offers a purse. “The Lame King moves,” she says. “And the Basilica burns with him. Your credit is good — for now. Find out who lit the fire, or the Flame will audit your soul at dawn. And stay away from the Amber Palace. The Vigil has been... *smiling*.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Once the heart of the Utaran Empire, Ecktoria has worn its laurels into chains. Three centuries of sack, fire, and slow decline have not stripped its marble forums nor its gold-sealed coin-houses — but each day, more of its wealth slips into the hands of mercenaries and factions. The Black Banners march on its purse, avenging old Ykrul wounds by proxy. Processions still crown its stairways, yet ash lines every step. The city burns not only with memory, but with ambition still unquenched.

Yet the true sickness is not in the streets. It is in the **Amber Palace**, where the old patrician families have walled themselves away. They sit on laurels preserved from the empire, drinking wine that costs a village's harvest, whispering deals with merchants who have never seen a loom. **Maelstraeus**, the demon of commerce and greed, has sunk his hooks into their ledgers; every contract they sign compounds interest in blood. **Livaea**, the demon of seduction and desire, has wrapped their hearts in silk; they marry for influence, divorce for scandal, and love only the reflection of themselves in gilded mirrors. The common folk call them the *Unburdened* — not because they carry no weight, but because they have forgotten what weight feels like.

The **Vigil** — once the empire's secret police, now a fractured ghost of an institution — fights a silent war over the dream of restoration. One faction, the **Chain-Lanterns**, serves the Everflame and the Synod, hunting heresy and latent magic. Another, the **Unburnt**, answers only to the old patrician houses, ensuring that no whisper of rebellion reaches the Amber Palace. A third, the **Red Vigil**, has sold itself to Maelstraeus, auditing debts and collecting interest in screams. They do not fight each other openly. They meet in the hypogeum of the Arena, under the gaze of statues that weep marble tears.

Beyond the capital's walls, the province is a patchwork of struggling towns, abandoned fortresses, and grainlands whose harvests are disputed by rival tax-collectors. The Everflame Orthodoxy preaches unity, but each sermon is a coded signal for a political camp. The statues watch. The fire judges. And in the sewers, the Vigil's informers listen for the name of the next person to vanish.

What you notice first: The smell of old incense and fresh bread — and beneath it, the faint sweetness of rot. The way crowds part for a procession — and close again for a knife. The marble steps, worn smooth by centuries of petitioners. The way the wealthy never step on the cracks.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse a toast in a coin-house. The ledgers are the true judges, and a declined cup is a declined credit. You will not borrow again. But more than that: never accept a gift from a patrician without naming its price aloud. Maelstraeus and Livaea both listen, and a gift accepted in silence is a contract signed in blood.

Regional Mood: The Flame That Remembers — And The Dancers Who Forgot

Here, the past does not fade — it is polished into monuments. Every statue, every obelisk, every triumphal arch is a legal precedent carved in stone. Ecktoria is not one city but three: the marble forums of the old patricians (where the Unburdened hold masques that last for weeks, their faces painted with ash from the Everflame), the soot-stained alleys of the mercenary camps (where Black Banner captains drink with Vigil informers), and the basilicas where the Everflame's priests balance piety against profit (and sometimes sell indulgences for the sin of being born poor). The Grand Magistrate presides over a skeleton empire, but the real power moves in coin-houses, grain ledgers,

and the whispered judgments of the Censor’s Hall — and in the dreams of patricians who no longer remember the scent of rain.

The **Vigil** does not patrol the streets. It *permeates* them. Every tavern has an informer; every bathhouse has a spy; every marriage is witnessed by someone who reports to a faction of the Vigil. The Chain-Lanterns hunt magic; the Unburnt hunt sedition; the Red Vigil hunts *debt*. They are not allies. They are not enemies. They are three creditors fighting over the same soul.

The **patricians** — the Old Blood — no longer govern. They *perform* governance. A session of the Parlement might see two senators debate the price of grain while their slaves hold silver trays of honeyed figs. A decree might be passed that doubles the salt tax, then rescinded an hour later because a duchess sneezed. They are not cruel. They are *distracted*. Livaea has taught them to crave the next pleasure before they have finished the current one. Maelstraeus has taught them that every transaction is a game, and every game is winnable if you have enough coin. They do not see the bread riots. They see a shortage of *entertainment*.

The **Everflame** still burns in the basilicas, but its light has grown dim. The High Priest speaks of unity, but his sermons are interrupted by coughing from the pews — not from illness, but from the ash that falls like snow. The common folk whisper that the flame no longer judges truth; it only *records* it, filing confessions in a vault that no one ever opens. The Vigil has a key. The patricians have a copy. The poor have nothing but their names, which the Censor’s Hall writes in disappearing ink.

At a Glance

- **Atmosphere:** Marble grandeur, ash-tipped ambition, the slow rot of imperial forms, and the cloying sweetness of a city drowning in its own nostalgia.
- **Key Conflict:** Legitimacy versus wealth; old families, new mercenaries, and the Everflame’s judgment — but beneath it all, the battle between Maelstraeus (greed) and Livaea (desire) over the souls of the powerful.
- **Notable Threats:** Bread riots, arena spills, ducal conflicts, inquisitorial visits, the Red List — and the Vigil’s three factions, who may arrest you for debt, sedition, or simply being unnamed.
- **Common Rewards:** Procession permits, coin-house credit, laurel deeds, a Golden Edict carved in precedent — and, if you are brave, a secret from the Vigil’s own ledgers.

Prominent NPCs of Ecktoria

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Valerius	Grand Magistrate	Preserve the forms of law while the empire crumbles	His gavel is a sundial; it only strikes at noon. He has not struck it in a year.

Flavia	High Priest of the Ever-flame	Balance the factions and keep the flame lit	She has never raised her voice; the flame speaks for her. Lately, it speaks in the voices of the dead.
Cassia	Duchess-Regent of the Dolmis Gate	Protect her family's trading rights	She rules from behind a silk screen; a dagger-hole is cut at eye level. The screen was a gift from Livaea.
Marcus	Coin-House Factor	Survive the next credit panic	He seals deals with three ribbons: white (ask), red (now), black (never). His black ribbon is fraying.
Lucius	Lanista (arena master)	Own the next champion and the secrets of the hypogeum	His fighters' brands are his signature; he never repeats a mark. One brand is a spiral — the mark of the Red Vigil.
The Red Clerk	Censor's Hall scribe	Control which names are remembered	His inkwell is a skull; the skull belonged to a name he erased. He has forgotten his own name.

Vigil-Commander Vorenus	Chain-Lantern prefect	Hunt untutored magic before it wakes the Ninth	His lantern burns green. He says it shows the truth. His shadow has two heads.
Lady Aelia	Patrician heiress, Livaea’s favourite	Outshine every rival before the next masque	She has not left the Amber Palace in seven years. She does not know the price of bread.

Names of Ecktoria

Inspired by late Latin and early Romance: strong vowels (ae, i, o), soft endings, and the weight of imperial bureaucracy. Surnames often denote a place of origin, a trade, or a notable ancestor.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Valerius	Flavia	de Urbe	<i>the Iron</i>
Marcus	Cassia	Aquilinus	<i>the Coin-Wise</i>
Lucius	Aelia	Honoratus	<i>Flame-Touched</i>
Tiberius	Cornelia	Lateranus	<i>the Unburned</i>
Gaius	Livia	Silvanus	<i>Bread-Counter</i>
Decimus	Valeria	Portinari	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

The Three Ecktorias: Faction Spectrum

Ecktoria is not a single polity but a battlefield of three competing visions. Most citizens and factions fall somewhere between these poles, shifting allegiance as the grain price changes. Superimposed on them are the whispers of Maelstraeus and Livaea, who have no faction — only debtors.

- **Old Blood (Patrician Traditionalists)** – The ancient senatorial families who remember when Ecktoria ruled the world. They worship precedent, hoard marble, and see mercenaries as necessary filth. Their power is in law, lineage, and the silent networks of the Censor’s Hall. *Clocks: PATRICIAN PATIENCE [4], BLOOD DEBT [6]. Patron whispers: Livaea* — they marry for influence, betray for pleasure, and mistake cruelty for wit.
- **Black Purse (Mercenary & Trade Leagues)** – The new power: condotta brokers, coin-house factors, and mercenary captains who have bought what birth could not give. They care about supply lines, not bloodlines. Their loyalty is to the next contract, and their god is the ledger. *Clocks: CONTRACT SPIRAL [4], PAYDAY FEVER [6]. Patron whispers: Maelstraeus* — they measure profit in interest, interest in suffering, and suffering in silver.
- **The Everflame (Church & Inquisition)** – The priests, inquisitors, and relic-keepers who claim that the Eternal Flame is the only true sovereign. They offer legitimacy to whoever pays

the tithe — and withdraw it from whoever forgets. Their power is in pulpits, processions, and the fear of excommunication. *Clocks: HERESY INDEX [4], SANCTUARY VIOLATION [6]. Patron whispers:* Neither — the Everflame remembers, but the Vigil has learned to filter its truths.

Superimposed on these are the **Ykrul creditors** (who hold Ecktoria’s debt like a leash), the **Black Banners** (who hold its streets like a lease), and the **Vigil** (who hold its secrets like a knife). A wise politician learns to balance all three — and keeps a boat ready on the Dolmis.

The Vigil — Three Faces of the Secret Police

The Vigil is not one order but three, each claiming the mantle of the old imperial secret police. They do not cooperate. They do not war. They *audit* each other.

- **The Chain-Lanterns (Orthodox)** — Hunters of untutored magic. They carry brass lanterns that reveal latent talent through candle-smoke tests. They answer to the Synod and the Everflame, but their true loyalty is to the *precedent* — the law that magic must be licensed, indexed, and taxed. A Chain-Lantern raid is heralded by a single, low bell. *Clocks: CANDLE-SMOKE SWEEP [4], HERETIC INDEX [6].*
- **The Unburnt (Patrician)** — Bodyguards and spies of the Amber Palace. They wear red sashes and carry no visible weapons. Their job is to ensure that no whisper of rebellion, no bread riot, no debt revolt ever reaches a patrician’s ear. They are experts at *redaction* — not killing witnesses, but making them forget. *Clocks: PALACE SECRETS [4], REDACTED MEMORY [6].*
- **The Red Vigil (Maelstraeus’s Own)** — Debt-collectors and interest-enforcers. They serve no noble, no church, no magistrate — only the ledger. They audit the wealthy for the wealthy, finding hidden obligations, unpaid tithes, and compound interest that has grown teeth. A Red Vigil agent never demands coin. They demand *names*. *Clocks: INTEREST DUE [4], LEDGER OF NAMES [6].*

The Vigil’s three commanders meet once a month in the hypogeum of the Arena, under the gaze of statues that weep marble tears. No record is kept of these meetings. No one admits they happen. The common folk say that if you see a Vigil agent, it is already too late — but they cannot agree on *which* Vigil.

Spades — Places

2. **Petition Steps** — Milk-stone steps where dawn petitions are pinned. *The petitions are written in ink and hope. The steps answer in marble and silence.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
3. **Tally-Ford Ferryhouse** — Rope-drums thrum all day; the ferrymaster watches coin and banners. *The rope-drums have a pattern. It spells the names of those who paid late.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
4. **Arena Hypogeum** — Practice sand and whispered secrets beneath the games. *The sand is from the Tiber. It still remembers the blood of the last revolt. The Vigil meets here.* ‘[DEATH]’
5. **Everflame Cloister** — Candle markets and side-chapels where flame speaks truth. *The flame has a voice. It is the voice of the last liar who tested it. Lately, it speaks in a whisper.* ‘[TRUTH]’
6. **Shatterline Bazaar** — Between quake-toppled columns, merchants hawk broken dreams. *The columns were toppled by an earthquake that killed a senator. He still haunts the rubble, counting his debts.* ‘[TRADE]’

7. **Coin-House Floor** — Counting ledgers under glass; factors seal credit with three ribbons. *The ribbons are colored: white for "ask," red for "now," black for "never." The black ribbons are all frayed.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
8. **Mile-Zero Obelisk** — Surveyors’ starting point; all roads measured from here. *The obelisk has a crack. The crack is a mile long — in the other direction. The Vigil uses it to measure disappearances.* ‘[LAW]’
9. **Triumph Stairs** — Processional Way switchback; marble worn smooth by ambition. *The stairs have a name: "The Rise of the Forgotten." No one remembers why. The patricians still climb them.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
10. **Aqueduct Walk** — Narrow guardpath above the city’s arteries; perfect for ambush or escape. *The water below tastes of iron. It is the city’s memory of its own blood. The Vigil drinks it to stay awake.* ‘[STEALTH]’
- J **Ducal Loggia** — High above a packed square; a duchess watches and waits. *The duchess has not blinked in three hours. She is counting. She has forgotten what she is counting.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- Q **Censor’s Hall** — Red-lacquered tablets record every name, every shame. *The tablets are redacted in invisible ink. The truth is underneath. The Vigil has the reagent.* ‘[LAW]’
- K **Grand Forum** — Statues tarped, echoes loud; where crowds become mobs. *The tarps were a gift from a dead emperor. The statues do not thank him. They whisper to the Vigil.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
- A **The Amber Palace** — Walled off from the city, where the patricians hold masques that last for weeks. *The walls are not stone. They are debt. No one has entered without an invitation in a decade. No one has left.* ‘[LEGEND]’

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Torchbearer Child** — Ash-smudged hands; knows every shortcut through the ruins. *She has never been lost. The ruins speak to her in dust. The Vigil pays her for echoes.* ‘[STEALTH]’
3. **Ferrymaster** — Knows which banners pay late; collects more than coin. *His ledger is a net. The names are the catch. He sold a name to the Red Vigil once. He does not sleep well.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
4. **Coin-House Factor** — Seals credit with three ribbons; eyes twitch at defaults. *His eyes are the color of old silver. They see through your purse. They also see the Red Vigil in the corner.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
5. **Lanista** — Owns fighters — and their secrets; sells victory in the sand. *His grin is a brand. The brand is on his fighters’ necks. One fighter has a brand that glows — a Vigil spy.* ‘[COMBAT]’
6. **Decumanus-Master** — Surveyor who "moves" stones; rewrites the city’s shape. *His rod is a finger bone. The bone belonged to the last surveyor who argued. The Vigil uses his maps.* ‘[LAW]’
7. **Procession Marshal** — Permits and whistle; keeps order in ceremonial chaos. *His whistle is for the living. His bell is for the dead. He has not used the whistle in a year.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
8. **Grain-Prefect** — Allots loaves; knives in the margins of every ledger. *His ledger has a stain. The stain is wine — or blood. The Vigil has a copy.* ‘[DEBT]’
9. **Censor’s Clerk** — "Misfiles" careers; knows which names to forget. *His inkwell is a*

skull. The skull belonged to a name he forgot. The Vigil pays him for the ones he remembers.
 ‘[LAW]’

10. **Veteran Standard-Bearer** — Sells honor as a retainer; medals heavier than sword. *His medals are from a war that never happened. The corpses are from one that did. The Vigil recruited him.* ‘[COMBAT]’
- J **Gladiatrix** — Darling of the crowds; owes no one but the sand. *Her sword has no name. The sand has many. The Vigil has a file on her. It is thicker than her arm.* ‘[COMBAT]’
- Q **Duchess-Regent** — Behind a silk screen; speaks through cousins, rules through silence. *The screen has a hole. The hole is for a dagger — hers. The screen was a gift from Livaea.* ‘[POLITICS]’
- K **High Priest of Everflame** — Smiles like law; flame judges truth and debt. *His smile is a candle. It can warm — or burn. The Vigil has asked him to smile less.* ‘[TRUTH]’
- A **Vigil-Commander Vorenius** — Leads the Chain-Lanterns. Fears the Unburnt. Hates the Red Vigil. *His lantern burns green. He says it shows the truth. His shadow has two heads — one for each faction he has betrayed.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Blocked Bridge** — A procession blocks the only crossing till sundown. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The procession is for a saint who died hungry. The saint is not forgiving. The Vigil is watching.*
3. **Proscribed Sigil** — A sudden edict: your mark is now forbidden. ‘[LAW]’ *The edict was written in the dead of night. The ink is still wet — and warm. The Vigil’s seal is on the back.*
4. **Bread Riots** — Grain barges are late; hunger hisses at the city’s edges. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The hunger has a face. It is the face of a baker who ran out of flour. The Vigil is looking for him.*
5. **Arena Spill** — A riot spills into streets; shutters slam, guards draw steel. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The riot started over a point. The point was a sword. The Vigil started it.*
6. **Ducal Conflict** — Rival dukes levy the same ward; your recruits vanish. ‘[POLITICS]’ *The recruits are not dead. They are hired. They are now your enemies — and Vigil informers.*
7. **Border Dispute** — A re-plat redraws boundaries; your deed becomes "disputed." ‘[LAW]’ *The surveyor’s rod is bent. He calls it "context." The Vigil calls it leverage.*
8. **Frozen Purse** — A coin-house calls in notes; your purse freezes at the worst moment. ‘[DEBT]’ *The notes were called by a dead man. His signature is still warm. The Red Vigil is at the door.*
9. **Inquisitorial Visit** — A relic’s authenticity is questioned; penalties are swift and public. ‘[TRUTH]’ *The relic is a nail from a cross. It has been forged seven times. It still works. The Vigil supplied the forger.*
10. **Aftershock** — Masonry and timetables fall; scaffolds groan with new cracks. ‘[DISASTER]’ *The crack has a name. It whispers it to the wind. The Vigil writes it down.*
- J **Counterfeit Laurel** — Your win is void unless you find the forger. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The forger is a child. The child is a slave. The slave is a senator’s son. The Vigil knows.*
- Q **Church Purge** — "Spectacles" are banned; your venue is canceled by zealots. ‘[DEATH]’ *The zealots are paid by a rival. The rival is in the front row. The Vigil is in the back.*
- K **Rerouted Triumph** — The crowd follows the favored path; your moment is stolen. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The favored path is lined with archers. The archers are not there for the ceremony. They are Vigil.*

- A **Red List** — A secret ledger; your patron’s name appears overnight. ‘[DEATH]’ *The list is written in a dead hand. The dead are still collecting. The Vigil holds the pen.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Bread Chit** — Ward sustenance for a week; street patience guaranteed. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The chit is a clay token. Break it to eat — or to bribe. The Vigil accepts both.*
 3. **Procession Permit** — Move sacred flame through a crowded quarter; law walks with you. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The permit is a torch. Carry it, and the city will part — or burn. The Vigil will follow.*
 4. **Arena Purse** — Settles debts and hires mouths; blood-money in coin. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The purse is a helmet. The helmet belonged to a champion who lost. The Vigil has his name.*
 5. **Survey Writ** — Reset one boundary stone; redraw the city’s shape. ‘[LAW]’ *The writ is a stone. Move it, and the map changes — on paper. The Vigil watches the paper.*
 6. **Ducal Safe-Conduct** — Four guards and a trumpet; noble favor walks ahead. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The guards are paid by the duke. The trumpet is paid by you. The Vigil has a key to the trumpet.*
 7. **Coin-House Credit** — Silent and immediate; debt becomes opportunity. ‘[DEBT]’ *The credit is a ribbon. Cut it to spend — or to owe. The Vigil will collect the interest.*
 8. **Magistrate’s Postponement** — Buy a tenday against any suit; law delayed, not denied. ‘[LAW]’ *The postponement is a letter. The letter is sealed with a tear. The Vigil has the other copy.*
 9. **Laurel-Deed** — Crowd favor follows you into court; glory as a shield. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The deed is a leaf. It was plucked from a victor’s crown. The victor is dead. The Vigil knows why.*
 10. **Grain Ledger** — Name who eats this month; hunger bends to your will. ‘[DEBT]’ *The ledger is a stomach. Feed it, or it will feed on you. The Vigil has the first page.*
- J **Minor Title** — A style that opens doors that bolts resist; rank as a key. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The title is a word. The word is "Patrician." The doors do not ask questions. The Vigil does.*
- Q **Basilica Audience** — One private hour with the High Priest; the flame speaks truth. ‘[TRUTH]’ *The hour is a candle. When it burns out, so does your favor. The Vigil lit the candle.*
- K **Censor’s Indulgence** — One banned thing becomes permitted (for you). ‘[LAW]’ *The indulgence is a silence. The silence is a scream. The Vigil has earplugs.*
- A **Golden Edict** — An exception carved in marble; precedent travels like law. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The edict is a crack. The crack in the law is now an opening. The Vigil is already inside.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/favor/precedence) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **marble and fire** motifs — statues that watch, flames that judge, and law that remembers every name. Also echo the **Vigil’s presence** — a cough in the crowd, a seal on a document you did not stamp, a mirror that shows a different face.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Imperial Ruins:** Every district bears half-collapsed arcades, serving as markets, courts, or shelters for mercenary companies. The Vigil knows every hidden passage.
- **Competing Factions:** Dukes, guilds, and priests stage processions that collide at bridges and squares, each claiming legitimacy. The Vigil collects bets on the outcome.
- **Monuments as Weapons:** Statues, obelisks, and colonnades are not only symbols — they are barricades, rallying points, and high ground when the city riots. The Vigil has a map of which statues can be toppled.
- **Everflame Orthodoxy:** The basilicas preach unity, but each sermon is a coded signal for a political camp. The High Priest plays balance while cultivating his own following. The Vigil decodes every sermon.
- **Black Banner Contracts:** Foreign mercenaries fill the gaps left by a shrinking citizen levy, their loyalty secured only by steady coin. The Vigil audits their pay.
- **The Amber Palace Quarantine:** The patricians have not left the palace in a decade. No one is certain if they are prisoners or patrons. The Vigil maintains the perimeter — and delivers the wine.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Saints & Cults):**
 - **St. Marcellus of the Gilded Scale (Mykkiel)** — *The Justiciar*. His order enforces unwritten laws; reading a sealed precedent binds the reader to enforce it. His shrine is the Censor's Hall. The Vigil keeps a copy of every precedent.
 - **St. Valeria of the Serpent (Isoka)** — *The Shedding Saint*. Pilgrims who confess at her chapel forget one sin — and one kindness. Her mosaic shows a snake eating its tail. The Vigil uses her chapel to erase memories.
 - **St. Lucia of the Undying Flame (Oath of Flame & Light)** — *The Witness of Embers*. Any oath sworn over her shrine's flame cannot be broken; the breaker sees their own face in every wave until they drown. The Vigil swears oaths there — and never breaks them.
 - **The Reckoner (Maelstraeus)** — *The Ledger Keeper*. A mystery cult of coin-house factors. They offer credit at the cost of a hidden interest that compounds in blood. The Red Vigil are their debt-collectors.
 - **The Ember Prefect (Heretic Cult)** — A schism that believes the flame should not be contained. They meet in the arena hypogeum, chanting the *Unspoken Ninth Citation*. The Grand Magistrate has outlawed them three times. The Vigil has infiltrated them twice.
 - **The Velvet Mask (Livaea)** — A secret society of patricians who worship pleasure as the only truth. Their rites are said to last nine days. No one has ever left a rite unchanged. The Vigil watches their parties — and reports to the Unburnt.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a hospice in the Shatterline Bazaar. They ask no payment — but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the arena slaves, trying to untie her cord from a coin-house debt. The Vigil has her file.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the grain-prefects. Take it, and your store never runs dry — but the coin will reappear in the

mouth of a starving child. The Red Vigil uses it to mark debtors.

- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Ecktorian psions are called “Flame-Readers.” They see the future in the Everflame’s flicker. The High Priest employs three — and has never trusted a forecast that didn’t smell of smoke. The Vigil employs their apprentices.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Imperial Arena is a Class IV Poltergeist site — the collective rage of every gladiator who died for the crowd. Saikou Ira would ring a bell eight times and leave a wreath of laurel. The Vigil rings the bell nine times. The Arena answers.
- **The Ninth:** In any Ecktorian court, the ninth citation of precedent voids all previous. The wise stop at eight and settle. Those who cite the ninth hear a faint laughter from the marble walls — and their cases are never heard again. The Vigil cites the ninth often. The laughter does not bother them.

Ecktoria Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Flame:** Crumble a crust into the Everflame. Ignore the first *Bread Riots* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Ribbon:** Tie a single knot in a coin-house credit ribbon. Cancel *Frozen Purse* or take –1 die on your next debt roll (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Marble:** Whisper a dead debtor’s name into a statue’s ear. Gain +1 Effect when collecting from their heirs this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Grand Magistrate. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Spit on the Seal:** Before signing any contract, spit on the wax seal. If it sizzles, the Vigil has a copy. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **city guards or rival factions**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **crowds or ceremonial processions**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **patrols or inquisitors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or ceremonial opportunity**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **City authorities or noble house** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **crowd movement or procession**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival faction member or city official** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **guards, mercenaries, or zealots** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.

- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes — **procession turns violent/boundary dispute erupts/patron turns**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: High Priest, Grand Magistrate, or Duchess-Regent** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically — **procession erupts/arena gate opens/monument collapses**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice — **flame speaks/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Ecktoria (Marble & Fire):** Statues turn their heads, flames burn blue, ceremonial masks appear in windows.
- **Ecktoria (Procession):** Crowds chant your name, banners block your path, trumpets announce your arrival.
- **Ecktoria (Patronage):** Seals break in your hand, favors are revoked, noble houses compete for your allegiance.
- **Ecktoria (The Vigil):** A seal appears on your documents that you did not stamp. A cough from the crowd sounds like your name. Your reflection in a polished shield has a red sash.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Cross-Region Hooks (optional draws):**
 - *Aeler True Masons* bid to shore a failing aqueduct; accepting stabilizes *Aftershock* but grants them soft leverage in the ward. The Vigil audits the contract.
 - *Aelinnel Green-Market* broker offers “truth-credit” on court gossip; pay later in favors or names. The Vigil pays in silence.
 - *Black Banner retainer* parade demands back pay on the Triumph Stairs; crowd sympathy tilts your next parley. The Vigil arrests the ringleader.
- **Faction Entanglements During Travel (use en route or on city entry):**
 - If the party holds any *Condotta* Diamonds, begin with *Bread Riots* at +1 segment (mercenary grain trains re-routed).
 - Entering with an *Underway Pass* (Aeler) grants +1 Position on *Aqueduct Walk* scenes but ticks *Ducal Conflict* once (guild jealousy). The Vigil notes your pass.
 - Carrying *Green Market* tags downgrades one *Censor’s Hall* action but flags *Inquisitorial Visit* at the next temple. The Vigil compares tags.
- **Trade Good Consequences (pick 1 when a haul sells):**
 - *Arena Steel* → street duels spike → start *Arena Spill* at 1. The Vigil collects the weapons.
 - *Relic Fragments* → basilica prestige swings → tick *Church Purge* or grant *Basilica Audience*. The Vigil inspects the relic.

- *Survey Rights* → boundary re-plot → downgrade one *Border Dispute* or upgrade a rival's. The Vigil updates the map.
- **Diplomatic Favor (minor currency):**
 - Earn by resolving a public scene without bloodshed (Forum, Procession, Coin-House).
 - Spend 1 to reduce DV of a permit/audience by 1, or to ignore *Blocked Bridge* for one crossing.
 - Holding 2+ makes you “interesting”: start a *Red List* [4] that advances on snubbed patrons. The Vigil adds your name.
- **Reputation Echoes (soft power):**
 - *Crowd-Loved (Laurel-Deed)*: first time per session you face a mob, set Position one step safer. The Vigil watches how the mob loves you.
 - *Coin-House Trusted (Credit)*: ignore the first *Frozen Purse*; next time, it returns at +1 severity. The Vigil audits your credit.
 - *Clerically Vouched (Everflame)*: downgrade one *Inquisitorial Visit*; if abused, promote *Church Purge*. The Vigil has a copy of your voucher.

Monuments as Mechanics (opulence with teeth)

- **Processional Geometry:** When acting on the *Triumph Stairs*, choose: +1 Effect *or* –1 Heat; on a miss, *Rerouted Triumph* advances. The Vigil stands at the top of the stairs, watching.
- **Aqueduct Leverage:** Securing an aqueduct span grants a one-scene *high ground* tag in any linked ward; if collateral hits, tick *Aftershock*. The Vigil knows where the aqueduct leaks.
- **Forum Acoustics:** Rally speeches at the *Grand Forum* grant an extra assist die if at least 20 witnesses; failure spawns *Bread Riots* at +1. The Vigil counts the witnesses.

Plug-in SB Conversions (Ecktoria flavor)

- Any 1 SB may become *Crowd Drift*: shift the scene's terrain in favor of or against you (bridges clog, stairs clear).
- Any 2 SB may become *Seal Revoked*: void one paper (Permit/Chit/Indulgence); to avert, sacrifice *Diplomatic Favor*.
- On 3+ SB offer *Patron Bargain*: accept a visible mark (ribbon, laurel brand) to halve consequences; start a *Patron Debt* [6].

Hidden Orders & Ancient Conspiracies (d12 hooks)

1. **The Ash Senate** – a ledger of “extinguished” patrician lines still voting by proxy through funerary guilds. The Vigil has the key.
2. **Surveyors of the Ninth Mile** – decumanus-masters who can *move* boundaries with ritual math; a lost rod sets precedent across the city. The Vigil owns the rod.
3. **Lantern Tetrarchy** – four basilica beadles who decide which miracles are counted; the fifth lamp was broken in a purge. The Vigil lit the purge.
4. **The Red Marble Compact** – coin-house founders who tithe 1 in 100 coins to a secret indemnity fund used to flip coups. The Red Vigil administers the fund.
5. **Archivum Umbrae** – censor clerks maintaining a *shadow index* of names that must not stand trial (yet). The Vigil reads the index nightly.

6. **Peregrine Brotherhood** – ferrymasters trading in sealed confessions; blackmail that floats. The Vigil buys the confessions.
7. **The Laurel of Dust** – a gladiators’ mutual that chooses which champions live long enough to hold office. The Vigil chooses the champions.
8. **Aqueduct Collegium Obscura** – engineers who keep a second set of sluice keys; droughts become elections. The Vigil has the third set.
9. **Order of the Broken Obelisk** – survey-cult that believes Mile-Zero is *wrong* and can re-found the city with one stone. The Vigil has the stone.
10. **The Funeral Republic** – undertakers running a parallel courier state through catacombs and wakes. The Vigil uses their couriers.
11. **The Ember Vault** – a sealed reliquary under the Arena; victors’ sweat was bottled for augury. The Vigil broke the seal.
12. **Triumphal Maskers** – procession costumers who encode heretical theses into robe pleats and torch patterns. The Vigil decodes the theses — and sometimes agrees.

Cults & Mystery Rites (d10)

1. **Children of the Phoenix** (*rebirth by fire*): ash-marks grant +1 die vs. fear in crowds; mark Fatigue if you hesitate near open flame.
2. **Verdant Laurel** (*blood to marble, sap to coin*): once/session turn 1 Harm into 1 Coin-House Credit; start a *Green Debt* [4].
3. **Mask of the Thirteenth** (*forbidden procession step*): walk through a riot unmolested; next parley with clergy begins one step worse.
4. **Brotherhood of the River Tongue** (*truth ferried at night*): ask the Dolmis one yes/no; a ferryman shows up later to collect a name.
5. **Candlemakers of Ever** (*flame remembers lies*): blue flame points to falsehood; the liar dreams of you for three nights (Exposure +1).
6. **Sable Standard** (*war saint cult*): your banner ignores morale checks once; start a *Blood-Tithe* [4] owed to the saint’s chapel.
7. **The Ninth Bell** (*hour that is not kept*): skip a queue or sentence; next edict you need arrives late (Delay SB free once).
8. **Guild of Red Accountants** (*sin as ledger*): convert 2 SB into a *Magistrate’s Postponement*; add *Karmic Debt* [6].
9. **The Marble Eaters** (*mortification sect*): bite stone, gain +1 Effect resisting crowd crush; take Harm 1 (Stress) if you boast.
10. **Torch of Saint Vessa** (*saint of necessary arson*): sanctify a fire to purge a tag (Plague/Corruption); City Heat +2.

Religious Schisms & Trials

The Everflame Divide (choose a live schism)

1. **Orthodox Basilica vs. Ember Reformers**: Is miracle *counted* by law or *kindled* by need?
2. **Laurel Theologians vs. Street Saints**: Does glory flow *down* from triumphs or *up* from bread-lines?
3. **Iconoclast Ward vs. Reliquary Keepers**: Is the flame purer without images?

Schism Mechanics (table-facing)

- **Heresy Index** [0–6]: ticks when players publicize a stance, defy clergy, or wield cult rites in view. At 3: inquisitorial audits become common; at 6: *Church Purge* (Q) auto-triggers once/session until lowered.
- **Sanctuary / Anathema Tags:** locations acquire tags during arc scenes. *Sanctuary*: first harm in scene becomes Fatigue; *Anathema*: first social miss spawns “Proscribed Sigil.”
- **Trial by Fire (mini-procedure, 3 beats):**
 1. *Assembly*: set the forum/stair as arena; state thesis in one sentence (players or NPCs).
 2. *Witness*: three proofs (relic, miracle, precedent). Each proof: test Social/Arcana/Resolve vs. crowd DV; on success, reduce Index by 1 or gain *Basilica Audience*.
 3. *Judgment*: roll Crowd Mood (1d6): 1–2 mobs, 3–4 silent acceptance, 5–6 laurel toss (gain *Laurel-Deed*). If Index ≥ 4 , –1 to the roll.

Ecktoria – Marble and Fire

Starting Location: The Coin-House floor, marble cracked with soot lines, where votive candles burn beside melted icons.

“In Ecktoria, even faith must balance its ledgers, and the gods audit in ash.”

In... the Coin-House floor, a factor with smoke-singed ledgers offers a purse. “The Lame King moves,” she says. “And the Basilica burns with him. The Amber Palace has not answered a summons in a month. The Vigil is asking questions. I suggest you find the answers before they find you.”

Regional Motifs Coin-oaths, basilica relics, marble acoustics, augury smoke, Vigil seals.

Whispers to Offer “Bid against the city,” “Pocket the relic shard,” “Name an innocent debtor,” “The Vigil’s informer sits in the corner.”

External Clocks Threat: *Procession of Ash* [6]; Community: *Credit Panic* [4]; Anchor: *Basilica Choir* [4]; Vigil: *Red List* [6].

Complications Smoke speaks truths; coins stick to skin; a reliquary runs hot; a seal appears on your documents that you did not stamp.

Anchors at Risk A choir novice; a patron account; a Vigil informer who owes you a favour.

Escalation Beat The Basilica tolls a note only one PC hears. The Vigil hears it too.

Relief Return the shard; pay a city-debt in blood or ; route the procession elsewhere; give the Vigil a name.

Boss Seeds (Cults & Conspiracies)

- **The Ember Prefect** (schismatic inquisitor): *Phase* [8] Citation → Censure → Auto-da-fé → Purge. Lair: Everflame Cloister. Counters: relic provenance, crowd-favor, rival sermon. *Vigil twist*: The Prefect was once a Vigil informer. The Vigil knows where he hides.
- **The Surveyor-Primus** (geomantic usurper): *Phase* [6] Re-plat → Dispossess → Erase. Lair: Mile-Zero. Counters: Aeler measure-rods, witness line, broken rod. *Vigil twist*: The Primus has a Red Vigil agent as a protégé.
- **Phoenix of the Arena** (miracle or hoax?): *Phase* [10] Hype → Immolation → “Rebirth” → Riot. Lair: Imperial Arena. Counters: doused ash, Mask of the Thirteenth, Everflame test. *Vigil twist*: The Phoenix is a Vigil experiment. The Unburnt want to contain it. The Red Vigil wants to sell tickets.
- **The Velvet Mask** (Livaea’s cult): *Phase* [8] Invitation → Masque → Debt of Pleasure. Lair: The Amber Palace. Counters: an unbroken oath, a mirror with no reflection, a name spoken without desire. *Vigil twist*: The Vigil’s Unburnt faction attends every masque. They are not there to stop it.

Diamonds: Forbidden Leverage (add to §4.1)

14. **Shadow Index Leaf** – remove one name from the Red List for a week; add *Countercoup* +1.
15. **Ember Writ** – sanction one cult rite as “orthodox” for a scene.
16. **Surveyor’s Ninth Rod** – redraw one ward line unnoticed (until dawn).
17. **Vigil Seal (Red)** – For one scene, the Red Vigil treats you as a contractor. Interest will be collected later.

Cross-Contamination (fast ties)

- **Aeler True Masons**: backing an iconoclast audit grants shoring crews; bell-codes now gate temple entries. The Vigil has the bell-codes.
- **Aelinnel Thorn Courts**: hawthorn chaplains host “mirror sermons”; a basilica gains *Sanctuary* while a rival becomes *Anathema*. The Vigil watches both.
- **Black Banners**: war-chaplains monetize indulgences; clearing *Payday* risks +1 *Heresy Index*. The Vigil takes a cut.

Patronage & Power

Ecktoria’s decline is not collapse, but transformation. Wealth bleeds into patronage webs: a senator’s indulgence, a censor’s indulgence, a noble’s purse. The city’s great houses keep mercenary captains on retainer, while priests sell ritual processions as public theater and private favor. And everywhere, the Vigil watches — not to stop the rot, but to take notes. Yet beneath the decay, two demons whisper. **Maelstraeus** teaches that every contract is a weapon, every debt a leash. **Livaea** teaches that every desire is a chain, every pleasure a payment. The patricians who once ruled the world now rule only the Amber Palace, and the Amber Palace is a gilded cage. They do not see the bread riots. They do not hear the Vigil’s footsteps. They dance. They drink. They forget that the flame remembers everything.

For the GM: Patronage should function as both opportunity and trap. Any gift (a purse, permit, or charter) binds the receiver to service, but patrons can die, fall from favor, or suddenly proscribe what they once allowed. The Vigil offers a different kind of patronage: *protection* in exchange for *information*. A party that pays the Vigil in secrets may find doors opening — and other doors closing behind them. To emphasize the decadence and dread:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, ribbons, laurel crowns, Vigil marks) that can be stolen, forged, or voided.
- Let rival patrons issue conflicting "safe-conducts," forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use processions, funerals, or trials as arenas for social contests, where patronage debts surface and shift allegiances.
- Introduce the **Vigil’s Faction Clock** [6] to track which Vigil faction (Chain-Lanterns, Unburnt, Red Vigil) has the most leverage over the party. When it fills, that faction makes a demand.

Patronage in Ecktoria is not mere background — it is the engine of politics, coin, and survival. And beneath it all, Maelstraeus and Livaea are writing a contract. The city is the collateral. The poor are the interest. The patricians are the signature — and they signed in blood long ago.

Chapter 5

Acasia

The Broken Province. Acasia is a land of petty kingdoms, free companies, and border lords. The Curse of the Blackwood haunts its crossroads, and every hill-fort flies a different banner. Silkstrand, its sole metropolis, sits at the mouth of the Acasian rivers, a city of bridges and dyewater where merchants and mercenaries mingle.

5.1 Acasia — “Broken Marches”

Margravine of the Broken March (Elite): “The tithe must be paid, not merely offered. A promise written in ash and sealed with iron will is worth more than a thousand gold coins scattered on the wind.”

Hedge-Witch (Commoner): “Don’t cross the Pale Causeway at dusk, especially not if you’ve got a silver tooth. The bridge’ll remember it, and next time you pass, it’ll want more than just your footfall. In Acasia, every road has a memory. The question is who pays the toll.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Acasia is a former province of the Utaran Empire that festers in the space between famine and ambition. Every hill wears a crown, every bridge demands a price, and every road curves back to the same cursed crossroads. Where once the Empire’s coin and grain flowed, now tithe-collectors gnaw the marrow of starving villages, and warlords dress themselves as kings. The land itself has grown bitter: grain blights spread like gossip, wine turns to vinegar in the cask, and the old Imperial roads have forgotten where they lead. The Curse—the nameless thing that makes crossroads loop back on themselves—is not a myth. It is the weight of broken promises, and Acasia is drowning in them.

What you notice first: The smell of mildew on old parchment and wet ash. The way every milestone has been recarved. The silence of a village that heard you coming and chose not to open its gates.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never sign a contract on a bridge. The river is a witness, and it never forgets a signature.

Regional Mood: Famine and Ambition

Here, the past is not a memory—it is a predator. The Utaran Empire left behind roads that lead to nowhere, laws that contradict each other, and a hunger that no harvest can fill. Acasia’s petty kings hold court in burned keeps, their crowns forged from iron nails pulled from famine coffins. The Margravine keeps a tally of feuds, binding bloodlines to her feast days. Free Companies trade loyalty like grain, swapping colors mid-march. And beneath it all, the Curse waits. It is not a monster. It is a geometry: the wrong turn, the bridge that leads back to the same shore, the bell that tolls for no funeral. In Acasia, the land itself has become a contract, and the fine print is written in mildew.

Starting Location: The Pale Causeway’s last inn, walls soot-blackened by coal and a century of gossip. A bounty poster flutters beside a half-empty hearth. The innkeeper is a one-eyed woman who pours small beer without asking. A stranger at the bar offers a sealed contract: retrieve a dowry chest from a Blackwood matriarch before the Margravine’s feast day. “The chest contains a claim, not coin,” the stranger whispers. “But a claim in Acasia is worth more than gold—it is a key to a bridge that does not loop.”

Prominent NPCs of Acasia

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Morwen <i>“the Ledger”</i>	Margravine of the Broken March	Keep the province from fracturing completely	She has never lost a feud; her sword is also a counting rod.
Oren <i>“Tin Crown”</i>	The Lame King	Be recognised as a true sovereign	His travelling throne is carried by debtors; he pays them in promises.
Ysabeau	Hedge-Witch of the Blackwood Charcoalers	Survive the Curse and keep her kin from the rope	She knows which bridges eat travellers, and her price is a story that ends badly.
The Bride	Dowry chest claimant (Blackwood matriarch’s heir)	Recover the chest before the Margravine’s feast day	She carries a dagger in her wedding veil. The claim is to a bridge that drowned.

Vladan	Free Company Captain (“The Rusted Banner”)	Find a permanent contract before winter	He has served three kings this year. He cannot remember their names.
Sister Ash	Ex-Imperial surveyor	Finish the old map of Acasia	She visits villages that no longer exist. The map shows them anyway.

Names of Acasia

Inspired by the martial duchies of a fallen southern empire: clipped Latin, war-names, and the hard consonants of mountain keeps.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Alboin	Theodelinda	da Ponte	<i>the Stiff</i>
Authari	Rosamund	del Ferro	<i>the Toll-Fist</i>
Liutprand	Gundiberga	di Rocca	<i>Bridge-Born</i>
Desiderius	Anspranda	Longobardus	<i>Blackwood</i>
Ratchis	Veleda	Saxo	<i>the Unremembered</i>
Aistulf	Gisela	Capoferro	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

(Pass/Ruin/Toll-Town) Broken milestone on the old Imperial Road; borders “moved” overnight. Vine-terrace hillside with an abandoned press; strangler ivy owns it now.

Spades — Places

2. **Broken Milestone** [RUIN] [OMEN]
On the old Imperial Road; borders “moved” overnight.
The stone has been chiseled seven times. The last mark is still wet.
3. **Vine-Terrace Hillside** [RUIN] [HARVEST]
Abandoned press; strangler ivy owns it now.
The ivy has grown around a skeleton. The skeleton still holds a wine cup.
4. **Toll-Bridge Town** [TOLL] [BOUNDARY]
Over a cold river; two tolls, no receipts.
The second toll is collected by a child. The child does not speak.
5. **Wolfstairs Pass** [MOUNTAIN] [AMBUSH]
Switchbacks beneath a stonefall cliff.
The stones were placed by a landslide that knew your name.
6. **Sootfall Abbey Ruins** [RUIN] [DEATH]
Bell tower intact; crypts breathing.
The breathing is a prayer. The monks are still down there.

7. **Hill-Motte** [FORTIFICATION] [WAR]
 Fresh palisade; ditch scattered with caltrops.
The caltrops are from a siege that ended last week. The bodies are still rotting.
8. **Border-Stone Ring** [BOUNDARY] [OMEN]
 Carved with seven crowns; each points wrong.
The crowns belong to kings who never existed. The stones remember them anyway.
9. **Blackwood Charcoalers' Hollow** [FOREST] [WITCHCRAFT]
 Witch-posts at every path.
The witch-posts were made from the gibbets of tax collectors. The tax collectors still swing.
10. **Salt-Road Ford** [RIVER] [DEATH]
 Rains expose old bones in the chalk banks.
The bones are from three wars. They are not all human.
- J **Iron Mine Adits** [UNDERGROUND] [WHISPERS]
 Held by a miners' commune; the air is full of whispers.
The whispers are the mine's memory. It remembers every collapse.
- Q **Margravine's Hunting Lodge** [NOBLE] [SECRETS]
 Tapestries of victories that never were.
The tapestries were woven by a blind weaver. The threads are from her own hair.
- K **War-Camp City** [WAR] [REFUGE]
 Tents around a burned keep; every banner claims the throne.
The keep was burned by its own lord. He did not want to share the heat.
- A **The Pale Causeway** [ROAD] [CURSE]
 The last high road that survives the spring thaws.
The causeway is made of bones. The bones are from the workers who built it.

(Petty Crowns/Priests/Companies) Tithe-collector's runner with a tally-rod and an empty stomach; roadside prior with three lay brothers guarding a relic.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Tithe-Collector's Runner** [AUTHORITY] [HUNGER]
 Tally-rod, empty stomach, and a list of names.
His tally-rod has notches from a dozen villages. The villages are now empty.
3. **Roadside Prior** [FAITH] [RELIC]
 Three lay brothers guarding a relic.
The relic is a finger bone. The prior claims it belonged to a saint who starved to death.
4. **Hedge-Witch** [WITCHCRAFT] [KNOWLEDGE]
 Knows which bridges eat travelers.
Her price is a story. The story must have a bad ending.
5. **Free Company Captain** [MERCENARY] [FATIGUE]
 Pike and shot between contracts.
He has served three kings this year. He does not remember their names.
6. **River Reeve** [LAW] [CORRUPTION]
 Rents every boat twice.
His paper is a single page folded into a boat. The other half is elsewhere.

7. **Salt-Baron** [TRADE] [VIOLENCE]
 Hired blades; owns the ford and your timetable.
His salt is grey. It was cut with ashes from a burned village.
8. **Blackwood Matriarch** [NOBLE] [VENGEANCE]
 Tends the feud like a garden.
Her garden grows tombstones. She waters them with tears—her enemies’.
9. **Ex-Imperial Surveyor** [KNOWLEDGE] [LONELINESS]
 Has the last accurate map.
The map shows villages that no longer exist. The surveyor visits them anyway.
10. **“King” of Three Villages** [CLAIMANT] [IRON]
 Iron-nail crown, iron-will taxes.
His crown was a plowshare. He reversed the curse.
- J **Bride with No Dowry but a Claim** [CLAIM] [DESPERATION]
 Daggers in the wedding chest.
The claim is to a bridge that drowned. The bride intends to collect.
- Q **Margravine of the Broken March** [AUTHORITY] [FEUD]
 Half saint, half tax roll.
She has never lost a feud. Her tally stick is her sword.
- K **The Lame King** [CLAIMANT] [FATIGUE]
 Traveling throne; makes law by pointing.
His throne is a sedan chair carried by debtors. They owe him everything.
- A **The Cursed Child of Silkstrand** [MYTH] [OMEN]
 A rumor more than a person; her laughter ends sieges.
She is said to be twelve years old. She has been twelve for a century.

(Feud/Levy/Weather/Curse) Peat-fog; all horns sound like someone calling your name. Sudden levy—every traveler pressed for a day’s service. Bridge feud; rival banners drop the chain on your cart.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Peat-Fog** [WEATHER] [FEAR]
 All horns sound like someone calling your name.
The name is not yours. Answer it, and the fog will take you.
3. **Sudden Levy** [AUTHORITY] [TIME]
 Every traveler is pressed for a day’s service.
The levy master has a list. Your name is on it—in fresh ink.
4. **Bridge Feud** [BOUNDARY] [VIOLENCE]
 Rival banners drop the chain on your cart.
The chain was forged from a broken oath. It rattles when liars approach.
5. **Grain Blight** [HARVEST] [FEAR]
 Doubles the tithe; refusal means torches at night.
The blight has a face. It is the face of a tax collector who died hungry.
6. **Scree Slide** [MOUNTAIN] [BLOCKED]
 Seals the pass; the “safe” detour is owned by your enemy.
The enemy raised the toll yesterday. He was expecting you.

7. **Wedding Turns Ambush** [SOCIAL] [TRAP]
 You are caught between two bloodlines.
The bride's veil is a shroud. The groom's ring is a knife.
8. **Witch's Tithe Night** [WITCHCRAFT] [DEBT]
 Lights move in the woods; owe nothing or else.
The lights have voices. They are arguing over who should collect.
9. **Pox Sign** [DISEASE] [ISOLATION]
 On a village gate; your escorts desert you.
The pox is a rumor. The desertion is real.
10. **Condotta Breaks** [MERCENARY] [BETRAYAL]
 The Free Company flips colors mid-march.
The new colors are the same as the old colors. The captain just wanted to raise morale.
- J **Heretic Preacher** [FAITH] [RIOT]
 Sparks a march; toll-gates come down in splinters.
The preacher's text is a tax receipt. He reads it like scripture.
- Q **Imperial Pretender** [CLAIMANT] [POLITICS]
 Arrives; every petty lord changes tabards.
The pretender's seal is a sunburst. The sunburst is slightly crooked.
- K **River Overruns the Levee** [WEATHER] [DESTRUCTION]
 The pontoon goes; your rivals don't.
The river's name is "Debt." It remembers every unpaid crossing.
- A **The Curse Stirrs** [CURSE] [TRAP]
 No matter the road, you return to the same crossroads.
The crossroads has a signpost. The arms are labeled "Regret," "Hunger," "The Same."

(Papers/Claims/Safe-Conduct) Toll-exemption plaque for one bridge (once); monastery letter for bed and bread on a named road.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Toll-Exemption Plaque** [TRAVEL] [ONCE]
 For one bridge (once).
The plaque is a bronze leaf. Hold it up, and the toll-keeper will spit—but step aside.
3. **Monastery Letter** [HOSPITALITY] [ONCE]
 For bed and bread on a named road.
The letter is sealed with a wax tear. The monks will honor it—or they will not.
4. **Wine-Right** [TRADE] [ONGOING]
 On an abandoned terrace; locals will work for shares.
The wine is from a vine that grows over a mass grave. It tastes of iron.
5. **Condotta Contract** [MERCENARY] [ONCE]
 A signed pike contract (one battle on your terms).
The contract is written in blood. The blood is from the captain's own finger.
6. **Tithe-Remission Writ** [AUTHORITY] [ONCE]
 For a village; they owe you a season's labor.
The writ is stamped with a bell. The bell's clapper is a finger bone.

7. **Border-Stone Adjustment** [BOUNDARY] [ONCE]
 Move a line two fields over.
The adjustment is a lie. The truth is that the line was always there.
8. **Pass-Key Charm** [TRAVEL] [ONGOING]
 Recognized by Pale Causeway watchmen.
The charm is a knotted cord. Untie it to pass—or to stay.
9. **Sealed Dowry Chest** [CLAIM] [MYSTERY]
 Of claims, not coin; certain doors open.
The chest is locked with a riddle. The answer is a name you do not know.
10. **Mine-Share** [RESOURCE] [ALLIANCE]
 In the commune; they fight like they mean it.
The share is a pickaxe. The commune will lend you a miner—or a grave.
- J **Blood-Peace Charter** [SOCIAL] [TRUCE]
 Suspend a feud long enough to move your wagons.
The charter is a white ribbon. Blood will not be spilled while it flies—but blood will remember.
- Q **Marriage Proxy** [SOCIAL] [ALLIANCE]
 From the Margravine; bind a hill-king to your cause.
The proxy is a wedding veil. The veil was worn by a ghost.
- K **The Lame King’s Traveling Writ** [AUTHORITY] [ONCE]
 Troops must make way (for now).
The writ is a broken scepter. The Lame King’s seal is a footprint.
- A **Curse-Redemption Rite (Temporary)** [RITUAL] [ONCE]
 For one night, no crossroads can hold you.
The rite is a whisper. The whisper is a name you have never spoken.

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/claims/safe-conducts) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo plague and curse motifs—crossroads that turn back on themselves, bells tolling for no funeral, banners blackened by mildew.

Additional Features

- **Feud as Currency:** Any insult, accident, or rumor can birth a feud; the GM may replace an SB result with a feud-token tied to a petty lord or house. Feud-tokens act as reusable complications: once per scene, the GM can spend a feud-token to have a rival appear, a bridge close, or a village refuse aid.
- **Rot & Tithe:** Each market or harvest scene carries a risk of rot—add a pressure if food or coin are exchanged without a blessing or a seal. A failed roll may double the tithe or spoil stored supplies.
- **The Curse Remembers:** When roads or negotiations stall, the GM may quietly repeat imagery—crossroads, whispers, mildew—to remind players that Acasia itself resists resolution. If the party ignores three such omens, the *Curse Stirrs* complication triggers automatically.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a hospice in a burned abbey. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the charcoalers, trying to untie her cord from a Rothari death warrant.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Pale Causeway is a Class II Anchor site—the ghosts of workers who died building it still carry stones. Saikou Ira would leave a silver coin in every crack.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the toll-collectors. Take it, and your passage is always free—but the coin will taste of blood every time the Causeway floods.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Acasian psions are called “Feud-Readers.” They taste the weight of old grudges in the water. The Margravine employs two—and has never trusted a settlement they didn’t whisper.
- **The Ninth:** In any Acasian scene, the ninth toll paid at a bridge is never the last. The wise pay eight and barter for the ninth.

Acasian Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Milestone:** Crumble a crust at a broken milestone. Ignore the first *Peat-Fog* penalty.
- **Knot the Contract:** Tie a single knot in a writ’s ribbon. Cancel *Bridge Feud* or take –1 die on your next negotiation (your choice).
- **Name to the Blight:** Whisper a dead tax collector’s name into a grain sack. Gain +1 Effect when avoiding tithes this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Margravine.

Decline & Patronage

Patronage here is as brittle as candle wax. The Rothari Clan holds their marches by fear and iron law—patronage from them is real, but cruel, demanding service in blood or levy. Elsewhere, noble names are little more than titles printed on parchment and sold like promises. The Margravine keeps a tally of feuds, binding bloodlines to her feast days, while mercenary captains trade loyalty for coin, switching colors with each bell.

To seek a patron in Acasia is to choose which hunger you will feed: the Rothari’s iron teeth, a Free Company’s purse, or the hollow blessing of a saint who may never have lived. Yet even false crowns cast shadows long enough to shelter those desperate enough to kneel.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **tithe-collectors or petty lords**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **Free Company patrols or village watchmen**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **feud-trackers or hedge-witches**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable road conditions**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** River reeve or Free Company captain becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **fog or bridge closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A rival bloodline or toll-lord’s enforcer arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **feud-kin, Free Company deserters, or Margravine’s** guards arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **contract voided/levy doubled/curse triggered**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** Margravine, **Lame King, or Cursed Child** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **fog thickens/bridge falls/curse loops**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Acasia (Feud & Tithe):** Toll collectors demand double, bloodlines take offense, wagons are seized as “payment.”
- **Acasia (Rot & Famine):** Grain blights spread, wells run dry, abandoned villages hold only ghosts.
- **Acasia (Curse & Crossroads):** Roads loop back, milestones point the wrong way, the same bridge appears twice.

Boss Archetypes in Acasia

- **The False King (Feud/Authority)** — A petty lord or pretender who crowns themselves on the ruins of empire. *Phases:* Levy Demanded → Feud Declared → Hasty Coronation. *Cracks:* a **Blood-Peace Charter** suspends his authority; a **Marriage Proxy** binds him to a rival.
- **The Witch of the Blackwoods (Witchcraft/Curse)** — A hedge-witch, matriarch, or revenant who manipulates feuds and curses. *Phases:* Tithe of Fear → Curse of the Crossroads → Hollow Wedding. *Cracks:* a **Curse-Redemption Rite** breaks her hold; a **Mine-Share** gives the commune courage to defy her.

- **The Tithe Collector (Greed/Extortion)** — A bureaucrat-priest with writs, escorts, and the ability to summon feuds or famine with a single decree. *Phases*: Audit of Souls → Seizure of Grain → The Reckoning. *Cracks*: a **Toll-Exemption Plaque** voids his claim; a **Wine-Right** buys off his debtors.
- **The Rotting Child (Mystery/Curse)** — A folkloric horror tied to Acasia's plague of false crossroads. *Phases*: Laughter in the Fog → The Bridge That Loops → The Feast of Ends. *Cracks*: a **Tithe-Remission Writ** fed to the fog; a **Monastery Letter** read aloud at the crossroads.

Encounter Seeds (Quick Hooks)

- **The Dowry That Walked:** A Blackwood matriarch's dowry chest has been stolen. The chest contains a claim to a bridge that never floods—and a curse that the Margravine wants broken.
- **The Lame King's Feast:** The Lame King invites the party to a feast. The feast is a trial. The food is memory. The wine is lies.
- **The Curse of the Pale Causeway:** The Causeway is repeating. Every crossing brings the party back to the same inn. The innkeeper is missing a finger. She says she gave it to the bridge.

Chapter 6

Vhasia

The Fractured Sun. A kingdom split between rival crowns, Vhasia’s chevauchée raids and parlement intrigues echo the twilight of empire. The Pont-du-Tithe is blessed by competing bishops, and the Last Dauphin is a rumor with a birthmark. Here legitimacy is a weapon, and every seal can be forged—or denied.

6.1 Vhasia — “The Fractured Sun”

Cardinal-Regent of the Broken Sun (Elite): “The sun may be fractured, but our authority is absolute within our domains. Every coin minted here carries our blessing, and every law written bears our seal – the rest is just politics.”

Road Warden (Commoner): “I’ve served under three different banners on this same stretch of road, and the only constant is that someone always wants to collect tolls. My horn calls honest warning – best heed it. The Fenwoods burned Lence, and now every duke with a coin purse thinks he’s king.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Vhasia is a realm of broken coronations and split loyalties. Once a proud province of the Utaran empire, the unified Sun-court shattered like its heraldic sunburst when the Fenwoods of Viterra and their allies sacked the capital of Lence and cast down the old Blood line. Now rival dukes, duchesses, abbesses, and parlements claim the fractured light. Everywhere, signs of fracture: chipped sun-discs on milestones, worn tabards bearing half a crown, coins minted in rival cities with different suns. In Vhasia, legitimacy is as fragile as a mirror, and every oath risks breaking along the fault lines of politics, faith, and fortune.

What you notice first: The smell of old smoke and fresh ink. The way every noble’s seal has a hairline crack. The constant, nervous laughter of courtiers who remember whose head rolled last season.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never carry a coin that bears only one sunburst. The realm has three mints, and the wrong metal on the wrong road is treason.

Regional Mood: Crowns, Courts, and Companies

Here, the past is a weapon and the future is a debt. The Fenwoods came from Viterra with fire and iron, broke the Sun-king’s army at the Ford of Ashes, and burned Lence until the mirrors melted.

They left the throne empty—not destroyed, but open. Now every duke with a long purse and a short conscience backs a claimant. The Queen-Mother weaves alliances from her riverside keep. The Two Crowns—rival dukes crowned in rival cathedrals—march their levies through fields that can feed neither. Routiers sell their swords by the season, and parlement clerks drown justice in procedure. Vhasia is not a nation at war. It is a nation that forgot how to be at peace.

Starting Location: The Pont-du-Tithe, its golden arches catching fire in the sunset as pilgrims chant from both banks. A Duchy Constable in splendid armor guards the toll gate. “The Chevauchee burns,” he says, gesturing to distant smoke. “Two Crowns march to meet it. Whose seal do you carry? Speak quickly—the levy waits for no one.”

Prominent NPCs of Vhasia

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Eliador Everblood	Queen-Mother (née Longblood) of Ethon	Restore her son Valdais to the throne	She has outlived three husbands and two sons; she is not mourning.
Valdais Longblood	Duke of Adria, claimant to the Sun-court	Unite Vhasia under a strong northern crown	He has never lost a joust. His opponents have a habit of falling ill before the tilt.
The Red Marshal	Exiled commander of the Sun-court’s army	Win back Lence or die trying	He lost the Battle of Ashes; he still sees it in his dreams—and his nightmares.
Seint Michel’s Justiciar	Magistrate of the Order of the Gilded Scale	Enforce the chivalric code without mercy	He carries a scale with one pan empty; the empty pan is for lies.
Sister Oria	Custodian of the Lantern-Rites House on the Belworth	Keep the rites of hospitality and witness	She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to.
The Cantor Alain	Iron Bard, bearer of the Cracked Ring	Sing the truth of Corin’s mercy before the armor closes again	Feathers grow from his temples; his shadow moves a half-step behind him.

Names of Vhasia

Inspired by the fractured duchies: Francien, Norman, and Brittonic influences. Soft vowels, silent consonants, and surnames that recall a bridge, a ford, or a stained banner.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Valdais	Eliador	de la Marche	<i>the Iron</i>
Renaud	Isabeau	de Lence	<i>the Unbuckled</i>
Corin	Oria	d’Aethor	<i>Bell-Sworn</i>
Touénot	Mael	du Pont	<i>the Silver</i>
Alain	Giselle	de la Croix	<i>Ash-Banner</i>
Ghiro	Celandine	l’Argent	<i>the Unpaid</i>

Spades — Places

(Château/Cathedral/Forest) Wayside shrine with pilgrims tacking petitions to a scorched sun-disc; vine-terraced clos above a millstream with napping watchmen.

2. **Wayside Shrine** — Pilgrims tack petitions to a scorched sun-disc; each parchment curls in different winds. *The petitions are never answered. The shrine is a mailbox for the dead.*
 3. **Vine-Terrace** — Clos above a millstream; watchmen nap, halberds traded for bottles. *The best vintage is called “Crownbreaker.” It tastes like smoke and regret.*
 4. **Bastide Square** — Neat as a checkerboard; merchants pay homage to different “hours” of the Sun. *The square has a gallows. It rotates to face whichever claimant lost the last duel.*
 5. **Royal Forest** — Antler posts mark laws no king remembers; poachers still hang. *The forest’s deer have grown bold. They wear crowns of shed antlers.*
 6. **Pont-du-Tithe** — Toll-bridge flanked by chapels and crossbows; chains blessed by rival bishops. *The chains were forged from melted sunbursts. They ring in different keys.*
 7. **Great Fair** — Outside a chartered town; counting sheds ring like bells, rumors louder still. *The fair has a Court of Miracles where counterfeiters sell to informers.*
 8. **Salt Pans** — Wind-pumps on an estuary; gulls own the law, smugglers own the night. *The salt is grey. It tastes of old tears and older debts.*
 9. **Siege-Château** — Hoardings patched, cistern low, banners cut into ragged suns. *The banner’s ragged edges are from a Fenwood sword. The owner still limps.*
 10. **Cathedral Yard** — Cranes creak, stones fly, scaffolds bristle with rival masons’ marks. *The mason’s marks are clan signs. A scratched-out mark means a dead foreman.*
- J **Parlement Hall** — Hung with faded tapestries; sunbursts spliced and re-stitched by claimants. *The tapestries show battles that never happened—and some that shouldn’t have.*
- Q **Queen’s Causeway** — Mile-long oath paved in quarried stone; half-sunk each spring. *The sunken half is a graveyard for vows. The stones are slippery with old lies.*
- K **Sun Palace (Lence)** — Shattered mirrors, brambled gardens; courtiers playing at kingship. *The mirrors were covered after the sack. No one wants to see what they show now.*
- A **King’s High Road** — Milestones chipped of crowns; yet every army still marches it. *The road is paved with the bones of tax collectors. They are not missed.*

Hearts — People & Factions

(**Lord/Court/Company**) Road warden with dented badge and honest horn; vintner-guild syndic counting saints' days as credit terms.

2. **Road Warden** — Dented badge, honest horn; ignored by both crowns but knows the roads. *His horn is cracked. It still sounds—but the note is always half a step flat.*
3. **Vintner Syndic** — Counts saints' days as credit terms, vintages as treaties; wine as diplomacy. *He keeps a bottle of Crownbreaker in every cellar. He knows which vintage each duke prefers.*
4. **Abbess-Chatelaine** — Rules a fortress-convent with iron accounts and sharper scripture. *She has never drawn a blade. The scaffold has, on her orders.*
5. **Routier Captain** — Scarred and mercenary; prefers ransoms to loyalty; coin as conscience. *He switches banners as often as his shirt. His loyalty is to the paychest—and his mother.*
6. **Duchy Constable** — Splendid armor, empty coffers, pride swollen as a banner; glory over gold. *His armor was his grandfather's. It still has the dent from a Fenwood axe.*
7. **Parlement Clerk** — Drowns foes in procedure, fishes them out for fealty; law as a weapon. *His quill is a dagger. He sharpens it every morning.*
8. **Salt-Farmer** — Gabelle lessee with cudgels, writs, and a river-chart no crown has; tax as tyranny. *His ledger is written in salt. One drop of water and the debts vanish—along with the evidence.*
9. **Trouvère** — A scandalous lay about the last Sun-king brings knives to tavern doors. *He sings the truth. That is why he sleeps in a different inn every night.*
10. **Marshal-Exile** — The Sun-court's hammer; now wielded by whoever pays in silver. *He lost the Battle of Ashes. He still sees it in his dreams—and his nightmares.*
- J **Heretic Perfect** — Preaches peace while tucking hidden daggers into parchment margins. *His sermon is a code. The psalms tell you which bridge to cross—and which to burn.*
- Q **Queen-Mother** — Riverside keep; weaves alliances as if they were dowers. *She has outlived three husbands and two sons. She is not mourning.*
- K **Two Crowns** — Rival dukes, each "crowned" in rival cathedrals, neither whole. *One wears a crown of iron. The other wears a crown of words. Both rust.*
- A **Last Dauphin** — A rumor with a birthmark; armies march for whispers alone. *He may be a baker's son. The armies don't care. They need a sun to follow.*

Clubs — Complications/Threats

(**Chevauchée/Law/Church**) Chevauchée burning loyalty oaths as well as barns; smoke curls like scripture. Interdict falls on a county; bells silenced, trade stalls.

2. **Chevauchée** [WAR] [RAID] — Raiders burn loyalty oaths as well as barns; smoke curls like scripture. *The raiders wear no colors. Their horses answer to whistles—and grudges.*
3. **Interdict** [RELIGIOUS] [LEGAL] — Falls on a county; bells silenced, trade stalls, heretics prosper. *The bells were melted for shot three wars ago. The silence is old.*
4. **Forest Law** [LEGAL] [HUNT] — Venison becomes treason; poachers hang from antler posts. *The antler posts are carved with the names of the hanged. They whisper at dusk.*
5. **River Spate** [WEATHER] [DELAY] — Ferries chained, bridges drowned, pilgrims stranded mid-prayer. *The water is the color of old gold. It washed away a mint last spring.*

6. **Coin Debasement** [ECONOMY] [LEGAL] — Three mints, three suns, no trust; soldiers demand silver alone. *The silver is from the same mine—but the stamp is a prayer, not a promise.*
7. **Parlement Divided** [LEGAL] [POLITICS] — A siege laid on parchment before walls; war by paperwork. *The clerks duel with citations. The loser pays the winner’s ink bill.*
8. **Company Mutiny** [WAR] [MERCENARY] — Unless arrears are paid—in blood or coin; mercenaries as a time bomb. *The mutineers have a list. Your name is on it—or will be by nightfall.*
9. **Relic Dispute** [RELIGIOUS] [LEGAL] — Two abbeys claim the same saint’s bones; mobs answer with stones. *The bones are actually from a cow. The saints don’t mind. They like the attention.*
10. **Harvest Blight** [ECONOMY] [WEATHER] — Bread locked behind pikes; bakers guarded as lords. *The blight has a name. It is the name of a duke who raised the levy too late.*
- J **Tournament “Accident”** [CHIVALRY] [ASSASSINATION] — Hides an assassination; your favor is now evidence. *The lance was filed with a prayer. The prayer was answered—but not for the target.*
- Q **Royalist Restoration** [POLITICS] [FEAR] — Sunburst badges painted overnight on doors and graves. *The paint is the color of dried blood. The badges face the wrong direction.*
- K **Feudal Levy** [WAR] [LEGAL] — Lords demand levies in days, not months, with three days’ bread. *The bread is hardtack from the last Fenwood siege. It still smells of smoke.*
- A **Winter Campaign** [WEATHER] [WAR] — Roads turn to mud, hooves to ice, armies to ruin. *The snow is grey with ash. The Pass of Ashes has a sister pass now.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

(**Charter/Patent/Right**) Safe-conduct sealed by a duke or abbey; honored only once, on one road; burgess charter for a market ward.

2. **Safe-Conduct** *The seal is cracked. The road is watched. Use it before the seal breaks.*
3. **Burgess Charter** *The charter is a bell. Ring it, and the town answers—or it doesn’t.*
4. **Bridge Farm** — Tolls at Pont-du-Tithe for a season, if you can hold it. *The tollkeepers are loyal to the last coin. Yours or theirs.*
5. **Paréage Charter** — Shared rule with a monastery—half justice, half rent, no peace. *The monks pray for you. They also pray for your enemies. Balance.*
6. **Wardship** — Over a minor heir; lands obey you “for now.” *The heir has a knife. He knows how to use it. He learned from watching you.*
7. **Gabelle Lease** — Salt-tax rights; lucrative, hated, and dangerous. *The lease is a death warrant written in profit. Cash it wisely.*
8. **Letters Patent** — Raise a free-company under your banner; an army as a business. *The letters are signed in blood—yours or the notary’s. Both are valid.*
9. **Remission** — Of feudal dues for a village; they’ll march when called. *The village has a long memory. They remember the last lord who promised mercy.*
10. **Low-Justice** — Grant (stocks, fines, gallows) in a troublesome hamlet. *The gallows rope is new. The notches are from the last hamlet.*
- J **Confiscation Writ** — Against a royalist estate—if you can seize it first. *The writ is a race. The other claimant rides a faster horse.*

- Q Queen’s Audience** — Private with the Queen-Mother; a whisper becomes policy. *The audience is a chess game. She always wins—but she lets you take a pawn.*
- K Sunburst Warrant** — Of the fallen court—most still bow if shown boldly. *The warrant is a ghost. It has no power—only the power of belief.*
- A General Pardon** — Temporary: rebels absolved if they bend the knee. *The pardon is a spring. It will close when the season turns.*

Quick Use Notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (charters/patents/rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **fractured sun** motifs—light that splinters, oaths that crack like glass.

Additional Features

Fractured Seals: When brandishing a writ, badge, or charter tied to a Sun-court claimant, step Position up one step for the scene’s next interaction at a gate, court, or checkpoint. Each use advances a **Legitimacy** [4] clock linked to the claimant; when it fills, rivals challenge the authority on sight.

Parlement Games: If a scene touches petitions, guild disputes, or feudal appeals, the first Diamond played becomes a policy lever: treat it as two Diamonds toward swaying a decision or rewriting a custom. Afterward, start or advance a **Whispered Precedent** clock; when it fills, backlash spreads as other courts cite the case against you.

Gabelle Knife-Edge: At bridges, fairs, or salt depots, convert Diamonds tied to tolls, leases, or safe-conducts into immediate passage or tariff relief for the company (no roll). Each conversion ticks a **Resentment** [4] clock for the locale; when it completes, expect boycotts, ambush rumors, or an audit by rival officials.

Vhasian Chivalry & the Round of Five Virtues: The knights of the western cantons (Ethor, Adria) follow the Round of Five Virtues: **Courage, Courtesy, Mercy, Prowess, Truth**. In a formal joust or a legal duel, the GM may award *Victory by Virtue* rather than by blood: the combatant with the higher Virtue score wins the dispute, even if they lost the physical exchange. This is the law of the tilt—and the law of the court.

The Armor Closes / The Song Escapes (Chivalric Clocks): The Cantor Alain, bearer of the Cracked Ring, sings a warning at every tourney:

- **Armor Closes** [6] – advances when knights choose protection over mercy, when gorgets are buckled tight, when chivalry becomes siege mentality. When full, the cantons close their borders and the raids become wars.
- **Song Escapes** [8] – advances when a Cantor sings the truth, when mercy is shown, when armour is unbuckled. When full, a moment of genuine connection occurs—though it may be fatal.

In Rouen, Alain still sings the *Planctus Armatus* each spring, and the congregation weeps for Sir Corin, who unbuckled his gorget to hear a thief’s voice and was undone by the mercy he offered.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Seint Michel, the Judge of the Scar (Mykkiel):** The Order of the Gilded Scale maintains the *Chivalric Ledger*—a record of every oath sworn and broken in the cantons. A page torn from this ledger can serve as a single-use Claim String (gain +1 Position in any court). The Order’s justiciars are feared and respected; they never unbuckle their gorgets, and they have never lost a case. The Queen-Mother keeps a copy in her riverside keep, wrapped in a grey shroud.
- **Seint Isabeau, Who Slumbers Amongst the Lilies (Ikasha):** In the Ethorian marches, knights whisper prayers to Seint Isabeau when they long to set aside their steel. Her shrine is a hawthorn grove where armour must be left at the gate. Pilgrims who enter bare-skinned and speak a true regret find that their next wound heals in a single night—but they dream of a woman in white who asks, “Will you remember how to be touched?” Those who return to the grove a second time are never seen again.
- **Seint Evroul of the Cairn (Mor’iraath):** In the high passes of the Ethorian marches, a rusted knight in an unopened helm haunts the old barrows. He is the patron of those who carry a blood-debt and cannot rest. To call upon him, one must pour a cup of salt water at a cairn and name the wrong done to your house. He will witness one blow; if it lands, the foe is *Marked by the Cairn*—any spirit may locate them for a year. If it misses, the blow turns inward. The Marshal-Exile carries a scar from such a bargain; he does not speak of it.
- **The Order of the Sunken Cup (The Hospice of the Broken Blade):** A grey-robed hospice in the ruins of Lence treats the wounded of both crowns. They ask no payment, but they record every name in a ledger that never dries. The Restorationists suspect they are spies for the Queen-Mother; the Two Crowns accuse them of erasing debts. Sister Oria, the hospice’s custodian, is also the keeper of the Lantern-Rites House on the Belworth—neutral ground where even claimants must leave their blades at the door.
- **The Ninth:** In any Vhasian court, the ninth citation of precedent voids all previous. The wise stop at eight and settle. Those who cite the ninth are said to hear a faint laughter from the marble walls—and their cases are never heard again.

Vhasian Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Sun:** Crumble a crust onto a cracked sun-disc. Ignore the first *Chevauchée* penalty.
- **Knot the Seal:** Tie a single knot in a charter’s ribbon. Cancel *Parlement Divided* or take –1 die on your next legal argument (your choice).
- **Name to the Salt:** Whisper a dead claimant’s name into a salt pan. Gain +1 Effect when collecting debts from their faction this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Queen-Mother.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Rival officials or court guards take notice.

- **Noise:** Parlement clerks or routier patrols are alerted.
- **Trace:** Trackers or tax collectors mark your route.
- **Delay:** A setback costs time or a favourable legal window.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant resource clock.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** A duchy constable or abbess-chatelaine begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** Legal challenge or road closure costs you advantage.
- **Foe Appears:** A rival claimant or free-company arrives.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes Compromised/Neglected.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional routiers, parlement guards, or ducal forces arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool or weapon becomes unusable.
- **Major Twist:** A writ is voided, an interdict declared, or a levy called.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark Fatigue 1/Harm 1 or an appropriate Condition.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates fully.
- **Authority Arrival:** The Two Crowns, Queen-Mother, or Marshal-Exile intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** A chevauchée hits, the river floods, or the parlement erupts.
- **Patron Omen:** An omen appears, a blessing is lost, or a curse manifests.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Fractured Authority:** Seals break mid-signing, legal papers rewrite themselves, badges refuse honour.
- **Legal Warfare:** Court decisions reverse, precedents are cited against you, writs expire prematurely.
- **Sun Symbolism:** Sun-discs crack underfoot, light splits into contradictory shadows, oaths shatter like glass.

Patronage & Power

In Vhasia, power flows through the remnants of imperial authority, fractured legitimacy, and the careful manipulation of legal and religious institutions. Former Utaran provincial structures still provide a framework for governance, but competing claimants to the Sun-court have created a complex web of overlapping jurisdictions and conflicting loyalties. The true power lies with those who can navigate this legal maze and maintain the appearance of legitimate authority.

For the GM: Patronage in Vhasia revolves around legitimacy, legal documents, and the ability to command respect from institutions that no longer have a clear central authority. Rewards often take the form of charters, writs, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, badges, writs) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival claimants issue conflicting authorities, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the parlements, cathedrals, and châteaux as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success.

In Vhasia, your papers are your power, and your power determines whether you rule or are ruled.

The Vacant Throne & Campaign Clocks

For long-form political campaigns:

- **Vacant Throne Clock [10]:** Advances when a claimant gains a major advantage (battle, noble defection, foreign alliance). Retreats when the party brokers a truce or exposes a weakness. When full, a claimant takes Lence and declares themselves king.
- **Armor Closes [6]:** Advances when knights choose protection over mercy, when gorgets are buckled tight, when chivalry becomes siege mentality. When full, the cantons close their borders and the raids become wars.
- **Song Escapes [8]:** Advances when a Cantor sings the truth, when mercy is shown, when armour is unbuckled. When full, a moment of genuine connection occurs—though it may be fatal.
- **Claimant’s Coup (per claimant):** A 6-clock that advances when that claimant wins a Parlement vote, a joust, or a skirmish. When full, they march on Lence.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Red Marshal (Exiled Sun-court hammer)** — *Phases:* Chevauchee Call → Banner Turn → Lists to War. *Cracks:* Letters Patent buys one round of obedience; General Pardon lets a unit stand down.
- **Cardinal-Regent of the Broken Sun (scarlet gloves)** — *Phases:* Interdict Blade → Seal Both Ways → Confessional Leak. *Cracks:* Queen’s Audience cancels Interdict Blade once; a Synod Indulgence treats a church check as controlled for one scene.
- **The Parlement Spider (chief clerk; quills like daggers)** — *Phases:* Motion to Delay → Counter-Citation → Filed at Dawn. *Cracks:* Sunburst Warrant opens a “royal window”; a

Burgess Charter lets a town court overrule once locally.

- **The Two Crowns (rival dukes)** — *Phases*: Contradictory Edicts → Levy in Hours → Coin Trial. *Cracks*: Sunburst Warrant + public mass unites them for one scene; General Pardon calms levy unrest once.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- **Tournament Ordeal (Bastide Square)** — Declare Purse, Patent, or Pardon as stakes. Win to cash a matching $\diamond$; *loseandspawnTournament* “Accident”.
- **Cathedral Scaffold Assize** — Argue law atop creaking beams; each good point moves Position up; each slip marks Exposure. A *Paréage Charter* lets you call a recess once.
- **Pont-du-Tithe Vigil** — Keep the bridge peaceful through dusk: clear 3 segments on *Bridge Peace* by feeding pilgrims, quieting relic zeal, and paying one tithe from your purse.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Legitimacy Dial (Claimant $\leftrightarrow$ Neutrality)**: Track the party’s public stance.
 - *Claimant High*: +1 Position when invoking seals, warrants, or feudal rights; first parley with a rival claimant starts one step worse.
 - *Neutrality High*: +1 Effect when brokering truces or smuggling between factions; first petition to a court or cathedral starts one step worse.
 - Center the dial by paying weight to both sides or hosting a neutral moot.
- **Parlement Mini-Game (legal duel)**:
 - Lay three counters: *Precedent*, *Equity*, *Force*.
 - Argue a point (roll Lore + Sway vs. DV 3). On a hit, move one counter to your side. On a miss, the clerk gains *Citation Edge*.
 - Win two counters to secure a temporary *Parlement Ruling* (treat as a Diamond for one scene).
 - *Spider’s Interjection* (2 SB): flip Precedent, but start *Whispered Precedent* [2].
- **Chevauchée Pressure (raid clock)**:
 - Two opposed clocks: *Outrun the Fire* vs *Scorched Earth* (size by highest rank in seed).
 - Each leg, choose *High Road* (fast, exposed), *Bypass* (slow, hidden), or *Ford* (risky, shortcut).
 - Advantage: Bypass → High Road (cover), Ford → Bypass (speed), High Road → Ford (navigation).
 - Spend a *Watch-Code* (from Three-Fires Ridge) to shift one segment from Scorched Earth to Outrun.
- **Favor of the Sun (prestige track)**:
 - Earn by resolving disputes between claimants without bloodshed, or by returning stolen relics.
 - At 3 Favor, treat one *Safe-Conduct* or *Sunburst Warrant* as unquestioned for a scene.
 - Each use after the first advances *Legitimacy Challenge* [4] against that claimant.
- **Start-of-Scene Omens (1d6)**:

1. *Cracked Bell*: first legal action gains +1d; first boast draws *Parlement Divided*.
2. *Smoke on the Ridge*: Chevauchée advances once; shortcuts open.
3. *Three Suns*: three claimants claim the same road; pick a side or start *Coin Debasement*.
4. *Queen’s Dove*: a message arrives; +1d on the next *Queen’s Audience* attempt.
5. *Salt Wind*: *Gabelle Lease* counts double value today; smugglers’ ears open.
6. *Routier Campfire*: mercenaries are hireable for one scene at half price—but they’ll ask questions later.

- **Plug-in SB Conversions (Vhasia Flavor):**

- 1 SB → *Seal Crack*: a writ loses half its value until re-witnessed.
- 2 SB → *Citation War*: increase DV by 1 unless you produce a precedent (spend a *◊orrecallapastruling*).
- 3+ SB → *Crown Fracture*: the claimant’s legitimacy splits; halve a consequence by accepting a rival’s seal on your paper (start *Legitimacy Challenge*).

- **Reputation Echoes:**

- *Court-Favored*: once/session, downgrade *Parlement Divided* to a minor delay; the next document you present is scrutinized (+1 DV).
- *Chevauchée-Tested*: +1 Position when evading raids; supply lines run 1 segment longer.
- *Neutral Broker*: +1d with both claimants in a truce scene; any betrayal earns *Resentment* [2] from both sides.

- **Cross-Region Hooks (quick integration):**

- *Thepyrgos Synod Leak*: a *Synod Indulgence* can suspend a Vhasian interdict—but starts *Whispered Precedent* in Thepyrgos.
- *Ubral Feud Echo*: paying wergild to a Vhasian claimant instead of a clan starts *Feud Rekindled* along the border roads.
- *Kahfagia Salt War*: cashing a *Gabelle Lease* to outbid corsair lanes adds *Market Knives* [4] in Silkstrand or on the coastal quays.
- *Valewood Relic Interest*: a relic from a Vhasian cathedral may be claimed by fae courts; a Diamond spent on relic control may instead draw *Court Tithe*.

Chapter 7

Viterra

The Hedge-Law Realm. Viterra breathes with the careful rhythm of precedent and petition. The Warrior Queen rules through legal precision as much as military might. Every hedge-row, every parish stone, every ferry crossing carries the weight of custom older than memory. In Viterra, a well-placed document can open doors that armies cannot breach.

7.1 Viterra — “The Hedge-Law Realm”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Every hedge is a boundary. Every boundary is a claim. Every claim is a blade.*

Warrior Queen (Elite): “Every hedge here marks not just a boundary but a principle — the careful balance between order and freedom, justice and mercy. Our law grows like the hedges themselves, tended with precision and patience. But a hedge that is not defended is only a suggestion.”

Fen Reeve (Commoner): “The dikes hold back more than water — they hold back chaos. Every rod measured, every stone placed, keeps the flood from washing away not just our fields but our very way of life. And across the Belworth? The Vhasians still claim our hedges are theirs. Let them try. We have lawyers. We have swords. Sometimes they are the same people.”

Genre / Mood: Legal warfare, post-imperial consolidation, border adventurism.

Starting Location: The Hall of Dawning tilt-yard at first light. Dawn-knights drill in armor polished like mirrors. Beside them, advocates rehearse arguments with the same intensity. A Queen’s Justiciar slides a parchment across an oaken rail. “Three charters, one road across the Belworth. The Vhasian claimant says the bridge is theirs. The local reeve says it’s crown land. The abbey says it’s a pilgrimage, not a toll. Carry the Queen’s writ, break the Quiet Tolls, and make them agree — by clause or by cut.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Viterra breathes with the careful rhythm of precedent and petition. Once a proud kingdom before becoming a Utaran province, it is now reborn under a new Warrior Queen who rules by legal precision as much as military might. The realm's true sinews lie not in steel but in writs, charters, and the ancient rights that bind lord to tenant, crown to county, and church to common. Every hedge-row, every parish stone, every ferry crossing carries the weight of custom older than memory.

But Viterra is also a kingdom of restless ambition — a young queen still testing the limits of her authority, with old dukes who remember when they ruled their own marches and a border that has never been truly settled. Northward, the Ubral highlands reject any crown but their own moots, watching for a chance to rekindle old feuds. Southward, the City of a Thousand Stairs — Thepyrgos — sends clerks and spies, testing the edges of Viterran jurisdiction with every disputed toll. Westward, across the Belworth River, lie the fractured cantons of Vhasia, where Viterran dukes hold ancient claims to estates and abbeys — claims that have fueled decades of raiding, ransom, and legal warfare. And in the Dolmis, the isles of Theona pledge nominal fealty but keep their own taboos, a constant tug between crown law and green custom.

Viterra is not a nation at peace. It is a realm that wages law as war, and war as law. The Queen's Peace is not a promise — it is a contract, renewed each morning by every magistrate, every justicar, every clerk who opens a ledger. And the ink is still wet on many pages.

What you notice first: The smell of damp parchment and fresh ink. The clatter of writ-runners' boots on cobblestones. The way every noble's hand rests on a seal ring — and every commoner's hand rests on a hatchet.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never cross the Belworth without a charter recognized on both banks. Viterran law and Vhasian claim fight every crossing, and the river takes the losers.

Regional Mood: Hedge, Crown, and Claim

Here, law is a blade. The Warrior Queen rules from Valora, her throne a bench of precedents. She is young, untested, and surrounded by counselors who mistake caution for loyalty. The old Fenwood dukes — whose ancestors sacked Lence and left the Vhasian Sun-court fractured — still hold vast estates in the northern marches, and their claims across the Belworth keep the border smoking like a low fire. Every spring, the Queen's justiciars ride west with warrants and escorts, demanding homage from villages that have paid Vhasian tithes for a generation. Every autumn, Vhasian routiers raid the grain convoys, and the legal duels that follow are fought with steel and citation alike. The border is not a line on a map. It is an argument. And the Queen intends to win it.

North, the Ubral clans watch from their cairns, ready to rekindle feuds if a Viterran levy crosses the passes. South, Thepyrgos sends clerks and spies, testing the edges of Viterran jurisdiction with every disputed toll. And in Theona, the Three Greens mumble old curses while Viterran bailiffs try to count their cattle — and always miscount by one. The Queen's rule is not yet secure. Every charter she signs is a challenge. Every justiciar she sends is a declaration. Every duel fought in her name is a step toward a throne that is still being carved.

Prominent NPCs of Viterra

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Queen Veralyn Everblood	Warrior Queen of Viterra	Consolidate her rule and reclaim the crown’s authority	Her crown has no jewels — only seals; each seal is a conquered claim.
Justiciar Elodie Venn	Queen’s Justiciar	Enforce the law without fear or favour	She has never lost a legal duel; her opponents tend to fall down stairs.
Baron Aldric	Disgraced turncloak	Restore his lost honour through loyal service	He was stripped of his lands for oath-breaking; now he haunts the northern marches.
Ser Roran	Knight of the Queen’s household	Remind himself that a stranger’s coin bought his life	He wears a silver gauntlet over his left hand; he never takes ransom.
Fen Reeve Cuthbert	Keeper of the dike guilds	Protect the fens from flood and the Queen’s tax men	His tally-rod has notches from three floods; the next notch will be from a Vhasian raid.
Master Advocate Halric	Legal duelist and scholar	Win the Great Law Day and retire undefeated	He has argued cases in three kingdoms and won all using their own precedents.
Sister Oria	Custodian of the Lantern-Rites House (Belworth)	Keep the rites of hospitality and witness on the border	She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to.

Names of Viterra

Inspired by Tudor England and early modern Britain: strong consonants, soft vowels, and surnames that recall a hedge, a dike, or a parish.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Veralyn	Elodie	Everblood	<i>the Law-Giver</i>
Cuthbert	Aldric	Fenwood	<i>the Unbuckled</i>
Roran	Halric	of the Scar	<i>Bell-Sworn</i>
Constano	Oria	de la Marche	<i>the Hedge-Wise</i>
Touénot	Mael	l'Argent	<i>the Silent</i>
Ghiro	Celandine	Riven	<i>Ash-Banner</i>

(Reeve/Guild/Knight/Legal Advocate) Fen reeve with tally-rod speaking for dike guilds; river-carter syndic moving grain faster than rumor; justices of the peace settling disputes with careful pen; master advocates who duel with words and swords.

Spades — Places

2. **Fen Causeway** — Stile with toll-rod and eel carts queueing; each reeve claims right to collect under a different charter. Dueling advocates argue cases on makeshift platforms. '[LAW]'; '[TRADE]'; *The causeway sinks an inch each year. The lawyers argue over whose fault that is.*
3. **Hedgerow Green** — In the Dales; bows strung under apple trees where justices of the peace hold court beneath makeshift arbors. Court duels permitted for matters of honor. '[LAW]'; '[COMBAT]'; *The apple tree is called "the Hanging Judge." Its fruit tastes of iron.*
4. **Beacon Hill** — Above the Highlands; fire-grate still warm from last winter's levy call, signal tower with semaphore arms for legal dispatches and military alerts. '[AUTHORITY]'; '[TRAVEL]'; *The hill has three beacons. One for Ubral raids, one for Vhasian incursions, one for paperwork.*
5. **Belworth Stairs** — Ferry ledgers gone damp with river-mist; three manors claim toll rights, writs in three different hands. Legal challenges fought in boats while waiting. '[LAW]'; '[TRAVEL]'; *The stairs were repaired last year. The Vhasian side uses a different measurement.*
6. **Bloom Quarry** — Old iron-bloom turned drill yard; hammer echoes carry, forge-reeve holds tally of crown contracts. Military contracts awarded through legal bidding wars. '[CRAFT]'; '[AUTHORITY]'; *The forge-reeve has never lost a contract. His opponents have a habit of finding better jobs elsewhere.*
7. **Parish Maze** — Stone maze where three maps disagree; hedge-priest's vote decides who pays tithe and who holds freehold. Legal disputes settled by navigating the maze correctly. '[LAW]'; '[RIDDLE]'; *The maze changes at night. The hedge-priest says that's God's will.*
8. **Fairport Works** — Tideworks at the Dolmis mouth; customs writs in three languages flutter, inspectors with magnifying glasses examine every manifest. Maritime law enforcement includes boarding actions. '[TRADE]'; '[AUTHORITY]'; *One language is Utaran, one is Linn, one is for the smugglers.*
9. **Law Quarter** — Valora archives, oath-rooms, Hall of Dawning where precedent is birthed in ink and sealed with wax. Adjacent training grounds for legal advocates. '[LAW]'; '[KNOWL-]

EDGE]‘ *The archives have a locked wing. The key is a legal argument no one has won.*

10. **Counting Fields** — Tarlington beside muster ground; wagons load, ledgers mis-sum, auditors with quill-pens and suspicious eyes. Military mustering follows strict legal procedures with armed oversight. ‘[AUTHORITY]‘ ‘[LABOR]‘ *The auditors carry swords. They say it’s for counting cattle. No one asks further.*
- J **Dike Crown** — Ring of turf and timber; brotherhood bells warn of flood — and spies who move like water through the fen. Legal sanctuary for those fleeing court judgments. ‘[COMMUNITY]‘ ‘[LAW]‘ *The sanctuary lasts for one tide. After that, the reeves can come — if they can find you.*
- Q **Progress Camp** — Queen’s canvas palisade, banners stiff, whispering old courtiers plot advancement through legal maneuver and sanctioned duels. ‘[AUTHORITY]‘ ‘[SOCIAL]‘ *The camp moves every week. The lawsuits follow at a measured pace.*
- K **Tilt-Yard** — Hall of Dawning at first light; Dawn-knights drill clean, loyalties in contracts signed with careful pen. Legal challenges often end in trial by combat. ‘[COMBAT]‘ ‘[LAW]‘ *The sand is raked between duels. Sometimes the rake turns up old blood — or old oaths.*
- A **Highway Stone** — Queen’s milestone above the Dolmis road; three sheriffs post seals over hers, each claiming different jurisdiction. Territory disputes resolved through armed arbitration. ‘[AUTHORITY]‘ ‘[TRAVEL]‘ *The stone has been broken and reglued seven times. Each crack is a forgotten compromise.*

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Fen Reeve** — Tally-rod; speaks for dike guilds, remembers every flood-year’s debts and the charters that govern them. Authorized to call local levies for legal disputes. ‘[AUTHORITY]‘ ‘[COMMUNITY]‘ *His tally-rod has notches from three floods. The next notch will be from a Vhasian raid.*
3. **River Syndic** — Moves grain faster than rumor; knows which writs matter and which customs officials can be... persuaded. Maintains armed merchant guards. ‘[TRADE]‘ ‘[STEALTH]‘ *His ledger has a watermark — a crown on one side, a sunburst on the other. He shows the right side to the right audience.*
4. **Parish Surveyor** — Three maps, one opinion; hedge-walks settle more disputes than courts, measures boundaries with careful chain. Expert witness in property disputes. ‘[KNOWLEDGE]‘ ‘[LAW]‘ *His chain is exactly one rod long. The rod changes length depending on who is paying.*
5. **Dawn Quartermaster** — Ledgers sharper than tongue; logistics before lances, counts every farthing spent in the Queen’s name. Legal authority over military supplies. ‘[AUTHORITY]‘ ‘[LABOR]‘ *He once tracked a missing farthing to a Vhasian counting house. The farthing was returned — with interest.*
6. **Levy Serjeant** — Dales bow calm, cider breath, memory keen for every loophole in the mustering laws. Commands armed civilians in legal enforcement actions. ‘[COMBAT]‘ ‘[LAW]‘ *His bowstring is made from a cancelled writ. He says it shoots truer now.*
7. **Cleric-Pair** — Light preacher vs. Everflame canon lawyer; debates decide tithe law, one for the spirit, one for the letter. Religious law carries weight in secular courts. ‘[SOCIAL]‘ ‘[LAW]‘ *They share a room at the inn. They have not spoken outside court in seven years.*
8. **Fairport Shipwright** — Dolmis cousins; skiff carries more secrets than cargo, knows which manifests to forge and which to honor. Expert in maritime law and naval combat. ‘[CRAFT]‘

- ‘[STEALTH]’ *Her skiff has no name. The customs clerks have given it three.*
9. **Fenwood Comptroller** — Conjures wagons with a signature, silence with a seal, counts the Queen’s coin and tracks every debt owed to the crown. Legal authority over taxation. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[TRADE]’ *His quill is a dagger. He has used it as both.*
10. **Queen’s Justiciar** — Law on the road, polite as a noose; bearing three kings’ judgments and a purse full of pardons for the right price. Authorized to conduct trial by combat. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *She has never lost a legal duel. Her opponents have a tendency to fall down stairs.*
- J **Border Routier** — Reads ledgers as ambushes; serves two crowns, collects from both, knows which border posts take bribes in what coin. Expert in frontier law enforcement. ‘[STEALTH]’ ‘[TRADE]’ *His loyalty is to the highest bidder. The Queen and the Vhasian claimant are currently in a bidding war.*
- Q **Warrior Queen** — Crown on helm, sword at side, patient sums behind her gaze; rules by law’s sharp edge and knows every precedent that supports her claim. Final arbiter in legal duels. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[LAW]’ *Her crown has no jewels — only seals. Each seal is a conquered claim.*
- K **Crown Council** — Fenwood dukes, guild envoys, abbots; weighing grain against glory, charters against coin, precedent against practicality. Legal battles fought through proxy advocates. ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The council has a standing rule: no weapons within the chamber. The advocates have found seventeen loopholes.*
- A **Master Advocate Halric** — Silver-tongued legal warrior who settles disputes through verbal duels that can end in physical combat. Keeper of legal combat traditions. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *He has argued cases in Vhasian, Thepyrgosian, and Ubral courts — and won all three using their own precedents.*

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Dike Breach** — Black-rain; the wrong reeve claims credit while wagons drown, insurance claims and liability writs fly like autumn leaves. Legal liability may require armed enforcement. ‘[DISASTER]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The water is brown with peat and lies. It carries old deeds downstream.*
3. **Feast Clash** — Light vs. Everflame processions collide; shutters slam, writs fly, justices of the peace called to settle which holy day takes precedence. Honor disputes may require legal duels. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The processions take different routes now. The clash was not an accident.*
4. **Quiet Tolls** — Sprout on the Queen’s Highway; escorts sniff traps, sheriffs argue rights, customs officials demand duties no one knew existed. Territorial disputes resolved through armed arbitration. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The toll posts have fresh paint. The paint is from the keep of a Vhasian claimant.*
5. **Audit Freeze** — Counting-house freezes cargo; Queen’s seal vs. old writs, auditors with suspicious eyes and quill-pens sharp as daggers. Legal challenges may escalate to physical confrontation. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The auditors work by candlelight. The shadows on the walls look like gallows.*
6. **Border Snarl** — Three courts arrest the same hay-cart; whose hay is it? Which lord’s charter takes precedence? Bribes flow like wine. Frontier justice often involves armed standoffs. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The hay is from a field that was Vhasian last spring. Now it’s Viterran. The field hasn’t moved.*

7. **Isle Refusal** — Theona withholds levy; the quays choke on rumor, ships idle while lawyers debate maritime law and ancient treaties. Naval blockades become legal enforcement actions. ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[LAW]’ *Theona’s envoy carries a hawthorn branch. The Queen’s justiciars will not touch it.*
8. **Delta Spat** — Fairport vs. Marcott customs; barges stack three deep, merchants pick sides, inspectors with magnifying glasses examine every manifest. Trade disputes fought with merchant guards. ‘[TRADE]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The magnifying glasses reveal truth and also start fires. Both are useful.*
9. **Routier Arrears** — A free-company flips unless someone pays; your name on a ledger, a debt owed to men who know the price of blood. Legal debts enforced through hired swords. ‘[DEBT]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The routiers have a list. Your name is on it — or will be by sunset.*
10. **Salt Pinch** — Import spikes, bakers barricade; the Queen’s promise tastes like thin gruel, merchants hoard salt like gold, riots brew in back alleys. Economic warfare becomes physical conflict. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The salt is grey. It was cut with ashes from a burned Vhasian customs post.*
- J **Dawn Recall** — Escort pulled to a flood-struck parish; the writ argues with the river, justices demand inquiry into who neglected the dikes. Military enforcement of legal judgments. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The escorts are back in a week. They bring new writs — and fewer men.*
- Q **Aberielist Intrigue** — Royalist seals in wrong hands; the Queen’s patience thins, conspirators plot in counting houses, whispers of rebellion. Treason charges carry death penalty in legal duels. ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The seals are from a dead duke. The duke’s ghost is said to approve.*
- K **Levy Call-Up** — Dalesmen mustered; your wagons seized “for the realm,” conscription writs signed with careful pen, families left to tend fields alone. Legal authority backed by armed force. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The conscription writs have a clause: “void if Belworth freezes.” The river is still warm.*
- A **Legal Duel Challenge** — Master Advocate Halric issues a formal challenge; refuse and lose legal standing, accept and risk life and fortune in court-yard combat. The ultimate legal weapon. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The challenge is written on both sides of the parchment. There is no blank space to refuse.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Ferry Priority** — Belworth crossing (once); a horn answers, though perhaps the wrong ferry; customs officials look the other way for the right coin. Legal right of way backed by armed escort. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The priority token is a writ signed by both banks. The ink on one side is newer.*
3. **Dike Allotment** — Brotherhood labor granted if three clerks are convinced and proper bribes distributed among the right hands. Work performed under legal contract with military oversight. ‘[LABOR]’ *The allotment includes a clause: “as tides permit.” The reeve decides what the tides permit.*
4. **Market License** — Valora’s square; a guild nod still needed, but the right seal on the right parchment opens many doors. Legal protection from merchant guild enforcement. ‘[TRADE]’ *The license is written on vellum from a Vhasian abbey. The irony is noted.*
5. **Dawn Escort** — Four lances at dawn; loyalty waxes and wanes with pay, but their presence

- keeps lesser men from troubling you. Legal authority to enforce your writs. '[AUTHORITY]' *The lances are from the Fenwood armory. The Fenwood dukes have their own plans.*
6. **River Charter** — Guaranteed haul on a grain artery — weather permitting and proper duties paid to the right officials. Legal right protected by river patrol. '[TRAVEL]' *The charter is stamped with a seal that looks like a crown — or a sunburst. No one can agree.*
7. **Map Correction** — A hedge moves, borders shift, lawsuits bloom; a new survey can make or break a man's fortune overnight. Legal survey backed by armed surveyors. '[LAW]' *The surveyors carry chains and swords. The swords are for when the chains disagree.*
8. **Customs Seal** — Fairport for Dolmis cargo; honored today, disputed tomorrow, but tonight it clears the way for what needs moving. Legal immunity from customs enforcement. '[TRADE]' *The seal is a wax crab. It pinches when pressed.*
9. **Thing Ruling** — Sharp local bite, but appeals run swifter than oaths; justice swift but not always just, depending on which purse feeds the judge. Court decisions enforceable by local levy. '[LAW]' *The ruling is carved on an oar. Break the oar, and the ruling breaks with it.*
10. **Salt Allotment** — Winter depot; the Queen's writ opens doors, old hands still count sacks, but the right connections ensure the best salt reaches the right tables. Legal monopoly backed by military force. '[TRADE]' *The salt is from a pan worked by Ubral exiles. They still count in clan measure.*
- J **Wardship** — A minor fen-keep; men-at-arms "for now," a tutor has plans, but the right guardian can be found for the right price. Legal guardianship with military authority. '[AUTHORITY]' *The ward is a child. The child has a seal ring. The ring is older than the kingdom.*
- Q **Queen's Audience** — Private; her questions strike like thrusts, but her favors can elevate a man from nothing to something overnight. Royal decree carries immediate enforcement power. '[AUTHORITY]' *The audience lasts one hour. The paperwork lasts a generation.*
- K **Ducal Warrant** — Fenwood to enforce customs; old power bows, new power watches, but the parchment carries weight in any court. Legal authority backed by noble house military. '[AUTHORITY]' *The warrant is signed in blood — or ink that looks like blood. The difference matters at trial.*
- A **Duel Sanction** — Right to challenge in legal combat; the Queen's seal makes it official, Dawn-knights serve as seconds, the winner takes all legally. Ultimate legal enforcement mechanism. '[LAW]' '[COMBAT]' *The sanction is a coin. Heads you duel, tails your opponent chooses the weapon.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (writs/charters/priority) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **hedge-law** motif — boundaries blur, charters contradict, precedent splinters, and the careful web of legal authority shows its cracks. Legal warfare escalates to physical conflict.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Hedge-Law Momentum:** When a valid *writ*, *charter*, or *warrant* is presented in the proper parish, step **Position** up one category on social or logistical actions in that locale for the scene. The first contradiction starts a **Border-Lace** [4] clock; advance each time competing papers are invoked.
- **Beacon & Bell Chain:** If two adjacent *beacons* or *brotherhood bells* are under your influence, convert one **Club** draw into a travel delay for *others* while the party proceeds with improved **Effect** for movement and logistics. The signal draws scrutiny; the GM may bank 1 SB tied to local authority.
- **River-Right Window:** At a ferry, tidework, or customs stair, play any **Diamond** tied to crossings or seals to open a short *window of lawful passage*: one convoy passes uninspected, or one cargo clears at priority. The window closes immediately if a storm, audit, or levy card is revealed.
- **Legal Duel Protocol:** When legal disputes cannot be resolved through argument, parties may challenge each other to a duel. The winner’s position becomes legally binding. Requires proper sanction and seconds (see **Duel Sanction** Diamond).
- **Vhasian Claims:** Any Viterran noble with land across the Belworth may invoke a *Ducal Warrant* to attempt to collect rents or enforce judgments in Vhasia. Doing so starts a **Border Snarl** clock, as the Vhasian claimants are unlikely to cooperate.
- **Theona Contest:** The Warrior Queen’s authority over the Three Greens is nominal at best. Any attempt to enforce Viterran law in Theona triggers an **Isle Refusal** complication, and the local taboos may twist the law into knots.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **Seint Michel of the Gilded Scale** — Mykkiel. *The law that does not bend; the judge who cannot be bought.*
 - **Seint Isabeau of the Lilies** — Ikasha. *The dream of setting aside the crown; the mercy of forgetting duty.*
 - **Seint Evroul of the Cairn** — Mor’iraath. *The oath that outlasts the oath-taker; the debt paid in blood and stone.*
 - **The Hedge King** — The Traveler. *The road that belongs to no lord; the path that finds its own way.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Saint Elodie of the Unbuckled Gorget (The Witness):** The Justiciar Elodie Venn invoked the long-forgotten *Right of Acknowledgment* in the trial of Baron Aldric the Turncloak. Her ruling forced a father to speak one truth aloud before his son. The precedent now stands in the Hall of Dawning: “The truth, once spoken, is payment in full. No further interest shall accrue.” The Temple of Light has adopted her as a saint of mercy; the Fenwood dukes still whisper that she overstepped.
- **The Hedge-Seal (The Dike Covenant):** Covenant judges in the eastern parishes adjudicate disputes over river tolls and inheritance. They carry no weapons, only a set of iron scales and a copy of the *Hedge-Law Tables*. A ruling from the Order is binding in both Viterra and the Vhasian marches, but any party who lies before them forfeits their right to appeal. The Warrior Queen has granted them a charter; the Fenwood dukes consider them spies.

- **Saint Cuthbert of the Fen (The Traveler):** A legendary reeve who walked the flooded dikes during the Great Storm and lit every beacon by hand. His shrines are stiles and bridge posts; travellers who touch the iron ring on his shrine and speak a destination find the road holds firm. The Temple of Light has absorbed his cult, but the fen folk still leave offerings of eels at his cairns.
- **The Cog-Cults of the Northern Hills (The Clockwork Monad):** In the high parishes near the Ubral border, secret fraternities of millers and surveyors believe that law is a machine that can be perfected. They meet in abandoned watermills, measuring boundaries with brass chains and reciting the *Canons of Proportion*. The Everflame calls them heretics; the Queen's justiciars ignore them because their charts are always accurate.
- **The Salt Sworn of the Eastern Coast (The Pale Shepherd):** Along the Dolmis shore, a syncretic cult tends to the drowned. They build cairns of salt stone and leave no offerings — only the names of the lost, carved into driftwood. The Temple of Light has tried to suppress them three times; each time, the mission ships have been found adrift with no crew and a single name carved into the mast: *Oblivion*.
- **The Ninth:** In any Viterran court, the ninth citation of precedent voids all previous citations. The wise stop at eight and settle out of court. Those who cite the ninth are said to hear a faint laughter from the marble walls — and their cases are never heard again.

Viterran Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Hedge:** Crumble a crust at a parish boundary stone. Ignore the first *Border Snarl* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Writ:** Tie a single knot in a charter's ribbon. Cancel *Audit Freeze* or take -1 die on your next legal argument (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the River:** Whisper a dead claimant's name into the Belworth. Gain +1 Effect when arguing against their heir's claim this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Queen's Justiciar. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **crown officials or rival advocates**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **writ-runners or levy guards**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or customs inspectors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable court date**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Queen's Justiciar or fen reeve** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **legal challenge or river closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival claimant or border routier** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Dawn-knights, levy forces, or Vhasian routiers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes — **writ voided/duel declared/levy called**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Warrior Queen, Crown Council, or Master Advocate Halric** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically — **dike breaks/river floods/court erupts**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice — **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Viterra (Hedge Law):** Boundary stones shift, charters contradict themselves, legal precedents split mid-citation.
- **Viterra (Cross-Border Claims):** Vhasian landlords appear with older deeds, Theonan taboos void writs, Ubral cairns declare neutrality with axes.
- **Viterra (Legal Warfare):** Court decisions reverse without warning, witnesses recant, duel seconds change sides.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Survival):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Thorn Hedge*.
- **Cut the Charter (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a **Ducal Warrant** is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Assize (Resolve + Lore):** On a hit in *Audit Freeze*, you pick whose ledgers are examined; on a miss, the GM does.

Legal Combat System (Summary)

When legal disputes cannot be resolved through negotiation, parties may engage in formal legal duels. These combine verbal sparring with physical combat:

Phase 1: Pleadings

- Each advocate presents their case (Wits + Sway vs. DV 3)
- Success grants +1 die to the next phase
- Failure creates 1 SB that the opponent can spend

Phase 2: Cross-Examination

- Attack opponent's arguments (Wits + Insight vs. DV 3)
- Success inflicts Fatigue 1 on the opponent
- Critical success forces opponent to answer truthfully

Phase 3: Trial by Combat (if unresolved)

- Physical combat with legal stakes (Body + Melee or relevant combat skill)
- Winner's position becomes legally binding
- Loser suffers legal consequences (fine, loss of claim, imprisonment) plus physical harm

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Violet Clerk (Master of Counter-Seals)** — *Phases*: Produce Earlier Patent → Split the Writ → Seal Fast. *Cracks*: a **Queen's Audience** overrules his seal; a **Duel Sanction** forces personal combat; a **Map Correction** voids his boundary claim.
- **The Thorn Captain (Queen's Quiet Hand)** — *Phases*: Queenspace Zone → Duel Warrant → Swap the Field. *Cracks*: a **Map Correction** reveals a loophole; a **Dike Allotment** lets you claim the field as "flood zone"; a **Border Routier** testifies to the Queen's favor.
- **The Saffron Abbess (Keeper of Bell-Law)** — *Phases*: Wrong Hour → Bless or Damn → Mixed Tribunal. *Cracks*: a **Queen's Justiciar** invokes crown supremacy; a **Border Routier** bribes her bell-ringer; a **Thing Ruling** from Theona forces her to recuse.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- **Belworth Stairs Ordeal** — Cross the river without a charter. On success, you prove that possession is nine-tenths of the law. On failure, the river takes your name — and your cargo. (Wits + Survival vs. DV 5.)
- **Hall of Dawning Vigil** — Spend a night in the tilt-yard. At dawn, you recall a forgotten legal precedent. Gain a one-use *Precedent Edge* (+1 die in any court). The ghost of a dead duelist may challenge you to a legal dream-duel. (Spirit + Lore vs. DV 4.)
- **Hedge-Moot at Dusk** — Settle a boundary dispute by walking the hedge. Each successful navigation test (Wits + Survival) clears 1 segment from a **Border Snarl** clock. A miss plants the thorn of a future feud (advance **Border Snarl** by 1).

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Legal Dial (Crown ↔ Local Custom)**: Track the party's stance on authority.
 - *Crown High*: +1 Position when invoking royal writs, charters, or the Queen's name; first appeal to local custom starts one step worse.
 - *Local High*: +1 Effect on hedge-law, parish rights, or ancient precedent; first royal petition starts one step worse.
 - Center the dial by hosting a mixed moot or surrendering a contested seal to a neutral third party.
- **Courtroom Mini-Game (fast trial)**:
 - Lay three stones: **Precedent**, **Equity**, **Force**.
 - Argue a point (roll Lore+Diplomacy vs. DV 3). On a hit, move one stone to your side. On a miss, the opposing advocate gains *Citation Edge*.

- Win two stones to secure a temporary **Court Ruling** (treat as a Diamond for one scene).
- *Halric’s Interjection (2 SB)*: flip **Precedent**, but start **Whispered Precedent** [2] with the losing side.
- **Cross-Border Tensions (fast pressure)**:
 - Two opposed clocks: *Queen’s Peace* vs *Border Fire* (size by highest rank in the seed).
 - Each leg, choose *Viterran Road* (safe, slow), *Vhasian Claim* (fast, risky), or *Ubral Pass* (hidden, costly).
 - Advantage: Vhasian Claim→Viterran Road (shortcuts), Ubral Pass→Vhasian Claim (concealment), Viterran Road→Ubral Pass (supplies).
 - Spend a **Ducal Warrant** to shift one segment from *Border Fire* to *Queen’s Peace*.
- **Start-of-Scene Rumors (1d6)**:
 1. *Wrong Wax*: a rival’s seals softened; +1d to forgeries this scene.
 2. *Empty Beacon*: tower unmanned; travel faster, scrutiny harsher.
 3. *Dawn-Lane Cleared*: first convoy action gains +1 Position.
 4. *Clerk’s Wedding*: filings delayed; first petition ignores *Audit Freeze*.
 5. *Fen High Water*: ferries slow; river-charters count double value.
 6. *Mask at Progress*: someone uses your name at court; +1d to social opens, +1 SB banked by GM.
- **Plug-in SB Conversions (Viterra Flavor)**:
 - 1 SB → *Hedge Shift*: a boundary moves; increase DV by 1 for navigation or legal rolls this scene.
 - 2 SB → *Citation War*: increase DV by 1 unless you produce a precedent (spend a $\diamond$ *orreallastruling*).
 - 3+ SB → *Seal Crack*: a writ loses half its value; swap one held $\diamond$ *foralesserrightuntilre-witnessed*.
- **Reputation Echoes**:
 - *Court-Favored*: once/session, downgrade **Audit Freeze** to a minor delay; the next document you present is scrutinized (+1 DV).
 - *Fen-Tested*: +1 Position when resolving dike or flood crises; legal arguments about water rights start one step worse.
 - *Double-Sealed*: +1d with both royal and local courts in a truce scene; any betrayal earns **Border Snarl** from both sides.
- **Cross-Region Hooks (quick integration)**:
 - *Ubral (Stone & Oath)*: A **Ducal Warrant** acts as a *Guest-Token* once at a clan hearth, but starts a **Feud Rekindled** tick if you collect tolls twice in a tenday.
 - *Thepyrgos (Synod Law)*: A **Queen’s Audience** can suspend a synod interdict — but starts *Whispered Precedent* in Thepyrgos.
 - *Vhasia (Fractured Sun)*: A **Duel Sanction** is recognized on the Pont-du-Tithe — but a rival abbey can turn it into *Parlement Divided* on a Club draw.
 - *Theona (No Ninth)*: **Ferry Priority** overrides a local taboo once; if the Ninth custom is in play, the writ “forgets” one clause on use (GM banks 1 SB).

Conspiracy Flourishes (keep it close, keep it quiet)

- **Hedge-Moots at Dusk:** Parish elders “trim hedges” while trading sealed whispers.
- **Cipher Roses:** Folded writs stamped with thorn-petals; one petal missing marks a false clause.
- **Mirror Hours:** Beacons flash lawful signals — reversed for those who know the counter-code.
- **Eel-Letters:** Oiled parchment smuggled in eel-baskets; ink runs in water, truth does not.
- **Quiet Steel, Quieter Quills:** Dawn-knights duel at first light; advocates settle three duels before breakfast with ink alone.
- **Progress Masks:** Courtiers wear legal devices as masque motifs (seal, chain, beacon) to signal faction at a glance.
- **Bell Penance:** A single off-hour peal grants amnesty to those who confess a clause before the twelfth echo.

Patronage & Power

In Viterra, power flows through the careful application of law, the management of ancient rights, and the delicate balance between imperial legacy and reclaimed sovereignty. The Warrior Queen maintains authority through a combination of military might and legal precision, while the old duchies and local officials wield influence through their knowledge of traditional customs and hedge-law. The true power lies with those who can navigate this complex legal landscape and maintain the appearance of legitimate authority while building genuine support.

But remember — in Viterra, law is warfare. Every document is a weapon, every courtroom a battlefield, and every advocate a soldier. The pen cuts as deep as any blade, and legal victory can be as decisive as military conquest.

For the GM: Patronage in Viterra revolves around legal documents, local rights, and the ability to command respect from institutions still finding their post-imperial identity. Rewards often take the form of writs, charters, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, writs, charters) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival duchies and Vhasian claimants issue conflicting authorities, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the courts, parishes, and muster grounds as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success.
- When legal conflicts escalate beyond words, transition naturally to physical confrontation with appropriate stakes.

In Viterra, your papers are your power, and your power determines whether you rule or are ruled. But when words fail, steel speaks — and the law says both are valid.

Chapter 8

Thepyrgos

City of a Thousand Stairs. Thepyrgos rises in tiers of towers, terraces, and endless stairs. Its universities and synods debate philosophy and precedent, while the Chain-Lanterns patrol the countryside, hunting unsanctioned magic. The Library of Keys holds forbidden knowledge, and the Harbor Boom answers only to the Archon’s seal.

8.1 Thepyrgos — “The City of Unfinished Proofs”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Every stair is a question. Every answer is a debt. The Ninth and the Witness argue over who holds the receipt.*

The Archon (Elite): “Every stair climbed is a word in the great conversation between earth and sky. This city is not built – it is grown, stone by stone, law by law, until the very architecture speaks wisdom. But the stairs remember more than the living. They remember the ones who never came down.”

Bell-Runner (Commoner): “I know every step that creaks a warning and every landing that whispers gossip. The bells tell the city’s mood better than any lord – three chimes means business, six means trouble, and nine means the hunters are coming. But on the ninth bell, the stairs themselves answer.”

Genre / Mood: Scholarly vertical city, Byzantine bureaucracy, Grecian folk horror in the hinterlands, metaphysical war between memory and forgetting.

Starting Location: The Synod Hall at dusk. Gold-glass mosaics glitter as a Matriarch reads a scroll aloud. “The Beacon Crown sees traitors in the smoke. A child’s talent was sold to the Commissary last night. Find the informer — or the next stair seized will be yours. And if you hear a stair creak where none exists, do not turn around. The Ninth is counting.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Thepyrgos is both realm and city, built on the bones of the drowned Astroegro Empire. The capital rises in tiers of towers, terraces, and endless stairs above the Dolmis shore – but the stairs are not stone. They are *fossilised vertebrae*, the spine of a leviathan that Khemesh dragged under when the last emperor broke a covenant older than the sea. Once a Utaran province, now a nation unto itself, Thepyrgos is famed for its universities, libraries, and debating synods, where precedent and philosophy weigh as much as pikes or coin.

Outside the city, the countryside is a rugged coastal landscape of whitewashed villages, olive groves, and timber churches – home to the **Hyro** people. The Hyro carry the fracture of the Astroegro in their blood. A child born in the hills might dream in geometries that do not exist. A farmer might hear the stones whispering in a language no living throat can shape. The Chain-Lantern order and other Witch-Hunter Commissariats ruthlessly patrol these villages, using bounty postings, candle-smoke tests, and stair-seizures to identify and kidnap children with arcane talent. The Hyro have learned to offer *substitutes* – a memory, a false name, a lock of hair – at crossroads, hoping the Hollow accepts the payment.

In the university's forbidden tiers, the **Witness** and the **Ninth** fight a proxy war via fraternal orders and occult mystery cults. The Witness wants the Astroegro Vaults *remembered* but sealed; the Ninth wants them *opened*, to trigger a Great Unlearning that would erase the concept of debt from the world. No one is sure which side the Archon secretly favors. And in the ruins of the Astroegro, something still ticks – gears of black glass, locked doors that hum, and the occasional survivor with eyes like burning tar who speaks of a pressure from below.

What you notice first: The endless chime of bells from different tiers, never quite in sync. The smell of brine and olive oil and candle wax. The way locals glance at the sky when a child coughs – and then at the nearest crossroads.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never let a bell-ringer count your breaths. The Chain-Lanterns pay well for names that ring false on the test stairs. But worse: never ask a question of a stair that has no end. The Ninth is listening, and it will answer.

Regional Mood: Stairs, Bells, and the Argument of Patrons

Here, every ascent is a plea and every descent a confession. Thepyrgos the city is a vertical labyrinth of stair-rights, rope-guilds, and synod edicts that shift with the tide. Thepyrgos the province is a haunted countryside of hidden talent and state-sanctioned abduction. The Hyro keep their arcane children in root cellars and haylofts, praying the hunters take the neighbour's instead. The Chain-Lanterns move at dawn, their brass censers swinging, their bells tuned to the frequency of latent magic. In the university's forbidden tiers, the Witness and the Ninth arm rival fraternities with citations and curses, and no one is sure which side the Archon secretly favors. And in the ruins of the Astroegro, something still ticks – gears of black glass, locked doors that hum, and the occasional survivor with eyes like burning tar who speaks of a pressure from below.

Prominent NPCs of Thepyrgos

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk

Archon Konstantinos	Ruler of the city, elected by the wards	Balance the synod, the guilds, and the Commissariat	He wears a key around his neck; no one knows what it opens – or that it is a key to the Ninth’s Vault.
Matriarch Eleni	Synod primate, head of the Temple of Light’s synod	Keep the Everflame from reclaiming the province	She speaks once a session; when she does, the bells listen. She has never spoken the ninth word.
Commissary Kyrillos	Chain-Lantern commander	Purge all untutored magic from the province	His lantern shows not only latent talent but also the bearer’s greatest fear. He refuses to look into it himself.
Sofia	Bell-Runner (commoner exemplar)	Outrun the hunters and protect the hidden gifted	She ties a knot in her hair for each hunter she has outrun; her hair is a thicket. One knot is white – a hunter she could not outrun.
Nomophylax Zoe	Law-scholar, master of citations	Reform the synod from within	She has never lost a case; her opponents have a habit of vanishing into the Unfinished Stair.

The Lighthouse-Patriarch	Reclusive seer of the Beacon Crown	Steer the city through the coming storm	He has no eyes – only mirrors where his eyes should be. In the mirrors you see the faces of those who owe the Ninth.
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Names of Thepyrgos

Inspired by the southern peninsulas and the Aegean coast: clear vowels, soft endings, and surnames that recall a stair, a tower, or a village.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Konstantinos	Eleni	Skalas	<i>the Stair-Wise</i>
Dimitris	Zoe	Platanos	<i>the Unseen</i>
Kyrillos	Sofia	Raptis	<i>Bell-Sworn</i>
Nikolas	Anastasia	Laskaris	<i>the Accursed</i>
Leonidas	Irini	Makris	<i>Ash-Finger</i>
Stephanos	Fotini	Koutroulis	<i>the Silent</i>

(Tower/Stair/Sea-wall) Pilgrim’s Stair zig-zagging sea-cliff to wicket gate; Tower Quarter with family keeps stitched by ladders and bridges.

Spades — Places

2. **Pilgrim’s Stair** — Zig-zagging sea-cliff to wicket gate; ascent as devotion. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[RITUAL]’ *Every hundredth step has a bell. Pilgrims ring once for mercy, twice for memory. The ninth bell has no clapper.*
3. **Tower Quarter** — Family keeps stitched by ladders and bridges; vertical neighbourhoods. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The lowest rung of each ladder is painted red — a toll for the rope-guild. The rope-guild’s ledger is written in disappearing ink.*
4. **Chain-Barbican** — Harbor gate; capstans ready to raise the boom at horn’s call. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The capstan pins are carved from the thighbones of executed smugglers. The bones still warm in your hand.*
5. **Blue Cistern** — Under the forum; cool echo, strict tally; water as law. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The water tastes of copper and old prayers. Drink deep, and you may forget a debt – but the water will remember your face.*
6. **Ropeyard Terrace** — Cranes walk cargo up slope by treadwheel; muscle and machinery. ‘[LABOR]’ *The treadwheel operators sing in eights. The ninth beat is always silent – that is when the Stair moves.*

7. **Storm-Wall Arcades** — Wind shrieks through arched galleries; defense as architecture. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The wind carries voices from the last siege. Some say they’re warnings. Others say they’re the Ninth rehearsing.*
8. **Beacon Crown** — Ring of watchtowers signaling along the Dolmis; eyes of the city. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The beacons burn juniper and saltpeter. Black smoke means fire; white smoke means hunters. Green smoke means the Stair is hungry.*
9. **Library of Keys** — Archive vaults; shelves locked by rung and rite; knowledge as power. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[SECRET]’ *The keys are graded by sin. The ninth key opens nothing – and everything. It is kept in a box that has no lid.*
10. **Siege Court** — Test ramp and scarred stones; war never far from peace. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The ramp’s stones are stained with lamp oil and regret. Practice charges end in the cistern – or the Unfinished Stair.*
- J **Ladder Monastery** — Perched on a needle of rock; monks climb toward truth. ‘[RITUAL]’ *The monks never speak. They write commandments in chalk on the rungs. The ninth rung has no chalk – only a smear of ash.*
- Q **Synod Hall** — Gold-glass mosaics; judgment audible at a whisper’s distance. ‘[LAW]’ *The acoustics are enchanted. A lie told here echoes twice – once in the liar’s voice, once in truth’s. The Ninth’s lies echo only once.*
- K **Archon’s Citadel** — Acropolis peak; mirror tiles glare like noon’s justice. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The mirrors were a gift from Kahfagia. They show not the sea, but the faces of debtors – and sometimes a stair that was not there before.*
- A **The Unfinished Stair** — A hidden flight that appears only to those who have asked a question the Synod cannot answer. ‘[THRESHOLD]’ ‘[MYSTERY]’ *The stairs have no end. Each step is a different year. At the top, the Ninth and the Witness are playing knucklebones with forgotten names.*

(Archon/Synod/Guild) Bell-runner child whose feet know every stair by heart; Master of Ropes with palms like oak, voice like a whistle.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Bell-Runner** — Child whose feet know every stair by heart; speed as currency. ‘[STEALTH]’ *She ties a knot in her hair for each hunter she has outrun; her hair is a thicket. One knot is white – a hunter she could not outrun.*
3. **Master of Ropes** — Palms like oak, voice like a whistle; guild head of lifters. ‘[LABOR]’ *He lost two fingers to a frayed line. He keeps them in a jar as a warning. The jar is on the ninth shelf.*
4. **Icon-Smith** — Portable shrine, temper about pigment; faith in detail. ‘[CRAFT]’ *His pigments are ground from stolen icons. He calls it recycling the divine. The Ninth calls it preparation.*
5. **Wall Strategos** — Drills levies on the test ramp; defense as daily ritual. ‘[COMBAT]’ *She lost a son to a Linn raid. She trains orphans now – and keeps a list. The list has nine names.*
6. **Chain-Keeper** — Harbor boom; hates “surprises” at dusk; order as obsession. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *His bell never rings the same note twice. He says the tide changes its mind. The Ninth changes its tone.*

7. **Oath-Examiner** — Weighs words like iron; notary of truth and consequence. ‘[LAW]’ *She carries a scale with one pan empty. The empty pan is for lies. When the Ninth speaks, both pans tip.*
8. **Archive Sister** — Key to the “forbidden rung”; keeper of dangerous knowledge. ‘[SECRET]’ *Her left eye is milk-white — a price for reading a cursed shelf. The shelf was a stair in a past life.*
9. **Salt-Fish Syndic** — Warehouse queen of the quays; profit in preservation. ‘[TRADE]’ *Her salt is cut with ground bone meal. The fish stay fresh — and quiet. The bones were from a stair.*
10. **Nomophylax** — Law-scholar whose citations close mouths; precedent as weapon. ‘[LAW]’ *He has never lost a case. His opponents have a habit of vanishing. The Unfinished Stair has a new step.*
- J **Palikar Captain** — Tower guards; ladder-quick and letter-shy; strength in motion. ‘[COMBAT]’ *His shield is painted with a ladder — each rung a battle he survived. The ninth rung is blank.*
- Q **Matriarch of the Ladder** — Synod primate; calm as stone, wisdom in height. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *She speaks once a session. When she does, the bells listen. She has never spoken the ninth word.*
- K **The Archon** — Elected, entrenched, counting bells; ruler of the ascent. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *He wears a key around his neck. No one knows what it opens. The key is a stair.*
- A **Lighthouse-Patriarch** — Reclusive seer; said to steer beacons in storms. ‘[MYSTERY]’ *He has no eyes — only mirrors where his eyes should be. In the mirrors you see the Unfinished Stair.*

(**Edict/Quake/Chain**) Tremor with hairline cracks racing down a stair; crowds freeze; iconoclast riot in the Tower Quarter.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Tremor** — Hairline cracks race down a stair; crowds freeze, dust speaks. ‘[DISASTER]’ *The dust spells names. Yours appears if you’ve broken a stair-right — or if the Ninth is curious.*
3. **Iconoclast Riot** — In the Tower Quarter; pigments and teeth fly through the air. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The riot started over a missing icon’s eye. The eye was a hunter’s informer. The icon was a stair.*
4. **Chain Jam** — At the barbican; capstan pins shear at the worst moment. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The pins were filed by a saboteur. The chain will hold — or not. The Ninth is taking bets.*
5. **Black Northerly** — Pins cranes; cargo hangs between tiers, prayers below. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The wind smells of iron and ice. Someone is using weather magic. The Witness disapproves.*
6. **Cistern Taint** — Sour water; inspectors padlock spouts, thirst rises. ‘[DEBT]’ *The taint is sweet — too sweet. Someone poisoned the cistern to flush out a talent. The talent is a stair.*
7. **Synod Summons** — A chant or badge is suddenly proscribed; law shifts like wind. ‘[LAW]’ *The summons is written on a bell-clapper. Read it, and you are a witness. The Ninth writes the margin.*
8. **Rope Guild Interdict** — No lifts until a grievance is heard; the city stops climbing. ‘[LABOR]’ *The guild’s grievance is a single name. The name is yours. The name is also a*

stair.

9. **Siege Drill Panic** — Practice horns mistaken for real; chaos in the ranks. ‘[FEAR]’ *The horns were blown by a child who didn’t know the difference. Or did they? The child is a step.*
10. **Smuggler’s Ladder** — Discovered; the whole stair sealed, routes rerouted. ‘[STEALTH]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The ladder was built by a Hyro family. Now they are all “guests” of the Commissariat. Their house is a stair.*
- J **Ropeyard Fire** — Sparks leap uphill faster than boots; smoke chokes the ascent. ‘[DISASTER]’ *The fire was set to cover a kidnapping. The victim’s name is on the bounty board. The board is a stair.*
- Q **Exarch’s Claim** — “Thepyrgos under my protection”; arrests follow the papers. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The Exarch is a puppet of the Chain-Lanterns. His seal is a bell without a clapper. The Ninth has the clapper.*
- K **General Watch** — All towers manned; levies seize carts “for the walls.” ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The levies are looking for one thing: children who flinch at candle-smoke. The children are stairs.*
- A **The Unfinished Stair Awakens** — A hidden flight appears in the middle of a crowded tier. The Ninth’s attention falls. ‘[THRESHOLD]’ ‘[BOSS]’ *The stairs have no end. The Witness is writing. The Ninth is counting. You are already on the third step.*

(Key/Rite/Paper) Stair token passes a barricaded stair without delay; harbor pass lowers the boom for your vessel on command.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Stair Token** — Pass a barricaded stair without delay (once); height as right. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The token is a bronze step. It fits into a missing rung. The missing rung is a secret.*
3. **Harbor Pass** — Boom lowers for your vessel on command; sea as ally. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The pass is a note written on a fish scale. The gate-keeper will not ask why. The fish was a witness.*
4. **Cistern Draw-Right** — A named ward during scarcity; water as favor. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The right is a clay cup. Break it to claim your share. The cup was a stair.*
5. **Crane Allotment** — One guaranteed lift on the Ropeyard Terrace; height as service. ‘[LABOR]’ *The allotment is a knotted rope. Cut a knot for each use. The ninth knot is a lie.*
6. **Icon License** — Display a disputed image without penalty; faith as leverage. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The license is stamped with the Archon’s ring. The ring is warm — the Archon is watching. The ring is a stair.*
7. **Archive Hour** — Library of Keys; one shelf opened to you; knowledge as power. ‘[SECRET]’ *The shelf is sealed with a riddle. Solve it, or the key will break. The riddle is about the ninth step.*
8. **Bellmark** — Lawful right to ring a tower bell (summons the watch); sound as law. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The bellmark is a brand on your palm. Show it, and the watch bleeds for you — once. The blood is a witness.*
9. **Watchlight Code** — Today’s beacon and mirror signals; navigation as paper. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The code is written in lemon juice. Heat it to read, then hide it again. The heat is a confession.*
10. **Synod Indulgence** — One proscribed chant or rite permitted (for you). ‘[MAGIC]’ *The indulgence is a bell-note held in a jar. Break the jar to release it. The bell-note is a name.*

- J Pronoia Grant** — Temporary farm/tax of a terrace hamlet; land as income. ‘[TRADE]’ *The grant is a wooden token. Present it to the village elder — if she is still alive. The elder is a stair.*
- Q Synod Audience** — Private with the Matriarch and clerks; wisdom as policy. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The audience is held in a fog hollow. What is spoken there is never written. The fog is a witness.*
- K Archon’s Writ** — Palikars escort you between towers; authority as escort. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The writ is a bell-rope. Tie it to your belt, and the guards will know your voice. The rope was a stair.*
- A Golden Key** — Open or seal any city gate once; access as power. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The key is a finger bone. The lock is a gauntleted fist. It will work — once. The fist is the Ninth’s.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (keys/rites/papers) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **height and sound** motifs — bells that carry, wind that remembers, stairs that echo with purpose.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Bell-Law:** Bells are law made sound. Once per session, a Bellmark or tower bell summons the watch, a levy, or a decree. False rings stain a reputation; the Synod may inquire. The ninth ring is never false — it is always the Ninth.
- **Stair-Rights:** Every stair is owned, owed, or leased. A token bypasses barricades and tolls; climbing the wrong stair without leave sparks a riot or a duel. The Unfinished Stair has no owner — only a debtor.
- **The Unfinished Stair Clock [6]:** Tracks the party’s entanglement with the hidden architecture of Thepyrgos. Tick it when you use a hidden stair, ask a question the Synod cannot answer, or speak a true name of an Astroegro ruin. At 6 segments, the party discovers a *new* hidden stair — one that leads to an Astroegro Vault — but they are also *marked*. The Witness’s attention falls on them. Their reflections in mirrors begin to lag by a heartbeat. The Chain-Lanterns receive a vision of their faces. Reduce the clock by feeding a memory to the Ninth’s Coterie (lose a fact, a skill point, or a Bond) or by recording a truth in the Synod’s archives (gain Obligation to the Witness).
- **The Offering at the Crossroads (Hedge Gift):** Once per session, a Hyro character (or someone who has learned their customs) may leave a *substitute* at a crossroads — a written name, a lock of hair, a childhood memory. For the next scene, they are *invisible to the Chain-Lanterns* (cannot be tracked or identified by candle-smoke). The substitute becomes a *Debt Token* that the GM may cash in later (the Hollow accepted it; the Hollow will ask for more).
- **The Candle-Smoke Test (GM Tool):** When the Chain-Lanterns test a village, the GM rolls 1d6. On a 1-2, they find a gifted child (the party must intervene or witness a tragedy). On a 3-4, they find a substitute (a false name, a hidden memory) and leave. On a 5-6, the

village has already paid in silence — no raid occurs. The party can influence the roll by offering their own substitute (use a Boon to shift the result by 1).

- **The Astroegro Singing (Player Tool):** A Hyro character can hum a fragment of an old empire song. The song has no words — only pressure. When hummed at a ruin, it may open a hidden door. When hummed at a Chain-Lantern, it may cause their lantern to flicker. Each use advances the *Unfinished Stair* clock by 1 (the past is waking).
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Unwritten Citation** — The Witness. *A precedent that exists only in the margin.*
 - **The Bell-Founder** — Mykkiel. *The law that rings true, even when it hurts.*
 - **The Abyssal Pressure** — Khemesh. *The weight beneath the city; the debt that the deep remembers.*
 - **The Silent Stair** — The Ninth. *The step that is never counted, the threshold that opens only once.*

The Astroegro Vaults

Beneath the city, nine vaults. The Synod knows of three and has sealed them with Witness-branded wax. The Ninth’s Coterie has found a fourth. The other five are still buried, waiting for the right key — a true name, a specific death, a memory that has never been spoken.

Each vault contains:

- A weapon (a bell that rings the target’s true name, a lens that shows the death of anyone you name, a stone that erases a page from the world’s ledger).
- A guardian (a spirit of an Astroegro archivist, bound to defend the vault with its last calculation).
- A cost (to open the vault, you must sacrifice something the empire valued — a memory of salt water, a dream of drowning, a confession of hubris).

The Ninth’s Goal: Open all nine vaults simultaneously. The resulting “unlearning” would erase the concept of *debt* from the world. No one would owe anything to anyone. The Hollow would starve. The Witness would have nothing to record. The Ninth would become the only law: *forgetting*.

The Witness’s Goal: Keep the vaults sealed, but *remember* them perfectly. Every weapon, every secret, every crime of the Astroegro must be recorded in the Synod’s archives — not to use, but to witness. The Witness does not want to prevent the Ninth’s plan; it wants to be *the one who writes down what happened*.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Astroegro Remnant (Khemesh):** Deep beneath the Beacon Crown, a sealed chamber contains a working Astroegro orrery. Its gears are carved from abyssal glass, and it still ticks. Those who listen too long hear a voice whispering the true names of drowned emperors. The Chain-Lanterns have posted a perpetual guard; they say the orrery is a beacon for something that should not surface.
- **Saint Methodia of the Silent Stair (The Witness):** A legendary archivist who climbed the Ninth Stair of the Library of Keys and never came down. Her ghost is said to appear to those who speak a truth the Synod has buried, offering a single citation that can overturn any edict. The price is a secret of equal weight, and the ghost never forgets.

- **The Cog-Cults of the Clockwork Monad:** Underground fraternities of gear-smiths and logicians who believe the Astroegro Empire fell because its geometry was imperfect. They meet in the basements of the Ropeyard Terrace, trying to reconstruct the lost orrery. The Chain-Lanterns tolerate them because their calculations sometimes predict talent blooms. Heretics from the Everflame call them clock-worshippers; the Cog-Cults call themselves the True Iterators.
- **The Daughters of the Cord (The Bitter Root):** A hospice in the lower tiers is run by grey-robed women who ask no payment, but they take names. They are tolerated because they treat the poor for free, but the Commissariat suspects they also hide gifted children. A renegade Sister hides among the bell-runners, trying to unbind her Hollowed from the Chain-Lanterns' ledger.
- **The Savage Heart (Red Maw):** In the highland villages west of the city, a bear cult has arisen. They believe the only way to escape the Commissariat's hunts is to become the hunter. They wear cured skins and speak in growls, and they have begun hunting Chain-Lantern patrols. The Archon has declared them outlaws, but the villagers leave offerings of raw meat at their shrines.
- **The Ninth:** In any Thepyrgos scene, the ninth bell rung in an hour opens a threshold. The wise stop at eight and cover their ears. Those who ring the ninth are said to see a pale figure standing on the Beacon Crown's mirror tiles — waiting to collect a name.

Thepyrgos Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Stair:** Toss a crust onto a rung before climbing. Ignore the first *Tremor* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Rope:** Tie a single knot in a crane line. Cancel *Rope Guild Interdict* or take -1 die on your next lift (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Smoke:** Whisper a hunter's name into the Beacon Crown's fire. Gain +1 Effect when evading the Chain-Lanterns this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Synod. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Offer the Substitute:** Leave a written false name at a crossroads. The next Candle-Smoke Test against you automatically fails — but the Hollow gains a Debt Token on you. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **tower guards or guild masters**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **bell-runners or civic patrols**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or archive keepers**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable ascent**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Wall Strategos or guild head** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **quake damage or stair closure**.

- **Foe Appears:** A rival faction or civic enforcer arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **palikars, guild enforcers, or synod guards** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes — **bell rings falsely/stair collapses/law changes**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Archon, Matriarch, or Lighthouse-Patriarch** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically — **quake hits/bells ring/bridge collapses**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice — **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Thepyrgos (Height & Law):** Stairs shift position, bells ring with the wrong tone, legal papers rewrite themselves.
- **Thepyrgos (Synod Power):** Edicts change mid-speech, citations appear in the air, wisdom comes unbidden.
- **Thepyrgos (Vertical City):** Ropes fray without warning, cranes swing cargo unexpectedly, tower windows show wrong views.
- **Thepyrgos (The Unfinished Stair):** A hidden stair appears behind the party. The Ninth is counting. The Witness is writing. The stairs have no end.

The Magic Colleges (University Extensions)

- **College of Ladders & Lines** — geomancy, architecture, constraint; stairs as sigils, capstans as circles.
- **College of Bells & Beacons** — acoustics, omen-fire, signal calculus; law made audible, augury made measurable.
- **College of Waters & Weights** — alchemy, cistern rites, dyes; solutions, precipitates, and lawful flow.
- **College of Names & Oaths** — nomikon theurgy; citations that bind, clauses that compel.
- **College of Mirrors & Haze** — illusion, scrutiny; seeing, being seen, un-being seen.
- **College of Quiet** — ethics of death, memory rites; permitted remembrances — anything more is heresy.

The Witch-Hunter Province (Commissariat Extensions)

Thepyrgos-the-Province funds Witch-Hunter Commissariats — ministries with bounties posted per ward. Notices hang on stair-landings; bells announce *hunts lawful and hunts less so*. The Chain-Lantern order is the most feared, but others compete for quotas.

Hunter Hearts (faces of the persecution)

- **Commissary-Exarch** — Writs in triplicate; quotas in private.
- **Bounty-Reader** — Weighs children like coin; “verification” by bell.
- **Pardoner-Chaplain** — Sells absolution to informers; keeps a careful ledger.
- **Stair-Runner Informant** — Knows which doors open to the right knock.
- **Chain-Lantern Captain** — Commands the most feared order; his lantern reveals truth through flesh.

Hunter Clubs (pressures and sweeps)

- **Bounty Posting** — New price on “untutored talent”; crowds turn into nets.
- **Candle-Smoke Test** — Lines at the Blue Cistern; smoke curls toward the Gifted.
- **Commissary Sweep** — Ladders chained; a whole tier searched under horn.
- **Quieted Child** — An “accident” near the Exam Stair; evidence goes missing.
- **Chain-Lantern Raid** — Dawn assault on a hamlet; children taken before the rooster crows.

Hunter Diamonds (leverage and reprieve)

- **Witness Pardon** — Informer absolved and paid; cancels one legal fallout *once*.
- **Archon’s Clemency** — Suspends a bounty clock for one named; bell-marked and public.
- **Hidden Stair Token** — Through a maintenance run unseen; good for one group escape.

Detection & Denial (Fast Procedures)

Scry & Deny (evading the tests)

1. **Mask the Trace:** dye, salt, bell-oil; pick *one* (each grants +1 die to one approach).
2. **Pick the Test:** *Smoke, Sound, Mirror*. State how you spoof it (alchemical veil, bell overtones, angle games).
3. **On a hit:** cancel a **Candle-Smoke Test** or **Proctors’ Gate** tag for this scene. **Consequence:** start *Bell Debt* [2] or *Rector’s Notice* [2].

Bounty Economy (quick table, GM picks or 1d6)

1. *Whisperer* (faint talent): 1 purse; informers abundant.
2. *Spark-Hand* (cantrip): 2 purses; “rehabilitation” promised.
3. *Mirror-Bent* (glamour): 3 purses; seized at once.
4. *Bell-Singer* (acoustic): 4 purses; Synod claims jurisdiction.
5. *Oath-Breaker* (binding): 5 purses; Exarch insists on custody.
6. *Quiet-Worker* (death-ethic): 6 purses; College of Quiet petitions for trial.

Scenario Starters (Plug-and-Play)

The Bright Child on the Exam Stair *Hook:* A Bell-Runner begs you to get a latent child to campus before the dawn sweep. *Complications:* **Candle-Smoke Test**, **Commissary Sweep**, a jealous **Street Thaum**. *Relief:* Trade a *Latency Seal* for testimony; or ring a lawful *Bellmark* to create a corridor — accept *Censure Murmurs* [2].

The Black Ledger of Bounties *Hook:* The College of Quiet wants proof that a Commissary inflates prices to fill quotas. *Complications:* **Synod Summons**, **Smuggler’s Ladder**, **Chain Jam**. *Relief:* Publish via a *Nomikon* colloquy (gain *Synod Indulgence*); or sell it to the Archon (gain *Archon’s Clemency* but start *Faculty Feud* [4]).

The Golden Key and the Silent Stair *Hook:* A dying Archivist gives you a Golden Key. “It opens the stair the hunters fear.” *Truth:* The stair leads to the Beacon Crown’s secret basement — a prison for children who passed the smoke test. *Relief:* Free the children and expose the Commissariat (gain *Archon’s Clemency* for the whole party, but start *Exarch’s Claim* at full); or seal the stair forever (gain *Golden Key* to use elsewhere, but the children are lost to memory).

The Ninth Vault *Hook:* A fragment of an Astroegro weapon has been unearthed in a hill village. The Ninth’s Coterie and the Synod both want it. The village elder offers it to the party — if they can offer a substitute that satisfies the Hollow. *Truth:* The weapon is a bell that rings the true name of anyone you name. Its guardian is the ghost of the Astroegro archivist who sealed it. The ghost will not speak to anyone who has not climbed the Unfinished Stair. *Relief:* Climb the stair, speak the archivist’s true name, and take the bell — but the stair adds a segment to the Unfinished Stair Clock. Or destroy the bell with a memory of the Astroegro’s fall (lose a cherished memory permanently). Or give the bell to the Synod (gain a Synod Indulgence) or to the Ninth’s Coterie (gain a Debt Token from the Ninth).

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Stealth):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Fog Bank*.
- **Cut the Stair (Presence + Lore):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a stair token is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Quake (Body + Athletics):** On a hit in *Tremor*, you pick who keeps their footing; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Bell & Inquisition)

- **The Bell-Exarch (Nine Bans)** — *Phases:* Candle-Smoke Sweep → Orchestrated Silence → Synod Coup. *Cracks:* ring a forgotten bell, expose a false bounty, survive a night in the Beacon Crown.
- **The Astroegro Engine (Pressure from Below)** — *Phases:* Gears Turn → Whispers Become Names → Seiche. *Cracks:* abyssal glass shard, survivor testimony, the Lighthouse-Patriarch’s mirror turning clear.
- **The Ninth’s Advocate (Living Stair)** — *Phases:* Count → Omit → Forget. *Cracks:* speak a true name that the Ninth does not know, offer a memory the Witness has not recorded, climb the Unfinished Stair and refuse to answer the Ninth’s question.

Patronage & Power

In Thepyrgos, power flows through elevation, education, and the precise application of law — but also through the hidden architecture of the Unfinished Stair. The Archon maintains authority through a complex web of guilds, synods, and civic institutions, but the real power lies with whoever can climb the stairs that should not exist. Social mobility is literally upward mobility, with stair-rights, bellmarks, and archive access serving as both currency and status symbols. But the highest status belongs to those who have seen the top of the Unfinished Stair — and remembered how to return.

For the GM: Patronage in Thepyrgos revolves around access — to towers, to knowledge, to the right to climb, and to the hidden stairs. Rewards often take the form of keys, passes, or legal exemptions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize the metaphysical war:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, keys, papers) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival guilds and the two Patrons (Witness and Ninth) issue conflicting rights, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the synods, towers, and staircases as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success — but where the Ninth's silence and the Witness's memory can tip the scales.
- Introduce the Unfinished Stair clock as a campaign tension; every time the party uses a hidden stair, they advance the clock and bring the Ninth's attention closer.

In Thepyrgos, your ascent is your standing, and your standing determines whether you rise or fall — or whether you are simply **forgotten**.

Part III

The Northern Reaches

Chapter 9

Aeler

Crowns & Under-Vaults. The Aeler hold the mountains by breath, bell, and bargain. Their cities open in thunderous caverns where bridges leap between ribs of stone. Survival is the first law: air is counted, water is barred, light is rationed by wick and prayer. Tradition is the second: seals are kept, measures remain true, and the dead keep their offices as carefully as the living.

9.1 Aeler (Dwarves) — “Crowns & Under-Vaults”

Elite (Vault-Queen of a crownland)

“The mountain remembers every word carved in its stone, every seal pressed into its walls. To govern here is not to command, but to harmonize with the ancient songs that still echo in the deep places.”

Commoner (Under-Mason who can hear stone shift a room away)

“When the stone starts singing a different tune, you best listen. Three knocks in the morning means all’s well, but three knocks at night means something’s coming through the walls that wasn’t meant to walk.”

Crowns & Under-Vaults

The Aeler Kingdoms hold the mountains by breath, bell, and bargain. Dozens of sovereign holds – some sealed for centuries, others trading openly with lowland markets – share only the deep roots of stone and the supremacy of the High King Beneath the Peaks. Their halls run like arteries, their cities open in thunderous caverns where bridges leap between ribs of stone and cisterns shine like night skies turned inward. *Survival* is the first law: air is counted, water is bartered, light is rationed by wick and prayer. *Tradition* is the second: seals are kept, measures remain true, and the dead keep their offices as carefully as the living. Between the two, a people learn to argue quietly and build loudly.

Collectives (clans, guild-kin, lamp-companies) own what the mountain allows; individuals are custodians by oath. Trade runs under and over the range through under-ways and pass-forts, stitching protectorates and lowland markets to vaultmouth gates. When tunnels whisper or the air tastes wrong, the Aeler move as one animal; when the Kingsmoot calls, crowns and abbesses argue in bell-code and sealed writs until the stone itself seems to lean in.

The Fractured Crowns: Aeler Faction Spectrum

Aeler society is not monolithic. Beneath the High King’s nominal authority, each crownland follows its own star. Attitudes toward the surface range from open partnership to militant isolation, and even the most reclusive holds maintain **Edgewalker** contacts to monitor the world above.

- **Traditionalist / “The Old Ways”** – These holds idealize the ancient mountain-empire: closed gates, iron tariffs, and the certain knowledge that surface-dwellers cannot be trusted. They resemble the dwarves of fireside tales: stubborn, insular, and quick to reach for an axe when a human mentions “progress.” Their kings speak of the days when no foreigner stepped past the vaultmouth. *Clocks: FOREIGNER SUSPICION [4], HOLD SEALED [6]*.
- **Cooperative / “Open Hand”** – These holds trade freely with Aelaerem, Kahfagia, and even the Vilikari. They staff the under-markets, send engineers to repair bridges in Viterra, and treat the surface as a resource to be managed, not a threat to be shunned. They prefer soft power: standardised measures, certified weights, and bell-code protocols that make others *want* to trade on Aeler terms. *Clocks: TRADE ROUTE PROSPERITY [6], CULTURAL FRICTION [4]*.
- **Isolationist / “Silent Stone”** – Deep holds that have not answered a Kingsmoot call in living memory. Their gates are lost, their peoples rumoured to have turned inward, worshiping forgotten depths. They neither help nor harm the surface – but when a White Flood or a gas flare occurs, their silence becomes a hazard of its own. *Clocks: SILENT HOLD AWAKENS [8], ANCIENT GRUDGE [6]*.

Most Aeler characters and settlements fall somewhere between these poles, and the same hold might shift its stance over a season, depending on grain prices, a new Vault-Queen, or a disaster that forces its hand.

Prominent NPCs of Aeler

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Valthor Aezelbron	High King Beneath the Peaks	Preserve the ancient concord and balance the crownlands	He has not spoken above a whisper in seven years. The court reads his will by bell-code.
Grunhelda Thrainsdottir	Vault-Queen of Irondeep	Expand trade routes while keeping the Old Ways satisfied	She keeps a pet geode that hums when a contract is fair.
Maeva Kaelen	Legate of the Under-Seal	Negotiate passage rights and standard measures with low-land realms	Her seal-rod is carved from a fossilised root. She has never lost a tariff dispute.

Thromm Stone-Tongue	Under-Mason (Com- moner exemplar)	Hear the mountain’s warnings and keep the tunnels safe	He can identify a false weight by tapping it once with his hammer.
Orthen White-Ribbon	Tunnel Courier	Deliver sealed writs across hos- tile jurisdictions	He has run the Spine Underway in darkness with- out a lamp. Twice.
Lumenor Saela	Keeper of the Under- Altars	Maintain the breath-rites and the old flame	She speaks only in bell tones during services. Her mundane voice is never heard.

Names of Aeler

Aeler names blend flowing vowels and soft diphthongs (ae, ei, ou, ui) with harsh consonants (k, th, z, r, g). Surnames are carved from mountain-roots: a hold, a forge, a seam, or a trade.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Thrain	Grunhelda	Aezenbron	<i>the Iron</i>
Kaelen	Maeva	Thrainkhar	<i>Breath-Steady</i>
Orthen	Saela	Valdurg	<i>Seal-Keeper</i>
Rurik	Aeldis	Kaelthane	<i>Bell-Tongue</i>
Bromm	Helka	Zarkul	<i>the Under-Mason</i>
Zelgur	Thorunn	Dornvael	<i>White-Ribbon</i>

Spades — Places (vaultmouths, descents, underways, crown seats)

- (Security/Gatekeeping) Vaultmouth Gate in a hillslope: bronze lungs for breath-tests, tally-niches for lamps.
- (Tradition/Oaths) Crown-Crypt Porch where oaths are sworn to sleeping kings.
- (Commerce/Underground) Under-Market: lantern alleys between cistern pillars; damp coin, dry wit.
- (Labor/Danger) Smoke-Shaft Stair spiraling up to a soot hatch; handprints black as seals.
- (Mystery/Whispers) Gloam Cistern—black water, lead scales, whispers carry too far.
- (Maintenance/Travel) Lamplighter’s Mile on the Under-Road; niches sting with spent wicks.
- (Precision/Authority) Measure Vault: standard rods and weights chained under glass and oath.
- (Sacred/Knowledge) Reliquary Arcade: bell-chimes answer drafts; saints keep their own tallies.

10. (Military/Strategic) Twin-Throne Gate—surface fortress straddling a chasm bridge.
 J (Knowledge/Secrecy) Deep Archive Stacks behind grillwork; scriptoria cells breathe ink and dust.
 Q (Royalty/Privilege) Queen’s Descent: private stair from palace to royal vault-house.
 K (Politics/Power) Kingsmoot Cavern—crownstones in a ring around a bottomless dark.
 A (Infrastructure/Majesty) The Spine Underway, a great tunnel linking crownlands beneath the peaks.

Hearts — People & Factions (crowns, keepers, guilds, legates)

2. (Apprenticeship/Dedication) Lamplighter apprentice with a jingling key-ring and soot in the lungs.
3. (Craft/Knowledge) Under-Mason who can hear stone shift a room away.
4. (Authority/Duty) Vault Warden with breath-ledger and seal-rods; patient as granite.
5. (Protection/Faith) Censer-Knight of the Dawn – fights miasma and men with equal zeal.
6. (Sacred/Craft) Key-Sister (monastic locksmith) who names wards like prayers.
7. (Commerce/Authority) Under-Market assessor whose stamp can starve or save a stall.
8. (Engineering/Expertise) Engineer of Underways (geometer) with rod, hammer, and the right maps.
9. (Tradition/Law) Oath-Keeper of the Crown Crypt – memory like iron, smile like law.
10. (Diplomacy/Authority) Legate of the Under-Seal, royal commissioner between kingdoms.
 J (Communication/Loyalty) White-Ribbon tunnel courier; runs blind, rings true.
 Q (Royalty/Authority) Vault-Queen of a crownland, sovereign above and below.
 K (Supreme Authority/Tradition) High King Beneath the Peaks, first among crowns by ancient concord.
 A (Spiritual Power/Resolution) Lumenor of the Under-Altars, one sentence opens doors and closes debates.

Clubs — Complications/Threats (air, water, stone, rite, jurisdiction)

2. (Danger/Disorientation) Bad air pocket—candles gutter blue; lungs complain, schedules fail.
3. (Disruption/Flood) Drip-flood from a burst cistern reroutes corridors without asking.
4. (Accident/Destruction) Gas flare kisses a lamp; eyebrows and evidence vanish.
5. (Error/Security) Seal misread—the wrong door opens, the right one will not.
6. (Quarantine/Delay) Under-mold quarantine shuts the market just as your crate arrives.
7. (Danger/Warning) Settling crack—dust snow warns the roof wants down.
8. (Accusation/Suspicion) Stolen key turns up in your kit; accusations ring like bells.
9. (Conflict/Jurisdiction) Bell-code conflict—two authorities claim the same chime.
10. (Political Conflict/Violence) Vault-right feud: crown guards face basilica wardens on a stair.
 J (Disaster/Trapped) Cave-in behind—proof, friends, and retreat on the far side.
 Q (Religious Conflict/Inquisition) Heresy inquest in the under-chapel; arrests in whispers.
 K (Authority/Restriction) General Under-Seal—all vault traffic halted by royal decree.

A (Natural Disaster/Destruction) White Flood—mountain thaw becomes a river through your route.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage (keys, passes, breath, priority, precedent)

2. (Utility/Time) Lamp-priority tally—skip one lamplighter queue.
 3. (Safety/Access) Breath-measure allotment—lawful time in a sealed chamber (once).
 4. (Security/Authority) Key-Writ—operate a named lock one time, witnessed.
 5. (Travel/Security) Underway Pass—escorted travel between two vaultmouths.
 6. (Commerce/Rights) Stall-Right in the under-market for a season.
 7. (Engineering/Safety) Engineer Shoring—a crew stabilizes your chosen corridor on your timetable.
 8. (Commerce/Trust) Assay Mark—your coin/metal accepted sight unseen below.
 9. (Protection/Law) Crypt Asylum—temporary sanctuary under crown law.
 10. (Authority/Access) Vault Inventory License—remove a named cache under witness.
- J (Military/Authority) Under-Guard Commission—command a vault detachment for a day.
- Q (Royalty/Privilege) Private Descent with the Vault-Queen or High King’s chancellor.
- K (Supreme Authority/Access) High King’s Sealed Writ—doors open, mouths close across crownlands.
- A (Exception/Power) The Under-Seal Clause—temporary exception to any lock, levy, or rite below.

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: **Spade** = place, **Heart** = actor, **Club** = pressure, **Diamond** = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5→4, 6–10→6, J/Q/K→8, A→10).
- Treat **Diamonds** as codified outcomes (keys/passes/rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any **A** appears, echo stone & breath motifs—keys click, bells answer, and the mountain listens (and remembers).

Additional Features

- **Count the Air:** When a scene establishes scarce air, a character who actively paces their breathing (counted steps, measured rests) may shift *Position* one step safer on their next physical action in a confined space.
- **Bell-Code Courtesy:** If the party adopts local bell etiquette (asking a warden which chime applies and heeding it), gain +1 assist die on negotiations or passage requests within a vault or under-market.
- **Measure is Mercy:** Presenting a certified measure (rod, weight, sealed tally) calms a dispute: cancel the first SB generated by commerce or jurisdictional friction in the scene.

Stone & Sovereignty

In the deep places, survival depends on precision and tradition. The Aeler understand that stone does not forgive error – a misread seal can mean death, a miscalculated air measure can doom an expedition, and a broken bell-code can spark jurisdictional war. Their society is built on layers of authority, each with its own rites, rights, and responsibilities. To navigate their realm is to learn a complex dance of deference and demand, where even the humblest lamplighter holds power over the darkness, and the smallest key can unlock the greatest vault.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **vault wardens or lamplighter companies**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **under-guards or echo bats**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or assessors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable air**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Breath warden or vault warden** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **air shift or seal change**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival crown's guard or gas wraith** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **crown guards, true masons, or lamp companies** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **seal misread/cave-in/flare ignites**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Vault-Queen, High King's Legate, or Lumenor** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **gas floods/water breaks/floor collapses**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Aeler (Stone & Breath):** Keys click in the wrong locks, bells answer without being rung, mountain air grows thin without warning.
- **Aeler (Authority & Tradition):** A seal is misread, bell-codes conflict between jurisdictions, a vault warden demands proper credentials.
- **Aeler (Underground Hazards):** Bad air pockets form, settling cracks warn of collapse, gas flares ignite unexpectedly.

Aeler — Under-Vault Tensions

Starting Location: An Underway junction lit by guttering brass lanterns, its stone walls scored with tally-marks from a dozen forgotten crowns.

“Among the Aeler, stone remembers the weight of oaths, and every echo calls a reckoning.”

In... An Underway junction, a Geometer halts the party with a tally-rod. “The Spine shifts,” he says, stone-dust in his beard. “Choose a crown—or be buried by one.”

Regional Motifs Load-bearing oaths, fault-prayers, crown-rights, catacomb guilds.

Whispers to Offer “Cut a supporting tie,” “Sign for another’s debt,” “Take a shortcut through the sealed tunnel.”

External Clocks Threat: “The Spine Slips”; Fracture: “Maps Reorder”; Community: “Surface Panic.”

Complications Load-lights dim; echoes reply in politics; crown agents arrive early.

Anchors at Risk A PC’s workshop; a shared refuge tunnel.

Escalation Beat The tally-rod points to the most guilty PC.

Relief Shore a vault with sacrifice (1 anchor), or complete a truce between crowns; Spirit + Resolve (5) to hold a cave-in long enough to evacuate.

Faction Entanglements

- **Edgewalkers (Prospectors):** If you accept their escort or intel, start a 4-segment *Opportunity* clock you can cash for +1 Effect on one venture. If you refuse a posted hazard, they post *your* route as “open” (first stealth or smuggling roll this leg suffers –1 die).
- **True Masons (Infrastructure Orders):** Pledge tools or labor to earn a *Mason’s Stamp* (treat as papers to traverse construction zones). Cross a marked barrier without their leave and gain the *Tampered Work* tag—first structural mishap SB against you is free.
- **Lamplighter Companies:** Donate wick, oil, or time on the Mile to bank a *Lamp Credit*; spend to ignore darkness penalties once on the Under-Road. Skip a service bell and all under-market buys that scene cost +1 clock tick (queues & suspicion).

- **Under-Market Assessors:** Submit to measure/weigh and reduce Commerce DV by 1 this scene. Try to pass unassayed goods—on a Miss, lose the load *or* accept a *Caveat Stamp* that poisons your price two markets downstream.
- **Breath Wardens:** Register bodies & flames before sealed work; compliance cancels the first air-hazard SB. Skipping registry adds a *Thin Air* tick to the leg (applies −1 die to the first exertion test in confinement).

Cross-Regional Ties & Soft Power

- **Agrarian Reliance (Human Breadbelts):** Grain, timber, tallow, and fleece convoys from Acasia/Vhasia/Viterra sustain vault populations. Famine or levy spikes uprange impose night rationing: Under-Road checks +1 DV and food trades add +1 SB pressure until relief.
- **Standards Diplomacy:** Aeler *Measure Vault* rods adopted abroad grant +1 die to settle disputes in foreign markets; rejecting Aeler standards increases toll and inspection frequency (first border scene gains a free “Lock/Barrier” SB).
- **True Mason Missions Abroad:** Accept a Mason cadre to “stabilize” bridges, ports, or sluices: reduce Travel DV by 1 on that route for the arc, but the route now respects Aeler closure bells (authorities can halt traffic with one writ).
- **Edgewalker Concessions:** Prospect notes traded to frontier lords exchange for wayleaves and salvage rights; cash once for an *Under-Seal Clause (local)* or accept a rival claimant clock that will mature if you delay.
- **Kahfagian Interface (Sea Monopoly):** Aeler export hard-goods via Kahfagian factors; storm seasons or privateer scares add a *Harbor Quarantine* tick to any surface leg feeding those ports (customs DV +1).
- **Aelerem/Aelinnel Fallout:** When *Valewood Weather* is signaled, Aeler works creak; all bell-codes in mixed settlements (Aelerem/Aelinnel) are one step easier to misread (first bell-etiquette scene: add a free “Error/Security” SB unless you consult a local).

Trade Goods & Consequences

- **Airworks & Wick (Oil, Char, Filters):** Donate to a vault—bank a *Breath Favor* to cancel the next bad-air complication. Hoard in a shortage and your lot is flagged; all purchases beneath that crown suffer −1 die until you settle a fine or tithe.
- **Stonework & Ironwork (Beams, Keys, Rods):** Selling to foreign keeps spreads Aeler codes: once per arc, treat a foreign gate as if it used Aeler warding (gain +1 die with Key-Sisters/warders there). Counterfeit measure rods trigger a cross-border inquest clock.
- **Foodflows (Grain, Fleece, Tallow):** Move relief trains to clear one *Rationing* tag for a settlement (DV −1 for social checks there). Divert a relief train and gain an *Audit* clock that follows you three markets hence.
- **Cistern-Right & Water Engineering:** Fund a sluice or cistern abroad to gain *Water Priority* (skip one queue during drought). Neglect maintenance and the keeper may invoke *Aeler Liability*—pay or lose access to the route for a season.

Patron Networks (Below and Beyond)

- **The Sealed Gate:** Consecrated door-nails from True Mason kits act as single-use *stay* writs (negate one forced entry this scene).

- **The Traveler:** Spine milestones double as wayshrines; leave a brass chit to reroll one failed travel test on that segment this arc.
- **Inquisitor Prime:** Breath-pure censers sanction “clean rooms”; once per delve, dispel one ambient miasma or ward-rot effect at cost of +1 Obligation to local abbey-knights.
- **Maelstraeus:** Under-Market stalls tithe to the Great Ledger; cash a *Market Dominance* tick to flip one price band in your favor for a scene, then mark a 4-segment *Karmic Debt* with assessors.

Survival-Horror Procedures (Use Often)

- **Headcount & Flamecount:** At scene start in confinement, ask “Who breathes, what burns?” If headcount+flamecount exceeds posted limit, add a free “Thin Air” SB and start a 4-segment *Stale Air* clock.
- **Two Bells to Safety:** Any time the fiction stalls underground, ring two nearby bells (authority vs. sanctum). PCs must pick one to heed; ignoring both increases the next hazard’s Cap by +1 (stone holds grudges).
- **Measure or Mistrust:** Producing a certified rod/weight cancels the first commerce/jurisdiction SB this scene; failing to present one imposes –1 die on haggling or passage until appeased.

Diplomatic Favor & Reputation Echoes

- **Breath Favor (minor resource):** Earned by donating wick/oil or assisting air wardens. Spend to downgrade one underground hazard outcome or to bypass a lamplighter queue.
- **Stamps & Seals:**
 - *Mason-Marked:* Doors to worksites open; smugglers avoid you (harder to buy contraband, easier to cross safely).
 - *Edge-Trusted:* Prospectors share fresh maps—first detour per leg is free; officials eye you as opportunists (first civic audience DV +1).
 - *Assessor-Clean:* Under-markets honor your assay; rivals spread rumors—add a trailing *Audit* clock if you score a windfall.

Boss Archetypes in Aeler

Systemic / Economic / Conspiracy

- **Under-Market Syndic (Cartel/Measure Fraud):** Price-fixes breath, wick, and water; wields corrupt assay marks to starve rivals. *Win by exposing forged measures or seizing the Assay Chain.*
- **True Mason Provost (Infrastructure Coup):** Locks cities behind “safety closures,” weaponizes detours and permits. *Win by forcing a public bell-code audit or breaking the Permit Clock.*
- **Edgewalker Concessionaire (Route Monopolist):** Controls salvage and short-cuts, posts hazards to strangle traffic. *Win by proving route tampering or opening a sanctioned bypass.*
- **Bell-Code Inquisitor (Silent Coup):** Rewrites chimes to shift jurisdiction; arrests arrive as echoes. *Win by restoring canonical bell charts or capturing the Chime Key.*

Survival Horror (Environment as Boss)

- **White Flood (Water/Pressure):** Thaw-swollen river through the halls; phases at *trickle* → *surge* → *roar*. Win by *sluicework*, *sacrificial breach*, or *riding the flood*.
- **Bad Air (Miasma/Invisible):** Candles gutter blue; thoughts slow; corridors choose the slowest. Win by *air discipline*, *filter rites*, or *opening a lung-shaft*.
- **Hungry Stone (Creep/Collapse):** Settling cracks hunt noise and heat; shudders on every miss. Win by *shoring*, *silence*, and *rerouting stress through old ribs*.
- **Lamp Famine (Darkness/Isolation):** Wicks fail in sequence; last lights lure you deeper. Win by *restoring the Lamplighter's Mile* or *kindling a saint-wick*.

Undead / Fallen Kingdom / Eldritch / Demonic

- **Crown-Lich of the Crypt (Undead Sovereign):** Keeps ancient offices; binds petitioners with oaths to the dead. Win by *repealing a mortmain writ* or *severing the Oath-Chain*.
- **Echo-King in the Deep (Eldritch Memory):** A throne of voices; answers every argument you will ever make. Win by *changing the Measure (new precedent)* or *striking the Silent Note*.
- **Seal-Devil (Demonic Contract):** Lives in locks and signatures; eats exceptions. Win by *offering a flawless counter-seal* or *starving it of loopholes*.
- **The Hollow Architect (Fallen Works):** A ghost-guilder rebuilding the empire wrong on purpose. Win by *unkeying the master plan* or *collapsing the false load paths*.

Boss Mechanics Notes

- **Air & Light Tracks:** In confined scenes, track *Headcount*, *Flamecount*. If *Headcount* + *Flamecount* exceeds posted limit, add a free “Thin Air” SB and start **Stale Air** [4]. Each tick imposes −1 die to exertion until vented.
- **Jurisdiction Clocks:** Many bosses run a **Bell-Code Conflict** [4] or **Seal Dispute** [6]. On fill, the boss gains *Authority Surge*: increase their social DV by +1 and seize initiative once.
- **Lair Actions (choose 2–3):**
 - *Collapse Probe*: Mark “Settling Crack”; nearest noisy PC tests PROWESS or risk *Pin/Separate*.
 - *Breath Tax*: Reduce *Flamecount* by 1; next exertion in zone costs Fatigue 1 on a miss.
 - *Blackout/Glare*: Snuff or flare lamps; impose Disorient (−1 die) until a *Lamplighter Action* restores balance.
 - *Bell Override*: Swap which faction’s law applies; social actions vs. boss gain +1 DV this round.
 - *White Flood Surge*: Advance environment clock; force MOVE/WRECK or be *Separated*.
- **Phase Triggers:** Environment bosses phase when *Air* hits 2/4, *Water* hits 3/6, or *Light* hits 0; Conspiracy bosses phase when *Audit* or *Permit* clocks fill.
- **Truth & Measure:** Producing a certified rod/weight cancels the first commerce/jurisdiction SB each phase; forging one gives the boss 1 SB and a free *Expose Fraud* reaction.
- **Crowd Pressure:** In under-markets, add **Panic Crowd** [4]; each tick adds +1 DV to precise actions (shoot, pick, ritual) unless calmed with bell-code or coin.
- **Fear Hooks (optional):** *Bad Air* inflicts FEAR vs. suffocation; *Echo-King* inflicts FEAR vs. isolation; *Seal-Devil* inflicts FEAR vs. helplessness. On Fail: mark *Shaken*; on Critical Fail: drop a resource (*lamp*, *key*, *breath*).

Chapter 10

The Mistlands

Bells, Salt, and Breath. A protectorate of the Aeler, the Mistlands belong to fog and bells. Every levee hums with ward-notes, every ferry takes salt as tithe, and every shadow is measured against the Direwood’s endless breath. The people here live by the weight of salt, the echo of bells, and the hope that their names will not be spoken by the mists.

10.1 Mistlands — “Bells, Salt, and Breath”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The mist counts your breaths. The bells remember your name.*

Legate of Mists (Elite): “The bells here do more than mark time — they weave the very fabric of reality, keeping the mist at bay and the dead in their proper places. Each chime is a thread in the pattern that holds the world together.”

Salt-Monk (Commoner): “Salt don’t just preserve the fish — it holds back the things that shouldn’t walk. Every grain blessed is a prayer, and every prayer keeps the mist from remembering your name.”

Genre / Mood: Folk horror, coastal gothic, supernatural debt-collection.

Starting Location: A Bell-Line levee veiled in fog, where bell-ropes sway though no wind stirs, and each ring tastes like a heartbeat. A Ferryman demands a name as toll. When the party hesitates, a Bell-Warden steps forward. “The Ninth Bell rings tonight. Will you answer — or flee?”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Mistlands lie north of the Aelerian mountains, where the Aberderrin Sea laps against reed-fens and drowned shores. To the west, the Direwood breathes; to the east, the salt tides of the Aberderrin. It is a Protectorate of the Aeler, but their iron passes only hold the southern roads — the land itself belongs to fog and bells. Every levee hums with ward-notes, every ferry takes salt as tithe, and every shadow is measured against the Direwood’s endless breath. The people here live by the weight of salt, the echo of bells, and the hope that their names will not be spoken by the mists.

What you notice first: The constant, distant chime of bells — never quite in sync. The taste of salt on your lips even inland. The way everyone holds their breath when crossing a bridge.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never answer a voice that calls your name from the fog. The mist collects names, and once it has yours, the ferryman will always know where to find you.

Regional Mood: Bells and Breath

Here, breath is currency and silence a sin. Every exhalation is counted by the ward-bells, and every stolen inhalation feeds something that should not be. The Aeler Protectorate maintains order with ledgers and patrols, but the real law is older: salt lines drawn at dusk, iron nails hammered into threshold posts, and the unspoken knowledge that the ninth bell must never ring. The Mistlands do not forgive forgetfulness. The mist has a long memory, and it shares its grudges freely.

Prominent NPCs of the Mistlands

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Legate Halvar	Aeler governor of the Protectorate	Keep the bell-lines intact and the grain flowing east	She carries a bell that has never been rung. It will ring once, at the end of her reign.
Mother Anja	Salt-Monk of the White Pans	Preserve the old wards against the Direwood	Her tongue is white with salt; she speaks only in blessings or silence.
Warden Kael	Bell-Warden of the High Line	Protect his village from the mist and the Aeler tax-men	He refuses to write down the ninth note; it lives only in his fading memory.

Sister Darya	Healer of the Grey Hospice of the Unnamed (Temple of Light)	Tend the fog-sick and the drowned	Her grey robes never stain, and she asks no payment — only a name for her ledger.
Notary Voss	Covenant judge (Mykkiel)	Impose Aeler law on local customs	He carries a water-clock to measure the shifting of legal moods. The mist ignores it.
The Ferryman	Oath-ferryman of the Ghost Slip	Collect fares in salt and whispered names	His left hand is always gloved; underneath, the names are carved into his palm.

Names of the Mistlands

Inspired by the coastal fens and the Aeler protectorate: clipped, breathy, with soft vowels and hard endings. Surnames often denote a marsh, a craft, or a ward.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Halvar	Anja	Foss	<i>the Bell-Sworn</i>
Kael	Darya	Mork	<i>Fog-Born</i>
Voss	Pia	Saltvedt	<i>the Unnamed</i>
Torben	Lise	Kyst	<i>Breath-Thief</i>
Stian	Ragna	Dyrep	<i>Ward-Keeper</i>
Vidar	Signe	Tangen	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

(Fen/Levee/Bell-line) Reed-fen causey with chalked ward-runes on every milestone; Bell-Line levee with iron posts and eight bells per span.

Spades — Places

- 2. Reed-Fen Causey** — Chalked ward-runes on every milestone; safe path through the mist. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *Step only on the chalked stones. The mud between has no bottom.*
- 3. Bell-Line Levee** — Iron posts, eight bells per span; one bracket empty, one note forbidden. ‘[WARD]’ *The empty bracket is for the bell that never rings. The rope is still there.*
- 4. Ghost-Ferry Slip** — Rope crosses black water; fares paid in salt and whispered names. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The ferryman never blinks. Some say he traded his eyelids for the right to collect.*

5. **Pall Watch-Tower** — Piles above mire; mirrors face west to the Direwood's breath. '[WARD]'
The mirrors are silvered on both sides. The wardens watch their own reflections as much as the trees.
6. **Mist-Chapel** — Stilted planks; votive lanterns gutter under damp rafters. '[RITUAL]' *The icon has no face. Worshippers say it lost its features to the fog, one by one.*
7. **Dead-Cut Canal** — Old imperial ditch; patrolled by eel boats and law. '[TRAVEL]' *The eels have eyes like men. Fishermen throw back any that blink.*
8. **Drowned Copse** — Root-tangles clutch tide like old hands; bones in the bark. '[DEATH]'
The trees were planted on a mass grave. They grew twisted, hungry.
9. **Fogmill Ridge** — Wind vanes vanish into cloud; gears hiss like prayers to fog. '[WEATHER]'
The miller grinds salt, not grain. His customers pay in breath, not coin.
10. **Salt-Pan Terraces** — Patched with peat; ward-salt dries under nets, watched by monks. '[RESOURCE]'
The monks chant without ceasing. If they stop, the salt spoils — and so does the warding.
- J **Fort-Stair** — Stacked timber and stone; flags swallowed by mist, guards by routine. '[AUTHORITY]'
The flags are changed daily. The ones that vanish are never spoken of again.
- Q **Witchlight Bridge** — Over black runnel; ninth plank "counted" but unseen. '[THRESHOLD]'
The missing plank is there — you just can't see it. Step where it should be, or don't step at all.
- K **High-Mist Pass** — Through Aelerians; cairns ringed in iron nails, bells in the stones. '[TRAVEL]'
Each cairn holds a bell that rang once at the death of a warden. They ring again when mist takes another.
- A **Weeping Gate** — Western palisade facing Direwood; bells wired to bones of trees. '[WARD]'
[DEATH]' *The gate weeps sap that smells of iron and old grief. Wardens collect it in silver cups.*

(Warden/Ferryman/Aeler) Bell-warden whose ringbook decides which notes keep which ghosts; oath-ferryman collecting fares in salt and names.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Reed-Cutter** — Peat-black hands, precise opinion on fog; knows every safe path. '[TRAVEL]'
She cuts reeds in a pattern — one snip, two snips, then a pause for the ninth.
3. **Salt-Monk** — Blesses pans, keeps ward-measure honest; salt as both shield and vow. '[RITUAL]'
His tongue is white with salt. He speaks only in blessings or silence.
4. **Bell-Warden** — Ringbook decides which notes keep which ghosts at bay. '[WARD]' *She refuses to write down the ninth note. It lives only in her memory — and that memory is fading.*
5. **Oath-Ferryman** — Fares in salt and names; remembers both, collects both. '[DEATH]'
[SOCIAL]' *His left hand is always gloved. Underneath, the names are carved into his palm.*
6. **Lantern Acolyte** — Trims wicks and arguments; light as law in the mist. '[AUTHORITY]'
He carries a bell on his belt. It rings once for each lie he hears.
7. **Mist-Pilot** — Linn refugee; ghosts ships through reed-lace — if paid in breath. '[TRAVEL]'
She never speaks above a whisper. Her voice is currency, and she spends it carefully.

8. **Protectorate Clerk** — Aeler oilskin ledgers, narrow smile; law in triplicate. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
His stamp is a bell. He presses it twice — once for the crown, once for the Hollow.
9. **Shroud-Diver** — Harvests tokens from drowned fields before dawn’s false light. ‘[STEALTH]’
‘[DEATH]’ *He wears a bell around his ankle. If it rings, he’s stayed too long.*
10. **Direwood Refugee** — Cold breath, colder stories; knows what the trees whisper. ‘[FEAR]’
She carved out her own tongue. The trees still speak through her — in a voice not her own.
- J **Fog-Knight** — Cavalry rides levee crowns by bellcode; mist as their steed. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
‘[COMBAT]’ *Their horses have no shadows. Some say they traded them for fog-sight.*
- Q **Legate of Mists** — Aeler governor; equal parts mercy and decree, bells at their command.
‘[AUTHORITY]’ *She carries a bell that has never been rung. It will ring once, at the end of her reign.*
- K **Lord Warden** — Local strong hand sworn to Legate’s seal; law walks the fens. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
He lost an eye to a wight. He wears a bell in the socket.
- A **Mist-Seer** — Bargains breath for answers; candles shorten when she speaks. ‘[MAGIC]’
‘[FEAR]’ *She has no shadow. The mist took it as a down payment.*

(Undead/Weather/Law) Ground-mist lifts off fen and eats tracks by the yard; witchlights try to count you; step wrong and bridge forgets you.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Ground-Mist** — Lifts from fen; eats tracks by the yard, names by the breath. ‘[WEATHER]’
‘[DEATH]’ *Your footfalls vanish behind you. The mist is following, not rising.*
3. **Witchlight Count** — Trying to count you; step wrong and bridge forgets your path.
‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *The lights flicker in a pattern — two short, two long. They’re signaling someone.*
4. **Ward-Salt Short** — Pans go green; bells ring, nothing answers from the other side. ‘[RE-SOURCE]’ ‘[WARD]’
The salt is grey, not white. Someone cut it with grave dust.
5. **Wrong Bell** — Cracked note opens a door the Legate can’t close; mist takes the gap.
‘[MAGIC]’ *The bell’s clapper is a finger bone. The original owner wants it back.*
6. **Linn Raid** — Slips reed-maze; hearths douse, horns travel on the fog. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The raiders wear bells on their belts — stolen from the last village.*
7. **Direwood Moan** — At dusk; Weeping Gate ropes go taut by themselves. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[FEAR]’
The moan has words. You don’t want to understand them.
8. **Valewood Wind** — Crosses Aberderrin; voices sweet, landmarks false. ‘[WEATHER]’
‘[MAGIC]’ *The wind smells of honey and rot. Do not follow it.*
9. **Bell-Line Failure** — Levee breaks silence; wraith steps across like it owns the road. ‘[WARD]’
‘[DEATH]’ *The wraith carries a lantern. The light is blue — the colour of drowned breath.*
10. **Marsh-Quake** — Sod heaves, dyke slumps; proofs and bodies sink together. ‘[DISASTER]’
The ground exhales. Your name rises from it like smoke.
- J **Protectorate Interdiction** — All ferries sealed “until review”; routes dry up. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’
The seals are stamped with a bell. The wax is mixed with bone ash.

- Q **Rite-Purge** — Inspectors call local customs heresy; tempers at a boil. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
 ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The inspectors carry blank ledgers. They fill them with names of the accused.*
- K **General Alarm** — Pall horns sound; every lantern becomes law, every shadow suspect.
 ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *The horns are made from the tusks of a sea beast. The beast’s
 ghost is angry.*
- A **Tide-Mist** — Rolls from Aberderrin; spirits ride the white and won’t be named. ‘[WEATHER]’
 ‘[DEATH]’ *The spirits have no faces — only the faces of the drowned.*

(Pass/Seal/Token) Ward-salt allotment draws safe circle once; ferry token crosses named black runnel regardless of curfew.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Ward-Salt** — Pure measure draws safe circle once; mist parts, briefly. ‘[WARD]’ *The salt is warm. It knows it will be used.*
 3. **Ferry Token** — Cross named black runnel regardless of curfew or tide. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The token is a knuckle bone. The ferryman accepts it without comment.*
 4. **Bell-Key** — Unlock and set one bell on the Line to your note; change the song. ‘[MAGIC]’
The key is a tuning fork. Strike it once to claim your note.
 5. **Lantern Writ** — Lawful travel at night along levee crown with escort. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’
The writ is written on dried bladder. It crinkles when you lie.
 6. **Exorcist’s Seal** — Stamped clause downgrades “haunt” to “nuisance.” ‘[MAGIC]’ *The seal is a bell without a clapper. It’s silent, like the wraiths it binds.*
 7. **Codeleaf** — Today’s mirror and horn sequences; fog cannot hide what you know. ‘[TRAVEL]’
The leaf is soaked in brine. Read it before it dries.
 8. **Protectorate Mark** — Priority rations and rope from Fort-Stair stores. ‘[RESOURCE]’ *The mark is a brand. It smokes when you show it.*
 9. **Wraith-Indemnity** — Legal immunity for actions taken under apparition threat. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
The indemnity is signed in salt water. It will dissolve if you misuse it.
 10. **Bone-Field License** — Salvage rights at drowned hamlet (with witnesses). ‘[RESOURCE]’
The license is a map drawn on a shroud. Follow the stitch marks.
- J **Refuge-Right** — Move a named household through Gate unchallenged; breath as passport.
 ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The right is a bell-rope. Tie it to your belt. Nonna will ask.*
- Q **Legate’s Audience** — One whisper exits as policy; bells ring your decree. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
The Legate’s ear is a silver bell. Speak into it once.
- K **Warden’s Commission** — Raise levee guards; local doors open, purses too. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
The commission is a whistle. Blow it, and the fens answer.
- A **Pall Indulgence** — Temporary exception to ward law, spoken and sealed by bell. ‘[MAGIC]’
 ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The indulgence is a single bell-note, held in a jar. Break the jar to release it.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (passes/seals/tokens) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **breath and boundary** — bells answering across water, salt that won’t dry, voices returning late.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Breath-Toll:** Many claim the mist remembers every breath. Travelers hold breath crossing bridges, fearing the mist will count them wrong. Mechanically, when you cross a threshold without a ward-salt or bell, roll Spirit + Resolve (DV 3). On a failure, the mist learns your name — gain the **MARKED** condition (the next spirit encounter starts at Desperate Position).
- **Salt as Promise:** A handful of salt is more than warding — it is a vow. Spill it on plank or stone to swear safety. Once per session, a character may spend a handful of ward-salt to create a **Salt Oath** [4] clock. While the clock has segments, the oath-taker gains +1 die to resist fear or possession. If the oath is broken, the clock fills and the breaker takes Harm 1 (spiritual backlash).
- **The Ninth Bell:** Legends say a ninth bell once rang on the Line. The note is not in any ringbook; no warden speaks of it. Some nights, though, it rings — and gates open where none should be. When the GM spends 3+ SB in a scene, they may declare that the Ninth Bell rings. All characters must test Spirit + Resolve (DV 4) or lose 1 Fatigue (the sound steals breath).
- **Payden’s Port:** The only true city in the Mistlands, huddled on the western coast of the Aberderrin. Its wharves are built from salvaged longship timber, and its law is split between the Aeler Legate’s seal and the old bell-wardens’ traditions. Grain ships leave from its harbour each autumn, carrying the Protectorate’s tithe east — and returning with iron, engineers, and the occasional missionary.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Bell-Keeper** — The Sealed Gate. *A bell that never rings, yet holds the threshold closed.*
 - **The Salted One** — Oath of Mercy and Grace. *A prayer that preserves body and soul, but demands a name in return.*
 - **The Mist-Father** — Khemesh. *The pressure beneath the fog; the hunger that waits in still air.*
 - **The Lantern Bearer** — The Traveler. *The light that guides lost ships — and lost souls.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Saint Kael of the Iron Bell (The Sealed Gate):** The bell-wardens venerate a legendary warden who hammered a ninth bell into the Weeping Gate to seal a Direwood breach. The bell cracked, but the breach closed. His chisel is kept at Payden’s Port; it is said to quench the mist for an hour if struck against an iron post. The Aeler Protectorate has tried to confiscate it twice; both attempts ended with the confiscators lost in fog.

- **Saint Anja of the White Pans (Oath of Mercy and Grace):** A salt-monk who died blessing the pans during a tide-mist. Her body never decayed, and her chapel now serves as a hospice for fog-sick sailors. The Temple of Light sends offerings of fresh water each spring; the Everflame considers her a heretic. Pilgrims who pray at her shrine may ask one question of a drowned ancestor — but the answer is always a single word, and that word is a tithe.
- **The Grey Hospice of the Unnamed:** Sister Darya runs a hospice near Payden's Port. She asks no payment, but she records every patient's name in a ledger that never dries. The Aeler clerks suspect she is erasing records, not healing wounds. She has been investigated three times; each time, the investigator vanished into the fog and returned with no memory of why they came.
- **The Bell-Ringer's Covenant (The Keeper of the Silent Seal):** Notary Voss is the Protectorate's appointed judge, charged with imposing Aeler law on local customs. He carries a water-clock to measure the shifting of legal moods, but the mist ignores it. His rulings are always delivered in triplicate, and the bell-wardens obey them — slowly. Those who lie before him find that their next passage through the Ghost-Ferry Slip is denied; the ferryman refuses to name them.
- **The Ninth:** In any Mistlands scene, the ninth person to speak in a room draws the mist's attention. The wise hold their tongues until someone else breaks the count. Those who speak ninth are said to see a pale figure standing at the foot of the bed that night — waiting to collect a breath.

Mistlands Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Fog:** Toss a crust into the mist before crossing a bridge. Ignore the first *Ground-Mist* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Hold the Ninth Breath:** Cross a threshold while holding your breath. Cancel *Witchlight Count* or take -1 die on your next action (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Salt:** Whisper a dead enemy's name into a salt pan. Gain +1 Effect against undead for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Legate. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **wardens or fog-knights**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **spirits or patrol boats**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or mist-spirits**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favourable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** Protectorate forces or local warden becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **mist shift or bell failure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A wraith, raiding party, or inspector arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.

- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **fog-knights, spirits, or Aeler forces** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes — **bell-line fails/ward broken/mist claims name**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Legate, Lord Warden, or Mist-Seer** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically — **mist thickens/bells ring/forest breathes**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice — **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Mistlands (Bells & Breath):** Bells ring without cause, breath forms visible words, mirrors reflect wrong faces.
- **Mistlands (Salt & Warding):** Salt refuses to dry, ward-runes bleed colour, protection tokens crack.
- **Mistlands (Direwood Threat):** Trees whisper your name, roots shift position, forest breath grows stronger.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Navigation):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Fog Bank*.
- **Silence the Bell (Presence + Stealth):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a ward-salt pouch is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Tide (Resolve + Survival):** On a hit in *Tide-Mist*, you pick who keeps their bearings; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Bell & Breath)

- **The Ninth Bell Ringer (Direwood herald)** — *Phases:* Lost Names → Broken Lines → Open Gate. *Cracks:* restore a ringbook; trade a breath; rehang a forbidden bell with copper nails.
- **Queen of Counting Lights (fae arbiter)** — *Phases:* Courteous Tithes → Geas-Market → Ledger of Leaves. *Cracks:* return stolen way-marks; speak said and meant; gild the iron.

- **Reed-Wolf Captain (Linn raider)** — *Phases*: Smoke Signals → Night Oars → Thing Verdict. *Cracks*: name a feud-token; win a skald-duel; force harbour-truce under bell and banner.

Patronage & Power

In the Mistlands, power flows through ritual, warding, and the careful balance between the living and the dead. The Aeler Protectorate maintains nominal control through military presence and legal frameworks, but true authority lies with those who understand the bells, the salt, and the breath of the land itself. Local wardens, salt-monks, and bell-keepers hold sway over daily life, while the Legate of the Mists mediates between imperial law and ancient custom.

For the GM: Patronage in the Mistlands revolves around protection — from mist, from spirits, from the encroaching forest. Rewards often take the form of tokens, seals, or safe passage that can be leveraged into greater security. To emphasise the folk-horror feel:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (salt, bells, lanterns) that can be challenged, depleted, or voided by the mist itself.
- Let rival factions (Protectorate vs. bell-wardens vs. Direwood refugees) issue conflicting protections, forcing players to choose whose favour matters more.
- Use the levees, ferries, and watchtowers as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of the old ways (counting breaths, naming spirits, offering salt) determines success.

In the Mistlands, your safety is your standing, and your standing depends on who remembers your name.

Black Barrow Keep — The Ruin Above Payden's Port

Looming over the eastern edge of Payden's Port, Black Barrow Keep is a jagged wound in the skyline. Its basalt walls weep salt, and its broken towers lean into the fog like old men listening for a bell that never rings. The Aelinnel built it in a forgotten age—not as a fortress, but as a *workshop*. Here, they forged bell-automata, copper sentinels, and the first ward-lines that still keep the Direwood at bay. When the Mistlands became a Protectorate, the Aelinnel sealed the deep forges and retreated. The locals say the keep is haunted. The truth is worse: it is not haunted—it is *occupied*.

Below the keep, the catacombs stretch down through nine known levels. Each level was sealed by a different generation of wrights: Aeler engineers, Aelinnel bell-smiths, Linn shipwrights, and older crafts whose names are scrubbed from the records. The lowest level is said to contain a working that has been ticking since before the Hollow learned to count.

Accessing the Keep: The main gate is chained with a bell-lock that requires a copper key and the correct sequence of rings (eight, never nine). Side entrances include a collapsed ropeway from the salt pans, a flooded stair from the Ghost-Ferry Slip, and a smugglers' tunnel that exits near the Grey Hospice. The Protectorate has officially sealed the keep, but wardens look the other way for a share of salvage—or a story about what moves in the deep.

Generator — Black Barrow Keep: Rooms & Encounters

Roll 2d6 (one for area, one for feature) or simply 1d12 for a quick room hook.

d12	Area / Encounter
1	The Hanging Bell-Garden. A collapsed floor reveals a chamber where bells grow from the ceiling like stalactites. Each bell has a clapper shaped like a finger bone. <i>Effect: A bell that rings once for each secret spoken beneath it. The ringing can be heard throughout the keep.</i>
2	The Copper Forge. Still warm, though the fire went out centuries ago. A half-completed automaton sits on the anvil. Its brass skull is hinged open; inside, a nest of salt-eels writhes. <i>Effect: The forge can be reactivated with a bell-key, producing a single ward-salt token per scene.</i>
3	The Oublette of the Unnamed. A pit lined with counting marks — eight scratches, a gap, eight scratches. At the bottom, a wright's skeleton still holds a hammer. The hammer rings when you touch it. <i>Effect: The hammer can drive a copper nail into any surface, sealing a threshold for one scene.</i>
4	The Echo Scriptorium. Shelves of slate tablets, each inscribed with a single number. The numbers are not in sequence. A ghost wright sits at a desk, writing the same number over and over. <i>Effect: The ghost will answer one question about the keep's history, but will then ask for a number you have never written.</i>
5	The Drowned Armoury. Sealed by a slow leak from the salt pans. Weapons float in brine. One of them — a bell-hilted sword — hums when you near it. <i>Effect: The sword counts your heartbeats. If you draw it in combat, you gain +1 die, but the sword will demand a name at the end of the scene.</i>
6	The Weeping Cistern. A stone basin filled with black water. The water rises when you speak. A voice from below asks, “What is the ninth number?” <i>Effect: Answer with silence, and the water recedes, revealing a sealed door. Answer incorrectly, and the cistern floods the room.</i>
7	The Cogwheel Choir. A chamber of interlocking copper gears, each tooth stamped with a rune. When the wind blows through the broken wall, the gears turn and the runes sing a cracked hymn. <i>Effect: A character who learns the tune may reroll one failed navigation test while in the Mistlands (once).</i>
8	The Salt-Liche's Studio. A wright who refused to die. Its flesh is replaced by salt-cured leather and copper wire. It still tries to finish a bell that has no clapper. <i>Effect: The salt-liche is not hostile, but will trade a bell-key for a memory of fresh water.</i>
9	The Unstable Lift. A chain-hoist that descends into darkness. The chains are warm. The lift stops at every eighth floor, never the ninth. <i>Effect: Riding the lift skips two levels of the catacombs, but ticks the FOG ATTENTION clock by 1.</i>
10	The Bone Gallery. A corridor lined with the remains of wrights from every generation. Each skeleton wears a different style of bell-maker's apron. The newest apron is still damp. <i>Effect: A PC may spend a</i>

Factions in the Keep

- **The Bell-Wrights' Ghosts:** Ancient Aelinnel spirits who still maintain the lower forges. They ignore the living unless the forges are disturbed. Offerings of copper nails or a correctly rung bell will buy safe passage.
- **The Protectorate Salvage Team:** Aeler engineers and a squad of fog-knights, ostensibly “surveying” the keep for hazards. They will confiscate any working bell they find and arrest anyone without a Protectorate writ. Their captain has a brass hand that is also a tuning fork.
- **The Hollow's Anticipators:** A cult that believes the keep was built to contain the Hollow's attention. They leave offerings of salt and silence. They are not dangerous — but they will follow you, writing down every bell you ring and every name you speak.

Catacombs Depth Clock For expeditions that descend below the first sub-level, track a **Depth Clock** [6]. Each time the party descends a stair, uses the unstable lift, or passes a sealed door, tick the clock. At 3 segments: all navigation rolls gain +1 DV (the walls shift). At 6 segments: the party reaches a sealed level that requires a bell-key, a blood offering, or a true name to open. The deepest level (Depth 6 or more) connects to the Ways Between — a mistake may drop the party into the Hollow's own threshold.

Chapter 11

Ykrul

Wolf Standards, Winter Camps. The Ykrul ride the Violet Steppe where horizon meets sky and law rides in saddlebags. Hosts gather by the thousand yet break into fragments at a word. Their banners are wolves' teeth, their treaties braided strings, their memory longer than the rivers that cross their roads. Midh-Akhaz, the war-camp turned city, marks the eastern edge of their grazing grounds.

11.1 Ykrul — “Wolf Standards, Winter Camps”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The steppe remembers every oath. The wolf counts your breaths.*

Genre / Mood: Nomadic epic, honour-bound geometry, wind-whispered law.

Starting Location: A winter camp on the steppe edge, banners snapping in frost-bright wind as the Khagan's fires burn in the east. A Khatun of the Ring offers a clay cup of salted tea. “The Khagan's kin ride from the salt pan. The old sayings say the straight road is a lie. You came by the bent path — the wolf knows you. Speak your errand before the wind changes.”

Khatun of the Ring (Elite): “The steppe remembers every oath sworn beneath its endless sky, and the wolf-standards carry the honour of clans that have outlasted empires. To lead here is to keep the old ways sharp as winter steel.”

Herd-Scout (Commoner): “The horses know the weather before it comes, and the wolves know the thoughts in a man's heart. Best speak true and ride steady – the steppe doesn't forgive lies or clumsy hands on the reins. An old saying: the straight road is a lie. The wise follow the bent twig.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Ykrul ride the endless Violet Steppe, where the horizon drinks the sky and law lives in saddlebags. Their sacred patterns are called Kon'reh — not a written code but a living way of reading routes, debts, and exits. Every crossing has its price, every ford its weight, every feud an angle measured in horse-lengths and heartbeats. Hosts gather by the thousand, then scatter at a word; one night you share their fires, the next they test your bonds. Their banners are wolves' teeth, their treaties braided cords, their memory longer than the rivers that cut the grass. The old folk still recite the Thirty-Six Sayings of the Road, but the wisest know the thirty-seventh is the one you learn alone, on a night when the stars blink out and the wolf does not howl.

What you notice first: The smell of horse sweat and woodsmoke. The way every rider counts hoofbeats under their breath. The silence when a stranger approaches the fire.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never ride between two wolves at dusk. The space between them is a blind angle — a route with no exit, a debt with no payment.

Regional Mood: The Geometry of the Steppe

Here, the horizon is not a line — it is a question. The Ykrul measure distance in oaths, not miles. A camp is a weave of favours owed and honour satisfied. A feud is a slow equation: blood in, blood out, with interest compounded by winter. The Khagan rules not by force alone but by keeping the old patterns — the unwritten rules that govern every crossing, every treaty, every duel. Break the pattern, and the steppe itself may turn against you. Keep it, and even enemies will share their salt. The Ykrul build no monuments. They build relationships, each one a stone in an invisible cairn that stretches from the Dolmis to the Aberderrin.

Prominent NPCs of the Ykrul

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Khatun Bortai	Keeper of the Ring	Keep the clans from tearing each other apart	Her hostage strings are braided from the hair of oath-breakers.
Noyan Temur	Banner-lord of the Red Reeds	Win a winter pasture without bloodshed	He has never lost a negotiation. He has never needed to speak.
Sogata	Herd-Scout (commoner exemplar)	Read the weather before the storm	He can read a trail by the way the grass bends — and a lie by the way a rider sits.

Elder Saruul	Bone-Singer	Keep the names of the dead	She sings the names of the departed each dawn; the dead sing back.
The Dust Prince	Raider who rides the wind’s lee	Amass enough salt to buy a clan	He offers escort braids for secrets, never seen from the front.
Storm-Singer Urum	Sky-Speaker	Sell weather on credit	His bills come due during the Wolf Moon.

Names of the Ykrul

Inspired by the open steppe and the deep east: guttural stops, flowing vowels, and suffixes that mark lineage or deed.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Bortai	Temur	Sogata	<i>the Grey</i>
Urum	Saruul	Khorch	<i>Red-String</i>
Khasar	Altan	Noyan	<i>the Unbuckled</i>
Mongke	Checheg	Borjigin	<i>Storm-Born</i>
Edil	Borte	Uriankhai	<i>Ash-Prow</i>
Toghrul	Orghana	Qasar	<i>the Silent</i>

(Steppe Road/Winter Ring/Ford) Wolf Road milepost of stacked stones with wind whining through eye-holes; winter camp ring with felt tents in horseshoe facing wind.

Spades — Places

2. **Wolf Milepost** — Stacked stones; wind whines through eye-holes. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *Each stone is a treaty. Remove one, and the wind names you oath-breaker.*
3. **Remount Station** — Low corral with stamped snow and tether-posts. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The tether-posts are carved with the names of dead horses. The living ones remember.*
4. **Birch Windbreak** — Above black-earth tracks; old offerings in the bark. ‘[RITUAL]’ *The offerings are strips of wool. Each strip is a prayer for safe crossing.*
5. **Salt Pan** — Crusted white; hoof-prints like stars across the void. ‘[DEBT]’ *The pan has a name: “The Khagan’s Mirror.” Look into it, and you see your debts.*
6. **Reed Ford** — River braids; poles mark yesterday’s safe line. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The poles shift in the night. The river’s path changes with the moon.*
7. **Trading Palisade** — Way-post with wolf-skull pennons snapping. ‘[TRADE]’ *The skulls face outward. They watch for liars and bad weights.*

8. **Winter Camp** — Felt tents in a horseshoe facing the wind. '[SOCIAL]' *The open end is for guests. The closed end is for the ancestors.*
9. **Kurgan Field** — Low barrows; horse-bones bead the grass like prayer beads. '[DEATH]' *The bones were placed by a bone-singer. Each bead is a name.*
10. **Watch Kopje** — Lonely tor with signal fire-scar; the eye of the steppe. '[WEATHER]' *The fire-scar is from a signal that saved a host. The smoke still smells of hope.*
- J **Pontoon Crossing** — Laced hides creak; the current speaks fast and hungry. '[TRAVEL]' *The hides are from horses that died crossing. Their ghosts still pull.*
- Q **Council Hollow** — Standards planted; the ground tamped like a war-drum. '[SOCIAL]' *The standards have ears. Speak a treason here, and every clan will know by dawn.*
- K **Khagan's Station** — Broad ger on a timber platform; guards in silence. '[AUTHORITY]' *The guards never blink. They are paid in salt and secrets.*
- A **Sky Steppe** — Open, wind like a voice; tracks keep pace beside you. '[MYSTERY]' *The tracks are not yours. They belong to the ancestors who ride with you.*

(Host/Envoy/Rider) Herd-scout with three ponies and six opinions; camp-mother who chooses where fires live.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Herd-Scout** — Three ponies and six opinions; the horizon as a map. '[TRAVEL]' *He can read a trail by the way the grass bends. He can read a lie by the way a rider sits.*
3. **Camp-Mother** — Chooses where fires live; hospitality is law. '[SOCIAL]' *She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to.*
4. **Banner Youth** — Minding the wolves' tooth standard; pride as duty. '[COMBAT]' *The standard is older than his grandmother's grandmother. He will die before it falls.*
5. **Salt-Broker** — Weighs promises like grain; trade as precision. '[TRADE]' *Her scales are honest—except when they aren't. The difference is a prayer.*
6. **Remount Keeper** — String-master with a book of brands; horses as currency. '[TRAVEL]' *His book is written in hoof-prints. He can read a horse's soul.*
7. **Bone-Singer** — Knows the kurgans' proper names; death as memory. '[DEATH]' *She sings the names of the dead each dawn. The dead sing back.*
8. **Road-Judge** — Tümen scribe with seals and a patient ear. '[LAW]' *His seals are from three empires. He uses whichever one is still valid.*
9. **Noyan Envoy** — Silver paiza, iron smile; diplomacy as a blade. '[SOCIAL]' *His paiza was a gift from a Khagan who is now dead. He does not mention that.*
10. **Host Captain** — The tent-wall is a map; strategy in every fold. '[COMBAT]' *He can see a battle in the way smoke rises. He is usually right.*
- J **Falcon Courier** — Leather gauntlets, answers sooner than asked. '[TRAVEL]' *The falcon is a sleeper agent. It belongs to a different clan. The courier doesn't know.*
- Q **Khatun of Ring** — Keeper of camp-law and hostage strings. '[LAW]' *Her strings are braided from the hair of hostages. She knows each strand's owner.*
- K **Khagan's Kin** — A nephew or niece sent to bind a foedus with a look. '[SOCIAL]' *They have never lost a negotiation. They have never needed to speak.*

A **Sky-Speaker** — Shaman of storms; shortcuts owe them a price. ‘[MAGIC]’ *They can call lightning—or call it off. The price is always a story.*

(**Law/Weather/Feud**) White squall with dry snow, lost horizons; rasputitsa turning the road to porridge; a feud spark from a name spoken wrong.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **White Squall** — Dry snow, lost horizons; navigation by instinct alone. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The snow tastes of iron. Someone is bleeding nearby.*
 3. **Rasputitsa** — The road becomes porridge; wheels are lies on the earth. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The mud has a smell—old blood and older lies.*
 4. **Remount Sickness** — A cough in the string; swaps get awkward, trust thinner. ‘[DEATH]’ *The cough is a curse. The horses know who cast it.*
 5. **Salt Shortage** — Meat spoils; tempers thin like winter air. ‘[DEBT]’ *The salt was cut with grave dust. Someone wanted the winter to be hard.*
 6. **Hostage Call** — Protocol invoked; someone must sit in the tent. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The tent has no floor. The hostage can see the earth beneath—and the bones.*
 7. **Feud Spark** — A name spoken wrong reopens an old cut; blood remembers. ‘[DEBT]’ *The name was spelled correctly. The insult was in the pause before it.*
 8. **Grassfire** — Runs with the wind faster than horses; escape as a prayer. ‘[DISASTER]’ *The fire has a face. It is the face of a Khagan who burned a village.*
 9. **Foedus Recall** — Treaty terms re-read; your papers disagree. ‘[LAW]’ *The treaty was written on both sides. The other side used a different ink.*
 10. **River Break** — Ice goes; ferries don’t; crossing becomes a gamble. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The ice is still thick in the middle. The edges are lying.*
- J **Raid Shadow** — Another banner follows at a patient distance. ‘[COMBAT]’ *They are not attacking. They are waiting for you to make a mistake.*
- Q **Kurultai Call** — Camps converge; travel becomes politics. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The kurultai has a list of grievances. Your name is near the top.*
- K **Wolf Muster** — A levy raised; every road a checkpoint, every rider a judge. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The muster horn is a wolf’s skull. It sounds like a scream.*
- A **Sky Omen** — Three suns, or none; routes rewrite themselves. ‘[OMEN]’ *The omen is a wedge of cranes flying north in winter. The sky is wrong.*

(**Pass/Remount/Truce**) Camp token for one night’s lawful fire and fodder; salt allotment from a named store without quarrel.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Camp Token** — One night’s lawful fire and fodder; hospitality as a right. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The token is a horsehair braid. Burn it to claim your fire.*
3. **Salt Allotment** — Draw from a named store without quarrel. ‘[TRADE]’ *The allotment is a salt-cake. Break it in half to share.*

4. **Ford-Right** — Cross a named braid at lawful depth. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The right is a pole. Plant it in the river, and the ford will hold—once.*
 5. **Remount Chit** — Swap two tired mounts for fresh. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The chit is a horse’s tooth. The remount keeper will not smile when you present it.*
 6. **Escort Braid** — Two riders see you through a bad stretch. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The braid is woven from the riders’ own hair. They will die before they cut it.*
 7. **Safe-Hostage** — Place or take token-kin for a truce. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The hostage is a child. The child is patient.*
 8. **Paiza Tablet** — Priority on the Wolf Road and at posts. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The tablet is bronze. It is warm when your reputation is good.*
 9. **Foedus Seal** — A treaty clause that trumps petty order. ‘[LAW]’ *The seal is a wolf’s head. Press it into wax, and the steppe listens.*
 10. **Market-Green** — Trade under a banner; weapons sheathed. ‘[TRADE]’ *The banner is a green field. No blood may be spilled beneath it.*
- J **Standard Guard** — Travel under wolf-tooth; raiders defer. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The standard is a wolf’s tooth on a pole. Raiders will bow—or die.*
- Q **Ring Audience** — The Khatun hears you alone; precedent sticks. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The audience is held at midnight. The fire is the only witness.*
- K **Khagan’s Writ** — Doors open, mouths close across the steppe. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The writ is a sheet of hammered silver. It bends, but it does not break.*
- A **Sky’s Exception** — Once, the weather ignores you (storm, whiteout, dust). ‘[WEATHER]’ *The exception is a single breath. Use it well.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (passes/remounts/truces) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **steppe and sky** motifs—wind that speaks, horses that remember, treaties that bind across generations.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Hostage Strings.** Every oath is secured with a **hostage string**—a token kin, retainer, or sworn ally left in the other camp. If the deal is broken, the hostage’s fate becomes the story’s next beat. (Mechanically: create a 4-segment *Hostage* clock; on breach, the clock becomes a countdown to vengeance.)
- **Steppe Law.** Travelers are bound by **steppe law**: hospitality lasts three nights, insults last three generations. The Keeper may demand 1 SB when either law is broken.
- **Sky Omens.** When the sky shows strange signs—mock-suns, green fire, thunder without storm—the steppe itself speaks. Once per scene, players may treat an omen as a *Diamond*, shifting Position without a roll. The GM may bank 1 SB for future weather complications.
- **Bowl and Board.** Ykrul elders settle disputes not by shouting but by drawing two circles in the dirt: the **Bowl** for fairness, then the **Board** for routes and concessions. A successful *Wits*

+ *Lore* (or a relevant skill) roll creates a *Seasonal Concession String* at a ford, harbor, or pass. On a miss, the **Market Moot** [4] clock advances as factions argue.

- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**

- **The Hoof** — The Traveler. *The path that never ends, the remount that never tires.*
- **The Wolf’s Tooth** — The Witness. *Every oath is counted. Every broken promise is a scar.*
- **The Salt Throat** — Maelstraeus. *The debt that salts your tongue; the interest that blinds your horses.*
- **The Sky Father** — Kuva. *The wind that carries names; the storm that erases them.*

The Thirty-Seven Sayings of the Road (Excerpts)

The Ykrul teach strategy not in manuals but in proverbs—each a line of play. A few of the most quoted:

Let the river freeze before you cross. — Do not rush. Let the opponent make the first move; your opening will be built on their impatience.

Borrow a corridor to trap a king. — When the enemy carves a path toward you, let it deepen. Then seal the mouth behind them.

Loot a burning house. — Strike only when the enemy is committed elsewhere.

Hide your dagger behind a smile. — Threaten one flank; strike the other.

The reed bends, the oak breaks. — Yield to overwhelming force, but do not break; preserve your core.

A distant banner casts no shadow. — A threat far away is no threat at all; control the centre.

The guest who outstays his welcome steals the host’s peace. — Allow no force, however small, to remain within your lines uncontrolled.

Count exits, not victims. — Before you move, count the ways your foe can flee. If the number is greater than zero, you have not yet won.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a hospice near the salt pans. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the herders, trying to untie her cord from a Ykrul blood-debt.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The kurgans are Class II Anchor sites—the spirits of old Khagans bound by unfinished wergild. Saikou Ira would carry a bag of salt in each hand here.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the salt-brokers. Take it, and your store never runs dry—but the coin will reappear in the salt pan at every new moon.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Ykrul psions are called “Weather-Readers.” They taste the future in the wind. Road-judges employ two—and have never trusted a verdict they didn’t hear from the sky.
- **The Ninth:** In any Ykrul camp, the ninth cup poured at a feast is for the ancestors. The wise pour eight and leave the ninth as a pause.

Ykrul Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Salt to the Wind:** Toss a pinch into the air before a long ride. Ignore the first *White Squall* penalty.
- **Knot the String:** Tie a single knot in a hostage cord. Cancel *Feud Spark* or take −1 die on your next oath (your choice).
- **Name to the Kurgan:** Whisper a dead enemy's name into a horse's ear. Gain +1 Effect when raiding their clan this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Bone-Singer.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Unwanted attention from **road-judges** or **border riders**.
- **Noise:** Sounds alert a **nearby camp** or **raiding party**.
- **Trace:** Hoofprints or broken grass mark your route for **feud-kin**.
- **Delay:** A horse throws a shoe, a rope breaks — lose time.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on **fodder** or **water** clock.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** A **watch kopje** signals; riders are coming.
- **Position Lost:** **Rasputitsa** or **white squall** hides the trail.
- **Foe Appears:** A **raid shadow** or **hostage taker** arrives.
- **Gear Trouble:** A saddle snaps, a bowstring frays.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A river breaks, a ford becomes impassable.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** A **wolf muster** or **kurultai** war party arrives.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A horse goes lame, a paiza cracks.
- **Major Twist:** A **grassfire** cuts off retreat, or a **feud spark** escalates.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a campaign clock (e.g. **Hostage Crisis**).
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Exhausted** or **Marked by Feud**.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A **hidden kurgan** collapses, a **pontoon** sinks.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Khatun of the Ring**, **Khagan's Kin**, or **Sky-Speaker** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** A **sky omen** rewrites the terrain; paths appear or vanish.
- **Patron Omen:** A wolf watches, a horse speaks, the wind carries a name.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The feud is not what it seemed; the hostage was a willing sacrifice.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Steppe Law:** Hospitality fails, insults echo, treaties shift mid-parley.
- **Horse Culture:** Mounts refuse to move, remount posts are empty, riding rolls suffer −1 die.
- **Sky Omens:** Weather changes instantly, stars point the wrong way, a raven shadows the party.

Extensions (Plug-in)

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Ride):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Dust Cloud*.
- **Cut the Herd (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a *remount chit* is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Squall (Resolve + Survival):** On a hit in *White Squall*, you pick who keeps their bearings; on a miss, the GM does.

Terrain Stock (d20)

Roll or choose a striking detail to dress a hex of the Violet Steppe.

1. Wolf milepost with fresh red thread; someone retied the law.
2. Reed ford poles lying on bank; current whispers a different depth.
3. Fallen standard tooth used as a chopping block; grooves still warm.
4. Circle of pony skulls facing east; one blinks when the wind shifts.
5. Snow trench with cudgel steps; no prints leave it.
6. Copper salt-scale hung from a birch; pans balance only under oath.
7. Hoof-bells threaded on hair; ringing calls riders – or storms.
8. Abandoned paiza shard wedged in a milestone; edges bite skin.
9. Kurgan capstone chalked with a name misspelled; feud waiting.
10. Flint knapper’s tarp half-buried; a perfect arrowhead points north.
11. Blue-fledged signal arrow stuck in frost; message in the vane.
12. Camp-sweep marks: three rings – last night was a council.
13. Wheel rut frozen like glass; a face looks up from inside.
14. Salt-brined jerky hanging from a tripod; untouched by birds.
15. River ice singing in thirds; ferryman’s pole wedged under.
16. Pony hobble-rope knotted in hostage-string pattern.
17. Cold forge dug into loess; tools wrapped in wolfskin.
18. Child’s braid-bead dropped in snow; still warm to the tongue.
19. Thorn-tether scratched with clan brands; two over-scratched.
20. Bone flute lodged in a cairn; playing it summons a road-judge.

Lair Seeds (One-Page Rides)

1. **Ger of Echoes** — Empty felt walls repeat anything uttered in the Khagan’s voice once per night.
2. **Salt-Pit Shrine** — Rope winch to brine caverns; offerings are tears and horsehair.
3. **Remount Vault** — Subterranean stables under reed mats; mounts won’t leave without a tale.
4. **Kite-Maker’s Bluff** — Bone kites pinned on racks; their shadows scout for raiders.
5. **Storm-Rider’s Stone** — Pillar that hums to hooves; racing round it sets weather wagers.
6. **Frozen Court** — Ice dais in a dry riverbed; law held here counts triple until thaw.

7. **Banner Grave** — Flags planted like trees; each knows the battle it died in.
8. **String-Mother's Yard** — Web of hostage cords; cutting one opens a secret but starts a feud.
9. **Fire-Under-Snow** — Warm vent where foals winter; spirits ask for salt-song.
10. **Quiet Palisade** — Trading post where voices fail; deals done in gesture and cut meat.
11. **Ashen Trident** — Three lightning-split birches; tie a braid to choose a road's luck.
12. **Grey Ger** — Moves at night; inside, a camp-mother tests your hospitality the other way around.

Steppe Bestiary (Palette)

- **Steppe Manticores** — Lionine torsos, porcupine tails of bone quills. *Signs:* quills in fence-posts; ponies refuse to drink. *Hook:* play a raid-song backward; they circle to listen.
- **Dust Hulks** — Wind-packed silhouettes that rise from dunes. *Signs:* dunes “breathe”; grit sifts upward. *Hook:* spill water on their shadow; they settle for a watch.
- **Bone Kites** — Carrion birds with rune-etched pinions. *Signs:* spiral flights over kurgans. *Hook:* offer a name-stake (twig with hair) to barter silence.
- **Frost Wargs** — Blue-pelt wolves that steam cold. *Signs:* rime on tracks; breath that crackles. *Hook:* warm milk poured on ice buys one unchallenged crossing.
- **Reed Stalkers** — Long-necked marsh hunters, gait like stilts. *Signs:* pole-pocks where no ferryman walks. *Hook:* carry reeds in your mouth; they read it as truce.
- **Salt Screamers** — Pale eels in dry pans; voices like flutes. *Signs:* fissures crusted with salt frost. *Hook:* scatter ash; they coil to sing and forget to bite.

Relic & Find (d10)

When you uncover a kurgan cache or a lost hoard, roll or pick:

1. Wolf-tooth standard tip; planted, it demands silence for parley.
2. Bronze paiza half; merchants honour it as full once – then talk.
3. Salt-needle that points to the nearest brine store.
4. Frost-bitten stirrup; mount that wears it ignores ice once.
5. Braid-bead of hostage glass; melts when a string is cut nearby.
6. River-depth rod carved with safe counts for three fords.
7. Iron hoof-bell that rings for liars at council.
8. Bone-lot cup; roll it to name which feud clause applies.
9. Wind-wrung scarf; pass it round to share breath in a white squall.
10. Wolf-road tablet scrap; reads as a *Foedus Seal* to one clerk.

Complication Twists (d8)

When a travel complication arises, roll or choose a twist that deepens the story.

1. *White Squall* reveals a remount vault's smoke hole; entering angers reed stalkers.
2. *Rasputitsa* exposes kurgan stones; riding around them starts a name-claim.
3. *Feud Spark* was staged by a salt-broker; paying in *Salt Allotment* unmasks them.

4. *Hostage Call* is for a *Safe-Hostage* you already carry – by another name.
5. *Grassfire* runs uphill toward a council hollow; smoke votes before riders do.
6. *Foedus Recall* cites a river you crossed yesterday – now it flows the other way.
7. *Raid Shadow* is your own tracks, mirrored by sky omens; choose which you admit.
8. *Kurultai Call* stacks councils; words spoken in one bind you in the other.

Boss Seeds (Three-Phase Foes)

- **The String-Mother (Nine Hostages)** — *Phases*: Knot → Tighten → Sever. *Cracks*: return a hostage string, win a Bowl and Board arbitration, cut the right knot.
- **The Dust Prince (Rider of the Red Wind)** — *Phases*: Raid Shadow → Salt Tithe → Kurultai Coup. *Cracks*: spill a salt allotment in his path, unmask his face before the council, outride him through a white squall.

Patronage & Power

In Ykrul society, power flows through the careful management of hospitality, the binding of oaths with hostages, and the ability to navigate the complex web of tribal relationships. The Khagan maintains authority through the loyalty of noyans and the respect of khatuns, while local leaders wield influence through their control of resources like salt, remounts, and safe passage. The true power lies with those who understand the ancient customs and can maintain the delicate balance between hospitality and honour.

For the GM: Patronage in Ykrul society revolves around hospitality, hostage exchanges, and the ability to command respect from hosts and courts. Rewards often take the form of tokens, treaties, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize the old ways:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, braids, standards) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Use the *Bowl and Board* procedure for disputes—first fairness (Bowl), then routes and concessions (Board), then a seasonal right.
- Let rival hosts issue conflicting protections, forcing players to choose whose favour matters more.

In Ykrul society, your word is your bond, and your bond determines whether you ride as guest or ghost.

11.2 Midh Ahkaz — “The Violet Gate”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Coin talks. Grass walks. Blood settles the rest.*

Khatun of the Ring (Ykrul Elder): “The wind carries names, not ledgers. But here, in the shadow of the Oasis Compact, both trade and oaths change hands. Do not mistake our patience for weakness. The grass remembers every hoof that crossed it.”

Vilikari Factor (Night Market Regular): “Ecktoria calls it uncivilized. We call it unbeatable. No tariffs, no seals, no questions. Coin talks. The rest walks.”

Genre / Mood: Frontier grit, steppe noir, law of the rope and the blade.

Starting Location: The Violet Bazaar at dusk — torches gutter, braids slap against leather vests, and a one-eyed horse trader spits into the dust at your feet. “You’re new. The Oasis Well runs low, the Khatun’s coughing blood, and someone’s been paying counterfeit silver. Pick a problem — or I’ll pick one for you.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Midh Ahkaz is not a city. It is a wound that learned to trade. A day’s ride north of the Ecktorian border, it squats on the edge of the Violet Steppe like a patient wolf. No walls. No gates. Just rings of felt tents, latrine trenches, and the smell of horse sweat, cedar smoke, and the faint copper tang of blood money.

The grass grows tall enough to hide a body. The locals cut it back at dawn — but never at dusk, because the things that crawl through it at night have sharp teeth and no patience for property lines. Ecktorian emissaries call this place “the Brink.” Caravan guards call it home. Thieves call it paradise.

Every morning, the Coin-Weigh Tribunal opens its scales under a canvas dome. Every night, the Dust Market auctions goods that fell off a wagon — or off a corpse. The Khatun’s word is law until someone stronger speaks. And in the Silver Stall Stable, a horse thief can buy a fresh mount with a story and a knife.

What you notice first: The constant low drumming of hooves — a heartbeat you feel in your teeth. The way every merchant has a scale on their table *and* a knife within reach. The braids in every horseman’s mane, each knot a story, a debt, a threat.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse the guest-cup. The first pour is courtesy. The second is negotiation. The third is a blood-price unspoken. And the fourth — the fourth means you’re already dead, you just haven’t stopped breathing.

Western Steppe vs. Eastern Steppe (GM Sidebar)

The Ykrul divide their world into two great grass seas:

Western Steppe (Violet Prairie): Rolling, fertile, forgiving. The grass grows tall enough to hide a crouched rider, but the land is laced with caravanserais, seasonal wells, and the smoke of permanent camps. This is where Midh Ahkaz sits — the soft underbelly of the steppe, where trade happens and clans winter. The violet seed-heads give the prairie its name.

Eastern Steppe (True Steppe): Vast, dry, harsh. Shared with the Kuvani horse-clans, it stretches east of the Valewood. Grass is shorter, winds are colder, and a rider can see a day’s ride in every direction. The Ostrihari who appear in Midh Ahkaz are from the eastern fringes of the *Western Steppe* — they speak with a harder accent, braid their horses’ tails differently, and carry bows of horn and sinew, not wood.

Why this matters: A Ykrul from the Eastern Steppe might find Midh Ahkaz almost claustrophobic. A trader from the Violet Prairie might feel lost in the east. Use the contrast to create tension between clans or to flavour foreign visitors.

Regional Mood: Wind, Grass, and a Knife in the Back

Midh Ahkaz thrives on movement — and on the friction that movement creates. Caravans arrive from every direction: Ykrul horse-tribes from the deep steppe, Ostrihari mercenaries with horn bows and longer grudges, Vilikari traders who keep two ledgers (one for the tax man, one for the grave), and the occasional bold Ecktorian factor with a silver tongue and a hidden dagger. The city’s “law” is the Oasis Compact — a shifting web of seasonal rights, grazing permits, and arbitration courts held under open sky. Disputes are settled by the Bowl (fairness) then the Board (geometry). A broken promise can cost a herd. A kept oath can buy a ford for a generation.

But when the Bowl spills and the Board cracks, the real law is the one you carry on your belt. The grass will hide your body — or someone else’s.

Starting Location: The Violet Bazaar, a sprawling market of felt tents and chalk circles, where horse traders shout over the jingle of brass bridles. A Vilikari merchant with oiled braids hands you a sealed letter. “The Coin-Weigh Tribunal suspects a counterfeit seal. Find the forger before the Grass Moon, or the contract on your head becomes public.” Behind him, a drunk Ostrihari is buying a knife he’ll use before dawn.

(Ring/Well/Cairn) The Oasis Well where water shares are drawn — the token-keeper has a scarred face and a heavier hand than he should. Counting pebbles placed on stone ledges by memory, not sight. The distant smoke of a Steppe Ranger campfire — or maybe a grass fire. Either way, it’s moving toward you.

Spades — Places

2. **Violet Bazaar** — Felt stalls, chalk circles, horse traders and rumor merchants. *The chalk circles are for disputes. Step inside and speak truth — or pay in grass. Blood washes off the chalk, but the stain stays.* ‘[TRADE]’
3. **Coin-Weigh Tribunal** — Tariff court under a canvas dome; scales of bronze and iron. *The scales were blessed by a dying Sky-Speaker. They tip even when the wind is still. The clerk has never smiled.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
4. **Oasis Well** — Stone-rimmed pool, token-keeper with a leather bag of water rights. *Each token is a carved pebble. Lose it, and your herd drinks dust. The keeper’s knife is sharper than his tongue.* ‘[SURVIVAL]’
5. **Steppe Ranger Camp** — Tent line on the eastern edge; trackers, scouts, feud mediators. *The rangers wear wolf tails. They do not smile — they wait. Their campfire is never allowed to go out.* ‘[WILD]’
6. **Caravan Rings** — Concentric circles of wagon shelters; fires lit inward, watch posts on ox carts. *The inner ring is for sworn allies. Outsiders sleep in the second ring, coin in hand — and a knife in the boot.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
7. **Sky-Speaker’s Cairn** — Stone heap atop a low hill; wind-knot ropes and bones. *The shaman leaves offerings of horsehair. The wind carries his prayers to Kuva — and sometimes his curses.* ‘[RITUAL]’
8. **Dust Market** — No-questions auction at the city’s edge; stolen goods, cursed relics, bad memories. *The auctioneer wears a hooded mask. No one knows his face. No one has asked twice. The last man who did now sells his own teeth.* ‘[UNDERWORLD]’
9. **Silver Stall Stable** — Remount station; horses for hire, gossip for free, blood for more. *The stable master has three fingers on his left hand. He lost the others in a bet over a mare. He*

won the bet. ‘[TRAVEL]’

10. **Grass Ring** — Ritual dueling ground; mourners and bookies share benches. *The grass grows back faster after a duel. The dead fertilize the peace. The bookies pay out before the body cools.* ‘[COMBAT]’
- J **Foreign Quarter** — Ecktorian, Vhasian, and Viterran merchants in permanent felt mansions. *The Ecktorian envoy winters here. He has not left in five years. He has a price on his head in three countries — but Midh Ahkaz doesn’t extradite.* ‘[POLITICS]’
- Q **Khatun’s Ring** — Largest tent, carpeted with woven battle scenes; the old chieftain’s seat. *The carpet is made of enemy cloaks. Each sash is a surrendered banner. The air smells of smoke, old blood, and the fear of petitioners.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- K **Under-Arcades** — Earthen tunnels below the bazaar; root-walled, bone-dusted. *The walls are packed with bone dust and old burrows. The dead whisper route tips — for a price. The price is never coin.* ‘[STEALTH]’
- A **Iron Well** — Ancient Aeler shaft, now used for vengeance contracts and whispered names. *The water tastes of rust and memory. Those who drink never lie again — or never speak. The keeper writes the names of the condemned in ash. The ash floats.* ‘[DEATH]’

(Horse/Tally/Token) Sky-Speaker’s apprentice with a drum and a dream; Ostrikari arms-master selling short bows (he names each after a dead rival); Ykrul elder counting braids (her hair is a map of debts).

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Horse-Braid Apprentice** — Young Ykrul with a head full of trade routes and a knot diary. *She ties a new braid for every paying passenger. Her hair is a map of debts — and grudges.* ‘[TRADE]’
3. **Ostrikari Arms-Master** — Selling short bows and longer grudges; fights for coin. *He names each bow after a dead rival. The bows never miss. His left ear is missing — a debt he paid in flesh.* ‘[COMBAT]’
4. **Coin-Weigh Clerk** — Ink-stained, patient, scales in her eyes; never lies, never forgives. *She records weights in blood. A single drop seals a verdict. She has never been wrong — or so she says.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
5. **Vilikari Factor** — Braided, oiled, quick with a smile and a second ledger. *His caravan has three names. Only the real one buys safe passage. The other two are for the tax man and the grave.* ‘[TRADE]’
6. **Steppe Ranger** — Tracker with a wolf-tail cloak and a debt to the Sky-Speaker. *He never draws his bow unless watched. Hunger is his real weapon. His arrows are fletched with crow feathers.* ‘[WILD]’
7. **Tokan (Ykrul Scout)** — Mute, sharp-eyed, always smelling the wind; her ears miss nothing. *She signs with her knuckles. Three taps is "danger." One tap is "run." No taps means you’re already dead.* ‘[STEALTH]’
8. **Ecktoria Emissary** — Proud, wax-sealed, fuming at the "primitive" customs. *He carries a copy of Imperial Code that he has never opened. The flies love his ink. The locals love his purse.* ‘[POLITICS]’
9. **Sky-Speaker’s Shadow** — Elder’s quiet apprentice; listens more than the wind. *She can*

name every clan’s sky-omen. She cannot name her own origin. Her eyes are the colour of ash. ‘[RITUAL]’

10. **Knot-Keeper (Tulkani)** — Counts caravan promises with a rope of nine strands. *Each knot is a contract. Untie one and the deal dissolves. Cut one and the debtor dies in his sleep. No one knows how.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
- J **Dust Market Auctioneer** — Hooded, genderless voice; knows the weight of every sin. *The hammer is a thigh bone. The block is a skull altar from the Direwood. The skull’s jaw moves when the price is right.* ‘[UNDERWORLD]’
- Q **Khatun of the Ring** — Grey-haired, one-eyed, still deadly at sixty; speaks for seven clans. *She lost her eye to a Linn raider. She killed him with his own hook. She keeps the hook on her belt.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- K **Kuva’s Voice (Wandering Priest)** — Weathered, ash-marked, offers omen readings for grass. *He prays to the sky by throwing bones. The bones never lie — they just mislead. The ash on his forehead is from a fire that hasn’t been lit yet.* ‘[RITUAL]’
- A **Iron Well Keeper (Vengeance Broker)** — Mute, scarred, accepts names written in ash. *A drink from the well costs a memory. A death costs a fortune. His ledger is written on human skin. The names move.* ‘[DEATH]’

(Drought/Feud/Blight) Dry well cuts water rations — the token-keeper has a list, and the list has a knife mark beside your name; blood-price feud spills into the bazaar — a boy’s corpse lies in a chalk circle, and no one will claim it; locust swarm from the east — the grass blackens, and the swarm leaves a sticky residue that smells of burnt honey and dread.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Dry Well Ration** — Water shares halved; prices spike, tempers fray. ‘[SURVIVAL]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The token-keeper has a list. The list has a knife mark beside your name. He didn’t put it there.*
3. **Blood-Price Feud** — A killing in the Horse Ring; kinsmen demand wergild in coin or flesh. ‘[DEBT]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The victim’s tribe drums the death rhythm. Every beat is a deadline. The bookies are already taking bets on the retaliation.*
4. **Locust Swarm** — Grass blackens; caravans stranded, fodder worthless. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The swarm leaves a sticky residue. It smells of burnt honey and dread. The locusts spell words as they fly — sometimes a name, sometimes a warning.*
5. **Counterfeit Coins** — Light silver floods the Dust Market; Oasis Compact inquiry. ‘[DEBT]’ ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The counterfeit coins are warm. The real ones are cold. Touch quickly. The forger has a scar on his left thumb.*
6. **Grass Fire** — Wind-whipped flame from the east; evacuations, scorched trade paths. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[DISASTER]’ *The smoke spells a name. Yours. Or your debtor’s. Hard to tell. The fire moves against the wind.*
7. **Horse Sickness** — Contagion at the Silver Stall Stable; quarantines, lost mounts. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The sick horses dream. Their screams sound like your last argument. The stable master is weeping. He never weeps.*
8. **Khatun’s Illness** — Old chieftain fading; succession knives out. ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *Her death will split seven clans. The Sword Oath lasts one year. The poisoner is already spending his payment.*

9. **Census Raid** — Ecktorian legion patrol "just visiting"; tensions high, bribes higher. '[AUTHORITY]' '[SOCIAL]' *The patrol leader wears a mask of imperial wax. Pull it off and see a dead man's face. The face is yours — from a life you haven't lived yet.*
10. **Sky-Omen (Red Wind)** — Dust storm from the Ashaani desert; all navigation Desperate. '[WEATHER]' '[FEAR]' *The dust tastes of iron and old blood. Breathe it and dream of falling. The wind whispers a name. Listen and you'll answer.*
- J **Oath Challenge** — A Kon'reh master demands geometry arbitration; your bond is the stake. '[DEBT]' '[SOCIAL]' *The board is a painted skull. The pieces are horse teeth. The master hasn't lost in forty years. He's due.*
- Q **Tariff Strike** — Coin-Weigh clerks refuse to audit; trade freezes, tempers explode. '[JUSTICE]' '[TRADE]' *The clerks chant a counting rhyme. Stop them before they reach nine. The ninth number is not a number. It is a name.*
- K **Duel for Rights** — Two clans claim the same well; witnesses needed to prove water share. '[COMBAT]' '[JUSTICE]' *The duel is fought with blunt spears. First blood wins the well. Both bleed. The well doesn't care.*
- A **Kuva's Vengeance** — The sky itself turns; hail, lightning, and a voice from the clouds. '[DEATH]' '[PATRON]' *The voice names a sinner. Your name. The hail has teeth. The lightning writes your confession in the grass.*

(Writ/Token/Pass) Grass Right for one season of grazing — a branded stick that warms when the grass is healthy; Oath-Bead to compel a Kon'reh master's arbitration — the bead is a single horsehair knot, tightening when the master speaks truth.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Grass Right** — One season of grazing on a named meadow; herders pay you tribute. '[TRAVEL]' '[SOCIAL]' *The right is a branded stick. Burn it to end the lease — or renew. The brand is a wolf's head. It howls when the meadow is overgrazed.*
3. **Oath-Bead** — A single knot of horsehair; compels a Kon'reh master to arbitrate your dispute. '[JUSTICE]' *The bead grows warm when the master speaks truth. Cold when he lies. He has never felt it grow cold.*
4. **Water Share** — Priority access to a well during drought; token from the Oasis Compact. '[SURVIVAL]' *The token is a polished pebble. Drop it in the well to claim your draw. The well will remember your face.*
5. **Steppe Ranger Favor** — One dangerous tracking job resolved off-screen. '[WILD]' *The ranger marks your name on his tent pole. He never forgets a favor. He also never forgets a slight.*
6. **Vilikari Voucher** — No-questions cargo space on three caravans; smuggle as you will. '[TRADE]' '[STEALTH]' *The voucher is a strip of oiled leather. The factor's scent guides the mules. The mules are smarter than the factor.*
7. **Census Waiver** — Ecktorian patrol leaves you alone for one crossing; paper shield. '[AUTHORITY]' *The waiver is stamped with a bear. The bear's eyes follow you. The stamp is a lie. The waiver still works.*
8. **Khatun's Whistle** — Summon a small warband once (Cap 3) for a single scene. '[COMBAT]' *The whistle is a hollow horse tooth. Blow it and the grass shivers. The riders come. They expect payment in stories.*

9. **Sky-Speaker’s Omen** — One weather forecast that cannot fail; plan your escape. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The omen is a bone thrown into fire. Read the cracks — carefully. The fire will answer. It will also ask.*
10. **Silver Stall Chit** — One free remount exchange; never be horseless. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The chit is a brass hoof. Present it and the stable master nods once. The horse will be fast. The horse may also be cursed.*
- J **Black Ledger Entry** — A written promise from a rival, witnessed by three camp elders. ‘[DEBT]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The entry is written in ash on felt. Wash it and the vow dissolves. Burn it and the rival dies in his sleep. No one knows why.*
- Q **Dust Market Cut** — A share of the auctioneer’s commission for a season; wealth in sin. ‘[TRADE]’ *The cut is paid in mismatched coins. Spend them fast before they curse you. The auctioneer’s mask has a new scratch every week.*
- K **Blood-Price Bond** — A criminal clan owes you a life; they will kill once for you or die trying. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The bond is a braid of enemy hair. Cut it to call the debt. The clan’s matriarch will come. She will ask whose.*
- A **Seal of the Oasis Compact** — Casting vote on any water right dispute. Once. ‘[JUSTICE]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The seal is a bronze well with a snake curled at the bottom. Turn it and the water booms. The snake will bite if you turn it back.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are narrative permits (grazing rights, oaths, witnesses) that shift Position rather than demand a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **grass and wind** motifs — shifting alliances, debts that ride with the seasons, the sky as witness, a body that vanishes into the tall grass by morning.
- The violet seed-heads of the steppe are a recurring omen: when they glow under moonlight, a spirit walks; when they shed, a caravan will be late — or never arrive.

Additional Features (Frontier Grit)

- **Kon’reh Arbitration:** Disputes are settled on a board painted on hide. Winners gain seasonal rights. Losers pay in grass or labor — or blood if they can’t afford either. The board is set up in the Grass Ring. The spectators bet on the outcome.
- **Grass Omens:** The steppe flickers violet when rain is near. When the seed-heads droop at noon, a blood-feud approaches. When they stand straight at midnight, the Hollow walks. No one stays outside when the seed-heads stand straight.
- **Khatun’s Braid:** The chieftain’s hair holds the memory of every oath she swore. Cutting a braid voids a promise — but the severed braid becomes a curse token. The current Khatun has nine braids. She is saving the tenth for something important.
- **The Law of the Rope:** Midh Ahkaz has no jail. Serious offenders are tied to a post in the Grass Ring and left for the steppe. If they survive the night, they are free — and owe a blood-price to the family of their victim. No one has survived the night in seven years.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**

- **The Wind Father** — The Traveler. *He who reads the grass and knows the safe routes — for a share of the cargo.*
- **The Scale Mother** — Mykkiel. *She who weighs the oath and the blood-price; her clerks carry knives.*
- **The Grass King** — Grimmer. *The wild that pushes back against the ring of tents; he demands a sacrifice of horseflesh each spring.*
- **The Toothless One** — Malachai. *A silver coin in the dust market that guarantees a fair deal — until the grass remembers.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a "free soup" wagon near the Dust Market. They ask no coin — but they measure your shadow. A renegade Sister hides among the horse-braid apprentices, trying to untie her cord from a blood-price feud.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** Saikou Ira once tracked a ghoul to the Under-Arcades. He left a silver mirror in the wall. It still shows the ghoul's face. The ghoul is still watching.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A broken Kon'reh board at the Iron Well is said to compel truth. Players who touch it gain +1 die to resist lies — but mark 1 Obligation to Malachai. The board was broken by a merchant who lied about a horse. The horse was a demon.
- **The Grey Wanderer's Grimoire:** Midh Ahkaz psions are called "Wind-Readers." They sense lies by the tremor in grass. The Khatun employs two; they never speak to each other. They communicate by writing in the dust. The dust blows away after each message.
- **The Ninth:** In any Midh Ahkaz scene, the ninth horse table in the Violet Bazaar sells nothing but bad advice. Spend a Boon to reroll a failed negotiation — but the advice may haunt you. The table is always empty except at midnight. At midnight, a hooded figure sits there. No one knows who.

Midh Ahkaz Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Hoofprint Pour:** Pour a cup of water into the first hoofprint of a new horse. Ignore the first *Horse Sickness* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Braid the Knot:** Tie a strand of mane hair around your wrist. Cancel *Counterfeit Coin* or take -1 die on your next Charisma roll (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Grass:** Whisper a debtor's name into the wind at noon. Gain +1 Effect when collecting from them this scene, but mark *Obligation* to a Sky-Speaker. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table (Midh Ahkaz)

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw attention from **Steppe Rangers** or **Coin-Weigh clerks**.
- **Noise:** The sound carries across the grass; a **rival clan's scout** overhears.
- **Trace:** Hoofprints, broken grass, or losing an arrow marks your path.
- **Delay:** A water ration takes longer; a horse tires without rest.
- **Grass Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** Border riders converge on your position; a horn sounds.
- **Position Lost:** You lose high ground/cover/the wind due to a **grass fire or horse stampede**.
- **Foe Appears:** A Vengeance broker, Ostrihari sell-sword, or clan champion arrives.
- **Gear Trouble:** A bridle breaks, bow string snaps, waterskin leaks.
- **Oath Hearsay:** A false rumor about your oath reaches the wrong ear.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional horsemen, blood-price hunters, or Dust Market thugs arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A horse goes lame, seal ring cracks, trade ledger burns.
- **Major Twist:** The situation changes – Khatun dies, well runs dry, duel interrupted by grass fire.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** (e.g., Blinded by dust, Parched).

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A hidden pit, poisoned water share, or false oath activates.
- **Authority Arrival:** Khatun’s warband, Ecktorian patrol, Sky-Speaker intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes – grass fire sweeps through, dust storm blinds, night falls without warning.
- **Patron Omen:** A bolide, strange animal, or wind that speaks your name appears.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn – the real forger was your ally; the water right was a trap.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Midh Ahkaz (Grass & Trade):** Grass catches fire, horses spook at shadows, bargains settled with a knife on the table, violet seed-heads floating in the wind.
- **Midh Ahkaz (Oath & Sky):** Clouds spell forgotten names, wind carries false testimony, a duel’s outcome shifts with the sun, a violet dusk signals a spirit.
- **Midh Ahkaz (Horse & Bow):** An arrow splits in flight, a horse refuses a rider, a bowstring sings a dying clansman’s tune, a braid comes undone at the wrong moment.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Ride):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Dust Cloud*.
- **Cut the Herd (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a Grass Right is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Stampede (Resolve + Survival):** On a hit in *Horse Sickness*, you pick which mount survives; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Counting Circle (cursed scale bound to the Oasis)** — *Phases:* Fair Auditing → Retroactive Drought → Naming of Debtors. *Cracks:* burn a counterfeit token in the Oasis

well; settle a seven-clan water debt; let a Sky-Speaker rebless the scale.

- **Grass Reaver (vengeful horse-lord, half-legend)** — *Phases*: Hoof Drum → Ghost Herd → Blood-Price Ride. *Cracks*: confess a broken oath at his cairn; return a stolen foal; outrun him on a borrowed horse.
- **Coin-Weigh Wraith (greedy merchant who sold his shadow)** — *Phases*: Tally of the Lost → Ledger Chain → Crack the Seal. *Cracks*: pay a forgotten wergild; break his contract with a witnessed error; let the Iron Well drink his name.

Patronage & Power in Midh Ahkaz

In Midh Ahkaz, power flows through horseflesh, water rights, and the geometry of oaths. The Khatun rules by consensus, but the true authority rests with the Oasis Compact — a loose council of clan elders, Vilikari factors, and Steppe Rangers who interpret the Wind Law. When the Compact fails, the Grass Ring becomes the courtroom, and the duel is the verdict.

For the GM – Actionable Examples:

- A player who wins a Kon'reh match earns a **Grass Right** (Diamond). That right could be contested by a rival clan the very next session — forcing a rematch or a chase across the prairie. The grass will be cut for the rematch. The loser's grass will be salted.
- A **Water Share** token is stolen. The thief leaves a violet seed-head as a signature. Tracking them leads to a seasonal camp where debt is repaid not in coin but in stories — and where the storyteller's shadow is just a little too short.
- The Khatun's illness (Club) is not natural. A Vilikari factor (Heart) knows the poisoner's name but demands a **Black Ledger Entry** (J Diamond) in exchange — a dangerous witness the player must then protect. The witness is a child who cannot speak. She writes in the dust. The wind keeps erasing her words.

These hooks turn the generator entries into immediate playable situations.

Chapter 12

Vilikari

Laurels & Longhouses. The Vilikari straddle the frontier between empire and steppe. They are tillers and treaty-makers who balance survival between Ecktoria, the Ykrul, and the Black Banners. Their halls are longhouses raised over ruined forums; their laws carved on both oak and marble; their loyalties braided like the braids of their war-maidens' hair.

12.1 Vilikari — “Laurels & Longhouses”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Two laws, one people. The oak remembers; the marble writes. The stone is cracking.*

Federate King (Elite): “We are the bridge between empire and wilderness, the marriage of law and custom. Our strength lies not in choosing one path but in walking both with equal surety. But the bridge is rotting, and no one sends hostages anymore.”

Hearth-Mother (Commoner): “The old ways and new laws both have their place at our table. Serve the right mead to the right guest, honor the proper customs, and you’ll find we’re better hosts than most kings. The trouble is, the guests are forgetting why they came.”

Genre / Mood: Early Holy Roman Empire on the steppe — legal dualism, hybrid identity, frontier pragmatism, **forgotten treaties**.

Starting Location: A longhouse quarter tucked into an old forum. Laurel garlands hang from broken columns. Smoke from a dozen hearths curls under cracked marble arches. A Hearth-Mother offers a cup of small beer and a piece of oatcake. “The Foedus Stone cracks,” she says. “The steppe listens. Which law will you speak when the Ykrul envoy arrives — oak or marble? The stone has a new crack. No one knows which promise it represents.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Vilikari are not caught between empire and steppe — they are *forgotten*. The Foedus Stone, the ancient treaty that guaranteed their autonomy, is *cracking*. Every season, another shard falls. The Ecktorian clerks have stopped renewing the oath; the Ykrul no longer send hostages. The Vilikari are becoming *invisible* to both sides. Their law still holds, but the witnesses are dying. The Elder of Elders speaks once a year, but fewer and fewer listen. Their halls are longhouses raised over ruined forums; their laws carved on both oak and marble; their loyalties braided like the braids of their war-maidens' hair. Unlike the Ykrul, who read the geometry of the steppe, the Vilikari read the geometry of *jurisdiction*. They are the bulk of the non-elite population in Ecktoria — the legionaries' descendants who never went home. A Vilikari blacksmith in Ecktoria might swear by the marble bench; his cousin two valleys over in Acasia still ties knots for the oak. This is not contradiction. It is survival. But survival requires witnesses. And the witnesses are fading.

What you notice first: The smell of woodsmoke and old parchment. The way everyone speaks two languages at once — switching mid-sentence. The longhouse roofs that use broken imperial tiles as shingles. The silence where there used to be oaths.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never invoke only one law. The *mallus* (oak-ring) and the *basilica* (marble bench) must both be honored. Choose one, and the other will find you. But now, neither may answer.

Regional Mood: Laurels and Longhouses

Here, the past is not a ruin — it is a *creditor*. The old Utaran forums still echo with the footsteps of legionaries, but now those columns hold longhouse roofs. The Vilikari do not choose between empire and tribe; they marry them, awkwardly, imperfectly, and with frequent arguments. Their kings wear both a laurel wreath and a wolf-tail cloak. Their courts meet twice: once under the oak for blood-price, once on the marble bench for statute. No verdict is final until both have spoken.

But the witnesses are dying. The Foedus Stone has a crack for every forgotten promise. The newest crack has no date. It appeared last winter. No one knows which promise it represents.

On the coast, Vilikari fishing villages double as smugglers' coves, running fugitives, forbidden goods, and whispered messages. Their boats are fast, their pilots know every reef and patrol route, and their loyalty is to the cargo's survival. They are the last people in the Amaranthine who still remember the old treaty's third clause. They are not sure why it matters. They keep it anyway.

Prominent NPCs of the Vilikari

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk

Federate Aldric	King	Rex-Dux of the Vilikari	Keep the two-law balance and the Foedus Stone intact	He has three thrones — oak, marble, and saddle. He uses whichever is not being argued over. Lately, all three are dusty.
Hearth-Mother Vesna		Keeper of guest-right (commoner exemplar)	Protect her village from raiders and tax men alike	She has never lost a quarrel; her voice is soft, her memory longer than the Foedus Stone. But the stone is shrinking.
Shield-Brother Rurik		Comitatus oath-bearer	Enforce the mallus code in the marches	His braids are his ledger; each knot is a debt paid — or owed. He has started tying knots in his sleep.
March Theodora	Notary	Utaran-trained legalist	Draft treaties that neither side can break	She writes in three scripts; her left hand writes Latin, her right writes runes. Her third hand writes in ink that no one can read — not even her.

Smuggler Captain Drago	Vilikari fisherman and trafficker	Run contraband and refugees past the Kahfagian patrols	He knows every reef and every lantern shift; the harbormasters cannot catch him. He says the Foedus Stone's cracks are good for business — no one checks the old treaties anymore.
Elder of Elders	Thing-council speaker	Preserve the old customs against imperial erosion	He speaks once a year; the rest of the time he listens — and remembers. But his memory is cracking like the stone.

Names of the Vilikari

Vilikari names blend Utaran (Latin) roots with steppe influences: hard consonants, fluid vowels, and surnames that recall a ford, a bridge, or a longhouse.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Aldric	Vesna	de la Marche	<i>the Two-Law</i>
Rurik	Theodora	Longwood	<i>the Fox</i>
Drago	Gisela	Kalderash	<i>Bridge-Born</i>
Oswin	Mira	Oakenshield	<i>the Unbuckled</i>
Vidar	Svanhild	Tregard	<i>Ash-Prow</i>
Kael	Ragna	Foedus	<i>the Grey</i>

(March Town/Villa-Fort/Old Road) Longhouse Quarter tucked into old forum with hearth-smoke under broken eaves; Milefort XVII with earth bank and faded eagle.

Spades — Places

2. **Longhouse Quarter** — Tucked into old forum; hearth-smoke under broken eaves. '[COMMUNITY]' *The forum's marble floor is worn smooth by dancing feet, not sandals. The ghosts of tax collectors weep in the corners.*

3. **Milefort XVII** — Earth bank, stone gate; faded eagle over fresh knotwork. ‘[MILITARY]’ *The eagle’s stone wings were reglued after a lightning strike. It still leans left — toward the steppe.*
4. **Stone Ford** — Plank-palings and a customs table at knee-height; border as bureaucracy. ‘[TRADE]’ *The ford changes hands every season. The customs table never moves. The wood is stained with ink and blood.*
5. **Villa Granary** — Barracks with a tile roof; spear racks where olives once slept. ‘[MILITARY]’ *The olive press still works. The pressers are now armorers. The oil is for lamps, not cooking.*
6. **Twin Court** — Mallus ring beneath an oak, basilica bench across the lane. ‘[LAW]’ *The oak and the bench are the same distance from the well. The well is neutral ground. The well has a chain.*
7. **Blackwood Road** — Milestones re-carved in runes and Latin both. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The runes say “safe passage.” The Latin says “toll payable twice.” The third line is scratched out.*
8. **Staple Market** — Frontier where Ykrul horses meet Vilikari iron. ‘[TRADE]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The horse-traders and smiths speak a pidgin of gestures and grudges. The scales are honest — mostly.*
9. **Burial Field** — Ship-ridge mounds beside tiled mausolea, both garlanded. ‘[DEATH]’ *The mausolea have fresh offerings. The ancestors are not picky. The ship-mounds whisper at dawn.*
10. **Repaired Bridge** — An arch of stone, a Vilikari trestle stitched on; past and present joined. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The trestle creaks in Vilikari, the stone groans in Utaran. They argue at midnight. The toll-keeper listens.*
- J **Hill Amphitheater** — A lord’s hall raised in an old arena’s curve; power in architecture. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The lord’s throne is a gladiator’s chair. He does not know who last sat in it. The sand beneath is still dark.*
- Q **New Raivon** — March capital; grid-streets colliding with wandering lanes. ‘[URBAN]’ *The grid was laid by a surveyor who never came back. The lanes are older. They move at night.*
- K **Dux’s Palace** — Purple awnings, wolf-hides, law tablets on the wall. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The tablets list every treaty broken. The wolf-hides are from the treaty-breakers. They still growl.*
- A **Foedus Stone** — At a crossroads; every treaty carved, every hand weighed. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[LEGEND]’ *The stone has grown. Each new treaty adds a finger of granite. The oldest fingers are worn smooth. The newest crack has no date.*

(Federate/Mixed Court/Diaspora) Hearth-Mother with guest-cup and wergild chest key; Shield-Brother with oaths braided into hair.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Hearth-Mother** — Guest-cup and wergild chest key; hospitality as power. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *She has never lost a quarrel. Her voice is soft, her memory longer than the Foedus Stone. She remembers debts that are not yet owed — and the stone is forgetting.*
3. **Shield-Brother** — Comitatus oaths braided into hair; loyalty as bond. ‘[MILITARY]’ ‘[OATH]’ *His braids are his ledger. Each knot is a debt paid — or owed. He has started tying knots in his sleep, hoping the stone will remember.*
4. **March Notary** — Utaran-trained; writes three scripts without blinking. ‘[LAW]’ *His left hand writes Latin, his right writes runes. He signs with his foot. The document is always*

binding — until the stone forgets.

5. **Horse-Reeve** — Rations pasture between plows and warbands. '[TRADE]' *He measures grass in fistfuls. The Ykrul respect his arithmetic. The Ecktorians pretend not to notice. He is saving fistfuls to patch the stone.*
6. **Ykrul Envoy** — Riding under safe-conduct; speaks debts in proverbs. '[SOCIAL]' *He never carries a weapon. His tongue is sharp enough. His hostage string has nine knots. He is running out of space — and the stone is running out of memory.*
7. **Old Legionary** — Drill-master for Vilikari levies; Utar in muscle memory. '[MILITARY]' *He still marks time in paces. The recruits call him "Grandfather Eagle." The eagle on his shield is chipped. He says the stone's cracks are just more places to put his thumb.*
8. **Ecktorial Factor** — Vilikari blood, Ecktorial coin; flows where the ledger points. '[TRADE]' *His coat has two collars — one for each loyalty. He wears whichever is warmer. His ledger has three columns. The third column is labelled "crack width."*
9. **Kahfagian Pilot** — Lantern-law chit and clan tattoo; sea-law on land. '[TRAVEL]' *He navigates by stars and tariffs. Both change with the season. He has never been lost — only delayed. The stone's cracks are good for smuggling.*
10. **Marcher-Lord** — Iron-nail crown, Vilikari law in pocket; a frontier king. '[AUTHORITY]' *His crown was a plowshare. He reversed the curse. His hands are still calloused. He does not sit on his throne. He spends his days pressing his ear to the stone.*
- J **War-Maiden** — Oath-braid names the dead and the owed; vengeance as memory. '[COMBAT]' '[OATH]' *Her braid is longer than her sword. Both have drawn blood. She never cuts the braid. The dead would forget her. The stone is forgetting everyone else.*
- Q **Queen of Marches** — Consort-regent; smiles like precedent. '[POLITICS]' *She married the Federate King for peace. She kept the kingdom for herself. Her seal is a broken arrow. She keeps a piece of the stone in her pocket — it gets smaller every year.*
- K **Federate King** — Rex-Dux sworn to forms, sung by his own. '[AUTHORITY]' *He has three thrones — oak, marble, and saddle. He uses whichever is not being argued over. His crown is a laurel and a wolf's tooth. He has stopped arguing. He just listens to the stone.*
- A **Elder of Elders** — Thing-council speaker; a nod can unmake a clan. '[LAW]' *He speaks once a year. The rest of the time he listens — and remembers. But his memory is cracking like the stone. He has started writing things on his own skin.*

(Two Laws/Two Fronts/Old Grudges) Annona late — grain stipend misses the comitatus; tempers quicken; jurisdiction tangle of mallus vs. basilica writ.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Annona Late** — Grain stipend misses the comitatus; tempers quicken like flint. '[SUPPLY]' '[SOCIAL]' *The granary is full. The keys are in the wrong vault. Someone is waiting for the price to rise. The soldiers are not. The stone does not care.*
3. **Law Tangle** — Mallus verdict vs. basilica writ — whose seal bites? '[LAW]' *The oak judge and the marble judge are cousins. They send each other holiday cards. The case has been open for three generations. The stone has forgotten who started it.*
4. **Raid Rumor** — A Ykrul boyar; levies panic the plowlands. '[COMBAT]' '[FEAR]' *The boyar is a ghost — or a tax collector. The farmers don't wait to find out. They burn the fields*

themselves. The stone’s cracks are good cover for ghosts.

5. **Bridge Levy** — Doubled for road-works; caravans balk, fists rise. ‘[TRADE]’ ‘[COMBAT]’
The road-works are a ditch. The ditch fills every spring. The bridge keeper has a new sword. He sharpens it on the stone.
6. **Succession Feud** — Wolf-brother claim vs. purple-charter heir. ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[DEATH]’
The wolf-brother has a better sword. The purple-charter has a better notary. The notary’s ink is mixed with blood. The stone’s crack drinks it.
7. **Foedus Recall** — A prefecture resettlement is “requested”; homes bristle. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’
The prefecture’s map is forty years old. It shows a village that drowned. The villagers are still there. The stone remembers their names — barely.
8. **Coin Talk** — Debasement; pay demanded in salt, hides, or hostages. ‘[TRADE]’ ‘[DEBT]’
The salt is from a disputed pan. The hides are from cattle that were never born. The hostages are children. The stone’s cracks are full of their names.
9. **Grave Offense** — A burial field disturbed; omens ride with the news. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[OMEN]’
The ancestors are angry. They have a list. Your name may be on it. The list is carved on a ship’s prow. The stone’s new crack is shaped like a finger pointing.
10. **Port Clash** — Lantern-law vs. street-law; confiscations bloom. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[TRADE]’ *The lanterns were moved last night. The old safe channel is now a reef. The harbor master is not answering questions. He is listening to the stone.*
- J **Warband Flip** — Colors change mid-pay; hostage protocol snaps shut. ‘[MILITARY]’ ‘[BETRAYAL]’
The hostages are eating well. Their captors are not. The captain’s new banner is stitched with his old captain’s hair. The stone’s crack has grown wider.
- Q **Restoration Preacher** — Stirs crowds against the “barbarian king in purple.” ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[FEAR]’
The preacher’s license was signed by a dead abbot. The seal is still warm. The crowd does not know. The stone does not care.
- K **General Levy** — The march is closed; markets freeze into spears. ‘[MILITARY]’ ‘[SUPPLY]’
The levy notice is posted in three languages. None of them are local. The tax collector has a bow. The stone has stopped listening.
- A **Spring Melt** — Eats the Wolf Road; proofs, plans, and armies bog. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’
The road is a memory. The ruts fill with water — and older things. The bridge keeper is fishing for boots. The stone’s crack is now a chasm.

(**Charter/Right/Escort**) Foedus Renewal Seal for settlement and stipends; Mallus Bench-Right to hold court under the oak.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Foedus Seal** — Settlement and stipends confirmed for a season. ‘[LAW]’ *The seal is a bronze wolf’s head. It warms when the treaty holds — and cools when it doesn’t. The wolf’s eyes are garnets. One eye is cracked.*
3. **Mallus Right** — Hold court under the oak and be obeyed. ‘[LAW]’ *The oak is older than the kingdom. Its roots have seen more verdicts than the throne. The acorns are bitter. The oak’s leaves are falling early.*
4. **Stipend Arrears** — Paid in salt and grain; portable, persuasive. ‘[SUPPLY]’ *The salt is grey. The grain is from last harvest. Both are worth more than coin. The soldiers will accept.*

The stone will not.

5. **Utaran Patent** — Citizenship-style privilege; doors open, bows deepen. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The patent is a worn scrap of vellum. It has been folded and refolded for a century. The seal is a sunburst. The sunburst is fading.*
 6. **Stall-Right** — Customs favor on a frontier market line. ‘[TRADE]’ *The stall is a painted plank. Plant it, and the tax man will pretend not to see you. He will remember the favour. The stone will not.*
 7. **Hostage Treaty** — Exchange fosters; grudges trade for leverage. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[OATH]’ *The hostages are children. Their parents are patient. The treaty has nine clauses. The ninth is unspoken. The stone has forgotten the first eight.*
 8. **Remount Allotment** — Fresh horses from royal paddocks, no questions. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The horses are from the king’s own herd. They know the roads better than you. They also know the king’s secrets. They refuse to cross the stone’s shadow.*
 9. **Wergild Table** — Recognized by both codes; vengeance priced and paid. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The table is a slate slab. The prices are carved deep — and often recarved. The newest price is a year of rain. The rain is washing away the carvings.*
 10. **Bridge Farm** — Imperial for a season; funds and friends accrue. ‘[TRADE]’ *The bridge toll is a copper a head. The bridge keeper is your new best friend. He also keeps a list of your enemies. He scratches the list on the stone.*
- J **Purple Warrant** — Wear the stripe; officials defer on sight. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The stripe is a sash. It was a curtain in a past life. The present life is yours. Do not lose it. The stone’s crack has swallowed one like it.*
- Q **Queen’s Audience** — Private; a whisper becomes policy. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The audience is held in a garden. The flowers are listening. The gardener is a spy. The gardener is also the queen. She keeps a piece of the stone under her tongue.*
- K **Dux Commission** — Command a mixed unit with pay authority. ‘[MILITARY]’ *The commission is a baton. It doubles as a mace in a pinch. It also doubles as a receipt. The receipt is overdue. The stone has a receipt for the stone.*
- A **Great Law Day** — Proclaim a new concord; one temporary exception to old law. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[LEGEND]’ *The proclamation is made at noon. By sunset, everyone will have an opinion. By dawn, the Foedus Stone will have a new finger — or a new crack.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (charters/rights/escorts) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **law and bond** motifs — oaths that bind, stones that witness, treaties that remember every hand — but also **cracks and forgetting**.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **The Witness Fading Clock [8]:** Tracks the erosion of Vilikari legal authority. **Ticks** when:
 - The party defies a Vilikari judgment or brings a dispute to an outside court (+1)

- The GM spends 2 SB to represent a forgotten oath (+1)
- A foreign envoy (Ykrul, Ecktorian, etc.) publicly ignores a Vilikari ruling (+1)

At 4 segments: Any Vilikari NPC the party interacts with suffers –1 die to social rolls (they doubt their own authority). The stone’s cracks are visible to all. **At 8 segments:** The Foedus Stone cracks completely. The Vilikari are no longer recognized as a neutral party. The Ykrul and Ecktorians begin fighting over their land. The party can reset the clock only by **renewing the treaty** — finding a witness older than the stone itself (a Lethai-al elder, a Trow, a ghost of the original signatory) and having them speak the oath aloud.

- **Two-Law Balance:** Whenever a *jurisdictional conflict* arises (mallus vs. basilica, oak vs. marble), players may step Position up by citing the Foedus Stone or an older precedent — but every use adds a tick to a **Two-Law** [4] clock. When it fills, one side demands exclusive authority. The other side sharpens its knives. If the Witness Fading Clock is at 4+, this clock ticks twice as fast.
- **Frontier Diplomacy:** If a *Heart* card involves a foreign envoy, a federate, or a mixed-blood courtier, treat the first **Diamond** played in the scene as doubled leverage. Once per session, a deal struck reverberates — advance or start a **Border Tension** front. If the Witness Fading Clock is at 6+, the deal also ticks the clock by 1 (the stone forgets another clause).
- **March Markets:** At any *Staple Market, Ford, or Bridge*, Diamonds tied to rights or escorts may be cashed as currency in lieu of coin, one-for-one. Doing so creates a **Ledger Debt** that the GM may call in later through factions or raiders. The debt is never written. It is remembered — until the stone forgets.
- **The Vilikari Diaspora (Ecktoria & Acasia):** Vilikari characters in Ecktoria gain +1 die on Streetwise checks (they know the back alleys and the bribes), but –1 die on social rolls with Old Blood patricians (who see them as upstarts). In Acasia, they gain +1 die on Survival checks (their ancestors were farmers here) but –1 die on social rolls with the Curse-touched (who remember imperial tax collectors). A Vilikari character may start with one “family ledger” — a minor asset that tracks a single unpaid favour across generations. If the Witness Fading Clock ever fills, the ledger turns to ash.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Two-Faced King** — Mykkiel. *Justice that wears a laurel and a wolf’s tail.*
 - **The Hearth Judge** — The Witness. *The flame that watches both sides of the bargain.*
 - **The Oak Father** — Grimmir. *The root that holds the law; the branch that signs the treaty.*
 - **The Coin Saint** — Maelstraeus. *Interest on a handshake; the ledger that never sleeps.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Smugglers’ Covenant (The Sealed Gate):** Vilikari pilots who run the Kahfagian coast swear by a secret oath to the *Unlatched Lock* — a threshold that never fully closes. They leave a copper nail at every hidden cove. A captain who breaks the covenant finds that their boat will not cross the tide line; the sea simply refuses to carry them. The Kahfagian Admiralty has tried to bribe the covenant’s keeper; he accepted the coin and sank the next morning in calm water. The stone’s newest crack appeared that same night.
- **Saint Theodora of the Dual Writ (The Witness):** A march notary who uncovered a Fenwood spy in the Federate King’s court. She forced the spy to sign a confession under both oak and marble, then burned the oak copy and kept the marble one. The spy vanished, but

his signature appears on every broken treaty in Vilikari history. Her quill is kept in the Dux's Palace; it writes in lemon juice, and the truth it records cannot be erased by fire or water. The stone's cracks drink the juice.

- **The Host of the Two Ledgers (The Longhouse Healers):** A hospice near the Foedus Stone is run by grey-robed healers who ask no payment. They treat wounded raiders from both sides of the steppe, and the Ykrul and Ecktorian captains have agreed to a truce around its doors. The Federate King tolerates them because they also hold the rite of the *Unbuckled Oath* — a ceremony where a knight may renounce a blood-debt without losing honour, by placing their sword on the stone and speaking a single true regret. The stone remembers these regrets. It has many.
- **The Ostrihari Cousins (The Savage Heart):** The eastern Vilikari, called Ostrihari by lowlanders, are no more savage than any frontier people. Their reputation comes from the bear cults of the upper Wolf Road, where initiates wear cured skins and speak in growls. The Ostrihari do not raid Vilikari villages; they trade furs for iron and send their young to serve as mercenaries in the Black Banners. A Vilikari proverb says: “The Ostrihari sharpen their teeth on stone, not on kin.” The stone does not mind. It has no teeth left.
- **The Ninth:** In any Vilikari scene, the ninth witness called to a mallus court is always a ghost. The wise stop at eight and settle out of court. Those who call a ninth witness find that the ghost speaks the truth — but the truth is always the worst possible version, and the living witnesses remember it as their own. The stone's cracks are full of these truths.

Vilikari Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Stone:** Crumble a crust at the base of the Foedus Stone. Ignore the first *Law Tangle* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Braid:** Tie a single knot in a horse's tail. Cancel *Annona Late* or take –1 die on your next supply roll (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Oak:** Whisper a dead enemy's name into the hollow of the mallus oak. Gain +1 Effect when collecting wergild from their kin this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Elder of Elders. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Press the Crack (new):** Touch the newest crack in the Foedus Stone and speak a promise you intend to break. Gain +1 die on your next deception roll, but the stone will remember your name. The Hollow will too. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **march officials or tribal elders**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **levy guards or market patrols**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or treaty keepers**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable legal window**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.
- **Crack Whispers (Vilikari only):** A character hears the stone whispering a forgotten promise. They must test Resolve (DV 3) or mark 1 Fatigue.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised: Horse-Reeve or March Notary** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **legal challenge or border closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival faction or warband** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.
- **Witness Fading:** Advance the **Witness Fading Clock** by 1 segment (the stone forgets something).

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **shield-brothers, levy forces, or foreign troops** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **treaty voided/levy called/border dispute erupts**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.
- **Stone Speaks:** The Foedus Stone whispers a forgotten clause that invalidates a character’s legal protection for the scene.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Federate King, Queen of Marches, or Elder of Elders** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **raid hits/levy called/treaty breaks**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.
- **Crack Splits:** The Foedus Stone’s newest crack widens. One of the party’s active Diamonds is lost (crumbles to dust).

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Vilikari (Two Laws):** Legal documents contradict each other, courts issue conflicting rulings, oaths bind to different authorities. The stone’s cracks eat ink.
- **Vilikari (Frontier Diplomacy):** Treaties expire without warning, foreign envoys demand additional concessions, mixed-blood courtiers shift allegiances. The stone forgets who signed what.
- **Vilikari (Border Tensions):** Frontier posts close without notice, markets shift locations, safe-conducts are revoked mid-journey. The stone’s shadow grows longer.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The March Notary (quills like daggers)** — *Phases:* Citation Tangle → Seal Swap → Precedent Trap. *Cracks:* produce a **Foedus Seal** to quiet him; a **Queen’s Audience** overrules his filing. If the Witness Fading Clock is at 6+, he gains +1 die in all phases (the stone supports him).

- **Ykrul Storm-Rider (wolf-cloak, bone whistle)** — *Phases*: Raid Cry → Herd Stampede → Blood Price. *Cracks*: a **Wergild Table** settles the feud without combat; a **Hostage Treaty** buys a season's peace. He fights harder if the stone is cracked (he smells weakness).
- **The Prefect's Auditor (Ecktorial ink on his fingers)** — *Phases*: Ledger Seizure → Tax Levy → Fort Closure. *Cracks*: an **Utaran Patent** grants immunity; a **Mallus Right** transfers jurisdiction to the oak. He carries a piece of the stone in his pocket; if the party takes it, the Witness Fading Clock resets by 2.
- **The Stone's Ghost (Foedus Avatar)** — *Phases*: Whisper of Forgotten Clauses → Crack Widens → The Hollow Steps Through. *Cracks*: speak the original treaty aloud (requires a Lethai-al witness), repair the stone with a memory of a kept promise, or sacrifice a personal oath to feed the stone instead of the Hollow.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Two-Law Dial (Oak ↔ Marble)**: Track which legal tradition holds sway.
 - *Oak High*: +1 Position when invoking mallus, blood-price, or tribal custom; first basilica petition starts one step worse.
 - *Marble High*: +1 Effect when citing charters, patents, or Utaran precedent; first mallus oath starts one step worse.
 - Center the dial by offering a wergild recognized by both sides or hosting a joint moot. If the Witness Fading Clock is at 4+, centering requires a sacrifice (a memory, a name, a drop of blood on the stone).
- **Treaty-Feast Procedure (fast diplomacy)**:
 1. **Set the Table**: Name 2–3 *terms* (what both sides want) and 1 *taboo* (off-limits).
 2. **First Cup (Position)**: Roll a social test; success grants +1 die to bargain, failure grants the host 1 SB.
 3. **Bread & Salt (Offer)**: Put *one* leverage on the table (Diamond or oath-promise). Host matches with an obligation (escort, market access, or hostage).
 4. **Smoke (Complication)**: The GM reveals a pressure tied to *Old Grudges* or *Two Laws*. Resolve it or accept a *Rider Clause*.
 5. **Knot the Braid**: On success, create a **Feast-Bond** [3] clock that protects both parties from betrayal in that matter while it has segments; on breach, the breaker immediately takes 1–2 SB and the clock flips to **Blood-Owed** [3].
 6. **Stone Witness**: If the Feast-Bond is sworn at the Foedus Stone, it also reduces the Witness Fading Clock by 1. The stone remembers one more promise.
- **Frontier Market (quick trading)**:
 - At any *Staple Market* or *Stone Ford*, players may convert a held $\Diamond$ into a *Market Edge* (+1 die to all buy/sell rolls).
 - Each conversion ticks a **Market Knives** [4] clock for that locale. When it fills, a rival factor challenges your right to trade — face a duel, a bribe demand, or a confiscation.
 - If the Witness Fading Clock is at 6+, the rival factor is a ghost — a forgotten signatory of the Foedus Stone. The duel is a legal dream-duel.
- **Start-of-Scene Omens (1d6)**:
 1. *Laurel Wilt*: first legal action gains +1d; first boast draws **Law Tangle**.

2. *Smoke on the Steppe*: **Raid Rumor** advances once; shortcuts open.
3. *Twin Bells*: both courts are in session; pick a side or start **Law Tangle**.
4. *Queen’s Dove*: a message arrives; +1d on the next **Queen’s Audience**.
5. *Grey Salt*: **Stipend Arrears** counts double value today; smugglers’ ears open.
6. *Old Eagle*: an Utaran relic surfaces; **Utaran Patent** use is free this scene.
7. *Crack Light (special when Witness Fading Clock 4)*: The stone glows. The next legal argument made at the stone is automatically binding — for both sides.

- **Plug-in SB Conversions (Vilikari Flavor):**

- 1 SB → *Seal Crack*: a writ loses half its value until re-witnessed.
- 2 SB → *Citation War*: increase DV by 1 unless you produce a precedent (spend a *◊orrecallapastruling*).
- 3+ SB → *Crown Fracture*: a treaty splits; halve a consequence by accepting a rival’s seal on your paper (start **Two-Law** clock).
- 2 SB (Vilikari only) → *Stone Whisper*: The Foedus Stone reveals a forgotten clause. The GM must answer one yes/no question about a treaty or oath in the region.

- **Reputation Echoes:**

- *Court-Favored*: once/session, downgrade **Law Tangle** to a minor delay; the next document you present is scrutinized (+1 DV).
- *Raid-Tested*: +1 Position when evading Ykrul or Black Banners; supply lines run 1 segment longer.
- *Neutral Broker*: +1d with both oak and marble in a treaty scene; any betrayal earns **Blood-Owed** [2] from both sides.
- *Stone-Marked (gained by renewing the treaty)*: The Foedus Stone remembers your name. Once per session, you may reroll a failed social roll involving a Vilikari or a treaty. The stone will ask for a memory in return.

- **Cross-Region Hooks (quick integration):**

- *Kahfagia (Lantern-Law)*: A **Foedus Seal** may stand in for a *Safe-Conduct* along a beacons lane once. Doing so starts **Port Clash** [2] in the next harbor touched.
- *Ecktoria (Imperial Remnants)*: An **Utaran Patent** counts as either *Archive Hour* (scholars open doors) or *Icon License* (display symbols) in Ecktorial sites — choose once per session.
- *Aelerian Mountains (Pass & Toll)*: A **Pass-Ring** (from the Aeler expansion) grants priority at dwarf switchbacks; cashing it to bypass inspection spawns **Ledger Notice** [3].
- *Direwood (Breath & Bells)*: Spending **Stipend Arrears** for levee labor converts one Direwood **Clubs** draw into a *Ward-Salt* Diamond for a scene, then begins **Names Disputed** [3] with bell-wardens.
- *Acasia (Curse Tithe)*: A **Wergild Table** accepted by a Curse-touched village also clears one *Feud Spark* clock, but the Hollow gains +1 Attention.
- *Lethai-ar Silk Bridges*: A **Hostage Treaty** can be witnessed by a Lethai-ar silk-warden, making it binding across the Crimson Valley. The price is a strand of the treaty-bearer’s hair.

Patronage & Power

In Vilikari society, power flows through the careful balance of multiple legal traditions, the management of frontier diplomacy, and the maintenance of complex oaths and treaties. The Federate King maintains authority through a combination of imperial forms and traditional customs, while local leaders wield influence through their knowledge of both Utaran law and tribal custom. The true power lies with those who can navigate this complex legal and diplomatic landscape while maintaining the loyalty of their people and the respect of their neighbors.

But the stone is cracking. The witnesses are dying. The Vilikari are becoming *invisible*.

For the GM: Patronage in Vilikari society revolves around legal documents, diplomatic relationships, and the ability to command respect from institutions that operate under multiple legal systems. Rewards often take the form of treaties, charters, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize the hybrid identity and the fading authority:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, writs, treaties) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided — and that may crumble if the stone forgets.
- Let rival legal systems issue conflicting authorities, forcing players to choose whose favour matters more. Neither may remember them tomorrow.
- Use the courts, markets, and frontier posts as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success — and where the stone's whispers can tip the balance.
- Remember that Vilikari characters are at home in Ecktoria's counting-houses and Acasia's hedgerow courts alike — but they are never fully trusted in either. That suspicion is their best tool. When the stone cracks fully, that suspicion becomes exile.

In Vilikari society, your word is your bond, and your bond determines whether you rule or are ruled. But a bond is only as strong as the stone that witnesses it. And the stone is forgetting.

Chapter 13

Black Banners

Condotta & Crowns. Mercenary leagues born from ex-Utaran legionaries, second sons, debt-dodgers, and exiles. The Black Banners sell steel to the highest bidder, today's ally becoming tomorrow's quarry. Between them move the Ykrul steppe-clans and the Vilikari hill tribes, while Ecktorian ministers call it "pressure management." The companies call it a season.

13.1 Black Banners — “Condotta & Crowns”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *A contract is only as good as the next payday.*

Banner-Captain (Elite): “A contract is only as good as the next payday, and a grudge is only as sharp as the sword backing it. In this game, we sell steel by the season and vendettas by the year.”

Veteran Sergeant (Commoner): “I’ve seen three captains rise and fall in the time it takes to grow a beard, but the mud stays the same and the pay comes when it pleases. Best keep your own counsel and your blade sharp. The camp sings? You live. They stop singing? Even the best charter bleeds.”

Genre / Mood: Mercenary realism, winter warfare, ledger-driven violence.

Starting Location: A war-camp crossroads where two banners snap in the same wind, their sigils bleeding into one another. A Condotta broker with ink-stained fingers lays two contracts on a barrel — one from Ecktoria, one from Ykrul. “Pick a war. Pick a grave. The bell tolls at noon.”

Condotta & Crowns

Ecktorian treasuries bankroll a perpetual border-war they claim to be *containing*. In truth, the gold keeps the fire burning. The Black Banners are mercenary leagues — ex-Utaran legionaries, second-sons, debt-dodgers, and exiles — who sell steel to the highest bidder, today’s ally becoming tomorrow’s quarry. Between them move the Ykrul steppe-clans (swift, pragmatic, oath-canny) and the Vilikari hill tribes (crafty, patient, and proud). Ecktorian ministers call it “pressure management.” The companies call it a season.

What you notice first: The smell of wet wool and old blood. The way every tent has a ledger pinned to its flap. The silence when the paychest is opened — and the murmur when it’s light.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never break a Bell Dawn. Three bells at sunrise means bury the dead, trade prisoners, fix the wells, no ambushes. Violating it is how legends end badly — and how captains end hanging.

Regional Mood: The Theater of Banners

Here, war is a marketplace. The Black Banners are not a single army but a squabbling league of freelance violence, bound by camp law, pay customs, and the shared knowledge that tomorrow’s enemy might be today’s employer. The real battles are fought in counting-tents over clauses and riders; the clash outside is just the audit. Loyalty is a coin that fluctuates with the market, and a captain’s true skill lies in reading the political winds that blow across contested borders. Between the rigid honour codes of Ecktorian nobility and the fluid pragmatism of steppe clans and hill tribes, mercenaries navigate a dangerous middle ground where survival depends on knowing when to keep an oath and when to break one — always at dawn, with a witness, and with surety paid.

Prominent NPCs of the Black Banners

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Castellan Thorne	Banner-Captain of the Iron Hand	Win a permanent contract for his company	He has never lost a siege, but he has lost three paychests to bad debt.
Old Sorka	Veteran Sergeant (commoner exemplar)	Keep her squad alive until spring	She counts scars like coins; her left ear is a nub from a mutineer’s apology.

Lys	Condotta Broker	Flip contracts for maximum margin	Her ink has a metallic smell. She says it’s from the silver in the seals.
Chaghan	Ykrul Clan Emissary	Test the Black Banners’ honour before the next migration	He speaks only in proverbs and pays in copper from a cursed mine.
Volund	Quartermaster-Provost	Stockpile leverage on every officer in the camp	His bribe book is thicker than his roster; he calls it “risk assessment.”
The Bannerless One	Mysterious warlord	Unite the scattered companies under a single will	She has no flag. Men follow her because she asked.

Names of the Black Banners

Names here are a polyglot stew – Acasian grit, Ecktorian formality, Ykrul harshness, Vilkari cadence, and the nicknames that arise from a season in the mud. Surnames may be patronymic, a place of origin, or a battlefield epithet.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Castellan	Sorka	Thornson	<i>the Iron</i>
Chaghan	Lys	Volund	<i>the Red-Tally</i>
Orthen	Maeva	Kaeldottir	<i>Bell-Breaker</i>
Rurik	Veleda	dei Conti	<i>the Unpaid</i>
Bromm	Gisela	Halvkirk	<i>White-Ribbon</i>
Zelgur	Thorn	Flint	<i>Ash-Foot</i>

(Camps/Battlefields/Fortresses/War-roads) Burned village turned field-hospital; flies, tinctures, and fever-prayers. Frozen ford with last month’s dead held under glass; standards trapped in the ice.

Spades — Places

2. **Burned Village** – Field-hospital; flies, tinctures, fever-prayers. ‘[DEATH]’ *The flies are fat. They’ve eaten well this season.*
3. **Frozen Ford** – Last month’s dead held under glass; standards trapped in the ice. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[WEATHER]’ *The ice is clear — clear enough to read the terror on their faces.*

4. **Latrine Row** – At dusk; mud, shame, whispered mutiny, a sergeant who hears too well. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The sergeant’s ears are scarred. He listened to a mutiny once and survived.*
5. **Crater Pasture** – From an alchemical barrage; in spring, glass flowers sprout like guilt. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The flowers cut. They remember the hands that sowed them.*
6. **Supply Road** – Twelve broken wagons; oxen nose the wreckage for salt. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The salt is from a burned caravan. The oxen are from the same village.*
7. **Half-Raised Siege Tower** – In an abandoned camp; every rung creaks with grudges. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The tower was paid for twice. It still leans toward the richer patron.*
8. **Salt-Cured Cache** – Behind the surgeon’s tent; the wrong kind of maggots move. ‘[DEATH]’ *The maggots have a pattern. It spells a name — yours, or the surgeon’s.*
9. **Command Tent** – Maps show borders that diplomacy has already erased. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The maps were drawn by a clerk who died last winter. He was still updating them.*
10. **Watch-Tower** – Stacked from skulls and slate; the crows know the countersign. ‘[WAR]’ *The crows are paid in eyes. They are very well paid.*
- J **Ancient March-Keep** – Held by a skeleton garrison of veterans; they remember when the banners were gold. ‘[DEATH]’ *The veterans are dead. They just haven’t noticed yet.*
- Q **The Bone Fields** – Where Ykrul elders parley among cairns and reckon oaths with the dead. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[OATH]’ *The dead vote. Their votes are always for war.*
- K **Marcher’s Fortress** – Three walls, two sieges’ scars, one gate that opens inward only. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The gate opens inward so the dead can leave. The living are not invited.*
- A **The Singing Wastes** – Fallen weapons hum with the voices of their last wielders on a wind that tastes of iron. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *The hum is a petition. The dead want their names back.*

(**Captains/Cadets/Clans/Tribes**) Young cadet with a father’s sword and a mother’s debt; veteran sergeant who counts scars like coins — and spends them on whiskey and mercy.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Young Cadet** – Father’s sword, mother’s debt, and a hunger to prove himself. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The sword is old. The debt is older. Both weigh the same.*
3. **Veteran Sergeant** – Counts scars like coins — spends them on whiskey and mercy. ‘[COMBAT]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *His left ear is gone. He says a mutineer took it. He says the mutineer apologized.*
4. **Ecktorian Banner-Captain** – Griffon standard, a ledger of noble grudges, and a smile like a winter. ‘[LAW]’ *The griffon’s eyes are rubies. They were looted from a temple. The god still watches.*
5. **Condotta Broker** – Changes colours when the wind turns, but always lands on his feet. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *His feet are calloused from landing. He has never broken an ankle.*
6. **Ykrul Clan Emissary** – Speaks in riddled proverbs and pays in copper and promises. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[OATH]’ *The copper is from a cursed mine. The promises are from a cursed tongue.*
7. **Vilikari War-Chief’s Second Son** – Honour burns brighter than his father’s patience. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *His father’s patience is measured in seasons. This is the last season.*

8. **Surgeon of the Red Ledger** – Treats friend and foe alike; her ledger balances only in blood. ‘[DEBT]’ *Her ledger is bound in human skin. The skin was a gift from a patient who lived.*
9. **Quartermaster** – Knows where every coin went and every man will fall. ‘[DEBT]’ *His bribe book is thicker than his roster. He calls it “risk assessment.”*
10. **Tribune’s Aide-de-Camp** – Sealed orders that contradict the general’s intent. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The general’s intent was to retire. The seals say otherwise.*
- J **The Black Colonel** – Legendary commander not seen in the line for months, yet his banner still rides. ‘[LEGEND]’ *The banner rides alone. The horse is riderless. The men follow anyway.*
- Q **Ykrul Clan-Mother** – Weaves war-braids from the hair of oath-breakers. ‘[OATH]’ *Each braid has a name. The names are still attached.*
- K **Vilikari High Chief** – Trades mercenaries like game pieces and never tips the board. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The board is an old treaty map. The pieces are real.*
- A **The Bannerless One** – Commands loyalty without rank or flag; men follow because they want to. ‘[LEGEND]’ *They follow into the Singing Wastes. They follow into the ice. They follow because she asked.*

(Betrayals/Weather/Politics/War) Payday delayed; supplies die before coin arrives. False orders: your target is now your ally — on paper. Blizzard pins two rival companies in the same cloister; vows and knives both come out.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Payday Delayed** – Supplies die before coin arrives. ‘[DEBT]’ *The coin was eaten by interest. The interest has teeth.*
3. **False Orders** – Your target is now your ally — on paper. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The paper is from a dead notary. The signature is warm.*
4. **Blizzard Pins** – Two rival companies, one cloister; vows and knives both come out. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The cloister’s abbot is counting. He will sell the winner’s story.*
5. **Ykrul Counter-Offer** – Better terms than Ecktoria; your contract becomes a liability. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The terms are written in salt. They will dissolve in rain — or blood.*
6. **Condotta Flip** – Unit switches colours mid-battle; your “relief” hits your flank. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The new colours are the same as the old colours. The captain just wanted a raise.*
7. **Camp-Fever** – Blooms in the surgeon’s tent; the counting-house for the dead. ‘[DEATH]’ *The fever has a face. It is the face of a soldier you left behind.*
8. **Vilikari Raid** – Cuts your supply road; winter moves the schedule. ‘[COMBAT]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The raiders took the salt and left a recipe. The recipe calls for tears.*
9. **Honour Code Collision** – Ecktorian ideals vs. mercenary pragmatism; the camp splits by doctrine. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The doctrine is written on a napkin. The napkin is from a feast that ended badly.*
10. **Tribune Captured** – The aide must choose: the rescue or the war. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The war is a ledger. The rescue is a name. Names are heavier than ledgers.*
- J **Black Colonel’s Banner** – Appears on the wrong field; confusion is a weapon. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The banner is frayed. It has seen too many wrong fields.*

- Q **Blood-Feast** – Clan-Mother calls it; all contracts suspended until dawn’s judgment. ‘[OATH]’
 ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The judgment is a feast. The feast is a trial. The trial is a knife.*
- K **High Chief’s Game** – Plays companies against each other; “winner” takes obligations, not spoils. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The obligations are written in invisible ink. You will see them when it is too late.*
- A **The Singing Wastes Awaken** – Every fallen blade rises to seek its last hand. ‘[MAGIC]’
 ‘[DEATH]’ *The blades remember the grip. They do not remember mercy.*

(**Contracts/Claims/Dispensations**) Emergency requisition — strip a fallen company for what you need (and their ghosts for what they’re owed). Dual contract — serve two masters with goals that cannot both be met.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Emergency Requisition** – Strip a fallen company; their ghosts watch. ‘[DEBT]’ *The ghosts will remember. They will collect.*
 3. **Dual Contract** – Serve two masters whose goals cannot both be met. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[DEBT]’
The masters are both paying. The interest is your reputation.
 4. **Honour Dispensation** – Your acts are justified regardless of code (for now). ‘[SOCIAL]’
The dispensation is a bell. Ring it, and the tribunal looks away — once.
 5. **Condotta Rider’s Pass** – Cross any camp perimeter unchallenged. ‘[STEALTH]’ *The pass is a feather. The feather is from a messenger who arrived too late.*
 6. **Ykrul Safe-Conduct Token** – Pass a named clan’s lands unmolested (until the moon changes). ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The token is a horse’s tooth. The horse was a gift from a Khagan. The Khagan is dead.*
 7. **Vilikari War-Mark** – Their scouts guide you through hostile hills — and remember the favour. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The favour will be called at dawn. The location will be a ridge. The odds will be even.*
 8. **Surgeon’s Debt-Note** – Medical care when no coin remains; the interest is names. ‘[DEBT]’
The names are of people who owe the surgeon. You are now one of them.
 9. **Tribune’s Cipher Ring** – Decode orders that do not exist yet. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The ring is warm. The future is cold.*
 10. **Banner-Captain’s Seal** – Commandeer resources from junior companies (and their resentment). ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The seal is a skull. The jaw moves when you press it.*
- J **Field Promotion Warrant** – Assume command of a shattered unit, inherit its clocks. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[DEBT]’
The clocks are ticking. The unit is watching.
- Q **Clan-Mother’s War-Braids** – Her chosen fight beside you this battle, then judge you after. ‘[COMBAT]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The judgment is a song. The song will be sung at your funeral.*
- K **High Chief’s Trading Charter** – Buy or sell *anything* in any camp, no questions asked aloud. ‘[TRADE]’ *The questions are asked in silence. The answers are paid in silence.*
- A **The Bannerless Word** – Loyalty that outruns rank, law, and coin. ‘[LEGEND]’ *The word is a whisper. The whisper is a promise. The promise is a grave.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (contracts/claims/dispensations) that shift position rather than call for a roll.
- If any Ace appears, echo war and winter motifs — ice that keeps the dead, weapons that remember, loyalty that needs no banner.

The Fractured League: Banner Alignments

The Black Banners are not a single army but a squabbling market of violence. Three loose alignments shape the loyalties of any war-camp. Most companies shift between these poles depending on the season, the paychest, and the weather.

- **Condotta Brokers (The Paper Men)** – They own the contracts, not the swords. They flip companies like playing cards and measure victory in percentages. Most captains hate them, but everyone pays them. *Clocks: BROKER’S GRIP [4], DOUBLE CHARTER [6]*.
- **Company Loyalists (The Old Banners)** – Veterans who remember when a banner meant a blood-oath, not a season’s wage. They grumble, they desert, they are sometimes bought – but they fight like demons when the paychest is full. *Clocks: VETERAN WRATH [4], OATH REMEMBERS [6]*.
- **Free Companies (The Tide)** – Newly raised, culturally mixed, and chronically unpaid. They are as likely to mutiny as to charge, and their loyalty can be bought with a hot meal and a day’s rest. *Clocks: MUTINY WHISPER [4], PAYDAY FEVER [6]*.

Superimposed on these are the **Ykrul steppe-clans** (honour-bound, quick to take insult) and the **Vilikari hill tribes** (pragmatic, patient, and skilled at ambush). A wise captain learns to read all three.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Payday & Supply Clocks:** Track two pressures common to the Black Banners: **Payday** [4] and **Supply** [4]. When Payday fills, morale falters and the Keeper may peel away a squad or impose a desertion SB. When Supply fills, all risky maneuvers begin one step worse Position until the players secure fresh provisions or bargain a Diamond.
- **Allegiances in Flux:** At the start of a scene, roll 1d6 to see if loyalties shift:
 1. Condotta broker flips colours mid-parley.
 2. Ykrul emissary offers better terms; accept and mark Obligation, or refuse and tick Payday.
 3. Vilikari scouts reveal a shortcut; gain +1 Effect but risk SB from hostile terrain.
 4. Ecktorian clerk “corrects” your orders; obey for +1 Position, defy and gain a Diamond but earn a Black Mark.
 5. Rival captain spreads falsified orders; unless revealed, counters are harder this scene.
 6. The Bannerless One’s messengers arrive; accept their word to clear 1 Payday, but the Keeper gains 1 SB.
- **Honour vs. Pragmatism Dial:** Place a two-step dial between *Honour* and *Pragmatism*.
 - **Honour:** +1 Position in parley or oathbound actions; logistics costs rise faster.

- **Pragmatism:** +1 Effect in ambushes or sabotage; parley begins one step worse Position.

Center the dial by a symbolic act – repaying arrears, returning prisoners, or honouring a broken writ.

- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**

- **The Red Ledger** – Maelstraeus (infernal bargainer). *Every contract signs in blood; every payment accrues interest.*
- **The White-Ribbon Courier** – The Traveler (roads and shortcuts). *A safe road is a contract; a shortcut is a rider.*
- **The Unbroken Bell** – The Sealed Gate (threshold guardian). *Bell Dawn is sacred; break it, and the road closes behind you.*
- **The Bannerless One** – An avatar of Ikasha (freedom and thresholds). *No flag, no oath, no debt – only the road and the choice.*

Mercenary Realpolitik

In the world of the Black Banners, loyalty is a currency that fluctuates with the market. A man's worth is measured not in noble blood or ancestral holdings, but in the sharpness of his blade and the reliability of his word. The condotta system creates a web of shifting allegiances where today's enemy may become tomorrow's employer, and a captain's true skill lies not in strategy alone but in reading the political winds that blow across contested borders. Between the rigid honour codes of Ecktorian nobility and the fluid pragmatism of steppe clans and hill tribes, mercenaries navigate a dangerous middle ground where survival depends on knowing when to keep an oath and when to break one.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Sealed Gate:** Deserters who flee a losing battle sometimes cross into the Singing Wastes at night. They return at dawn with their mouths sewn shut and a ward-sigil branded on their palms. The Bannerless One pays well for such men – they cannot speak of what they saw, and they never run again.
- **Maelstraeus, the Infernal Bargainer:** A black ledger circulates among the condotta brokers, its pages written in dried blood. A captain who signs it never misses a payday – but the ledger's interest is collected in souls, not silver. The Bannerless One has refused to touch it. Twice.
- **The Traveler:** Before every major march, a White-Ribbon courier from the Aeler tunnels appears at the edge of camp, plants a brass way-stone, and vanishes by dawn. Companies who follow the stone's direction find safe passage through the worst terrain. Those who ignore it are never seen again.
- **Xhak'Thul, the Thunder-Speaker:** A drummer walks the camp on the night before a battle, beating a rhythm that has no source. Veterans do not look for the drummer; they sleep with their hands over their ears. When the drum stops, the battle begins – and one side will be annihilated by a storm that came from nowhere.
- **The Ninth:** In any war-camp, the ninth tent pitched in a row will collapse before dawn. The wise pitch eight and leave a space. Those who ignore this find that the ground beneath the ninth tent is always damp – and the footprints leading out of it never match any boot in the company.

Black Banner Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Paychest:** Crumble a crust into an empty chest. Ignore the first *Payday Delayed* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Colours:** Tie a single knot in a banner’s cord. Cancel *Condotta Flip* or take –1 die on your next morale check (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Wastes:** Whisper a dead captain’s name into the wind. Gain +1 Effect when rallying their former unit this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Bannerless One. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table**Minor Complications (1 SB)**

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **condotta brokers or camp guards**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **rival companies or camp followers**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or debt collectors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favourable contract terms**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Banner-Captain or quartermaster** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **blizzard or camp upheaval**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival mercenary squad or debt collector** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **free companies, Ykrul riders, or camp enforcers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes – **contract voided / paychest stolen / Bell Dawn broken**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **The Bannerless One, Clan-Mother, or Black Colonel** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically – **Singing Wastes awaken / camp splits / blizzard seals the pass**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice – **omen appears / blessing lost / curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Black Banners (Camp Law):** Payday disputes escalate to blades, a banner is stolen, a sergeant calls a mutiny.
- **Black Banners (Winter War):** Frostbite slows movement, supply lines freeze, mercenaries demand double pay or desert.
- **Black Banners (Condotta):** A rival broker offers a better charter, a clause is invoked that voids your contract, a captain demands a duel of honour.

Field Procedures (Use at the Table)

- **Colours & Countersigns:** Declaring correct countersigns cancels the first “False Orders” SB each night; wrong signs worsen Position on first contact.
- **Payline Drill:** If a scene depicts orderly pay, clear 1 *Payday*. If pay is “creative,” clear it but mark *Black Mark* – future officers begin one step colder in parley.
- **Scavenge Doctrine:** After battles, you may gain 1 temporary Gear tag or advance *Supply* by 1; on a 1–2 on 1d6, spawn “Honour vs. Pragmatism” conflict immediately.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Survival):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Deep Snow*.
- **Cut the Contract (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a Condotta Rider’s Pass is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Blizzard (Resolve + Endurance):** On a hit in *Blizzard Pins*, you pick who finds shelter; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Archetypes in the Black Banners

Contract & Command (Human Adversaries)

- **Banner-Captain (Fixer General)** – Wins by paperwork and parade-ground precision. *Break their chain-of-command clock [6] by flipping lieutenants, forging orders, or seizing the paychest.*
- **Condotta Broker (Colour-Flipper)** – Turns loyalties like cards. *Expose a dual contract or force public arbitration under neutral bells to collapse their leverage track.*
- **Quartermaster-Provost (Logistics Tyrant)** – Starves you with ledgers. *Complete the Three Cuts: road, ration, rumor — any two stalls them; all three topple their supply engine.*

Tribe & Tactic (Field Sovereigns)

- **Ykrul Raid-Mother (Oath-Weaver)** – Fights with remounts and safe-hostages. *Honour horse-rites to gain truce windows; break one braid in parley to end a phase.*
- **Vilikari Hill-Fox (Ambush Architect)** – Owns ridgelines and feint paths. *Clear Three High Stones (overwatch, supply cache, signal cairn) to force even ground.*

Faith & Fear (Camp Powers)

- **Field Chaplain–Inquisitor (Morale Engine)** – Smelts guilt into zeal. *Win by sanctifying plague-ground or redeeming prisoners; each rite drops their Zeal track [0–3].*

- **Surgeon of the Red Ledger (Mercy’s Price)** – Keeps units marching past sense. *Expose graft or pay blood-debts; on three reconciled names the operating tent stands down.*

The Unquiet Field (Supernatural Front)

- **The Singing Wastes (Weapon-Host)** – The battlefield itself retaliates. *Complete the Silencing Acts: oil the choir (funeral honours), bury the standards, ring the wind-break bell — each lowers its Tier for one exchange.*
- **Black Colonel’s Banner (Legend in Motion)** – A rumour that commands. *Prove the lie or become the truth: either unmask the courier network (three ciphers cracked) or fly a counter-sigil to pull rank on the myth.*

Faction Entanglements

- **Condotta Brokers’ Syndicate:** Register your charter and bank a *Broker’s Favor* – spend to reduce one parley DV inside a war-camp. Skipping registration flags your unit with *Unauthorised Colors*: the first checkpoint scene gains a free “False Orders” SB.
- **Camp Quartermasters:** Accept ration-scale audits to cancel the first *Supply* tick this leg; refuse and mark a 4-segment *Short Rations* clock that worsens Position on marches.
- **Field Chaplains & Leech-Circles:** Donate time or tithe to clear 1 segment from *Camp-Fever*; if ignored, the Keeper may convert the first 1 SB of a scene into “Disease/Death.”
- **Steppe Envoys:** Honour horse-rites (salt, water, shade) to gain *Remount Rights* – once, treat a retreat as movement with +1 Effect. Break rites and add a *Soured Oath* tag that raises parley DV with riders until cleansed.
- **Hill Truce-Holders:** Enter a stones-circle under their witness to bank a *Blood-Truce* – spend to negate one ambush on hill roads. Violating the circle spawns a 4-segment *Guest Right Forfeit* clock.

Cross-Regional Conversions (Using Diamonds Elsewhere)

- **Vhasia:** A *Condotta Rider’s Pass* can substitute for a *Safe-Conduct* on the Pont-du-Tithe once; after use, start a *Parlement Divided* tick.
- **Viterra:** A *Ykrul Safe-Conduct Token* may be notarised as a *Ferry Priority* in Viterran courts; the notary’s fee is a story.
- **Ubral:** A *Clan-Mother’s War-Braid* counts as a *Guest-Token* in hill-forts; the clans will ask whose side you took in the war.
- **Mistlands:** A *Banner-Captain’s Seal* can be presented to a Bell-Warden as proof of lawful passage; the Warden will test it with a bell. If it rings false, the mist takes a day.
- **Valewood:** A *Field Promotion Warrant* can be offered to a Green Knight as proof of worth; the Knight may challenge you to a trial of paths instead of blades.

Patronage & Power

In the Black Banners, power flows through contracts, paychecks, and the weight of a reputation. A Banner-Captain's authority rests on the number of companies he commands; a Condotta Broker's on the thickness of his ledger. There is no loyalty, only the shared understanding that a broken contract costs more than a broken blade.

For the GM: Power in the Black Banners is measured in payday clocks, broker's favours, and the length of a duel record. Patronage often takes the form of dual contracts, emergency requisitions, or the Bannerless Word – each tied to a specific company, broker, or debt. To emphasise the mercenary realism:

- Use **Payday & Supply Clocks** as visible pressure. Let players negotiate, raid, or pledge future services to clear ticks.
- Enforce **Allegiances in Flux** – every scene, loyalties may shift. The Keeper's SB pool grows when the party betrays a contract.
- Let **Honour vs. Pragmatism** be a dial the party can slide through their actions. Centre it by a costly act of mercy or a profitable betrayal.
- Track **Black Marks** as a persistent reputation score. Three Black Marks and no condotta broker will write a clean charter for you.

In the Black Banners, the camp sings when payday comes – and falls silent when the ledger is written in blood.

Chapter 14

The Linns

Skerries & Storm-Oaths. North of the Aberderrin Sea, where fjords split the coast and skerries break the tide, dwell the Linn. They are traders and raiders in equal breath, their longships crowding the whale-road and river mouths. Their oaths are sworn to storm and sea, and their skalds compose law as easily as they compose satire.

14.1 Linn — “Skerries & Storm-Oaths”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Oaths woven in salt, remembered in verse, witnessed by the tide.*

High Jarl (Elite): “The sea keeps better counsel than any scribe, and the storm remembers every oath sworn upon its winds. To rule these shores is to dance between their moods and never miss a step.”

Net-Wife (Commoner): “The water speaks to those who know how to listen – the way it moves tells you if the fish are running, if the weather’s turning, or if something’s coming that wasn’t invited to the feast.”

Genre / Mood: Norse coastal saga, oath-driven honour, horror of the unwitnessed death.

Starting Location: A longship house lined with storm-charms and whale-bone runes, salt wind clawing at the doors. A Net-Wife binds a storm-token into a PC’s palm. “The Whale-Road sings,” she says. “But the Mistlands whistle back. Bring us three keel-lengths of ironwood from the Valewood edge, or the tide will take our boats in the spring.”

Theme & Atmosphere

North of the Aberderrin Sea, where fjords split the coast and skerries break the tide, dwell the Linn. They are traders and raiders in equal breath, their longships crowding the whale-road and river mouths. They descend the Ylolka like an axe-blade and cut into southern shores, or slip through the Thin Strip where the Valewood dares not touch salt. Yet even these storm-oath people dread the Mistlands and the Valewood, whose fog and trees have no need of ships or harbors to claim their due.

What you notice first: The smell of tar and salt fish. The creak of oars from unseen boats. The way everyone—jarl to thrall—touches a knotted cord before speaking of the sea.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never name a drowned person aloud while underway. The sea collects names, and if it hears you speaking one it doesn't recognize, it may reach up to correct the ledger.

Regional Mood: Skerry Stormcall

Power here is spoken, not written. A jarl's authority rests on the weight of his oath-chest and the sharpness of his skald's tongue. Longships are not vessels; they are promises carved in timber. Every voyage is a gamble against tide, reef, and the attention of things that sleep beneath the waves. The Linn do not fear death—they fear dying without a witness, swallowed by fog where no verse will remember their name.

Prominent NPCs of Linn

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Jarl Skjold	High Jarl of the Southern Fjords	Unite the scattered strands under one oath	His beard is braided with silver from every ship he has taken.
Volva Hervor	Mist-seer and oath-reader	Read the tides of fate before they turn	She speaks once a year; the rest of the time she listens to the fog.
Astrid	Net-Wife (commoner exemplar)	Keep her village safe from the Hollow and the deep	She ties a knot for every storm she's survived. Her belt has thirty.

Brother Halvard	Missionary of the Temple of Light	Convert the Linn to the Lens of the White Flame	He carries a water-clock to measure the hours of prayer, but the skerries have no hours.
Gunnhild	Sea-Queen’s Hand	Enforce the queen’s will without drawing a blade	She never draws her sword. The threat is enough.
The Draugr Jarl	Unfinished business (rumoured)	A dead jarl whose oath was never fulfilled	Said to rise from the Thing-Holm when the ninth bell tolls.

Names of Linn

Inspired by the northern fjords: short, hard consonants, compound words that evoke the sea and the storm. Surnames are often patronymic (-son, -dottir) or taken from a notable deed.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Skjold	Astrid	Einarsson	<i>the Oath-Keeper</i>
Bjorn	Gunnhild	Hervorsdottir	<i>Tide-Reader</i>
Ragnar	Sigrid	Ketilsson	<i>Bell-Sworn</i>
Halvard	Yrsa	Ormsson	<i>the Unfinished</i>
Torsten	Runa	Sturladottir	<i>Whale-Bone</i>
Vidar	Helga	Haakonsson	<i>Ash-Prow</i>

(Fjord/Skerry/Hall) Kelp-skerry gut: a narrow channel where oars scrape weed and rock; tide-shed of longship houses with tar smoke and gulls for sentries.

Spades — Places

2. **Kelp-Skerry Gut** — Narrow channel where oars scrape weed and rock. *Kelp strands like dead men’s hair; row silently or the reef listens.* ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[STEALTH]’
3. **Tide-Shed** — Longship houses; tar smoke and gulls for sentries. *Each shed holds a keel’s ghost; old crews sleep under the floor planks.* ‘[REPUTATION]’
4. **Wave-Gate Reef** — Just off a raiding beach; only locals know the cut. *One wrong turn and the wave breaks over you—twice.* ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[DEATH]’
5. **Runestone Causey** — Across tidal flat; names half lost to barnacle. *Touch the stone with your left hand. If it’s warm, the ancestors approve.* ‘[LEGEND]’

6. **Herring-Stairs** — Drying racks above cliff path; knives flicker like fish. *Workers sing a counting song—eight verses, never nine.* ‘[LABOR]’
7. **Winter Hall** — Turf walls, smoke-eye roof, benches crowded with shields. *The fire never goes out. Feed it a story each night or it goes hungry.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
8. **Mistlands Maze** — Reed-channels braid and vanish; navigation by instinct. *The reeds whisper names you’ve forgotten. Do not answer.* ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[FEAR]’
9. **Boomed Harbor** — Iron rings in whale-bone posts; controlled access. *The chain was forged from a broken oath. It rattles when liars approach.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
10. **Aberderrin Headland** — Current rips past wreck timbers in the kelp. *On foggy nights, the drowned signal with lanterns. Never follow.* ‘[DEATH]’
- J **Dolmis Waystation** — Low isle with fresh water and old debts. *The well is lined with copper. A single dropped coin returns as a blessing.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
- Q **Thing-Holm** — Flat islet ringed with stones for speaking and swearing. *The stones have ears; oaths spoken here echo for three tides.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
- K **High Jarl’s Seat** — Above fjord, beacon tower glaring out to sea. *The beacon oil is mixed with whale fat. It burns green when a storm is close.* ‘[WEATHER]’
- A **Whale-Road Horizon** — Open water where storms are born and names are made. *Here, the sky meets the sea. Here, the dead meet the living.* ‘[LEGEND]’

(Jarl/Oar-Crew/Keeper) Net-wife who reads the sea like a ledger and the sky like a mood; steersman whose tiller-hand never shakes.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Net-Wife** — Reads sea like ledger, sky like mood; weather-witch in all but name. *She ties a knot for every storm she’s survived. Her belt has thirty.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
3. **Steersman** — Tiller-hand never shakes, even when keel does. *His left ear is scarred—he listened too long to a siren’s promise.* ‘[REPUTATION]’
4. **Shipwright** — Pitch on palms, schedule in teeth; knows every plank’s story. *He names each timber after a dead relative. The keel is his grandmother.* ‘[CRAFT]’
5. **Oar-Master** — Sets beat that decides if home is today or never. *He drums on a hollowed skull. The rhythm is a prayer to the sea.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
6. **Mist-Pilot** — Ghosts boats through marsh lanes; reed-runner with secret paths. *He never blinks in fog. Some say he traded his blink for safe passage.* ‘[STEALTH]’
7. **Skald** — Verses buy silence, start fights, end them; law in rhyme. *Her tongue is forked—she can praise and curse in the same breath.* ‘[JUSTICE]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’
8. **Shield-Band** — Cousins fine with coin, better with cattle. *They sharpen their swords on runestones. The sparks tell fortunes.* ‘[COMBAT]’
9. **Foster-Son** — Southern coast birth; speaks both laws and subtext. *He wears two brooches—one iron, one bone. Neither is his true allegiance.* ‘[POLITICS]’
10. **Thing-Speaker** — Makes war into lawsuit, lawsuit into lunch. *He carries a water-clock. When it runs out, so does your patience.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
- J **Sea-Queen’s Hand** — Envoy with seal-bag and sword-belt; queen’s will made manifest. *He never draws his blade. The threat is enough.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’

- Q **Sea-Queen** — Crown of hammered silver, eyes for weather and law. *She lost an eye to a storm—or to a spy. She won’t say which.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- K **High Jarl** — First among raids, last to boast; paramount over strands. *His beard is braided with silver from every ship he’s taken.* ‘[REPUTATION]’
- A **Volva of Mist** — Oath-reader whose nod stills surf; seer of tides and truth. *She speaks once a year. The rest of the time, she listens to the fog.* ‘[LEGEND]’

(**Weather/Reef/Feud**) Black squall drops from clear band; oars or prayers—pick one; fogfall makes friend and reef trade places.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Black Squall** — Drops from clear band; oars or prayers—pick one. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The wind screams a name. Listen carefully—it might be yours.*
 3. **Fogfall** — Sound travels, sight does not; friend and reef trade places. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *You hear oars. Then you don’t. Then they’re behind you.*
 4. **Boom Lift** — Harbor chain rises; schedules drown in harbor mouth. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The chain’s links are inscribed with names of debtors. Each one rattles differently.*
 5. **Levy Clash** — Viterra’s wardens arrive with polite spears. ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *They carry a writ stamped with the queen’s seal. The seal is still wet.*
 6. **Keel-Rot Rumor** — Crews beach mid-voyage; trust in timber fails. ‘[DISASTER]’ *The rot smells sweet—too sweet. Someone poisoned the tar.*
 7. **Feud Token** — Raid becomes wedding... or funeral; oath-debt called due. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *A bronze ring arrives on an arrow. The meaning is clear.*
 8. **Oath Matured** — Verse sworn last winter comes due today. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The skald clears her throat. The room goes cold.*
 9. **Mistlands Miscount** — Channels “move,” cargo vanishes without witnesses. ‘[DEATH]’ *The fog lifts to reveal a different shore. Your charts are now lies.*
 10. **Aberderrin Race** — Contrary currents split flotilla; half late, half lost. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The water churns like a dying man. Something beneath is feeding.*
- J **Southron Fire-Pots** — Night-run turns to daylight; surprise ashore. ‘[COMBAT]’ *Pots shatter on the deck. The fire burns blue—alchemical.*
- Q **Thing Injunction** — No sailing till grievance heard (hours? days?). ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The Thing-Speaker smiles. He has all the time in the world.*
- K **General Muster** — Horns on every headland; all bays become spears. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The war fleet assembles. Your ship is the smallest.*
- A **Ground-Sea** — Long, blind swell rolls under; steering lies. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *The swell has a rhythm—two short, one long. A signal from below.*

(**Right/Token/Escort**) Harbor-green mark—dock without levy in named strand; oar-share claims two benches on fast longship.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Harbor-Mark** — Dock without levy in named strand (once). ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The mark is a notch cut in a bone. Match it to the harbor post.*
3. **Oar-Share** — Claim two benches on a fast longship for a season. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The oars are carved with your name. Row well, or they’ll be recarved.*
4. **Pilot’s Token** — Mist-runner guides through reed-maze safely. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The token is a dried eel skin. Keep it dry.*
5. **Wharf-Right** — Dolmis waystation loading priority; first ashore. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The harbormaster frowns but steps aside. Your name is now on a list.*
6. **Salvage Claim** — Flotsam on reef stretch becomes “inventory.” ‘[TRADE]’ *You must name each piece before touching it. The wrong word forfeits the claim.*
7. **Thing Ruling** — Verdict in your favor that travels with you. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The verdict is carved on a whale-rib. Carry it as a shield.*
8. **Raid-Truce** — Immunity in named bay for one market day. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *A white banner on your mast. No one will attack—openly.*
9. **Foster-Bond** — Guest-kin by jarl’s house; hospitality guaranteed. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *You share a cup with the jarl. The cup is silver. The promise is iron.*
10. **Herring Allotment** — Priority barrels when the run hits; silver in season. ‘[TRADE]’ *The barrels are sealed with your mark. Break one to test quality.*
- J **Escort Writ** — Eight shields and wolf-banner from cape to cape. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The shields are painted with a wolf’s head. They die before you do.*
- Q **Queen’s Audience** — Whisper exits as policy; sea-law bends. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The Queen’s hand writes your words on vellum. The ink is her blood.*
- K **High Jarl’s Pennon** — Levies open booms and mouths when it flies. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The pennon is torn from a captured ship. Fly it proudly—or else.*
- A **Storm-Oath Clause** — Temporary exception to any sea-law, sealed. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *The clause is whispered, never written. The sea hears and obeys—once.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (rights/tokens/escorts) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **sea-omens**—horns on wind, white horses on swell, verse unfinished until landfall.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Storm-Oaths:** A Linn may swear an oath by touching salt water. Breaking a storm-oath inflicts 1 Fatigue (the sea’s disappointment) and gives the GM a free SB to represent the sea’s attention. Keeping an oath until its completion grants +1 die on the next roll involving the sea or sailing.
- **Saga Reputation (Community Track):** Every Linn settlement has a Saga Track [6] that reflects the community’s oral memory. The party can increase it by performing deeds worthy

of verse (rescuing a ship, slaying a sea monster, keeping a difficult oath). At 3 segments, locals offer hospitality without question. At 6, the party gains a permanent epithet and may call on one favour from any Linn jarl.

- **Mist-Dread:** Linn characters suffer –1 die on navigation rolls when entering the Mistlands or Valewood, but gain +1 die on rolls to avoid supernatural fear (they have learned to dread the right things).
- **Skald’s Burden:** A PC who publicly composes a verse about an event may choose to increase or decrease the Saga Track by 1 (as they shape memory). On a failed Performance roll (DV 3), the verse backfires and the track moves the opposite direction.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Salted Anchor** — The Sealed Gate. *The harbour that never closes, the oath that never rusts.*
 - **The Wave Mother** — Raéyn. *The tide that carries and the storm that answers.*
 - **The Drowned Chorus** — Khemesh. *The pressure beneath the keel, the debt the sea collects.*
 - **The Unwritten Verse** — The Witness. *The memory that survives the drowning.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Draugr Jarl (Unfinished Business):** The Thing-Holm is haunted by a jarl who died before his oath was fulfilled. He rises when a storm-oath is broken, demanding a blood-price paid in stories. The Temple of Light has sent three missionaries to lay him to rest; all three drowned in calm water.
- **Saint Adar of the Dawnfire (Oath of Flame & Light):** The Temple of Light’s soft crusade has reached the Linn coast. Missionaries build school-houses and healers’ huts, teaching that oaths sworn by the White Flame are as binding as any storm-oath. The old Sea-Queen tolerates them because they bring iron trade, but the Volva of Mist has warned that the Hollow does not distinguish between faiths.
- **Saint Hervor of the Salted Cord (The Witness):** A Linn skald who swore never to sing a false verse. After she discovered her jarl had faked a raid’s spoils, she composed a *nothing* verse that cursed his line to seven generations. The Sea-Queen keeps Hervor’s runestone at the Thing-Holm; those who lie there hear their own words echo back as mockery.
- **The Tide-Washed Covenant (The Hospice of the Salted Anchor):** A grey-robed healer runs a hospice on the edge of the Mistlands, treating wounded raiders and fog-mad sailors alike. She asks no payment, but she writes every name in a ledger that never dries. Linn captains leave offerings of fresh water before a voyage; those who refuse find their ship plagued by the drowned.
- **The Ninth:** In any longhouse, the ninth horn blown at a feast summons the Hollow. The wise stop at eight. Those who blow the ninth are said to see a pale figure standing at the high table—waiting to collect a debt.

Linn Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Wake:** Toss a crust over the gunwale before a voyage. Ignore the first *Black Squall* penalty. [SUPERSTITION]
- **Knot the Oar:** Tie a single knot in your oar’s leather grip. Cancel *Keel-Rot Rumor* or take

–1 die on your next rowing check (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

- **Name to the Deep:** Whisper a dead enemy’s name into the tide. Gain +1 Effect against his kin for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Sea-Queen. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **coastal guards or rival crews**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **ships or harbor watch**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or mist-pilots**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local jarl or harbor master** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **weather shift or reef hazard**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival crew or levy force** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **ships, warriors, or skalds** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **storm hits/oath invoked/feud declared**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Sea-Queen, High Jarl, or Volva** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **storm rises/reef shifts/mist closes in**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Linn (Storm-Oaths):** Sudden calm, breaking waves speak names, verses come unbidden to lips.
- **Linn (Mistlands):** Channels shift without sound, voices call from reed-beds, compass spins.

- **Linn (Thing-Law):** Witnesses appear, oaths are demanded, skald begins composing your saga.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Sail + Wits):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Wake Surge*.
- **Cut the Lane (Pilot + Tactics):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a beacon is under your color, +1 die.
- **Weather the Squall (Resolve + Sail):** On a hit in *Black Squall*, you pick who drifts; on a miss, the Keeper does.

Boss Seeds (Sea & Signal)

- **The Net-Father (Nine Nets)** — *Phases:* Harbor Favours → Orchestrated Wrecks → Thing Coup. *Cracks:* cut a cord lineage; reveal swapped verdict; survive a staged squall.
- **The Blue Cantor (Brine-Gospel)** — *Phases:* Drownings Called Mercy → Procession at Reef → Tide-Baptism of a Jarl. *Cracks:* relic earplugs, survivor testimony, storm turning against them.

Patronage & Power

Among the Linn, power flows through oaths, kinship, and the spoken word. Jarls maintain authority through successful raids and wise judgments, while skalds wield influence through their ability to immortalize deeds in verse—or damn names through satire. The Sea-Queen holds sway over the coastlands, but her rule depends on the respect of the High Jarl and the Thing-speakers who interpret ancient laws.

For the GM: Power in Linn society is fluid and performance-based. Patronage often takes the form of foster-bonds, oar-shares, or raid-truces—each binding the recipient to service and reputation. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, banners, verses) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival jarls issue conflicting claims, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the Thing-holm and harbor gatherings as arenas for social contests, where oaths are sworn and broken.

In Linn society, your word is your bond, and your reputation is your greatest treasure.

Part IV

The Eastern Dolmis & The Valewood

Chapter 15

Theona

Three Greens, No Ninth. The isles of Theona rise green and jagged from the Dolmis, their basalt cliffs wrapped in mists and moorland song. The greatest law is the silence of Nine: no bell tolls a ninth, no bridge counts that span, no oath dares its syllable. Those who break the ban invite the Green Host, and debts of nine can never be paid in coin.

15.1 Theona — “Three Greens, No Ninth”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The Green Host rides for those who count to nine. Viterra counts to nine.*

Matron of Wells (Elite): “The wells here hold more than water – they hold the dreams and prayers of generations. To govern is to tend these sacred spaces where the living commune with what came before. The Viterran sheriffs call it superstition. The Green Host calls it trespass.”

Peat-Cutter (Commoner): “The land here remembers everything, especially what you don’t say. Skip the ninth step, forget the ninth name, and the green earth takes note. Best keep your omissions honest. The Viterran scribes write everything down. That’s why they’ll never understand.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The isles of Theona rise green and jagged from the Dolmis, their basalt cliffs wrapped in mists and moorland song. Nominally a duchy sworn to Viterra, in truth the Three Greens heed no crown but their own moots, no law but their taboos. The greatest of these is the silence of Nine: no bell tolls a ninth, no bridge counts that span, no oath dares its syllable. It is said that those who break the ban invite the Green Host – the *Aos Sí*, the fair folk who were here before the first Viterran longship. The Viterran Viterrans call it superstition. The Theona call it survival.

The Viterran crown claims the isles by right of conquest and papal bull. Its sheriffs impose common law, its bishops build stone churches, its undertakers plant English towns on confiscated lands. But the old ways persist: Brehon judges still speak judgment at the Moot Hill, and the Green Host still rides on the ninth night. To break a taboo is to invite not only the fae but the Viterran inquisitor. Both collect debts. Only one accepts coin.

What you notice first: The smell of wet peat and salt. The silence that follows every eighth bell-ring. The hawthorn trees at every crossroads – the *fairy trees* that no local will touch, and that Viterran surveyors learn to avoid after the first one disappears.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never pour the ninth cup at a feast. Never speak the ninth name in a bargain. Never step where a step is missing. The Green Host rides for those who complete what should remain incomplete. The Viterran sheriff will hang you for the same offence – but the Host takes your name, not your neck.

Regional Mood: Three Greens, No Ninth

Here, peace is a ritual, and every word sharpens the blade that seals it. Theona is claimed by Viterra but ruled by moots, well-keepers, and the old faith. The Viterran sheriffs demand taxes in silver; the Brehon judges settle disputes in cattle. The Viterran bishops burn offerings to the White Flame; the well-keepers leave butter at hawthorn groves. Every hedge is a boundary, every bridge a negotiation, every ninth step a door the Green Host might open.

Linn longships cut through the fog for raiding; Ashaani slavers hunt the coves in stolen coracles; pirates from Zakov and the Vilikari shore trade stolen goods for kelp and salt. Sidhi sailors and Aelinnel factors run cargo up the tide-stairs, and Aelaerem hedge-wives barter red thread for hawthorn passes. Through it all, the Ninth Taboo threads every handshake, every toast, every whispered prayer. To break it is to invite the Green Host—and the Host does not bargain. To break Viterran law is to invite the sheriff's noose. The Theona have learned to break neither – and to bend both.

Starting Location: A Moot Hill under rain, where vows are carved into stone and knives gleam beside the altar. A Bride-Peacemaker draws a blade between two bloodlines. “The ninth vow was never spoken,” she says. “But the Green Host remembers. Bring us the head of the slaver who burned the eastern strand, and the feud will end. Fail, and your name will join the uncounted. Or the sheriff will take you for vagrancy – the crown has declared our moots unlawful assemblies.”

Prominent NPCs of Theona

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk

Matron Eithne	Keeper of the Sacred Wells	Preserve the old ways against Viterran encroachment	She drinks only from the ninth well—the one no one admits exists. Her well was declared a "nuisance" by the crown. It still flows.
King Conall	Three-Isles King (elected by the moots)	Balance the demands of Viterra with the taboos of the Green Host	He lost his left hand to a Linn raid; the replacement is carved from hawthorn. He signs Viterran writs with the false hand.
Brid	Bride-Peacemaker	End feuds before the Green Host rides	Her knife has a wooden blade; families cut their palms with wood—blood without iron. She has never lost a client to Viterran justice.
Sister Cera	Missionary of the Temple of Light	Convert the islanders to the White Flame	She preaches in the old tongue and leaves offerings at hawthorn groves; the locals are not sure whether she is a saint or a heretic. The Viterran bishop calls her a traitor.

Brother Iarlath	Everflame inquisitor (Ecktoria)	Purge the 'pagan' taboos and impose imperial orthodoxy	He carries a censer that never cools, but it smokes green in the fog. He has condemned nine "fairy trees" to burn- ing. Eight burned. The ninth vanished overnight.
Sheriff Markham	Viterran crown officer	Extend the king's peace (and tax) to the Three Greens	He carries a copy of the Statutes of Kilkenny. He has never read them. He uses them to beat witnesses.
The Lady Beneath	Dream-queen of the hol- low hills	Keep the old bargains and col- lect the ninth name	She has no face; those who see her forget their own names for a year. The Viterran surveyors who saw her now call themselves "John" and refuse to speak of it.

Names of Theona

Inspired by the green isles of the western sea: soft consonants, melodic vowels, and surnames that evoke a hill, a well, or a sacred grove.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Conall	Eithne	O'Malley	<i>the Ninth</i>
Cormac	Bríd	Mac Gowan	<i>Well-Sworn</i>
Iarlath	Cera	Ó hAodha	<i>Hawthorn</i>
Turlough	Ríona	Ó Braonáin	<i>the Uncounted</i>

Lorcán	Máire	Ó Dálaigh	<i>Fog-Born</i>
Finán	Gobnait	Ó Cuilinn	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

(**Ringfort/Well/Cliff**) Basalt tide-stairs cut into cove; everyone steps past a “missing” rung; Saint’s Well under hawthorn hung with ribbons.

Spades — Places

2. **Tide-Stairs** — Basalt steps into cove; everyone skips the “missing” rung. *The missing step is still there—you just can’t see it. Step where it should be, or don’t step at all. The Viterran engineers measured the stairs. They counted nine. They are no longer here.*
3. **Saint’s Well** — Under hawthorn hung with ribbons and secrets; wishes tied in cloth. *The ribbons are knotted in eights. The ninth knot is never tied—only imagined. The crown calls it idolatry. The locals call it irrigation.*
4. **Fog-Wick Tower** — Burning peat; bell plays eight notes, never nine. *The bell-ringer wears a mask. Underneath, he has no mouth—only a whisper. The sheriff has tried to arrest him three times. Each time, the tower was empty.*
5. **Black Bog Causeway** — White stones like teeth; will-lights test your stride. *The stones were set by a king who drowned. He counts each footstep from below. The Viterran surveyors replaced the stones with wooden posts. The posts burned.*
6. **Cliff Ringfort** — Over kelp-nets; storm-ladders creak like hymns. *The ladders are hauled up at dusk. If you’re left below, you sleep with the tide. The crown calls it a “fortified dwelling without licence.” The fort has no licence. It has never needed one.*
7. **Barrow Field** — Standing stones; birds hush at noon, the earth remembers. *The stones have ears. Do not speak a secret you cannot afford to lose. The Viterran antiquary who tried to excavate one now tends the barrow as a shrine. He does not remember why.*
8. **Sea-Cave Harp** — Tide-ropes sing under headland; echoes bargain for safe passage. *The harp has no player. It plays itself when the drowned want to speak. The crown has posted a notice: “Unauthorized musical performances prohibited.” The notices wash away.*
9. **Uncounted Bridge** — Nine-arch causeway; locals tally “eight-and-one.” *The ninth arch is there—but the locals will deny it. Walk it at your own risk. The Viterran cartographer marked it on his map. His map now shows a bridge to nowhere.*
10. **Ogham Grove** — Carved pillars around an absent ninth post; runes speak in silence. *The missing post was removed by a king who broke a vow. The runes still curse his line. The Viterran bishop ordered the grove destroyed. The axes broke.*
- J **Coracle Harbor** — Jammed in a notch; upturned boats roof the sheds. *The coracles are made of hide and guilt. Each one has carried a secret. The harbormaster pays no tax. The crown cannot find him.*
- Q **Green Moot Hill** — Three Greens’ court; benches of turf, salt wind judges. *The wind never stops. It carries the votes of the dead. The Viterran sheriff declared the moot an “illegal assembly.” The wind knocked his hat off. He has not returned.*
- K **High Hall** — Whale-rib beams; storm banners sleep, kings are chosen. *The kings are chosen by lot—a knotted cord pulled from a pot. The cord has eight knots. The crown’s appointed governor was given the ninth knot. The knot came undone.*

- A **Lookout Cliff** — One vantage where all three isles stand in a single gaze. *From here, you can see the Green Host riding on the horizon—if it wants you to. You can also see the Viterran garrison on the far isle. They do not wave.*

(**Moot/Keeper/Court**) Peat-cutter with steady barrow and steadier gossip; well-keeper who ties ribbons and unknots feuds.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Peat-Cutter** — Steady barrow, steadier gossip; knows every hidden path. *Her barrow has a false bottom. She hides debts there—and bodies. She also hides the Viterran tax collector when he comes. He is always grateful.*
 3. **Well-Keeper** — Ties ribbons, unknots feuds; wishes and wisdom in equal measure. *She never ties a ninth ribbon. The ninth wish is always her own. She has wished for the sheriff's departure every day for seven years. He is still here. She is patient.*
 4. **Kelp-Netter** — Reads rip lines like ledgers; tide as teacher. *His net has a torn patch. He sewed it with thread from a hanged man's shirt. The hanged man was a horse thief. The net has never torn again.*
 5. **Harp-Satirist** — A few bars can end a career or a war; music as a weapon. *Her harp is strung with catgut and grudges. Each string is a name. She has a string for the sheriff. She has not played it yet. She is waiting.*
 6. **Wick-Warden** — Tends fog-lamps, counts in eights; guardian of the silent count. *He counts on his fingers—thumb, finger, finger, finger—and stops. The ninth is for the fog. He taught the Viterran lighthouse keeper to count. The keeper lost his job.*
 7. **Taboo-Witness** — Geas-keeper who knows which words ruin deals. *She carries a bell with no clapper. She rings it with her tongue. The Viterran magistrate demanded she testify. She rang the bell. He withdrew the charge.*
 8. **Island Abbot** — Saint's bell, tolerant smile; faith in the old ways. *His bell rings eight times. The ninth ring is the silence that follows. The Viterran bishop sent a letter of censure. The abbot used it to light his fire.*
 9. **Green Neighbor** — Polite emissary from under the hill; borrowed boots, strange customs. *He never steps on a crack. He says the earth has teeth. The Viterran tax assessor stepped on a crack. He now has a limp.*
 10. **Coracle-Captain** — Eight-boat flotilla; swift as rumor, sure as the tide. *Her boats have no names. She says naming a vessel invites the Green Host to count it. The Viterran harbormaster tried to register one. He could not find it. It was right in front of him.*
- J **Bride-Peacemaker** — Walks between bloodlines with a silver knife; peace in marriage. *Her knife has a wooden blade. The families cut their palms with wood—blood without iron. The Viterran magistrate declared the ritual "superstitious." The knife is now his letter opener.*
- Q **Matron of Wells** — Queen-mother in truth if not in name; wisdom in water. *She drinks only from the ninth well—the one no one admits exists. The Viterran governor demanded to see it. She showed him a dry hole. He believed her.*
- K **Three-Isles King** — Elected by the moots; whale-bone throne, weathered eyes. *He lost his left hand to a Linn raid. The replacement is carved from hawthorn. He signs Viterran writs with the false hand. The signatures are legally binding. He is not.*

- A **Lady Beneath** — Unseen queen who bargains in dreams; hawthorn’s whisper. *She has no face. Those who see her forget their own names for a year. The Viterran surveyor who saw her now calls himself "John." He does not remember his wife’s face.*

(Fog/Feud/Taboo) Ground-mist erases tracks; horns travel, edges do not; bog-lights lure teamster off the causeway.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Ground-Mist** — Erases tracks; horns travel, edges do not; navigation by sound alone. *The mist has a voice. It whispers your name—but only once. The Viterran patrol that entered the mist returned speaking only in questions.*
 3. **Bog-Lights** — Lure teamster off the causeway; recovery costs time and pride. *The lights are the souls of debtors. Follow them, and you’ll never pay your way out. The Viterran tax collector followed them. He now lives in the bog. He pays no tax.*
 4. **Spoken Geas** — No ninth word in parley—or the deal curdles like milk. *The word you cannot speak sits on your tongue like a stone. The Viterran merchant who said "nine" in a contract now sells only in eights. His customers have not noticed.*
 5. **Salt-Rot** — Smokehouse fails; fish spoil, tempers rise like the tide. *The salt was cut with grave dust. Someone wanted the winter to be hard. The Viterran garrison’s supplies rotted. They bought from the locals. The price was a promise.*
 6. **Procession Clash** — Saint-day vs. hawthorn taboo; shutters slam, peace fractures. *The saint’s banner and the green branch cannot touch. When they do, blood follows. The Viterran bishop ordered the hawthorn removed. The tree grew back overnight.*
 7. **Wave-Count** — Eighth swell, Nameless follows; boats tremble, sailors pray. *The ninth swell never comes. But something rides the eighth. The Viterran customs cutter that chased a smuggling boat did not see the eighth swell. It is at the bottom.*
 8. **Ringfort Wakes** — A bone-judge is “consulted”; now you’re named in the old law. *The bone-judge’s skull is filled with peat smoke. It speaks in riddles—and judgments. The Viterran magistrate who ignored a bone-judge’s ruling now has no memory of the case.*
 9. **Ninth Law** — Something vital cannot be counted, measured, or named. *You try to count your crew. The number keeps changing. The Viterran census taker who tried to count the islanders now lives in a cave. He counts seagulls.*
 10. **Net-Surge** — Harbor stairs; kelp wraps ankles and alibis like truth. *The kelp moves against the current. Someone underneath is pulling. The Viterran harbormaster who tried to dredge the kelp is now missing. The kelp is thicker.*
- J **Bride-Theft** — At Moot—peace flips to feud; you’re caught mid-ritual. *The stolen bride’s hand is cold. She has been dead for a year. The Viterran sheriff who tried to stop the theft now wears a wedding ring. He does not remember the wedding.*
- Q **Mainland Return** — Exile with papers; elders arrested “for progress.” *The papers are stamped with a Viterran seal. The seal is still warm—and wrong. The elder who was arrested now works in the governor’s garden. He does not speak. The plants are very healthy.*
- K **Green Host Rides** — Hooves like drums, cattle scatter, sentries sleep. *The riders have no faces—only masks of woven hawthorn. The Viterran garrison that saw the Host now stands watch at noon. They will not explain why.*

- A **Great Fog** — Routes loop, bells lie, every promise takes the long way. *The fog is old. It remembers promises made to the dead. The Viterran governor who swore to "pacify" the isles is still lost in it. His dispatches arrive late. They make no sense.*

(**Blessing/Token/Right**) Well-blessing for a named ford crossing; moot token with eight-knotted cord skips local queues.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Well-Blessing** — Named ford crosses you safely, once; water remembers your need. *The blessing is a ribbon. Tie it to your wrist. Do not tie a ninth knot. The Viterran sheriff's horse refused to cross the blessed ford. He had to swim.*
 3. **Moot Token** — Eight-knotted cord; skip any local queue or judgment. *The cord is braided from horsehair and silence. Cut a knot to speak. The Viterran magistrate who tried to arrest a token-holder found his courtroom empty. The case was dismissed.*
 4. **Harbor-Green** — Painted mark exempts your boat from the next levy; tide as ally. *The mark is a circle with an eighth cut. The missing slice is the toll. The Viterran customs officer who tried to collect from a marked boat now collects shells on the beach.*
 5. **Hawthorn Pass** — Immunity from a single local taboo (for one scene). *The pass is a hawthorn twig. Carry it in your mouth. Do not chew. The Viterran inquisitor who tried to burn a pass-bearer found his pyre would not light.*
 6. **Bell-Right** — Lawful ring at a fog-wick summons the watchers; law travels on sound. *The bell has no clapper. You must ring it with your own breath. The Viterran constable who heard the bell now refuses to speak of it. His ears are scarred.*
 7. **Coracle Share** — Crew and oars pledged for one crossing; tide as a steed. *The share is a tally stick. Break it in half to claim your passage. The Viterran governor who tried to seize a coracle share found his hands would not close.*
 8. **Ogham Ruling** — Monk's reading settles a dispute in your favor; runes as law. *The ruling is carved on a slate. The slate is damp. The runes may change by morning. The Viterran judge who ruled against an Ogham ruling now dreams in runes. He cannot read them.*
 9. **Unnumbered Right** — Ignore the Ninth prohibition for one action (costs a favor later). *The right is a silence. Use it, and the Green Host will ask for its name. The Viterran spy who used it now has no shadow. The Host has his name.*
 10. **Salt-Cure License** — Process scarce fish despite ration edicts; preservation as power. *The license is signed with a thumbprint. The thumb is not yours. The Viterran ration officer who refused a licensed boat now has no appetite. He eats only ash.*
- J **Bride-Charter** — Two feuding houses sheath knives for a season; peace in marriage. *The charter is written on a wedding veil. The bloodstains are from the dowry. The Viterran crown's peace commissioners have tried to copy the charter. Their copies burn.*
- Q **Private Moot** — With Matron and King; whispers become policy. *The moot is held in a fog hollow. What is spoken there is never written. The Viterran governor's spy who tried to listen now speaks only in fog. He is very popular with the locals.*
- K **Whale-Escort** — Eight-oar guards across the Dolmis reach; strength in numbers. *The crew carries your name on a scrap of vellum. If the paper gets wet, you are alone. The Viterran warship that tried to intercept a whale-escorted vessel now has no name.*

A **Green Favor** — One uncanny exception to custom, spoken beneath hawthorn. *The favor is a dream. When you wake, the hawthorn will remember—even if you don’t. The Viterran governor who asked for a Green Favor now believes he is a king. The actual king is amused.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (blessings/tokens/rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- The “No Ninth” custom: whenever a 9 appears in your seed, add an omission to the scene (a missing step, an unsaid name, an unseen guest). If the 9 is a Diamond, you may break the taboo once—but someone will come to collect later.
- If any A appears, echo **green and count** motifs—hawthorn that whispers, bells that miscount, promises that take the long way home.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **The Silent Count:** Players and GMs are encouraged to omit a detail (a name, a step, a tally) when the Ninth appears, echoing Theona’s taboo. This is how the islanders evade Viterran law: they simply do not say what the law requires. The law cannot count what is not spoken.
- **Green Host’s Omen:** Any dream sequence or omen may be framed as the ride of the Green Host—hoofbeats across the sky, wind through the moors, sea spray tasting of salt and blood. The Viterran garrison has learned to ignore the omens. The garrison is understrength.
- **Bride-Peace Feasts:** Weddings, truces, and funerals blur; sharing a feast can end a feud for a season—or doom a guest if the ninth cup is poured. The Viterran crown has outlawed these feasts. The feasts continue. The crown’s officers attend. They never pour the ninth cup.
- **The Viterran Plantation Clock [8]:** Tracks the Viterran crown’s efforts to colonise the isles. Advances when the party assists the crown (provides evidence, enforces a writ, pays a tax) or when a Viterran sheriff successfully imposes common law. Retreats when the party supports a moot, hides a fugitive, or exposes a crown official’s corruption. When full, a new plantation is declared: a Viterran town is built, lands are confiscated, and a new sheriff is appointed. The Green Host’s attention ticks up.
- **Brehon Law vs. Common Law:** In any legal dispute, the party may choose to invoke Brehon law (custom, precedent, witness) or Viterran common law (statute, seal, written evidence). Brehon law grants +1 die if the party can produce a respected elder or a witnessed oral history; Viterran law grants +1 die if the party has a writ or a seal. Choosing one over the other shifts the Viterran Plantation clock by 1 segment toward or away from the crown.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Saint Bríd of the Unquenched Well (Syncretic):** A local saint venerated by both the Temple of Light and the old well-keepers. Her shrine is a well hung with red ribbons; pilgrims who tie an eighth knot and leave a silver coin may ask one question of the Green Host—but the answer comes in a dream, and the dream always costs a memory. The Viterran bishop has declared her a heretic three times. Each time, the declaration was found burned. The well still flows.

- **Saint Colmán of the Eighth Bell (Oath of Mercy and Grace):** A missionary who tried to convert the isles by ringing a ninth bell. The Green Host took his tongue, and he spent the rest of his life speaking in eights. His hospice still stands near the Fog-Wick Tower; it heals the fog-sick, but every patient leaves unable to count past eight. The Viterran crown has tried to close the hospice. The hospice's patients now include the governor's son.
- **The Dullahan (The Headless Horseman):** A fae omen that rides when a Viterran sheriff is about to die. It carries its own head under its arm, and it calls the sheriff's name. Those who hear it are dead before dawn. The current sheriff has heard it three times. He is still alive. He is very afraid.
- **The Banshee (Bean Sidhe):** A spirit who keens when a pure-blooded Theona chieftain dies. The Viterran crown has tried to suppress her songs as "noise pollution." The keening continues. The chieftains die. The crown's record-keepers have given up counting.
- **The Morrigan (The Phantom Queen):** A war goddess who appears as a crow before battle. She does not choose sides. She chooses the dead. The Viterran soldiers who see a crow before a skirmish often desert. The local fighters see a crow and sharpen their blades. The Morrigan is amused.
- **The Ninth:** In any Theona scene, the ninth person to speak in a room draws the Green Host's attention. The wise hold their tongues until someone else breaks the count. Those who speak ninth are said to see a pale rider on the horizon the next night—and the rider is always one name closer. The Viterran governor who spoke ninth now has a portrait of himself that ages instead of him. He has not looked at it in a year.

Theona Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Bog:** Toss a crust into the mist before crossing a causeway. Ignore the first *Ground-Mist* penalty.
- **Knot the Eighth:** Tie a single knot in a ribbon before a moot. Cancel *Spoken Geas* or take -1 die on your next oath (your choice).
- **Name to the Well:** Whisper a dead enemy's name into Saint's Well. Gain +1 Effect against his kin for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Matron.

Patronage & Power

In Theona, power flows through ancient custom, sacred spaces, and the careful observance of taboo. The Three Greens maintain their independence through a web of moots, well-keepers, and geas-keepers who ensure the old laws are honored. The King and Matron rule by consensus and tradition, while the unseen Lady Beneath influences events through dreams and whispers. Against them stands the Viterran crown — a Viterran power of sheriffs, bishops, and undertakers who seek to replace Brehon law with common law, hawthorn with church stone, and the Green Host with the White Flame.

For the GM: Patronage in Theona revolves around blessings, exemptions, and the delicate balance of keeping or breaking taboos. Rewards often take the form of tokens, rights, or divine favor that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize the Viterran-Irish conflict:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (ribbons, tokens, blessings) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided by crown officials.
- Let the Viterran crown and the Green Host issue conflicting exemptions — players must choose whose favor matters more, and whose curse is worse.
- Use the moots, wells, and causeways as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of Brehon law (and its deliberate omissions) determines success against Viterran common law.
- The Viterran Plantation Clock is a visible campaign front. Players can accelerate or delay it, but once it fills, the isles change forever — new towns, new sheriffs, new taboos.

In Theona, your word is your weave, and your weave determines whether you walk the green path or invite the Host — or the sheriff’s noose.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **moot-keepers, well-guardians, or Viterran sheriffs**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **coracle crews, ringfort sentries, or crown patrols**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers, green neighbors, or crown informers**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Wick-warden, moot official, or Viterran bailiff** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **mist shift, taboo breach, or a sheriff’s roadblock**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **feuding house member, bone-judge, or crown soldier** arrives on

scene.

- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **coracle crews, green neighbors, moot enforcers, or crown militia** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **taboo broken/green host rides/feud declared/crown warrant issued**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **King, Matron, Lady Beneath, or Viterran Governor** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **fog rises/bells ring/causeway shifts/crown forces arrive**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Theona (Silent Count):** Steps disappear mid-climb, names vanish from lips, the ninth item in a list goes unmentioned.
- **Theona (Green Host):** Hoofbeats echo without a horse, mist takes familiar shapes, dreams predict the next action.
- **Theona (Viterran Law):** A writ is declared void, a sheriff's seal cracks, a witness remembers the ninth name.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Stealth):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Fog Bank*.
- **Cut the Writ (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a moot token is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Host (Resolve + Spirit):** On a hit in *Green Host Rides*, you pick who is named; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Unsung Bell (forbidden note given will)** — *Phases:* Hum in Mist → Echo Under Well-stone → Command of Fog. *Cracks:* bind its clapper with eight ribbons; let a rival speak the ninth and pay; drown the echo at the Sea-Cave Harp.

- **Bride-Thief of the Green Host (dream raider)** — *Phases*: Invitation in Sleep → Procession Across Moor → Feast Without Ninth Cup. *Cracks*: cut the dream-veil with silver; sing satire at the Green Moot Hill; trade a Bride-Charter.
- **The Sheriff’s Reckoning (Viterran enforcer)** — *Phases*: Plantation Decree → Common Law Assize → The Ninth Hanging. *Cracks*: produce a witnessed Brehon judgment older than the crown’s claim; pay a wergild in cattle, not coin; let the Green Host take his name.
- **The Missing Step (living omission)** — *Phases*: Vanished Witness → Unread Clause → Unwalkable Bridge. *Cracks*: invite a Taboo-Witness to count aloud; spill nine drops into Saint’s Well but *name only eight*; let the Lady Beneath keep a memory.

Chapter 16

Zakov

Salt & Serpent. Zakov is the pirate-city of the Dolmis coast, where tides trade secrets and knives settle debts. Its streets are piers, its courts are taverns, and its rulers are whoever the Syndicates fear most this season. The Salt Prince claims the throne, but the real power ebbs and flows with the tide—and the tide remembers everything.

16.1 Zakov — “Salt & Serpent”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The tide keeps a better ledger than any scribe. The reef remembers every secret.*

Salt Prince (Elite): “The tide here keeps better ledgers than any scribe, and the reefs remember every secret whispered above their depths. Power flows like the currents – those who understand them rule the waves.”

Dock-Rat (Commoner): “The sewers and the sea both carry what folks want to forget, but they also remember everything. Best keep your business above water and your enemies guessing which dock you’ll use next. The Salt Prince’s crown floats, and the tide pulls for anyone with a sharp knife and a sharper tongue.”

Genre / Mood: Lovecraftian dread meets pirate swagger; eldritch tide-horror, maritime noir, debt as a living force.

Starting Location: A smuggler’s gate built into the seawall, its iron mouth crusted with barnacles and secrets. The gatekeeper is a one-eyed woman who accepts payment in stories. Behind her, the Dregs Quarter stretches on stilts into the harbor, and the Salt Prince’s flagship, the *Red Wake*, rides at anchor off the Iron Pier. “The levy rises tonight,” she says, spitting into the water. “Every ship pays, or every ship burns. You look like the burning type. Good. The Prince needs a reminder that the tide turns for everyone.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Zakov is the pirate-city of the Dolmis coast, where tides trade secrets and knives settle debts. Its streets are piers, its courts are taverns, and its rulers are whoever the Syndicates fear most this season. The Salt Prince claims the throne, but the real power ebbs and flows with the tide—and the tide remembers everything. Here, every manifest is a lie, every harbor a doorstep to a dozen conspiracies, and every fog-light a lure or a warning. The city breathes with the sea: at low tide, secrets exposed; at flood, the drowned walk the Sunken Quarter and knock on doors that should be locked. Zakov is not a place you visit. It is a place you survive—or rule.

What you notice first: The smell of brine and tar. The constant slap of water against stone. The way every tavern has a door that leads to a different dock—and every dock has a name that changes with the tide.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never take a coin that tastes of brine. The Serpent's Mark is not a blessing. It is a debt that drowns.

Regional Mood: Salt and Serpent

Here, the sea is not a border—it is a landlord. Zakov rose from the wreckage of a sunken empire, and every stone is a salvage claim. The Salt Prince rules from a throne of driftwood and extortion, but the real lords are the Syndicate factors who own the docks, the eel-cults that whisper from the sewers, and the fae courts that launder their influence through tide-bargains. Ships arrive with goods no customs post will name, and depart with cargoes no manifest will show. The city's law is the Tide Clock: low water for killing, flood water for trading, slack for negotiation. Break the rhythm, and the city will break you.

Beneath it all, the Reaping. Centuries ago, the Salt Prince—then a common adventurer—dove into a submerged vault off the coast. What he found there no one knows for certain. Some say it was a Lethai weapon, a crystalline shard of the first sin. Others whisper it is the father of Khemesh, or the true name of the Hollow written in salt. The oldest tales call it simply *the Reaping*: a hunger that does not kill, but *harvests*. The Reaping seeps into Zakov like groundwater, corrupting slowly, tainting every soul who stays too long. Dreams curdle into obsession. Generosity rots into debt. The city's famous “everyone owes everyone” is not a culture; it is a symptom.

Prominent NPCs of Zakov

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Salt Prince Lev	Nominal ruler of Zakov; keeper of the Reaping	Keep the syndicates from tearing the city apart	His crown is a circlet of driftwood; he has never taken it off. Beneath it, his hair is white as bone.

Pirate Queen Mila	Rules the Shallows with charm and cutlass	Carve out a kingdom free of the Salt Prince’s levies	Her cutlass was her grandmother’s; the grandmother was also a queen. She refuses to walk the Sunken Quarter.
Kraken’s Tongue	Tide-oracle who speaks in riddles	Survive another season without being sacrificed to the deep	She lives in a bell tower that only exists at high tide; the bell does not ring. She has seen the Reaping. She will not describe it.
Dock-Master Olena	Syndicate factor who “loses” ships	Own the waterfront, one debtor at a time	Her ledger has a secret page that is a map of debtors’ bones. The bones move.
The Reckoner	Broker of cosmic debts (Maelstræus)	Collect interest on every contract signed in Zakov	His coin appears in the pocket of the opposing counsel the next day. The coin is warm. It tastes of brine.
The Salt-Bitten Angel	Cursed messenger (Malachai)	Offer cruel bargains that always leave a scar	A silver coin that tastes of brine circulates among the smugglers; take it, and your cargo always passes inspection. The Angel’s smile has too many teeth.

Names of Zakov

Inspired by the Black Sea and Odessa: Slavic, Turkic, and Greek inflections, with nicknames that stick like barnacles.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Lev	Mila	Voloshyn	<i>the Grey</i>
Dmytro	Olena	Bondarenko	<i>Tide-Foot</i>
Sarkis	Anush	Torosyan	<i>the Unpaid</i>
Kostya	Zoya	Morozov	<i>Bell-Sworn</i>
Ruslan	Nadia	Kravchenko	<i>Ash-Prow</i>
Taras	Halyna	Shevchenko	<i>the Silent</i>

(Harbor/Bolt-hole/Black Market) Salt-cracked wharf where tide brings back what law forgets; Bone-yard beach with wrecks and corpses in kelp; Smuggler’s Gate behind the Fish Market.

Spades — Places

2. **Salt Wharf** — Cracked and crumbling; the tide brings back what law forgets. ‘[TIDE]’ *The wharf has a memory. It remembers every cargo that passed—and every captain that didn’t.*
 3. **Bone-Yard Beach** — Wrecks and corpses tangled in kelp and rope. ‘[DEATH]’ *The bones are from three empires. They shift at high tide to form new constellations. The oldest bones are not bone—they are crystal. The Reaping’s first harvest.*
 4. **Smuggler’s Gate** — An alley behind the Fish Market; always unlocked, always watched. ‘[STEALTH]’ *The lock is a riddle. The answer changes with the moon. The gatekeeper’s eyes are the colour of the deep.*
 5. **The Shallows** — A reef-ridden cut only locals dare; navigation as survival. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The reef has a name: the Serpent’s Spine. It grows longer each year. At night, it sings.*
 6. **Dregs Quarter** — Shanties on stilts; boats tied to doorframes like pets. ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *The stilts are whale ribs. The quarter rises and falls with the tide—and the mood. Some doorframes have no doors. Those houses are empty. The residents are still inside.*
 7. **Iron Pier** — Gangplank to the *Red Wake*, the corsair flagship; power as a vessel. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The ship was a slaver once. It still smells of chains and salt. The Salt Prince’s cabin has a locked hatch. No one asks what is below.*
 8. **Crow’s Roost** — A tavern built into the hull of a beached galleon; the past as the present. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The hull was a prize from a war that ended forty years ago. The crew who took it still drink there. They have not aged. They do not speak of the Reaping.*
 9. **Black Bazaar** — Tents under tarps; goods that scream if you listen. ‘[TRADE]’ *The scream is not pain. It is a warning. The most expensive stall sells “clean” souls. No one knows what that means.*
 10. **Salt Maze** — Marsh paths only the lost know; confusion as protection. ‘[MYSTERY]’ *The maze was a graveyard. The dead rearranged the hedges. The centre is a stone basin filled with water that reflects a sky you have never seen.*
- J **Sunken Quarter** — Half the city is underwater at high tide; wealth as depth. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[STEALTH]’ *The flooded houses have air pockets. People still live there—damply. They*

whisper about a door at the lowest tide, a door that leads to the vault where the Salt Prince made his bargain.

- Q **Crimson Docks** — Contracts signed in blood; commerce as violence. ‘[DEBT]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The blood is not always the signatory’s. The docks do not care. The inkwells are filled from a common source. No one knows where the source is.*
- K **Anchorhead** — A floating fortress of the Pirate Syndicate; law as an anchor. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The fortress is built from the hulls of seized ships. You can hear the captains weeping in the timbers. The lowest deck is sealed. The seal is warm.*
- A **Serpent’s Spine** — A reef pass to the city’s secret heart; danger as a gateway. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[LEGEND]’ *The pass is a submerged arch. Swim through, and the city shows you its true face—once. The true face is a wound. The wound is the Reaping.*

(**Syndicate/Corsair/Fence**) Dock-rat pickpocket with a map tattoo and no fear; a fence dealing in stolen names and secondhand loyalties.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Dock-Rat** — Pickpocket with a map tattoo and no fear; the street as education. ‘[STEALTH]’ *His tattoo is of the Sunken Quarter at low tide. The buildings are upside down. The tattoo moves when he sleeps.*
3. **Fence** — Deals in stolen names and secondhand loyalties; trust as currency. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *Her ledger is written in disappearing ink. She is the only one who knows the antidote. The antidote is a drop of Reaping-crystal brine. She keeps it under her tongue.*
4. **Tavern-Keeper** — Remembers every face—and sells the list; hospitality as a trap. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *His memory is a curse from a fae court. He cannot forget—and he cannot stop talking. He is the only source of the Reaping’s true name. He does not know he knows it.*
5. **Corsair Lieutenant** — A letter of marque signed in blood; authority as paper. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The letter is stained with a thumbprint. The thumb is still attached to the signatory. He has not aged in ten years.*
6. **Dock-Master** — “Loses” ships that owe the Syndicate; bureaucracy as a weapon. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *His ledger has a secret page. The page is a map of debtor’s bones. The bones are still warm.*
7. **Smuggler Captain** — A false manifest and a quicker blade; honesty as a liability. ‘[STEALTH]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *She names her boats after dead lovers. The current boat is named “Mistake.” The previous boat, “Regret,” was taken by the Reaping. She does not speak of it.*
8. **Poison-Tongue** — Trades secrets like coin; words as blades. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *His tongue is forked—not by birth, but by a curse. He can speak two truths at once. The Reaping speaks through him in his sleep. He no longer sleeps.*
9. **Exiled Admiral** — Runs a black-market shipyard; rank as a resource. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *Her flag is a torn imperial pennant. She keeps it to remind herself why she left. The real reason is a crystalline shard she found in a ship’s hold. She keeps it in a lead box. The box is warm.*
10. **Pirate Queen** — Rules the Shallows with charm and cutlass; beauty as power. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *Her cutlass was her grandmother’s. The grandmother was also a queen. The grandmother was also the first person to see the Reaping and refuse it. The refusal cost her her shadow.*

- J **Silent Syndicate** — No names, just favors and faces; anonymity as strength. ‘[MYSTERY]’ *Their messenger is a child with no tongue. She writes in the air with smoke. The smoke smells of crystal and salt.*
- Q **Kraken’s Tongue** — An oracle who speaks in riddles and tides; the future as a mystery. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *She lives in a bell tower that only exists at high tide. The bell does not ring. The bell is a fragment of the Reaping’s prison. She tends it with her own blood.*
- K **Salt Prince** — The nominal ruler; real power in the shadows; a crown as a mask. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *His crown is a circlet of driftwood. He has never taken it off. Beneath it, his scalp is cracked like dry earth. Something moves in the cracks.*
- A **Drowned Admiral** — A legend says he still gives orders from the deep; death as command. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[LEGEND]’ *His orders arrive in bottles. The bottles are corked with finger bones. The ink is crystalline. It glows in the dark.*

(**Betrayal/Storm/Syndicate Feud**) The tide turns early—your ship is now ashore on the wrong side; a rival syndicate burns a warehouse with your goods inside.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Tide Shift** — Turns early; your ship is now ashore on the wrong side. ‘[TIDE]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The tide stole a day. Your alibi is now a lie. The water has a new taste. It tastes of crystal.*
 3. **Warehouse Fire** — A rival syndicate burns it; your goods are inside. ‘[DISASTER]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The fire is green. It burns paper and wood—and secrets. The smoke leaves a crystalline residue on the skin.*
 4. **Cursed Cargo** — Something in the hold is *watching*; cargo as a curse. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *The cargo is a mirror. The reflection is not yours. The reflection has too many teeth.*
 5. **Storm Warning** — Ships flee, prices soar, lawmen vanish. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *The storm has a name. It is the name of a captain who swore revenge. The rain tastes of brine and old regrets.*
 6. **Double-Cross** — You are holding a fake shipment and real enemies. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[TRAP]’ *The fake shipment is real. The real shipment is a trap. The trap is a shard of the Reaping. It whispers.*
 7. **Prince’s Levy** — Every ship pays tithe or gets sunk; tax as a threat. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The levy collector wears a mask. The mask is the face of a dead admiral. The admiral’s mouth moves. It asks for a name.*
 8. **Plague Ship** — Quarantine flags are ignored; sickness spreads. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *The plague is a cough that speaks the name of who infected you. The last name spoken is the Salt Prince’s. He does not cough.*
 9. **Blood Feud** — Erupts between pirate crews; collateral damage mounts. ‘[COMBAT]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The feud began over a stolen duck. The duck is still alive. The duck is made of crystal. No one admits to having seen it.*
 10. **Kraken Rising** — Reefs shift, ships vanish, sailors scream. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *The kraken is not a monster. It is a debt that has grown teeth. The teeth are crystalline. They are the Reaping’s first children.*
- J **Voided Contract** — Your protection now means nothing. ‘[DEBT]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The contract was written on shark skin. It dissolved in salt water. The shark still swims. It*

remembers your name.

- Q **Syndicate Split** — Zakov becomes a warzone overnight. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The split was orchestrated by a third party. You are the third party. You do not remember agreeing. The Reaping remembers for you.*
- K **Naval Blockade** — No ships in or out without a fight. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The blockade is a fae illusion. The ships are real. The captains are hollow. Something else steers.*
- A **Tide Forgets** — Half the city is cut off, drowning in secrets. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[MYSTERY]’ *The water is warm. The drowned are not dead—they are waiting. They are waiting for the Reaping to finish its work.*

(Pass/Contract/Stolen Goods) A smuggler’s token to pass a checkpoint unseen; a forged manifest that makes your cargo “clean”; a debt-marker the Syndicate cannot refuse.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

- 2. **Smuggler’s Token** — Pass one checkpoint unseen; stealth as paper. ‘[STEALTH]’ *The token is a dried eel skin. Show it, and the guards will not see you—or will pretend not to. The eel was not dead when skinned. It still twitches.*
- 3. **Forged Manifest** — Your cargo is now “clean”; truth as forgery. ‘[TRADE]’ ‘[DECEPTION]’ *The manifest is a leaf from a salt-cured book. The ink reads differently in moonlight. Under moonlight, it reads the true name of the Reaping.*
- 4. **Safe Berth** — Bone-yard; no questions, no law; sanctuary as a wreck. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The berth is a beached ship. Its captain still lives below decks—and does not age. He has been counting the same grain of sand for forty years. He will not tell you why.*
- 5. **Corsair’s Charter** — Raid with impunity for one moon; violence as a license. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The charter is a whip. Crack it, and the Syndicate will answer—or flog you. The whip’s handle is carved from a piece of the Reaping’s prison. It is warm.*
- 6. **Prince’s Writ** — Levies cannot touch you (yet); authority as a delay. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The writ is a feather. The Salt Prince’s signature is a claw mark. The feather came from a bird that drowned. It still tries to fly.*
- 7. **Black Ledger** — Names, debts, and where they sleep; knowledge as power. ‘[DEBT]’ ‘[INFORMATION]’ *The ledger is a skull. Read the names, and the skull will whisper their secrets. The skull’s teeth are made of crystal. They hum.*
- 8. **Salvage Rights** — A named wreck; first claim, no questions. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[WEALTH]’ *The wreck is a ghost ship. The ghost is the original owner. The ghost does not remember its name. It will trade the ship for a new one.*
- 9. **Lighthouse Key** — Stolen; redirect ships where you will. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[DECEPTION]’ *The key is a tuning fork. Strike it, and the lighthouse will lie for you. The lie becomes truth for one tide. The lighthouse keeper weeps.*
- 10. **Debt-Marker** — The Syndicate owes you a favor; obligation as an asset. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The marker is a coin. The Syndicate’s symbol is worn smooth—by regret. The coin is warm. It tastes of brine.*
- J **Queen’s Blessing** — Safe passage through the Shallows; charm as protection. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The blessing is a kiss. The Pirate Queen’s lips taste of salt and blood. After the kiss, you dream of the Reaping. You wake with a new debt.*

- Q Kraken's Favor** — The tides part for your ship, once; nature as an ally. '[TRAVEL]' '[MAGIC]' *The favor is a tentacle wrung dry. When you need it, soak it in seawater. The tentacle will write a name in the foam. Do not speak that name.*
- K Prince's Coin** — Bribe any official, silence any witness. '[SOCIAL]' '[DEBT]' *The coin is a finger bone. The official who takes it will not speak—or not listen. The bone belonged to the Salt Prince's predecessor. He is still alive. He is in the coin.*
- A Serpent's Mark** — The reef itself will guide you home; danger as a guide. '[TRAVEL]' '[MAGIC]' *The mark is a scar on your palm. The reef will cut you—but it will also open. The cut bleeds crystalline brine. The brine is the Reaping's attention. Use it sparingly.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (passes/contracts/goods) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **salt and serpent** motifs—tides that remember, reefs that shift, the deep that listens.

Additional Features

- **Tide Clock:** Scenes run on a four-segment **Tide Clock** (Low → Flood → Slack → Ebb). Each advance shifts Position: *Low tide* reveals hidden wrecks and bolt-holes; *Flood tide* drowns streets and seals doors. When the Clock turns, the Keeper may demand 1 SB tied to the waters.
- **Reaping's Corrosion (Clock [8]):** Tracks the slow corruption of the party's souls. Tick when you accept a bargain from the Salt Prince, use a Serpent's Mark, or fail a Resolve test while in Zakov. At 4, you gain a *Crystalline Whisper* condition (you hear the Reaping's voice in quiet moments; –1 die to resist fear). At 8, you become *Harvested*: your shadow detaches and walks into the sea, and you owe the Reaping a name. To clear the clock, you must offer the Reaping something it values more than your soul—a memory of a crime you did not commit, a true name you were never told, or a shard of its own prison (a heist into the vault).
- **Syndicate Debt:** Every deal leaves a mark. Track a single **Debt** value (0–3). At 3, the Syndicate calls it in: a betrayal, a levy, an unwanted escort. Clear 1 Debt by paying a Diamond or sacrificing a useful contact.
- **Whispers Deep:** Rumors carry teeth. When characters openly boast, bargain, or betray, roll 1d6: 1–3, Whispers spread, increasing SB generation; 4–6, Whispers favor the PCs, lowering suspicion until the tide turns.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Reckoner** — Maelstræus. *Interest on every contract; the coin that always comes back.*
 - **The Salt-Bitten Angel** — Malachai. *A silver coin that tastes of brine; a blessing that drowns.*
 - **The Kraken's Father** — Khemesh. *The pressure beneath the keel; the debt the sea collects.*
 - **The Tide Father** — The Traveler. *The current that carries you home—or to the reef.*

- **The Crystal Matrix** — The Ninth. *The Reaping’s true nature; silence that has taken form.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a hospice in the Sunken Quarter. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the eel-cults, trying to untie her cord from the Salt Prince’s ledger. She claims the Reaping is the Cord’s original sin. No one knows if she is right.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Serpent’s Spine is a Class II Anchor site—the bound spirit of a drowned admiral. Saikou Ira would trade his silver mirror for a single reef chart. The mirror shows the Reaping as a crystalline spider. He has not slept since.
- **The Salt-Bitten Angel (Malachai):** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the smugglers. Take it, and your cargo always passes inspection—but the coin will taste of brine every time you touch it, and the Angel will ask for a favour before the next full moon. The favour is always to carry a message to the Salt Prince. The message is a single word: "Soon."
- **The Reckoner (Maelstraeus):** The Crimson Docks keep a ledger signed in salt water; those who borrow from the Reckoner find that their interest compounds with every tide. A captain who defaults may wake to find their ship’s name struck from all records, as if it had never sailed. The Reckoner’s ink is crystalline. It writes itself.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Zakov psions are called “Tide-Readers.” They taste the future in the salt. The Pirate Queen employs two—and has never trusted a forecast that didn’t cost blood. The Reaping’s presence makes their predictions unreliable. They taste crystal instead of salt.
- **The Ninth:** In any Zakov scene, the ninth ship to enter the harbor in a tide will be claimed by the reef. The wise wait for the tenth—or pay a name to the Kraken’s Tongue. The reef is not a reef. It is a crystalline mouth. It has been feeding for centuries.

Zakov Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Tide:** Toss a crust into the water before a voyage. Ignore the first *Tide Shift* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Manifest:** Tie a single knot in a corner of your cargo list. Cancel *Voided Contract* or take –1 die on your next customs check (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Reef:** Whisper a dead captain’s name into the Serpent’s Spine. Gain +1 Effect when navigating the Shallows this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Kraken’s Tongue. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **syndicate enforcers or dock guards**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **pirates or tavern patrons**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or fence networks**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised: Dock-master or corsair lieutenant** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **tide shift or syndicate patrol**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival syndicate or pirate crew** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **syndicate enforcers, pirate crews, or naval forces** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **contract voided/storm hits/syndicate splits**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Salt Prince, Pirate Queen, or Drowned Admiral** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **tide shifts/storm hits/blockade imposed**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Zakov (Tide Power):** Water levels change without warning, ships become stranded or flooded, tidal currents shift direction.
- **Zakov (Syndicate Politics):** Protection money demands increase, rival factions make conflicting demands, contracts are voided mid-deal.
- **Zakov (Pirate Culture):** Ships are commandeered, crews mutiny, pirate codes are enforced with violence.
- **Zakov (Reaping Corruption):** A character's reflection speaks in a different voice, a crystalline growth appears on a weapon, the party hears a harmonic hum from the deep.

City Operating System (Fast Play)

Tide-State (4) Track a **Tide Clock** (Low → Flood → Slack → Ebb). At each shift:

- change **Position:** Low (+Infiltration), Flood (-Mobility), Slack (+Deals), Ebb (+Getaway).
- Keeper may bank 1 SB tied to *water, rot, or rumor*.

Heat & Debt Track **Heat** (0–4) and **Debt** (0–3) citywide.

- *Heat* rises on noisy jobs; at 4, a *Syndicate Split* tick or *Naval Blockade* rumor triggers.

- *Debt* rises when you stiff a faction; at 3, a creditor picks the next scene’s complication.

Crew Playbooks (pick one tag) *Cutters* (+Effect on coercion at Crimson Docks); *Ghosts* (ignore first Tide penalty each job); *Lighters* (cargo swaps create 1 **Forged Manifest** per session); *Lanterns* (fae bargains count as Diamonds once/session).

Signal, Cipher, & Circuitry

Harbor Flash (d6 quick comms) 1 one-lantern (safe) 2 two-lantern (watch) 3 red rag (fire) 4 black gull (hit) 5 three knocks (meet) 6 eel-twine (fae eyes)

Dock Cant (micro-phrases) “wet ledger” = bribe; “green rope” = cursed cargo; “white rain” = blockade rumor; “dead wake” = tail on you; “crystal voice” = the Reaping is listening.

Shadow-Net Each *Crow’s Roost*/tavern can host one **Cache**: 3 rumors total; *spend* 1 rumor to bump Position on info-gathering. When emptied, add +1 **Heat**.

The Fae Leak

Saltbound Rules Fae cannot *enter* a circle salted with **tidewater salt**, but can *bargain* across it. Breaking circle = 1 SB and a personal *Mark*.

Eel Court Wharf-spirits (eel-hooded) adjudicate vows “where water hears.” Presenting a **Serpent’s Mark** lets you reroute a single clause in a contract once.

Drowned Names Names thrown from *Bone-Yard Beach* return as *Echo Debtors*. Cash one to erase 1 **Debt**—but the name occasionally speaks from your mouth.

Heist Skeletons (Plug & Play)

The Manifest Swap (3 beats) **Beat 1:** *Entry* (Smuggler’s Gate or Sunken Quarter); on miss, *Tide Shift*. **Beat 2:** *Edit* (swap bill at Dock-Master); spend **Forged Manifest** to auto-pass. **Beat 3:** *Exit* (Shallows); fail = *Cursed Cargo* wakes.

Anchorhead Skim (4 beats) **Case** a ledger → **Turn** a clerk → **Lift** a page → **Ghost** on the Iron Pier. Any alarm = *Prince’s Levy* this scene.

Syndicate Play (Mini-Game)

Stacks & Faces Pick a patron *Stack* each arc: **Red Wake** (muscle), **Silent Syndicate** (intel), **Salt Prince** (papers). During downtime, exchange *Faces* (favors) for one of: reduce **Heat** by 1; clear 1 **Debt**; mint one **Black Ledger** page (one-use leverage on any named).

War Track (0–6) Each conflicting job advances **War**; at 3, *Blood Feud*; at 6, *Syndicate Split*. Reset if PCs deliver a **Queen’s Blessing** or sacrifice a crew asset.

Urban Terrain & Glitches

Glitch Table (fae-punk fuzz, d8) 1 door opens to water 2 lantern whispers your alias 3 rope grows kelp 4 coin tastes like brine and lies 5 footprints go opposite 6 eel writes your name 7 reef sound indoors 8 tide remembers a promise you didn't make

Zones (quick tags) *Dregs*: +Stealth, -Status; *Crimson*: +Force, -Subtle; *Sunken*: +Weird, -Mobility; *Salt Maze*: +Escape, -Clarity.

NPC Templates

Kraken's Tongue (Oracle) *Wants*: Tribute in secrets. *Leverage*: once/session convert a **Club** to a **Diamond**. *Cost*: forget a friend's face for a night.

Dock-Master Briga *Wants*: A rival's ledger singed. *Leverage*: "lose" any hull for a day. *Cost*: your real name in her book.

Pirate Queen Mael *Wants*: A tide-warden compromised. *Leverage*: **Queen's Blessing**. *Cost*: carry her mark where it shows.

Contraband & Curses

Hot List (d6) 1 saint-glass (screams when lied to) 2 eel-ink (writes back) 3 tide-bell (rings at wrong hour) 4 serpent charts (reef moves for bearer) 5 name-wine (drink a memory) 6 drowned coins (buy help, cost breath) 7 (rare) crystal shard (Reaping fragment; use to clear one **Reaping's Corrosion** segment, but ticks the clock twice in the next scene)

Tagging Cargo Each illicit lot has 1 *Tag*: **Watching, Hungry, Bound, Cold**. Tag can be "disarmed" by the right shrine/fee/contact.

Cross-Region Conversions

- **Theona**: *Smuggler's Token* counts as *Hawthorn Pass* if bells play eight; a ninth sound voids both.
- **Viterr**: *Prince's Writ* can masquerade as *Customs Seal* for one audit before *Audit Freeze* ticks.
- **Ubral**: *Black Ledger* page buys one night of *Guest-Token*—if read aloud at Wergild Ford.
- **Vhasia**: *Lighthouse Key* spoofs a beacon on *Beacon Crown*/King's High Road ferries once.
- **Valewood**: *Serpent's Mark* = one-scene *Way-Cord* if dipped in Moon-Cistern.
- **Ways Between**: A complete *Forged Manifest* recited at a *Threshold Arch* becomes a *Passage Token*.

Clocks & Pressures

Levy Teeth (6) 1–2: Quayside "inspections" 3–4: Tithe brigades 5: Fire at the wrong warehouse 6: Floating gallows at Anchorhead.

Smuggler War (6) 1–2: Protection doubled 3–4: Routes trapped 5: Crews defect 6: Open water gunwales—everyone draws steel.

Gate Truce (4) 1: Coins tied on rope 2–3: Gate stays “neutral” 4: New Keeper named; reroute *Tide Clock* once/session.

Reaping’s Corrosion (8) (see Additional Features)

Score Seeds

- **The Eel That Spoke:** A *Cursed Cargo* eel whispers court gossip from Thepyrgos; bottle it before *Syndicate Split*. The gossip includes a fragment of the Reaping’s true name.
- **Red Wake’s Shadow:** Lift a *Black Ledger* page naming the Salt Prince’s heir; payment is *Prince’s Coin*—and a knife in the dark. The heir is a child. The child is made of crystal. The child does not know it.
- **Lighthouse Down:** Swap the *Lighthouse Key* during a storm; success grants *Kraken’s Favor*, fail triggers *Naval Blockade*. The lighthouse keeper is the only living person who has seen the Reaping’s vault and returned sane. She will not return a second time.

Boss Seeds (Tariff & Flame)

- **The Hook-Master (Nine Stamps)** — *Phases:* Tariff Forgeries → Orchestrated Strike → Port Coup. *Cracks:* recover a true stamp, expose a forged ledger, survive a night in a lighthouse. The lighthouse reveals the Reaping’s reflection. The Hook-Master is terrified of it.
- **The Drowned Admiral (Ghost Fleet)** — *Phases:* Lost Ships Called Home → Procession of Empty Lanterns → Tide-Baptism of a Factor. *Cracks:* relic green flame, survivor testimony, the lighthouse keeper’s lens turning clear. The Admiral’s flagship is the vault where the Reaping sleeps. He guards it not out of loyalty, but because he is the first Harvested. He does not remember his name.

Patronage & Power

In Zakov, power flows through the control of smuggling routes, the management of syndicate debts, and the ability to navigate the complex web of pirate politics. The Salt Prince maintains nominal authority, but real power lies with those who control the tides, the reefs, and the flow of information through the city's taverns and black markets. The true authorities are those who can provide safe passage, protect cargoes, and mediate between competing syndicates.

The Reaping changes everything. Whoever controls the crystalline shard—or understands its nature—holds a weapon that could unmake the city or save it. The Salt Prince keeps the Reaping's location secret, but the Syndicates whisper that he is no longer its master. The Reaping has begun to act on its own. It reaches through the tide, through the dreams of the drowned, through the taste of brine in a smuggler's coin. Zakov is not ruled by the Prince. It is ruled by a hunger that has been patient for centuries.

For the GM: Patronage in Zakov revolves around smuggling rights, safe harbors, and the ability to provide protection from both legal and illegal authorities. Rewards often take the form of tokens, charters, and safe passage that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize the city's fluid power:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, manifests, keys) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival syndicates issue conflicting protections, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the docks, taverns, and smuggling routes as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of custom and connections determines success.
- Track **Reaping's Corrosion** as a campaign clock. Its advance is the city's slow death. The players can delay it, redirect it, or even embrace it—but they cannot ignore it.

In Zakov, your reputation is your wealth, and your wealth determines whether you rule the waves or feed the fishes. But beneath the waves, the Reaping feeds on reputation too. And it is very, very hungry.

Chapter 17

Aelinnel (Aevrossa)

Stone, Bough, and Bright Things. The gnomish homeland of Aevrossa clings to the Dolmis coast beneath the shadow of the Valewood, its halls threaded through granite and hawthorn. Promises have weight and numbers have manners. Even steps are safe, odd words are careful, and truths are traded like copper nails—bright, useful, slightly dangerous in the wrong pocket.

17.1 Aelinnel (Gnomes) — “Stone, Bough, and Bright Things”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Count the steps, weigh the words, and never trust a single ledger.*

Stone Prince of Aelinnel (Elite): “The law here flows like water over stone – it finds its own path, and woe to those who try to dam it with paper and pretense. The earth itself will testify against the unjust.”

Charcoal-burner (Commoner): “Our kilns tell us more than your books ever could. When the smoke curls left, the tide’s with you. When it splits in three, best stay by your own hearth till it burns straight again. And never trust a court that speaks in only one ledger.”

Genre / Mood: Dark faerie tale, moonlit groves, polite iron, and the uncanny weight of a promise.

Starting Location: A tide-shed at dawn, fog curling over anchored barges, gulls crying omens over the river’s black glass. A gnomish reeve offers passage on a sealed barge: “The Green Gate opens at neap tide. What we trade there, the Dolmis will not name.”

Stone, Bough, and Bright Things

Aelinnel homeland of Aevrossa clings to the Dolmis coast beneath the shadow of the Valewood, its halls threaded through granite and hawthorn, its roads counted by antler-posts and moonlit courtesy. Here, promises have weight and silence has meaning. *Even* steps are safe, *odd* words are careful, and truths are traded like copper nails – bright, useful, and slightly poisonous in the wrong pocket.

To the north, the Valewood looms; to the south, the downs of Amedell where the Aelaerem keep their red doors. The Green Gate sometimes opens onto halfling barrows – a fact neither people speaks of aloud.

Yet no single crown rules the gnomish lands. Dozens of courts, guilds, and seasonal pacts weave a shifting lattice of loyalty. Some Aelinnel hold fast to ancient fae treaties, speaking in two ledgers and never carrying naked iron; others barter in the Green Market with pragmatic coin, treating courtesy as a bargaining chip; still others vanish into the deep woods, listening to stag-roads and root-galleries where the Wild Hunt sometimes rides. The gnomish heart is divided – and that division is their shield against the fae.

Craft and courtesy govern every traffic between mortal keeps and the courts under the hill. Gnomish stone-singers tune bridges with a hum that keeps the Green Gate at bay; forester-wardens hammer copper where iron would draw unwanted attention. In markets under living roofs, a sentence can be cut to fit a purse, and a memory can be wrapped for travel. Paths sometimes shorten for those who keep good count, and lengthen for those who sneer at patterns. The fae are never rude – but they are never safe.

At a Glance

- **Atmosphere:** Moonlit groves, polite iron, and the uncanny weight of a promise.
- **Key Conflict:** What is said versus what is meant; fae courtesy versus mortal bluntness.
- **Notable Threats:** Glamour fog, iron offence, geas-catch, the Green Gate yawning at the wrong hour.
- **Common Rewards:** Hazel tokens, tide-path keys, oath-beads, and the Wild Hunt's clemency.

Prominent NPCs of Aelinnel

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Thorn	Lady of Thorns, Sovereign of the Hawthorn Court	Remind mortals that courtesy is a leash, not a gift	She never repeats herself. Her silences are verdicts.
Caelum Viridant	Green Knight, Warden of the Stag-Roads	Test the worthy and trap the careless	His armour is woven from living boughs that bleed when he lies.

Eilidh Stone-Prince	Mortal ruler of the Hall of Aelinnel	Keep the old pacts indexed and the fae at arm’s length	She speaks only in conditional tense. No one has heard a declarative sentence from her lips in seven years.
Riven	Huntsman of the Moonlit Ride	Chase down debts, oaths, and those who flee the Green Gate	His horn is carved from a fossilised scream. He only blows it when the debt is nine days old.
Tallow	Charcoal-burner (commoner exemplar)	Read the smoke and warn the village before the fae come	He has never lost a sheep to the Hollow. He has lost three helpers who did not listen.
Sable	Green-Market Broker	Trade truths for trinkets, and never lose the margin	Her receipts are written on leaf-vein paper. They curl when the bargain is unbalanced.

Names of Aelinnel

Aelinnel names are built from soft vowels (ae, ei, ui, oi) and liquid consonants (l, r, n, m) with occasional sharp endings (-k, -t, -x). Surnames are often taken from a notable grove, a tide-mark, or an ancestor’s defining courtesy. They evoke the sound of water over stone and wind through hawthorn.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Caelum	Eilidh	Thornweave	<i>the Green-Wise</i>
Riven	Sable	Tidespeak	<i>Two-Tongue</i>
Tallow	Merrow	Evenstep	<i>the Unseen Guest</i>
Fennel	Briar	Hawthorn	<i>Barrow-Kept</i>
Osprey	Vesper	Silverbough	<i>the Uncounted</i>
Linden	Ash	Foxtail	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

The Three Courts: Aelinnel Alignments

Aelinnel society is not a single crown but a lattice of courts, guilds, and seasonal pacts. Three broad stances shape their dealings with outsiders and with the fae. Most gnomes shift between these postures depending on the season, the tide, and who is asking.

- **Thorn–Courteous (Fae–Lean)** – These gnomes keep the old pacts with the Lady of Thorns and the Green Knight. They speak in two ledgers, never carry naked iron, and treat every threshold as a negotiation. They are the ones who remind visitors to count their steps and pour no ninth cup. *Clocks: COURTESY DEBT [4], HAWTHORN PATIENCE [6].*
- **Market–Square (Trade–Lean)** – These gnomes prioritise the Green Market, the Under-Market, and the flow of quartz, copper, and name-script. They are pragmatic, will use iron if it is gilded, and view fae courtesies as bargaining chips rather than sacred laws. *Clocks: TARIFF DISPUTE [4], MARKET DOMINANCE [6].*
- **Forester–Trusted (Wild–Lean)** – These gnomes live among the stag-roads and root-galleries, closer to the stone-singers and the tree-wardens. They speak the old names of tides and groves, and they are the first to notice when the thorn blight spreads or the moonwell stains a name wrong. *Clocks: ROOT CALLING [4], WILD HUNT INTEREST [6].*

Most Aelinnel characters and settlements fall somewhere between these poles, and the same gnome might wear a different mask when trading at the Green Market than when walking the stag-roads.

Spades — Places (stone spires, sea-rock, deep woods)

2. **Tide-rift steps** – Cut into black rock; limpets and old votive nails keep count for those who forget. ‘[THRESHOLD]’
 3. **Moonwell basin** – A granite bowl; coins turn green in a week, names in a season. ‘[MAGIC]’
 4. **Dolmen stair** – Up a ridge; each capstone rings a different interval if you tap it true. ‘[MUSIC]’
 5. **Charcoal coppice** – Under witch-hazel; a neat ash-heap hides a door that opens on even knocks only. ‘[SECRET]’
 6. **Basalt organ cliffs** – Sea-caves breathe like slow bellows; the wind prefers prime numbers. ‘[NATURE]’
 7. **Stag Road** – Game-trail marked by antler-posts; hooves know it best, maps accept it grudgingly. ‘[TRAVEL]’
 8. **Quartz spring** – Sand shines like ground stars; drinkers tell the same story with better structure. ‘[HEALING]’
 9. **Elf-causey** – Pale flags through a marsh; visible at dawn and dusk and whenever someone is counting aloud. ‘[FAE]’
 10. **Root gallery** – Under an oak hill; lanterns hang from living bark – two lit, one listening. ‘[UNDERGROUND]’
- J **Barrow gallery** – Stone chimes; a cold draft from below plays scales no throat can sing. ‘[DEATH]’
- Q **Thorn Court ring** – Hawthorns trained into arches; petals fall like knife-points and settle into proofs. ‘[FAE]’ ‘[DANGER]’
- K **Hall of Aelinnel** – A timber keep threaded between standing stones; floors level themselves

for guests. ‘[CIVILISATION]’

- A **The Green Gate** – In a sea-arch; at certain tides it opens to a forest not on any map, and expects exact change. ‘[GATE]’

Hearts — People & Factions (keepers, courts, craftsmen, hunters)

2. **Goat-herd of the stone edges** – Measures danger in hoof-widths; never wrong twice. ‘[SURVIVAL]’
 3. **Charcoal-burner clan** – Read draught and omen by smoke; their kilns hum in thirds. ‘[DIVINATION]’
 4. **Hedge-witch** – A pocket of thorns and prices stated in *unlesses*. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’
 5. **Stone-singer (quarryman)** – Hum finds a seam and a secret; walls relax when they pass. ‘[CRAFT]’
 6. **Forester-warden** – Copper nails and a polite dislike of iron; paths obey their hammer. ‘[NATURE]’
 7. **Reed-net fisher** – Knows when the selkies listen; mends nets to lullabies in 5s and 8s. ‘[TRADE]’
 8. **Oath-carver** – Sets promises in quartz so they can be seen; breaks none, bends many. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[OATH]’
 9. **Way-keeper of the Stag Road** – Never lost, often followed, sometimes found ahead. ‘[GUIDE]’
 10. **Green-market broker** – Trading truths for trinkets and back again; receipts in leaf-vein script. ‘[COMMERCE]’
- J **Green Knight** – Antler helm, mirror-bright blade, courtesy old as frost; keeps a tally of saved insults. ‘[FAE]’ ‘[DUEL]’
- Q **Lady of Thorns** – Sovereign of a hawthorn court; smiles like a snare and forgives in exact measures. ‘[FAE]’ ‘[LAW]’
- K **Stone Prince of Aelinnel** – Mortal crown with fae debts properly indexed and current. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- A **Huntsman of the Moonlit Ride** – His horn turns shortcuts into roads, and debts into destinations. ‘[HUNT]’

Clubs — Complications/Threats (glamour, geasa, weather, neighbours)

2. **Glamour fog** – Time drifts, footfalls don’t match, conversations arrive neatly folded. ‘[ILLUSION]’
3. **Iron offence** – Someone brought the wrong nails to the right grove; paths take it personally. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[DEBT]’
4. **Root-slide** – Pulls a trail two ridges away while you blink; your footprints stay where they were. ‘[TRAVEL]’
5. **Wrong tide at the sea-arch** – Boats rise where arithmetic says no and physics excuses itself. ‘[WEATHER]’

6. **Spoken geas** – Catches on an unlucky word; the task names itself and refuses synonyms. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[OATH]’
7. **Green Market price** – Payment demanded in names and memories; change returned in riddles. ‘[COMMERCE]’ ‘[DEBT]’
8. **Stone-wight stirs** – In a barrow; echoes hate company and file complaints as drafts. ‘[DEATH]’
9. **Lost day** – The sun miscounts; your dawn arrives at supper and demands bread. ‘[TIME]’
10. **Thorn blight** – Crawls across orchards; pruners bleed stories that grow where they drip. ‘[CURSE]’
- J **Stag horn sounds** – Everyone owes the chase – especially you, especially now. ‘[HUNT]’ ‘[DEBT]’
- Q **Thorn Court tithe** – Levied on the Hall; arrests wear flowers and quote etiquette. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’
- K **Muster of the Bough** – Forest banners rise; travel becomes trespass by default. ‘[CONFLICT]’
- A **Green Gate yawns** – At the wrong hour; roads rewire across your path with excellent logic. ‘[GATE]’ ‘[MYSTERY]’

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage (charms, passes, host-rights, exceptions)

2. **Hazel token** – Step through a hedge uncut, once; the scratch you did not get will *remember* you kindly. ‘[PROTECTION]’
3. **Salt license** – Carry and use ward-salt where it’s discouraged; doors frown and open anyway. ‘[UTILITY]’
4. **Dolmen carving-right** – Inscribe a name or claim on a speaking stone; arguments quiet while you carve. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
5. **Guest-bough** – From the Thorn Court; one night’s safe table among thorns; knives behave. ‘[HOSPITALITY]’
6. **Quarry allotment** – Of clear quartz; subtle doors open to its bearer if asked in the right tense. ‘[ACCESS]’
7. **Green Market voucher** – Buy a truth at face value (today only); tomorrow costs interest. ‘[COMMERCE]’
8. **Oath-bead** – A spoken promise warms the bead when kept, chills when not, glows if misunderstood. ‘[OATH]’
9. **Tide-path key** – Lawful crossing of a named sea-cave at neap; the cave will wait. ‘[TRAVEL]’
10. **Forest truce** – Hunt, cut, or travel through a warded copse without offence; the birds file no reports. ‘[PERMISSION]’
- J **Green Knight escort** – From ridge to gate; watchers bow, paths part, insults lodge elsewhere. ‘[PROTECTION]’
- Q **Private audience** – With the Lady of Thorns; a whisper exits as policy with petals attached. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- K **Stone Prince’s seal** – Levies defer, foresters guide, scribes stop arguing and fetch tea. ‘[AUTHORITY]’

A **Wild Hunt clemency** – Ride under the horn for one night; no hound will take you, no debt will sleep. ‘[PROTECTION]’

Quick use notes

- Draw until all four suits appear: **Spade** = place, **Heart** = actor, **Club** = pressure, **Diamond** = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Treat **Diamonds** as codified outcomes (charms/passes/host-rights) that *change position* rather than call for a roll.
- If any **A** appears, echo dark fae motifs: antlers in shadow, petals that cut, a tide that breathes, and a shortcut that insists on proper payment.

Additional Features

- **Two-Ledger Courtesy:** Once per scene, a character who states both what they *say* and what they *mean* (in or out of character) may shift *Position* one step safer on a social roll against a fae or fae-touched being. The GM may demand a small token (a copper coin, a knotted thread) as earnest.
- **Copper over Iron:** When the party visibly favours copper or brass tools over iron in fae-facing scenes, gain +1 assist die from locals (or avoid a –1 penalty) for acts of courtesy, passage, or petition. Iron is not forbidden – it is simply *impolite*, and impoliteness is remembered.
- **The Unsaid Clause:** In any bargain or promise, if the players explicitly leave one term unspoken (but agreed upon by all at the table), the GM may bank 1 SB to introduce a complication later where that omission becomes the hinge of the deal. The fae love what is not said.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Thorned Lady** – The Lady of Thorns (fae sovereign). *Courtesy is a leash; mercy is a snare.*
 - **The Green Knight** – The Sealed Gate (threshold guardian). *Prove your worth, or be turned aside.*
 - **The Still Count** – Mykkiel (divine arithmetician). *Every miscount is a sin; every correction is a prayer.*
 - **The Root-Speaker** – Grimmer (wild patron). *Stone sings, wood remembers, the grove witnesses.*

Courtesies of the Green Gate

- **Never bring naked iron** past a hawthorn arch unless it is gilded or named. Copper is polite, silver is opinionated, cold iron is an accusation.
- **Always return what points the way.** Way-cords, antler-posts, chalk. Borrow the path; do not keep it. The fae count what you take.
- **Speak debts in the daylight.** Promises made under lantern-boughs are heard by leaves as well as by law. The Green Gate listens.
- **The ninth cup is never poured.** Leave it empty for the uninvited guest. If you pour it, drink it yourself – and hope the guest does not arrive.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord sometimes serve as oath-carvers, binding promises with red thread instead of quartz. A renegade Sister hides in the Root Gallery, trying to untie a cord tied by the Lady of Thorns herself.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends appears in the moonwell. Take it, and the water will show you a perfect reflection – but the coin will reappear in the well every new moon, each time a little warmer.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Aelinneal psions are called “Proof-Readers”. They hear the weight of hidden clauses and can detect an omission in any bargain by the way the air tastes of copper.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Green Gate is a Class III Procession – the gate itself walks the coast once a season, and those who cross it must answer a riddle about debts or be pulled into the Hollow.
- **The Ninth:** In any Aelinneal scene, the ninth word spoken in a bargain becomes legally binding – even if the speaker did not intend it. The wise count to eight and then gesture.

Regional Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Gate:** Crumble a crust before the Green Gate. Ignore the first *Glamour fog* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Cord:** Tie a single knot in a way-cord. Cancel *Spoken geas* or take –1 die on your next promise (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Stone:** Whisper a dead oath-carver’s name into a standing stone. Gain +1 Effect when negotiating with fae this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Stone Prince. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table (Aelinneal)

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **thorn-courtiers** or **forest-wardens**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **stone-singers** or **green-market traders**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **stag-road trackers** or **oath-carvers**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Green Knight** or **Lady of Thorns’ herald** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **glamour fog** or **root-slide**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **stone-wight** or **thorn blight spirit** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **fae courtiers, forester-wardens, or stag-horn riders** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes – **geas triggers / green gate opens / iron offence declared**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Lady of Thorns, Stone Prince, or Huntsman of the Moonlit Ride** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically – **tide turns / green gate yawns / thorn blight spreads**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice – **omen appears / blessing lost / curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options (Aelinnel)

- **Courtesy & Geas (1–3 SB):** A hawthorn arch closes behind you; copper tools glow with fae attention; a polite phrase becomes a binding geas. The fae have noted your manners – or your lack thereof.
- **Glamour (1–2 SB):** Conversations arrive folded and misaddressed; time drifts unexpectedly; your footfalls no longer match your steps. The Green Gate breathes.
- **The Unsaid (1–2 SB):** An omission you did not know you made becomes the price of passage. The Lady of Thorns smiles. You do not know why.

Aelinnel – Tidal Bargains

Starting Location: A tide-shed at dawn, fog curling over anchored barges, gulls crying omens over the river’s black glass.

“In Aelinnel lands, the river speaks with many tongues, and each tide demands a name in return.”

In... a tide-shed at dawn, a gnomish reeve offers passage on a sealed barge. “The Green Gate opens at neap tide. What we trade there, the Dolmis will not name.”

Regional Motifs Tide-ledgers, river gods, sealed cargo, name-taboo.

Whispers to Offer “Peek in the crate,” “Speak the hidden name,” “Break quarantine.”

External Clocks Threat: *Green Gate Thirst* [6]; Community: *Dockside Fear* [4]; Anchor: *Barge Oath* [4].

Complications Freshwater turns brackish; the cargo sings; a rival reeve boards with knives.

Anchors at Risk A PC's river-kin; the barge's blessing.

Escalation Beat The Gate opens early; the tide runs backwards.

Relief Offer a river-gift; carry a name written in river-mud across the threshold; spend 2 to seal the leak for a scene.

Faction Entanglements

- **Stone–Singer Conclave:** Sponsor a bridge-chant or way-tuning and bank a *Harmonic Favor* – spend to shift *Position* one step safer on any passage across worked stone or living root. Skip their rites and the first crossing this leg gains a free “Lock/Barrier” SB as paths sulk.
- **Forester–Wardens:** Accept copper-nail protocols to cancel the first *Fae Offence* SB in a wood scene. Drive iron stakes or break taboo and mark a 4-segment *Polite Apology* clock you must clear before locals assist you again.
- **Green-Market Brokers:** Submit an itemised truth (what was said / what was meant) to reduce barter DV by 1 for the scene. Try to haggle on single-ledger terms, and the market tags you with *Exact Change Only* – all bargains hereafter demand a tithe of memory or name until appeased.
- **Oath–Carvers’ Guild:** Have a promise set in quartz to gain a *Visible Oath* token; spend to treat one social test as if aided by a reputable witness. Breaking a quartz-oath spawns a 4-segment *Shattered Nuance* clock that complicates future negotiations.
- **Tide–Reeves:** File a tide-plan before neap to earn a *Tide Window* – ignore one tidal timing penalty this leg. Skipping the ledger adds a free “Wrong Tide” SB the first time you touch the Dolmis.

Cross–Regional Ties & Soft Power

- **Way of Silk Interface:** Kon"reh-counted caravans that adopt Aelinnel step-metrics (even steps, counted halts) gain +1 die to avoid ambushes on the Way this arc. Breaking count invites a free “Glamour Fog” SB at the next way-shrine.
- **Aeler Standards (Rods & Wards):** Recognise Aeler measures publicly to reduce dispute DV by 1 with dwarven legates; insist on gnomish dual-ledger and foreign merchants grumble – first mixed-market scene gains an “Assay Doubt” SB.
- **Vhasia/Viterra Complications:** Vhasian hedge-duties (wood rites) and Viterra tithe-scripts (grain flows) cross your ledgers. When either region is “Stressed,” add +1 DV to Green-Market exports that travel their roads unless you carry a *Forest Truce* or *Tithe Waiver*.
- **Valewood Fallout:** On a *Valewood Weather* signal, fae proofs spill downslope; counting etiquette cancels the first navigation SB each scene, but any iron shown gains a free “Fae Complaint” SB (even among humans). Aelaerem hospitality rites mitigate this: presenting guest-loaf removes one such complaint per hall.

Trade Goods & Consequences

- **Quartz & Proof–Stone:** Donate clear quartz to a shrine to bank a *Seen Promise* – once, treat a murky contract as if properly witnessed. Peddle clouded quartz as “ritual grade” and spawn a roaming *Counterfeit Proof* inquiry clock.

- **Copper Etiquette Kits:** Issuing copper over iron in mixed courts grants +1 assist die on petitions; flooding markets with cheap copper pins offends foresters – add a “Copper Resentment” tag that raises DV in wood jurisdictions until you make amends.
- **Name-Script & Memory Wraps:** Legal export of name-script lowers espionage DV by 1 for allies who carry it. Smuggling wraps risks a *Name-Tax* – first customs scene converts 1 SB into a compelled disclosure.
- **Tide Rights & Barge Seals:** Funding barge-seals creates a *Waiting Cave* – once per arc the cave “waits” an extra beat for your crew. Ignoring seal-maintenance flips it: first Dolmis crossing suffers “Wrong Hour” SB.

Patron Networks (Patterns & Thresholds)

- **Sacred Geometry:** Chalk a golden-mean spiral at a ford to reroll one failed prediction/trajectory check this leg; doing so in view of fae courts adds a 2-segment *Proof Envied* clock.
- **The Sealed Gate:** Hawthorn-gilded door-nails act as single-use stay writs: negate one forced entry or pursuit at a hedge-gate.
- **Lunara:** Counting under moonlight lets you ask one terse yes/no about a hidden path; on a Miss, secrets spread – mark Exposure +1 in the nearest Green Market.
- **The Traveler:** Antler-posts double as wayshrines; leave a copper and recite a sequence to finish one travel clock tick for free on forest legs.

Field Procedures (Use At the Table)

- **Two-Ledger Talk:** When parley stalls, the GM asks: “What was said? What was meant?” If players state both, cancel the first social SB this scene; if they refuse, the next bargain demands collateral (memory/name).
- **Count or Be Counted:** At any fae-touched crossing, a player who audibly counts in a fitting sequence (steps, heartbeats, breaths) shifts *Position* one step safer for that crossing. Boasting or mocking numbers adds a free “Geas Catches” SB.
- **Copper Courtesy Check:** Producing copper/brass tools in a ritual space removes the first *Fae Offense* tag this scene; drawing iron instead escalates the next Complication by +1 Cap.

Diplomatic Favor & Reputation Echoes

- **Hazel Favors (minor resource):** Earned by returning way-cords, restoring antler posts, or paying tide-dues. Spend to downgrade a *Glamour* or *Geas* complication once per leg.
- **Alignment Reputation:**
 - *Thorn-Courteous:* Doors of the hawthorn courts open a step easier; human clerks distrust your clauses (first city office DV +1).
 - *Market-Square:* Brokers vouch your weights; rival stalls circulate riddled slander – add a trailing *Folded Rumor* clock.
 - *Forester-Trusted:* Paths shorten for you once per journey; port inspectors assume concealed copper – first harbor search gains a free “Alarm Raised” SB unless declared up front.

Boss Archetypes in Aelinnel

Court & Courtesy (Fae Sovereigns)

- **Lady of Thorns (Etiquette Engine)** – Punishes breaches with precise harms, rewards perfect courtesy with literal boons. *Win by satisfying three courtesies in sequence (no iron, two-ledger speech, return the waymark).*
- **Green Knight (Trial by Pattern)** – Duel of paths and proofs, not blades. *Win by presenting a higher-count route (Fibonacci, even-steps) or yielding a deserved apology at the right number.*

Threshold & Hunt (Environment that Judges)

- **Moonlit Ride (Wild Hunt)** – Three phases: *Sounding* (horns), *Coursing* (paths shorten for the bold), *Closing the Ring*. *Win by naming safe-clemency, joining the chase without taking a prey, or blowing the right counter-call (2–3–5).*
- **Green Gate (Living Crossing)** – Demands exact change in truths. *Win by paying a memory that fits the posted proof; forcing passage triggers “Roads Rewired.”*

Numbers & Glamour (Logical Anomalies)

- **Glamour Fog (Layered Illusion)** – Each layer dispelled by a correct count, courtesy, or copper rite. *Win by completing the Three Proofs: count aloud, return a borrowed path token, trade a said/meant receipt.*
- **Lost Day (Time Mismatch)** – The sun misnumbers hours. *Win by reconciling two ledgers (what happened / what should have), then ringing a prime-number chime.*

Market & Oath (Contract Tricksters)

- **Green-Market Broker (Truth Arbitrage)** – Buys your meanings, sells your words. *Win by catching them in a one-ledger statement or producing an Oath-Bead that chills (misunderstood clause).*
- **Oath-Carver Gone Wrong (Quartz Tyrant)** – Binds towns with over-precise promises. *Win by carving a Release Unless into communal quartz at cost of a public truth.*

Stone & Memory (Ancestral Hazards)

- **Stone-Wight Chorus (Echo Jurors)** – Resent footsteps, adore proofs. *Win by tapping the dolmen scale that matches the grievance and returning a taken token to the barrow.*

Boss Mechanics (Use 2–3 levers)

- **Courtesy Track [4]:** Each breach (iron bared, skipping greetings, single-ledger lie) ticks it. On fill, boss gains *Polite Punishment*: escalate DV +1 and impose a Geas.
- **Counting Proofs (three steps):** Name a pattern, perform it, return a waymark. Completing all three lowers boss tier for one exchange or ends a phase.
- **Said/Meant Ledgers:** Any bargain scene runs two mini-clocks; if *Said* fills first, glamour favours the boss; if *Meant* fills first, PCs gain a *Visible Oath* token.
- **Iron Offence Meter [0–3]:** Showing iron, striking hawthorn, or salting impolitely raises it. At 3, fae gain a free “Thorn Blight” SB; reduce by copper rites or gifts.
- **Hunt Phases:** *Sounding* (fear checks; pass to gain +1 die to pace), *Coursing* (paths shorten for counted strides), *Closing* (only truth-payment or clemency halts the circle).

- **Lair Actions (pick two):** *Fold the Conversation* (re-target a statement); *Shift the Count* (odd ↔ even penalties); *Petal Cut* (apply 1 Harm unless copper shown); *Wrong Tide* (swap entry/exit costs at a gate).

Patronage & Power

Among the Aelinnel, power flows through courtesy, oath, and the hidden geometry of the land. A Stone Prince’s authority rests on indexed fae treaties; a Green Knight’s on the trials he has witnessed. There is no single crown, only the shared understanding that a broken promise cuts deeper than a sword.

For the GM: Power in Aelinnel society is measured in hazel tokens, oath-beads, and the precision of a courtesy. Patronage often takes the form of guest-boughs, tide-path keys, or the Green Knight’s escort – each tied to a specific court, grove, or debt. To emphasise the cultural mechanics:

- Use **Two-Ledger Courtesy** to reward players who pay attention to the unspoken.
- Enforce **Copper over Iron** – carrying iron is not forbidden, but it is a statement.
- Let **The Unsaid Clause** be a source of future complications; the fae love what is not said.
- Track **Obligation to the Green Gate** as a persistent clock. Each crossing without proper payment ticks it toward a visit from the Huntsman.

In Aelinnel society, the stone remembers every step – and the Green Gate forgets no debt.

Chapter 18

Aelaerem

Hearth & Hollow. The halfling downs of Aelaerem hide deep barrows and darker hungers. Hospitality is a sacred law—and a trap. Red doors promise bread and salt, but the Neighbors walk the hedge-lanes, and the Pale Shepherd appears at every stillbirth and funeral. Their homeland’s true name is hushed, spoken only in euphemisms.

18.1 Aelaerem (Halflings) — “Hearth & Hollow”

Apple-Matron (Elite): “A proper harvest feast requires three things: the finest cider aged in the right barrel, a guest-loaf baked with intention, and the wisdom to know when to invite the quiet ones to sit by the fire.”

Miller (Commoner): “My geese know a stranger’s step from a mile off, and they’ve never been wrong. If they start honking at noon, you best check your larder – someone’s coming who wasn’t invited. And when the Hollow walks, the only safe place is a lit hearth with the ninth cup unpoured.”

Theme & Atmosphere

In Amedell, the Aelaerem keep their bonds with bread, bells, and careful counting. Lanes run under ash and hawthorn; doors reddened with thread promise a seat and a story to any who step right. Their magic is housekeeping writ large – thresholds groomed, names jarred like jam, the Hollow fed with silence and the ninth cup left unpoured. When the Neighbors stir beneath the barrows, the folk answer with kettle songs and lantern law, and the fields behave because someone asked them to. Hospitality here is not kindness—it is a covenant. Every meal is a promise, every gift a thread, every candle an argument against the dark. Amedell lies south of the Aelinnel homeland of Aevrossa, separated by the rolling downs and the slow waters of the River Adder. The two small-folk peoples share trade in red thread, copper, and seasonal hospitality, though the Aelaerem keep a wary distance from the fae-touched gnomish courts. It lies on the southeastern coast of the Dolmis, although the Aelaerem are rarely out to sea beyond coastal fishing.

What you notice first: The smell of baking bread and old apples. The way every threshold has a red thread tied at eye level. The silence of children when a stranger passes the village stone.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse an offered cup. The Hollow counts refusals as invitations. Pour the ninth cup for the empty chair, and you may feed it—or feed it.

Regional Mood: Warm Hearths, Cold Thresholds

Here, the land is not wilderness—it is a living weave of favors and omissions. The Aelaerem do not build walls; they build hedges, stiles, and the careful geometry of guest-right. A red door means bread, salt, and one safe night if you come honest. A cup-mark stone on the verge accepts butter as a prayer. The watch-geese know your step before you do, and the scarecrow turns to face the road when the Hollow is hungry. The Neighbors—the things that live under the barrows, in the uncounted ninth step, in the space between the candle and its shadow—are not enemies. They are neighbors. And neighbors, if treated politely, will stay on their side of the hedge.

Starting Location: A cider-press barn perfumed with crushed apples and rain, where masks hang from beams awaiting the next festival. The Apple-Matron sits on a stool of woven twigs. Behind her, a Moot Oak leaf bleeding red sap onto a stone. “The Hollow walks early this year,” she says. “The Moot Oak bleeds wine. Will you speak for the field, or let the Neighbors claim it? Speak true—the geese are listening.”

Prominent NPCs of Aelaerem

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
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Oria <i>“Crimson Door”</i>	Apple-Matron of the Harvest Moot	Keep the Hollow at bay and the feasts true	She pours the first cup for the eldest, the ninth for the empty chair. Never takes the ninth herself.
Bram	Miller of the Watch-Geese	Protect the village from unseen strangers	His geese have names; one is “Stranger,” and it has never been wrong.
Celia	Hedge-Witch Midwife	Tie red thread and untie feuds before they fester	Her thread is from her own hair. She never cuts it—only knots it.
Drogo	Thresher-King (seasonal)	Lead the harvest rites and keep the sheaf’s secret	Chosen by the last sheaf, which is always a little damp.
Alda	Lantern-Warden of the Downs	Trim the lamps and know which shadows are wrong	Lights them in a pattern that is a prayer.
Finnian	Mummers’ Captain	Guard the masks and the laws of festival	The masks are not carved. They are grown.

Names of Aelaerem

Inspired by the pastoral hill country of a green and misty isle: earthy, clipped, with soft vowels and hard consonants, evoking hearth, hedge, and hollow.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Tolly	Daisy	Underhill	<i>the Red-Door</i>
Bram	Posy	Bywater	<i>the Goose-Wise</i>
Corbin	Marigold	Brookside	<i>Barrow-Born</i>
Willum	Hazel	Holloway	<i>Hollow-Touched</i>
Hodge	Fern	Fielding	<i>the Uninvited</i>
Pippin	Ivy	Hayward	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

(Lanes/Orchards/Mills/Downs/Barrows) Willow ford with flat stones and a bowed pollard that remembers faces; cider-press barn with sweet reek, old songs, doors that stick after dusk; chalk

sheep-downs with a turf maze cut like a wheel.

Spades — Places

2. **Willow Ford** [RIVER] [OMEN]
 Flat stones, bowed pollard that remembers faces.
The willow has a name. It will tell you if you sit beneath it and listen.
3. **Cider-Press Barn** [HARVEST] [MEMORY]
 Sweet reek, old songs, doors that stick after dusk.
The press was built from a barrow oak. The oak still dreams.
4. **Chalk Sheep-Downs** [PASTURE] [RITUAL]
 Turf maze cut like a wheel; sheep know the pattern.
The maze is a prayer. Walk it backward to ask a favor.
5. **Millpond Under Alders** [WATER] [OMEN]
 The wheel turns some nights without water.
The water is not water. It is the memory of rain.
6. **Bluebell Wood Path** [FOREST] [WARD]
 Rabbit-gates and snares set by careful hands.
The snares are for the Hollow. They catch only shadows—mostly.
7. **Hedge-Tunnel Lane** [BOUNDARY] [TRICK]
 Between fields; nine stiles, locals count “eight-and-one.”
The ninth stile is a gap in the hedge. Step through, and the lane behind you changes.
8. **Cup-Mark Stone on the Verge** [RITUAL] [OFFERING]
 Butter left in niches goes missing kindly.
The butter vanishes before dawn. The Hollow leaves a pebble in exchange.
9. **Barrow-by-the-Beech** [DEATH] [SILENCE]
 Bees go quiet at noon.
The bees are not sleeping. They are listening.
10. **Market Green** [COMMUNITY] [JUDGMENT]
 Maypole and stocks; carved village stones turned inward.
The stones face the green. They watch the maypole dance—and the dancers.
- J **Dovecote Hill** [OMEN] [FEAR]
 The scarecrow faces the road, not the rows.
The scarecrow has a face. It is the face of the last person who broke guest-right.
- Q **Mother’s Orchard** [HARVEST] [PROMISE]
 Rows straighten if you don’t look—curve if you do.
The orchard is a promise. Break it, and the apples will taste of ash.
- K **Moot Oak** [LAW] [MEMORY]
 Lantern nails hammered deep; benches at the roots.
The nails are from a hundred feuds. Each one holds a grudge.
- A **Hollow Field** [CURSE] [DANGER]
 A ring where no plow will hold a line, not for any coin.
The field is a mouth. It has not fed in a century.

(Keepers/Elders/Mummers/Quiet Powers) Hedge-witch midwife who ties red thread and unties feuds; miller and his watch-geese—better sentries than men.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Hedge-Witch Midwife** [HEALING] [BOUNDARY]
Ties red thread, unties feuds, and knows which births the Hollow watches.
Her thread is from her own hair. She never cuts it—only knots it.
3. **Miller** [WATCHFUL] [LOYALTY]
Watch-geese that remember faces; better sentries than men.
The geese have names. One is “Stranger.” It has never been wrong.
4. **Orchard Reeve** [AUTHORITY] [HARVEST]
Tally-stick, cider-stained smile, and a list of who owes what harvest.
His tally-stick is an apple branch. The notches grow back.
5. **Beekeeper** [SACRED] [SECRET]
Keeps odd honey aside for “winter churches.”
The honey is from barrow flowers. It tastes of earth and old promises.
6. **Shepherd** [COMMAND] [SPIRIT]
Bone whistle that calls dogs—and other things.
The whistle is from a wolf. The wolf still answers.
7. **Lantern-Warden** [WARD] [RITUAL]
Trims lamps and knows which shadow is wrong.
She lights the lamps in a pattern. The pattern is a prayer to keep the Hollow back.
8. **Mummers’ Captain** [TRANSFORMATION] [LAW]
Chest of masks, stricter rules than church.
The masks are not carved. They are grown.
9. **Traveling Tinker** [TRADE] [OATH]
Bright kettles, dull knife for cutting oaths.
The knife was his father’s. His father used it to cut a promise with the Hollow.
10. **Bailiff of the Moot Oak** [LAW] [MEMORY]
Polite as a noose, carries a tally of grudges.
His tally is bark. The writing grows deeper each year.
- J **Wold-Wardens** [TRADITION] [BOUNDARY]
Elders who swear by hedges, not crowns.
They measure time in hedge-layers. A hedge that has grown for a century has a hundred opinions.
- Q **Apple-Matron** [AUTHORITY] [HOSPITALITY]
Hostess of harvest feasts; power sits where she pours.
She pours the first cup for the eldest, the second for the guest, the eighth for the fire. The ninth cup is for the empty chair.
- K **Thresher-King** [SEASONAL] [SACRIFICE]
A title that moves but never leaves; harvest robes, seasonal authority.
He is chosen by the last sheaf. The sheaf is always a little damp.
- A **The Pale Shepherd** [DEATH] [THRESHOLD]
Comes when lambs are born and when people go missing.

He has no face. His hat is a shadow.

(Folk Omens/Rites/Beasts/Night) Unseasonal fog; the road walks you back to your own gate. Scarecrow turns; it watches the lane, not the field. Black sow through the orchard; hooves scuff every charm.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Unseasonal Fog** [WEATHER] [TRAP]
 The road walks you back to your own gate.
The gate is closed. The latch is red. Do not touch it.
3. **Scarecrow Turns** [OMEN] [FEAR]
 It watches the lane, not the field.
The scarecrow's head follows you. The crows are silent.
4. **Soured Wassail** [RITUAL] [DEBT]
 The bowl gives back names you did not speak.
The names are of people who died last winter. They are not listed in any tally.
5. **Black Sow in the Orchard** [CURSE] [OMEN]
 Hooves scuff every charm.
The sow was a woman once. She broke a vow.
6. **Hive-Swarm at Dusk** [NATURE] [OMEN]
 Smoke curls the wrong way.
The bees are spelling a word. The word is "guest."
7. **Old Song Taken Up by Children** [MEMORY] [TABOO]
 Adults remember the verse none should sing.
The verse is about a barrow that opened. The children think it is a lullaby.
8. **Lanterns Burn Blue at the Ford** [THRESHOLD] [TOLL]
 Crossing costs more than coin.
The blue light is a toll-keeper. Payment is a story—or a secret.
9. **Out-of-Season Mumming** [TRANSFORMATION] [TRAP]
 Masks stick; faces won't come off.
The masks are warm. They have a heartbeat.
10. **Chalk Maze Fills with Mist** [DIMENSION] [DANGER]
 You step out somewhere older.
The mist has a smell—old wool and older bread.
- J **Church Bell Rings Thirteen** [OMEN] [SPIRIT]
 Something attends the sermon.
The thirteenth pew is empty. The dust on it is fresh.
- Q **Harvest Tithe Demanded** [DEBT] [SPIRIT]
 Hands gloved in leaves.
The hands do not belong to anyone in the village.
- K **Moot Oak Bleeds Sap** [OMEN] [VIOLENCE]
 The color of wine; talk turns to knives.
The sap is warm. It tastes of blood and honey.
- A **The Hollow Opens** [CURSE] [DIMENSION]

Burrows and barrows connect; footfalls answer underground.
The footsteps are counting. They stop at eight.

(Blessings/Tokens/Host-Rights) Guest-loaf and salt—one night’s safe board anywhere with a red door; cider-mark—a free cup on the green buys gossip and patience.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Guest-Loaf & Salt** [HOSPITALITY] [ONCE]
 One night’s safe board anywhere with a red door.
The loaf is barley and rye. Break it with the host, and the Hollow will not cross the threshold—for one night.
3. **Cider-Mark** [SOCIAL] [ONCE]
 A free cup on the green buys gossip and patience.
The mark is a notch on a barrel. The tapster will remember you—or pretend not to.
4. **Hedge-Pass Ribbon** [TRAVEL] [ONCE]
 Step through any thicket unsnagged, once.
The ribbon is red. Tie it to a branch, and the thorns will part—once.
5. **Bee-Queen Share** [WARNING] [ONGOING]
 Honey and a warning from the hives when danger nears.
The honey is from a queen who died last year. Her ghost still guards the comb.
6. **Shepherd’s Whistle** [COMMAND] [ONCE]
 Dogs and door-bolts heed you for one scene.
The whistle is a knucklebone. Blow it, and the dogs will obey—or they will hide.
7. **Lantern-Writ** [LIGHT] [ONCE]
 The lamps stay lit along your path despite wind.
The writ is a bell. Ring it, and the lamps will not flicker—until dawn.
8. **Mummers’ License** [MASQUERADE] [ONCE]
 Lawful mask and after-dark crossing for a feast day.
The license is a wooden mask. Wear it, and the Hollow will see a stranger—not a guest.
9. **Orchard Right** [SECRET] [ONCE]
 Pick at Mother’s Orchard without offense; the fruit hides a truth.
The fruit is a secret. Bite it, and the secret will become yours—or it will become you.
10. **Mill Token** [UTILITY] [ONGOING]
 The wheel turns at any hour, grain or rumor ground.
The token is a millstone chip. Feed it to the wheel, and it will grind anything—truths included.
- J **Apple-Matron’s Blessing** [PROTECTION] [ONCE]
 Hands help unseen when you ask no coin.
The blessing is a cup. Pour it out in trouble, and the fields will send rain—or roots.
- Q **Private Moot Under the Oak** [JUSTICE] [ONCE]
 Elders hear you alone; precedent sticks.
The moot is held at midnight. The oak’s roots are the jury.
- K **Thresher-King’s Guard** [ESCORT] [FEAR]
 Six red-hooded harvesters escort you; doors open.
Their hoods are the color of dried blood. They do not speak.

A Pale Shepherd's Clause

[IMMUNITY] [ONCE]

Once, the Hollow will not notice you; pass uncounted.

The clause is a silence. The Hollow will step aside—and will remember that it did.

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (blessings/tokens/host-rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo Hearth & Hollow motifs—quiet bells, red thread, watch-geese, footsteps under the soil—so the dread feels woven through the hedges.

Additional Features

- **Bread & Lantern:** Presenting a guest-loaf and a lit lantern at a threshold shifts your next social action one step safer while you remain a guest of that hearth. The lantern must be lit from the host's fire.
- **Neighorly Courtesies:** When you keep local taboos (count “eight-and-one,” turn village stones inward, leave butter at cup-marks), cancel the first SB generated by rites or negotiations in that scene.
- **Listen at the Stile:** A quiet pause at a stile, barrow, or hedge-tunnel yields a true omen—ask one short question about what the Hollow wants *here and now*; the answer arrives as a sign, a sound, or a small animal.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Sealed Gate:** Some Aelaerem thresholds are marked with a nail from the Sealed Gate's original shrines. A door with such a nail can be barred against any spirit for one night—but the nail must be removed before dawn, or the door will never open again.
- **The Savage Heart:** In the deepest hollows, the Hollow is said to wear a bear's shape during the winter famine. Hedge-keepers leave raw meat at the boundary, not as an offering but as a treaty: “Eat this, not our children.”
- **The Traveler:** Lantern-wardens sometimes find a grey pilgrim waiting at a stile at dusk. The pilgrim asks for directions to a village that no longer exists. Those who answer truthfully find that the next road they walk is half as long.
- **The Clockwork Monad:** Aeler engineers tried to map the hedge-tunnel lanes using breath-bonds and brass chains. The surveyors reported that the lanes would not hold still. The maps were burned. The Aelaerem still smile when asked about it.
- **Ikasha, She Who Sleeps:** The Hollow is sometimes called Ikasha's shadow—the part of her that did not fall asleep. Aelaerem children are taught never to whisper the name of the dreamer before bed, lest the Hollow mistake them for a messenger.
- **The Ninth:** On the ninth night of a feast, the empty chair is left for the Hollow. If a guest sits in it, the Hollow will take their place at the table. The feast will continue, but the guest will never be full again.

Aelaerem Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Barrow:** Crumble a crust at a cup-mark stone. Ignore the first *Hive-Swarm* penalty.
- **Knot the Ribbon:** Tie a single knot in a red thread at a threshold. Cancel *Out-of-Season Mummung* or take -1 die on your next festival roll (your choice).
- **Name to the Hollow:** Whisper a dead person’s name into an empty chair. Gain +1 Effect when invoking guest-right this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Pale Shepherd.

Hearth Magic

The Aelaerem weave their power through careful observance and small courtesies. Their magic lies not in grand gestures but in the precise attention to thresholds, seasons, and the proper ordering of things. Red thread binds more than wounds—it ties names to places, promises to people, and the living to the Hollow that walks beneath their feet. To offend a hedge-witch is to invite the Neighbors’ attention; to earn an elder’s blessing is to walk with the earth’s favor.

Thematic SB Spend Table**Minor Complications (1 SB)**

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **wardens or hedge-keepers**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **watch-geese or mummers**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or the Hollow**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable light**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Orchard reeve or lantern-warden** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **fog or threshold shift**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **scarecrow or Hollow spirit** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **wold-wardens, mummers, or Neighbors** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **taboo broken/geese turn/Hollow stirs**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Apple-Matron, Thresher-King, or Pale Shepherd** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **fog thickens/barrow opens/Hollow walks**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Aelaerem (Hearth & Hollow):** Quiet bells toll for no reason; red thread appears tied to your belongings; watch-geese honk warnings in the night.
- **Aelaerem (Threshold Magic):** A door you passed through earlier now leads somewhere else; your shadow walks behind you instead of beside you.
- **Aelaerem (Folk Customs):** You forget a crucial local taboo and offend the Neighbors; small things begin to go wrong—milk sours, knots loosen, a child points at the empty chair.

Boss Archetypes in Aelaerem

- **The Scarecrow Regent (Omen/Threshold)** — A hedge-raised guardian wearing twelve charms and one wrong knot. *Phases:* Stare of the Lane → Scare the Crows → Harvest of Faces. *Cracks:* a **Guest-Loaf** offered to its post; a **Mummers' License** to wear a mask it cannot read.
- **The Hollow Bride (Otherworld/Hospitality)** — A Neighbor wearing a borrowed name and wedding veil. *Phases:* Invitation Drifted → Feast of Shadows → Ninth Cup Poured. *Cracks:* a **Shepherd's Whistle** to call the dogs that guard the threshold; a **Lantern-Writ** to see her true face.
- **Lantern Bailiff of the Moot (Justice/Order)** — Enforcer of hedge-law with warrant-nails and bell-keys. *Phases:* Lantern Law → Midnight Moot → Binding Geas. *Cracks:* a **Cider-Mark** to buy a night's silence; a **Moot Oak bench** to appeal his ruling.
- **Beekeeper of Winter Church (Sacred/Whisper)** — Keeper of cold honey and sleeping hymns. *Phases:* Swarm Omen → Waxed Vow → Memory Tithe. *Cracks:* a **Bee-Queen Share** to call her swarm to heel; a **Lantern** lit from a winter church candle.

Faction Entanglements

- **Wold-Wardens:** Honor hedge-law (count stiles, turn stones inward) or suffer +1 SB on each night march; bringing steel disputes to the Moot Oak reduces the next travel DV by 1.
- **Mummers' Companies:** Travel under mask grants advantage crossing parochial borders; anger them (perform out of season) and village gates close at dusk (Position –).
- **Lantern-Wardens:** Donate oil or HEAL lamps to earn an escort marker; ignore a lit-lane and pay a “darkness toll” (first Stealth/Scout roll each night suffers –1 die).
- **Apple-Matron Circles:** Feast-days open barns and purses; snub an invitation and local prices double until amends are made.

- **Neighbors (quiet powers):** Leave butter at cup-marks to cancel the first supernatural SB this leg; break taboo and the Hollow stirs (add a *Hollow Attention* tick).

Cross-Regional Ties

- **Aeler Soft-Power:** Red-thread guest-right and courtesies are fashionable among Aeler houses; reputation for keeping hearth-law grants +1 die to parley with Aeler stewards and toll-clerks.
- **Kahfagian Sea-Lanes:** Beeswax, cider-brandy, and wool ride river-to-coast. Storm seasons push Kahfagian factors inland—good silver, stricter contracts.
- **Way of Silk Spurs:** Caravans detour across the downs for night-safe lanes under lantern law; counterfeit guest-loaf tokens discovered here echo as distrust along Silk waystations (Social DV +1 until cleared).
- **Valewood Fallout (North):** Moon-sap and dream pollen drift on certain winds: chalk mazes misalign, barrow-whispers grow bold. When *Valewood Weather* is in effect, the first night omen is always true (good or ill).

Encounter Seeds (Quick Hooks)

- **The Hollow Bride’s Invitation:** A wedding invitation arrives at the inn. The bride is not from any village on the map. The groom has not been seen in a week. The ninth chair at the feast is already occupied.
- **The Scarecrow’s Harvest:** Crows are building a nest on the scarecrow’s shoulder. Inside the nest is a key. The key opens a door that should not exist.
- **The Beekeeper’s Tithe:** The winter church’s bees have stopped producing honey. They are producing wax effigies of the PCs. The beekeeper wants to know why.

Chapter 19

The Valewood

Empire Under Leaves. Beneath the canopy of the Valewood lie the bones of a Lethai empire whose name is forgotten. Star-roads crack and phase between worlds, and the air hums with half-remembered songs of magic. Fae courts linger in clearings that shift with moonlight, beast-kin patrol moss-choked cairns, and echoes of imperial shades still march on vanished streets.

19.1 Valewood — “Empire Under Leaves”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The forest remembers. Speak truth, step lightly, and never eat the fruit of a tree with a face.*

Hazel Queen (Elite): “The forest here remembers empires that crumbled to dust, and its laws are older than your kingdoms. To walk these paths is to enter into covenant with powers that measure time in seasons, not years.”

Pathweaver (Commoner): “The woods here got a mind of their own – they’ll lead you where you need to go if you ask right, but they’ll just as soon lose you if you’re carrying ill intent. Best know which is which before you wander off the path.”

Genre / Mood: Dark forest, fey remnant, imperial echo, folk horror.

Starting Location: A moss-covered amphitheatre where roots crawl through marble benches and owls whisper verdicts to the wind. An Owl-Sister speaks in riddles: “The Lethai-ar stir. The paths remember your true name. Speak it into the hollow of this stone, or the forest will learn it from your footsteps.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Valewood is older than kingdoms, older than the maps that skirt its borders. Beneath its canopy lie the bones of a Lethai empire whose name is forgotten, its towers swallowed by vine and root, its star-roads cracked and phasing between worlds. The air hums with half-remembered songs of magic, and the ruins bleed their mysteries into root and stream. Fae courts linger in clearings that shift with moonlight, beast-kin patrol moss-choked cairns, and echoes of imperial shades still march patrols on vanished streets. To walk the Valewood is to risk being claimed by it: as guest, prey, heir—or trespasser.

What you notice first: The smell of wet moss and old stone. The way the light filters through leaves like stained glass. The silence that falls when you speak a name too loudly.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never eat the fruit of a tree that has a face. The forest does not forget its debtors, and the first bite is always the price of admission.

Regional Mood: Leaves, Oaths, and Echoes

Here, the past is not past—it phases in and out like moonlight on water. The Lethai-ar who remain are not conquerors but custodians, tending to laws written before the first human kingdom rose. The fae courts of Hazel and Alder play their endless games of courtesy and obligation, and the beast-kin speak in parliaments where every vote is a scent. Imperial shades march through walls that no longer exist, and the star-roads hum with geometries that twist the unwary into yesterday. The Valewood does not forgive arrogance. It expects humility, patience, and the willingness to trade a piece of yourself for safe passage.

Prominent NPCs of the Valewood

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Queen Amalthea	Hazel Queen, sovereign of the Hazel Court	Preserve the old pacts and keep the empire from waking	She has never spoken a lie. She has never needed to.
King Thorn	Alder King, ruler of the Twilit Court	Collect debts, old and new, and expand the forest's reach	His crown is a noose of thorns. He wears it proudly.
Pathweaver Sila	Lethai-ar guide (commoner exemplar)	Knot safe routes and keep the star-roads from bleeding	Her cord has eight knots; the ninth is the one she never ties.
Bramble	Fox-headed courier of the beast-kin	Deliver messages that cannot be written	The price is always a secret, and the secret is always bitter.

The Huntsman	Antlered hunter of the Moonlit Ride	Claim those who break the forest’s laws	His face is a stag’s skull; his voice is the wind in the leaves.
Shardwright Kael	Artisan who repairs the star-roads	Wake the ancient ways before they fade forever	Her chisel is a tooth from the first dragon. She stole it.

Names of the Valewood

Inspired by the old Lethai language and the fae courts: flowing vowels, soft consonants, and names that feel like they belong to a forgotten song.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Caelith	Amalthea	Thornweave	<i>the Green</i>
Eryndor	Sila	Starfoot	<i>Oath-Woven</i>
Kael	Liriel	Hawthorn	<i>the Unseen</i>
Oren	Vesper	Silverbough	<i>Hollow-Tongue</i>
Riven	Fenn	Mossglen	<i>the Last</i>
Thorn	Myrin	Gloaming	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

(Phasing Ruin/Star-Road/Living Stone) Star-road shard with pale flagstones that hum when trod in sequence; rooted amphitheatre with moss-seats remembering speeches.

Spades — Places

2. **Star-Road Shard** — Pale flagstones hum when trod in sequence; a path between worlds. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The sequence is always incomplete. The missing step is the one you hesitate to take.*
3. **Rooted Amphitheatre** — Moss-seats remember speeches not yet given; a stage for fate. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *Sit in the high seat, and the roots will ask you a question. Answer wrong, and you may never stand.*
4. **Moon-Cistern** — Reflecting sky that isn’t tonight’s; water as a mirror of truth. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[TRUTH]’ *The reflection shows what you lost, not what you carry. Look away before it names you.*
5. **Glyphed Bridge** — Across a dry stream; glyphs glow when lies pass; truth as a toll. ‘[TRUTH]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The bridge has no railings. Liars fall—into the stream, or into memory.*
6. **Glassleaf Gallery** — Boughs grown into panes, dust like constellations; beauty as a barrier. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The dust is crushed star-road. Breathe it, and you will dream of the empire’s fall.*
7. **Hollow Aqueduct** — Water runs uphill if the song is right; magic in the melody. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The song has eight verses. The ninth is the silence that follows.*

8. **Calendar Grove** — Standing-trees aligned to solstices; one trunk is stone; time as architecture. ‘[RITUAL]’ *The stone tree bleeds sap once a year. Collect it, and the forest owes you a season.*
9. **Unfound Arcade** — Arches appear at dusk, vanish at dawn; reality as a schedule. ‘[MYSTERY]’ *The arches have names—Carved on the inside. You must walk through to read them.*
10. **Breathing City** — Vine-choked streets shift on the hour; a ruin as a living thing. ‘[DUNGEON]’ *The vines pulse with a slow heartbeat. The city is sleeping, not dead.*
- J **Amber Ziggurat** — Caught mid-construction for a thousand years; time as an artifact. ‘[LEGEND]’ *The workers are statues of amber. Their eyes follow you.*
- Q **Ivory Observatory** — Brass orrery tracks two lost moons; the sky as memory. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The moons are not in any sky you know. One of them is yours.*
- K **Throne-Bower** — Living alder and argent wire; the seat of forgotten power. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *Sit here, and the forest will crown you—or crush you. You won’t know which until the leaves settle.*
- A **Valeheart Spire** — The empire’s axle; stairs that end where they began. ‘[LEGEND]’ *The spire has no top. It has only a center. Finding it is the journey.*

(**Lethai-ar/Fae/Beast-kin**) Pathweaver who knots safe routes into cord; fox-headed courier with a promise braided into its tail.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Pathweaver** — Lethai-ar guide who knots safe routes into cord; navigation as community. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *Her cord has eight knots. The ninth is the one she never ties.*
3. **Fox-Courier** — Promise braided into its tail; messages as living things. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *It will deliver anything—for a price. The price is always a secret.*
4. **Owl-Sister** — Pupils show yesterday; her hands show yours; sight as prophecy. ‘[MAGIC]’ *She never blinks. If she does, the future has changed.*
5. **Antler-Hunter** — Sworn to keep the cities sleeping; a guardian of rest. ‘[COMBAT]’ *His spear is a sharpened root. It grows back when broken.*
6. **Moss-Scribe** — Writes deeds in lichen, reads stone like vellum; law as growth. ‘[LAW]’ *Her ink is rainwater and regret. The words fade when the promise is kept.*
7. **Lark-Keeper** — Caged bird sings warnings strangers can’t hear; danger as song. ‘[OMEN]’ *The lark’s song is a map. Learn it, and you can walk anywhere—once.*
8. **Green Neighbor** — Fae courtier wearing a borrowed smile and boots; hospitality as a trap. ‘[FAE]’ *Never accept a gift from a Green Neighbor. It’s never a gift.*
9. **Warden-Coterie** — Beast-kin (badger, stag, lynx); one law: no digging deep. ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *They speak in growls and gestures. The lynx is the one who remembers faces.*
10. **Echo-Legionary** — Imperial shade bound to a patrol that never ends; duty as a curse. ‘[DEATH]’ *Its sword passes through stone but not through flesh. Run, don’t fight.*
- J **Shardwright** — Ancient artisan who wakes star-road with a chisel; craft as resurrection. ‘[CRAFT]’ *Her chisel is a tooth from the first dragon. She stole it.*

- Q **Hazel Queen** — Lethai-ar sovereign in leaf and law; wisdom as authority. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
She has never spoken a lie. She has never needed to.
- K **Alder King** — Twilit Court sovereign in shadow and debt; power as obligation. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
His crown is a noose of thorns. He wears it proudly.
- A **The Huntsman** — Antlers of moonlight; shortcuts owe him; the path as price. ‘[DEATH]’
 ‘[TRAVEL]’ *His face is a stag’s skull. His voice is the wind in the leaves.*

(Glamour/Ward-Trap/Imperial Residue) Sweet wind nudges landmarks hedge-width—enough to matter; path reverses—footprints vote to go elsewhere.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Sweet Wind** — Nudges landmarks hedge-width—enough to matter; navigation as deception. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[TRICK]’ *The wind smells of honey and lies. Do not trust your nose.*
3. **Path Reversal** — Footprints vote to go elsewhere; direction as democracy. ‘[MAGIC]’ *Your tracks point the way you came—even when you haven’t turned.*
4. **Ward-Trap** — Ancient security treats you as yesterday’s invader; the past as prison. ‘[TRAP]’ *The glyphs were set by a dead queen. She still enforces her grudges.*
5. **Oath-Magnet** — Spoken promises stick and reshape plans; word as binding magic. ‘[OATH]’ *Every “I will” becomes a knot. Every “I won’t” becomes a chain.*

Oath-Magnet Mechanics

When a character makes a promise in the Valewood, the GM creates a **Promise Clock [4]**. Each time the character acts against that promise (or fails to act in its favour), tick the clock. When it fills, the forest extracts a toll: 1 Fatigue, a lost memory (erase a minor fact or face), or a minor geas (the GM chooses). Breaking a promise intentionally (not through failure) instantly ticks the clock twice.

6. **Geas Catch** — A careless word triggers a task that names itself; speech as summoning. ‘[OATH]’ *You said “if only.” Now the forest has heard you.*
7. **City Phase** — Streets rotate; the exit becomes a balcony; space as puzzle. ‘[DUNGEON]’ *The city breathes. You are in its lungs.*
8. **Name-Theft** — Something learns your true name’s edges; the tests begin. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *First, you forget a minor debt. Then a friend’s face. Then your own.*

Name-Theft Mechanics

When **Name-Theft** occurs, the GM secretly records one piece of the target’s identity (a memory, a bond, a talent name). The target suffers –1 die on any roll that would rely on that piece until it is restored by a quest or a bargain with the thief (often a fae or shade).

9. **Ring Claim** — A circle names you host; feeding guests becomes law. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *The mushrooms are listening. They will remember what you serve.*

10. **Mirror Rain** — Leaf-drips replay choices you didn't make; the past as echo. '[MAGIC]' *The rain shows you a path you refused. Now it offers it again—with interest.*
- J **Redcaps Abroad** — Hats wet, boots quick, courtesies thin; violence as hospitality. '[COMBAT]' '[FAE]' *They will ask for a kiss or a coin. Refuse, and they take both.*
- Q **Court Tithe** — Truth, song, or memory you'd miss; the price as sacrifice. '[SOCIAL]' '[OATH]' *The courtier opens its hand. What you place there is never returned.*
- K **Must of Boughs** — Green banners rise; travel becomes trespass. '[WAR]' '[FEAR]' *The boughs bear old sigils. The war they remember ended a thousand years ago.*
- A **Empire Wakes** — A district aligns; doors open, guardians open farther. '[APOCALYPSE]' *The shades have orders. You are the target.*

(Charm/Key/Truce-Bough) Way-cord knot points to the true next turn; dew-mirror shows a thing as it is, not as it is sung.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Way-Cord** — A knot points to the true next turn (once); navigation as a gift. '[TRAVEL]' *The knot is a breath tied in silk. Untie it to find your way—or to lose it forever.*
3. **Dew-Mirror** — See a thing as it is, not as it is sung, for one scene; truth as a tool. '[TRUTH]' *The mirror is a drop of water on a leaf. It dries when the lie dies.*
4. **Hazel Token** — Lawful crossing of a warded hedge without snag; permission as paper. '[TRAVEL]' *The token is a hazelnut. Crack it open; the kernel is your password.*
5. **Honey-Right** — Eat and speak safely at any bee-stone ring; hospitality as law. '[SOCIAL]' *The honey is golden. Taste it, and the bees will know you as a guest—once.*
6. **Name-Bead** — A kept promise warms; a broken one chills and glows; an oath as a magic item. '[OATH]' *The bead is warm in your palm. If it cools, you have forgotten someone.*
7. **Wind-Veil** — Mute a sweet wind's lies for a short walk; truth as protection. '[WEATHER]' *The veil is a scrap of silk. Breathe through it, and the wind cannot speak.*
8. **City-Shard** — Wake one gate or stair in a phasing ruin; a key as a catalyst. '[MAGIC]' *The shard is a piece of a star-road. Hold it to the lock, and the ruin answers.*
9. **Truce-Bough** — Hunt, cut, or camp without offense in a named copse; peace as a branch. '[SOCIAL]' *The bough is green. Plant it in the ground, and the forest will not harm you—or help you.*
10. **Oathsap** — Seal a pact that even echoes respect; a promise as a binding force. '[OATH]' *The sap is warm. Drink it, and your words become stone—for good or ill.*
- J **Shardwright's Favor** — Repair or light a length of star-road; craft as power. '[CRAFT]' *The favor is a chip of amber. The Shardwright will come when you break it.*
- Q **Hazel Audience** — One whisper exits as policy; word as law. '[AUTHORITY]' *The audience is a leaf. Speak into its spine, and the Hazel Queen will listen—once.*
- K **Alder Writ** — Levies defer, wardens guide, scribes stop arguing; authority as writ. '[AUTHORITY]' *The writ is a thorn. Carry it in your boot, and the Alder King's debtors will make way.*
- A **Valeheart Clause** — A temporary exception to any local rule, spoken in leaves. '[LEGEND]' *The clause is a rustle. The forest will pretend it didn't hear—but it will remember.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (charms/keys/passes) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- Empire Echo: when a J/Q/K is the highest rank in your seed, add one visible relic-logic (floating stairs, singing locks, patrol shades).
- If any A appears, echo **leaf and light** motifs—paths that remember, leaves that whisper, light that moves like water.

Additional Features

- **Forest Claims:** Any oath, bargain, or gift exchanged binds with more weight. Once per session, a spoken promise becomes magically enforceable: breaking it creates 1d4 SB and echoes through scenes.
- **Ruins Awaken:** If you linger at an ancient site, roll or draw to see which mechanism stirs. May grant guidance (lit star-road, a memory shown) or danger (patrol shades, collapsing glyphs).
- **Court Interference:** Encounters with fae or beast-kin are never neutral. Once per session, the GM may convert a Diamond into a demand for hospitality, tribute, or alliance—shifting the expedition’s tone.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Unseen Court** — The Witness. *A parliament of silent roots that remembers every broken promise.*
 - **The Root-King** — The Alder King (local aspect). *Debt that grows like a vine, choked by its own leaves.*
 - **The Star-Weaver** — The Ninth. *The missing thread in every star-road, the silence after the song.*
 - **The Green Saint** — Oath of Flame & Light (syncretic). *A martyr who fed her own name to the Hollow to seal a breach.*

Forest Mood (d6 per scene)

Forest Mood Table

1. **Hazel’s Favour** – Paths open willingly. +1 die to navigation rolls this scene.
2. **Alder’s Hunger** – Debts are called. Someone in the scene must offer a memory or service to proceed.
3. **Empire Wakes** – A patrol of imperial shades marches through. Avoid or pay a toll (1 Fatigue or a secret).
4. **Beast-kin Moot** – Animals gather and watch. They will not attack unless provoked, but they remember faces.
5. **Sweet Wind** – All navigation rolls suffer –1 die; landmarks shift subtly.
6. **Green Gate Breath** – A threshold appears. Crossing it leads to a different part of the forest (or a different time).

Star-Road Discovery (d6)

When the party encounters a star-road shard or attempts to wake a segment, roll on this table for an additional feature:

1. **Singing Stones** – The flagstones hum a tune. Anyone who sings along gains +1 die on the next roll.
2. **Echo of an Emperor** – A ghostly figure appears and asks a riddle. A correct answer grants a **City-Shard**.
3. **Fractured Timeline** – The road shows a glimpse of the future (1d6 scenes ahead). The GM must answer one yes/no question truthfully.
4. **Ward-Trap** – The segment is booby-trapped. Trigger a **Ward-Trap** complication (see Clubs).
5. **Shardwright's Cache** – Hidden nearby is a **Shardwright's Favor** (Diamond) or a rare component (e.g., amber shard).
6. **The Ninth Step** – The sequence has a hidden ninth stone. Stepping on it teleports the party to a **Valeheart Spire** or a court audience.

Beast-kin Traits (for NPCs or PC ancestry)

Beast-kin are not a single species but a loose alliance of animal-aspected beings. Use these traits for quick NPCs or optional player characters.

Beast-kin Traits

- **Scent Memory:** +1 die to track a creature you have smelled before.
- **Parliament Oath:** Once per session, you may invoke the beast-kin moot to ask a local animal one simple question (the GM answers truthfully).
- **Claw or Fang:** Unarmed strikes deal Harm 1 and count as Light weapons.
- **Optional:** Choose a lineage:
 - *Stag:* +1 die to resist being moved or knocked prone.
 - *Lynx:* +1 die to stealth in forest terrain.
 - *Badger:* You may burrow through loose earth at half speed.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Genesis Vats (The Clockwork Monad):** Deep beneath the Amber Ziggurat lie the empire's failed laboratories. Here, the Lethai ancients combined elf and beast, hoping to create the perfect guardian. The vats still hum, and the beast-kin who survived do not speak of what they saw. The Shardwrights say the Monad's pressure is still optimising the old designs, and that one day the vats will open again.
- **The Parliament of Claw and Fur (The Savage Heart):** The beast-kin are not savages. They hold a moot once every season, deep in a clearing that no star-road touches. Their laws are carved in scent and scar, and their judgments are final. The Savage Heart speaks through their eldest, but it does not command—it suggests. Outsiders who attend the moot must bring a true name of a foe and leave it on the speaking stone. Those who lie are given fur and four legs, and are hunted at the next moon.

- **Saint Oren of the Unfinished Star (The Ninth):** A Lethai-ar astronomer who calculated the exact angle at which the empire’s star-roads would collapse. He was erased from the imperial records, but his ghost still walks the Ivory Observatory, tracing equations in starlight. Those who find him may ask one question about the forest’s hidden geometry. The answer is always a single number, and that number is a debt.
- **The Grey Pilgrims (The Traveler):** A wandering order of Lethai-ar who maintain the old way-cords. They wear grey cloaks woven from mist and speak only in riddles. It is said that if you give a Grey Pilgrim a lock of your hair, they will knot it into your way-cord, and you will never be lost in the Valewood again—but you will also never find a place you truly wish to leave.
- **The Daughters of the Cord (The Bitter Root):** A renegade Sister hides among the moss-scribes of the Rooted Amphitheatre, trying to untie her own cord from the Hazel Queen’s ledger. She claims the queen’s hospitality is a cage, and that the forest’s memory is a trap. The Hazel Queen has not corrected her; she only smiles, and the roots grow tighter each night.
- **The Ninth:** In any Valewood scene, the ninth leaf to fall from a tree will land pointing to a hidden threshold. The wise catch it—or pretend they didn’t see. Those who follow the leaf’s direction find a place that was not there a moment ago, and something old waits inside.

Valewood Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Roots:** Crumble a crust at the base of a standing stone. Ignore the first *Sweet Wind* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Cord:** Tie a single knot in a way-cord. Cancel *Oath-Magnet* or take –1 die on your next promise (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Cistern:** Whisper a dead enemy’s name into the Moon-Cistern. Gain +1 Effect when evading fae this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Alder King. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Patronage & Power

In the Valewood, power flows through ancient magic, forgotten oaths, and the delicate balance between guest and host. The Lethai-ar maintain influence through their knowledge of paths and ruins, while the fae courts wield power through hospitality and geas. Beast-kin serve as guardians of the deeper mysteries, and the echoes of the empire still patrol their eternal rounds, enforcing laws written in starlight and stone.

For the GM: Patronage in the Valewood revolves around hospitality, knowledge, and the careful navigation of ancient laws. Rewards often take the form of charms, keys, or safe passage that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, mirrors, cords) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival courts issue conflicting protections, forcing players to choose whose favour matters more.
- Use the ruins, groves, and star-roads as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of ancient customs determines success.

In the Valewood, your word is your world, and your world determines whether you walk as a guest or a ghost.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **wardens or fae scouts**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **echo-legionaries or beast-kin**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or imperial shades**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable phase**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Pathweaver or moss-scribe** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **path reversal or city phase**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **redcap band or patrol shade** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **fae courtiers, beast-kin, or imperial echoes** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **geas triggers/ruin awakens/court interferes**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Hazel Queen, Alder King, or Huntsman** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **city phases/paths shift/empire wakes**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Valewood (Magic Paths):** Routes rearrange without warning, bridges appear mid-step, directions become riddles.
- **Valewood (Fae Law):** Promises bind mid-speech, gifts carry hidden costs, hospitality turns to obligation.
- **Valewood (Imperial Echoes):** Patrols march through walls, ancient mechanisms activate, past and present blur.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Huntsman of Shortcuts (antlers of moonlight)** — *Phases*: Owe the Cut → Step Across → Tally the Tread. *Cracks*: present a **Truce-Bough** to halt pursuit; a **Way-Cord** cancels *Step Across* once.
- **Redcap Captain Rill (hat never dries)** — *Phases*: Hospitality Turned → Knee the Truth → Boot-Hook. *Cracks*: **Honey-Right** reverses one phase; **Dew-Mirror** exposes his “host right.”
- **Echo Centurion of the XIII Star-Road (bronze mask)** — *Phases*: Reform the Line → Juridical Recall → Standard Rekindled. *Cracks*: a **City-Shard** lets you counter-order once; a **Moss-Scribe** ruling cancels *Juridical Recall*.
- **Shardwright Unmended (glassy chisels)** — *Phases*: Cut the Clock → Wrong Stone → Wake the Segment. *Cracks*: offer **Oathsap** to bind a repair oath; **Shardwright’s Favor** flips *Wrong Stone*.
- **The Hazel Advocate (mask of living bark)** — *Phases*: Measure the Word → Prune the Lie → Court Silence. *Cracks*: **Hazel Token** grants speaking rights; **Oathsap** lets you safely retract one bound clause.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- **Glyphed Bridge Ordeal** — Speak a hard truth to pass dry; lie, and the bridge demands a memory tithe (mark *Name Leverage* +1, gain *Bridge’s Favor* only if confessed).
- **Moon-Cistern Vigil** — Watch someone else’s sky until the owl calls; success grants a single **Dew-Mirror** charge; failure spawns **Mirror Rain**.
- **Valeheart Spiral** — Climb stairs that return to start; map with verse, gift, count, listen (all four once) to unlock a *Between-Places* shortcut.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Name Economy (true-name pressure)**:
 - Each PC has *Name Facets*: **Called-Name** (common), **Given-Name** (trusted), **True-Edge** (dangerous).
 - When a foe or court learns a deeper facet, mark *Name Leverage* [3]. At 3, they may compel one precise action or forbid one path unless countered by a $\Diamond$ or **Oathsap**.
 - You may trade a shallower facet to erase 1 tick from *Name Leverage* but gain *Rumor Tail* condition until scene end.
- **Hospitality Ledger (guest/host law)**:
 - When *Honey-Right* or *Truce-Bough* is invoked, set a 3-step *Table Owed* clock for the host and a 3-step *Courtesy Owed* for the guest.
 - Ticking your clock grants +1d to social tests with that party; overpaying (4+) converts 1 tick into a portable *Favor Twig* (spend for +1 Position later).
 - Breaking either clock spawns **Ring Claim** or **Oath-Magnet** at the keeper’s option.
- **Path-Logic Mini-game (finding the true way)**:
 - Two opposed clocks per journey: *True Way* vs *Forest Has You* (size by highest rank in the seed).

- Each leg, pick an *Approach*: **Rhyme** (speak a pattern), **Count** (steps/time), **Gift** (leave a token), **Listen** (ambient omen).
- Edge: Rhyme→Gift (courtesies bind), Gift→Count (the land answers), Count→Listen (timing frames the omen), Listen→Rhyme (echo feeds verse).
- Spend a **Way-Cord** to flip a failed leg; spend a **Wind-Veil** to ignore **Sweet Wind** once.
- **Truth Mechanics (seeing through glamour):**
 - **Dew-Mirror** reveals one *Unkind Fact* in the scene; naming it aloud gives +1 Effect but ticks **Court Tithe** +1.
 - **Glyphed Bridge** judges the next lie uttered; if you pass speaking truth, gain *Bridge's Favor* (+1 Position on crossings hereafter). If you lie, mark **Name-Theft** +1.
- **Star-Road Procedure (phasing traversal):**
 - To wake a segment: meet two of three—*Proper Footfall* (count/pattern), *Shard Key* (City-Shard, Shardwright help), *Witness* (owl, echo-legionary, or courtier).
 - Success grants *Between-Places*: one safe shortcut and one *Echo Fee* (memory, song, or small timeline bruise chosen by the GM).
 - On a miss, spawn **Ward-Trap** or **City Phase**.
- **Court Etiquette (Hazel vs Alder):**
 - **Hazel Audience**: pays in *precision*—exact words, measured gifts. +1d when you cite prior custom or present a **Moss-Scribe** ruling.
 - **Alder Writ**: pays in *obligation*—future tasks, debts. +1 Effect when you promise service; tick **Oath-Magnet** +1.
- **Start-of-Scene Omens (1d6):**
 1. *Leaf-Whisper*: first Listen/Study gets +1d; first boast draws **Geas Catch**.
 2. *Antler Shadow*: the Huntsman watches—shortcuts improve; hiding worsens.
 3. *Mirror Drip*: **Dew-Mirror** free use but **Court Tithe** starts at 1.
 4. *Root Push*: terrain shifts in your favor once; buildings dislike you (locks complicate).
 5. *Bird Parliament*: a rumor arrives true; one plan becomes public knowledge.
 6. *Star-Tingle*: star-road easier (+1d to wake) but every $\diamond$ hereafter risks **Ward-Trap** on 1~2.
- **Plug-in SB Conversions (Valewood Flavor):**
 - 1 SB → *Sweet Wind Shift*: reposition an approach vector; –1d unless you adjust method (Rhyme/Count/Gift/Listen).
 - 2 SB → *Obligate Courtesy*: immediate small gift or truth required; refuse and tick *Name Leverage* +1.
 - 3+ SB → *Empire Echo*: add a patrolling **Echo-Legionary** cohort or activate a dormant mechanism that reframes the scene.
- **Reputation Echoes:**
 - *Guest-Faithful*: once/session, downgrade **Ring Claim** to simple hospitality; the next refused invitation spawns **Oath-Magnet**.
 - *Path-Favored*: +1 Position on *Path-Logic* legs; any shortcut taken owes a *token or tale*.
 - *Truth-Bearer*: +1d with the Hazel court when presenting facts; –1d with the Alder court

when declining obligation.

- **Quick Cross-Region Hooks:**

- *Kahfagia Lanes* ↔ *Star-Roads*: a **Mirror Warrant** can stand in for a **Shard Key** once.
- *Mistlands Bells* ↔ *Path-Logic*: paying **Ward-Salt** counts as the *Gift* approach with +1d.
- *Aelinnel Math* ↔ *Proper Footfall: Counting Etiquette* grants +1 Position on the **Star-Road Procedure**.

Artifacts of the Valewood

The Valewood remembers not only oaths and names but also the tools of those who came before. Some artifacts are cursed by the empire’s fall; others are blessed by the forest’s slow patience. Each artifact carries its own burden—a fragment of will that accumulates Obligation as it is used. When the Obligation fills, the artifact demands a price, just as a Patron does.

Artifact Obligation Rules

- An artifact has an **Obligation Capacity** equal to the wielder’s **Spirit** (or a fixed number, as noted). Mark Obligation each time a Rite is invoked.
- When Obligation exceeds Capacity, the wielder marks 1 Fatigue per extra segment (as per standard Obligation overflow).
- When the artifact’s Obligation clock reaches double its Capacity, it **demand**s a price (see each artifact’s “Demand”). Refusing the demand may cause the artifact to become *Compromised* (unusable until a quest is completed) or to inflict a permanent curse.
- Obligation can be cleared through acts of service aligned with the artifact’s nature (e.g., protecting a grove, telling a forgotten truth, shedding your own blood).
- Bound by Obligation: An artifact cannot be permanently discarded or destroyed while you owe it Obligation. If you deliberately abandon it (or attempt to destroy it by mundane means), it reappears beside you at the next dawn, and you mark +1 Obligation. This penalty applies only once per artifact; subsequent attempts to abandon it cause the artifact to become Compromised – it still reappears, but its Rites cannot be invoked until you perform a minor act of devotion (GM’s choice). An artifact can be legitimately transferred to another willing creature, clearing your Obligation; the new owner inherits any remaining Obligation. An artifact can be permanently destroyed only by a specific method (e.g., a star-road shard, a dragon’s tooth, or the Hazel Queen’s permission), which typically requires a quest.

Artifact	Description	Rites (Abilities)	Demand (Obligation 2×Cap)
<i>Echo’s Lament</i>	A silver hand-bell with a cracked clapper. When rung, it repeats the last words spoken at the site of an imperial execution.	Rite of the Last Echo (Low) – Ask one question about a death that occurred within Near range; the bell answers with a whisper. Mark +1 Obligation.	The wielder must pronounce a true name of someone they have wronged, aloud and unasked, before the next full moon.

<i>Thorn-Fang</i>	A dagger carved from a single hawthorn root, its edge weeping sap that smells of iron and honey.	Rite of the Unhealing Prick (Low) – On a successful melee attack, the wound bleeds for 1 additional Fatigue per scene (non-stacking). Mark +1 Obligation.	The dagger demands a drop of the wielder's own blood before each dawn; if refused, it turns on its owner (next attack targets self).
<i>Glassleaf Lantern</i>	A lantern whose panes are made of petrified leaves. It burns without oil, casting light that reveals only things that are lost.	Rite of the Unfound Path (Standard) – Once per scene, the lantern illuminates a hidden threshold or a forgotten memory in the area. Gain +2 dice to Investigation or Navigation for that task. Mark +2 Obligation.	The lantern demands to be left at a crossroads at midnight. If not, it will guide the wielder into a dead end (next travel leg automatically fails).
<i>Cord of Eight Knots</i>	A finger-thick rope of braided grey wool, with eight tight knots. The ninth knot is missing.	Rite of the Unbroken Promise (Low) – Tie the cord around a willing creature's wrist; until untied, that creature cannot willingly break a spoken oath. Mark +1 Obligation.	The cord demands a ninth knot, which must be tied in a strand of hair from someone who has broken a vow. Untying any existing knot costs 1 Fatigue.
<i>Alder King's Tooth</i>	A black, curling tooth set in a copper ring. When worn, it whispers the debts of those nearby.	Rite of Debt-Sense (Low) – Concentrate for a moment; learn the single greatest debt owed by a creature you can see (in vague terms: "a life," "a stolen heirloom"). Mark +1 Obligation.	The tooth demands that you collect a minor debt (a few coins, a favour) from someone weaker than you before sunset. If you refuse, it begins listing your own debts aloud.
<i>Shardwright's Mallet</i>	A stone hammer with a handle of petrified wood. One side is smooth (to repair), the other rough (to break).	Rite of the Broken Seal (Standard) – Strike a phasing ruin or star-road shard. Either temporarily stabilise it (open a safe passage) or shatter it (destroy the path, cause a Ward-Trap). Mark +2 Obligation.	The mallet demands that you break something precious to you (a gift, a memento, a tool) and leave the pieces on a star-road.

<i>Mirror of Unfinished Faces</i>	A hand mirror with a silvered surface that shows not your reflection but a version of you who made a different choice.	Rite of the Other Self (Low) – Gaze into the mirror; gain +1 die on your next roll that involves a decision (the other self’s memory guides you). Mark +1 Obligation.	The mirror demands that you speak aloud the choice you regret most, to a stranger, within a day. If you refuse, the other self begins to appear in reflections, whispering doubts.
<i>Whispering Horn</i>	A curved horn of amber, cracked along one side. When blown, it sounds like the roar of a forgotten beast.	Rite of the Imperial Hunt (Standard) – Once per session, blow the horn to summon a spectral pack of hounds that track a designated target for one scene (grants +1 die to tracking and pursuit). Mark +2 Obligation.	The horn demands a hunt – you must chase and catch something (even a mouse) within the hour, or the spirits will hunt you instead (suffer Harm 1 from ethereal bites).
<i>Grave-Moss Cloak</i>	A heavy cloak woven from moss that grows only on imperial barrows. It is always damp and smells of rain.	Rite of the Walking Dead (Low) – Pull the hood up; for one scene, imperial shades treat you as one of their own (no attacks, you may pass patrols). Mark +1 Obligation per scene of use.	The cloak demands that you bury something that was never buried – a memory, a secret, a tooth. If you fail to do so before the next moon, it wraps itself around your throat in your sleep.
<i>Hazel Queen’s Comb</i>	A wooden comb carved with thorned vines. Running it through your hair removes tangles and also removes recent memories.	Rite of the Forgetful Stroke (Low) – Stroke the comb through your hair; erase one recent short-term memory (a face, a password, a few minutes of events). The memory is stored in the comb. Mark +1 Obligation.	The comb demands that you give a stored memory to a stranger without explanation. If you refuse, the comb begins to remove random memories each dawn (GM chooses).

Using Artifact Rites in Play

- Activating a Rite takes an action unless noted otherwise.
- Unlike Patron Rites, artifact Rites do not require a Codex or Familiar – only possession of the artifact.

- The GM may allow a wielder to clear artifact Obligation by performing a small act of devotion (e.g., for *Thorn-Fang*: cut a thorn bush; for *Glassleaf Lantern*: leave it in a moonbeam overnight).
- Artifacts can be stolen, lost, or destroyed. If an artifact is destroyed, any accumulated Obligation is cleared, but the destruction itself may trigger a final demand (GM's discretion).

Part V

The Spaces Between

Chapter 20

Ubral

The Stone Between Spears. Ubral is a land of upland mists, stone cairns, and clan oaths held tighter than iron. Law is written not in charters but in cattle, wergild, and songs. A guest's word can buy more than a sword, but one broken vow can spark a feud lasting generations. The dwarves of Khaz-Vurim guard their mountain steps with tolls and grim patience.

20.1 Ubral — “The Stone Between Spears”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The lowlands write their laws in ink. We carve ours in stone. The ink fades.*

Lady of Tor (Elite): “The stone here remembers every oath sworn upon it and every blood spilled in its shadow. To lead is to understand that the land itself is the true sovereign, and we are merely its stewards. The lowland kings write their claims on parchment. We write ours in cairns.”

Hearth-Aunt (Commoner): “Hospitality's a sacred thing in these hills – break bread at my table and you're family till the sun sets twice. But cross that trust and the very stones will remember your name. The Viterran tax men learned that. Their bones are under the sheepwalk now.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Ubral is a land of knife-edged ridges, mist-veiled glens, and stone cairns that mark the bones of old kings. Caught between the Aelerian mountains to the north and the lowland courts of Viterra to the south, its hills are scarred by centuries of raiding and reprisal. The clans speak a tongue thick with swallowed consonants and older grudges. They measure wealth in cattle, honour in wergild, and time in the generations since a Viterran banner last burned in the high passes. Exiled Aeler — dwarves who could not abide the Deep Vaults' suffocating tradition — have found refuge here, sharing their cunning with forge and toll-road, and their outcast bitterness with any clan willing to listen. The lowland lords of Viterra claim suzerainty over Ubral; the clans call those claims “ink on wet stone.” Every pass holds a watch-fire, every ford a memory of a battle, every hearth a knife waiting for a guest who stays too long.

What you notice first: The smell of peat smoke and wet granite. The constant lowing of cattle on distant hills. The way every threshold has a knife hidden nearby—for guests, not against them.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse a cup from a hearth-aunt. Hospitality is a contract sealed in salt and bread. Refusal is an insult that blood must answer.

Regional Mood: Cairn, Tor, and Oath

Here, the past is never past. Every cairn holds a voice, every burn scar on a hillside remembers a raid. Viterra has tried to conquer Ubral a dozen times; each attempt ended with supply lines cut by reivers, passes sealed by Aeler outcast engineers, and lowland knights lost in mist. The Utaran Imperium itself broke its leg on these hills and limped away. Now the clans watch the lowlands with patient eyes, and the exiled Aeler of Khaz-Vurim weigh every traveler's honesty on iron scales. A guest here is kin—until they prove otherwise. And kin here will die for you—or kill you over a stolen cow. The Lady of Tor rules by consent of the Council of Cairns, and the Council speaks for the dead as much as the living. Every nine years, a moot is called at Grey Tor to settle the great feud — a dispute between the two oldest clans that no one can remember the origin of, but everyone remembers the blood.

Starting Location: A Warden's Cairn at the fog line. Spears planted like grave markers, their shafts wrapped in faded clan ribbons. Hoofbeats echo in the valley below. The Hearth-Aunt offers a cup of small beer and a piece of oatcake. “The Wolf Road wakes,” she says. “Viterran tax men are asking which passes you used. The clans are counting your steps. Speak true, or the cairn will add your name to its tally. And mind the Aeler outcast in the smithy — he's been here forty years and still forgets to duck under doorframes.”

The Clans of Ubral (A Highland Primer)

The Great Houses of the Stone

Clan	Homeland	Feuds (Ancient)	Relationship with Vittera
Mac Tern	Grey Tor, upper Glen Tern	O’Creagh (blood feud)	Defiant; has never paid a lowland tax
O’Creagh	Black Broom Bog, eastern fells	Mac Tern, Mac Gowan	Wary; accepts bribes but no garrisons
Mac Gowan	Khaz-Vurim Steps, western passes	O’Creagh	Pragmatic; trades iron for lowland silver
O’Ruarc	Bride’s Causey, southern marches	None active	Collaborator; factor in Valora is a cousin
Mac Taggart	Three-Fires Ridge, northern heights	Mac Tern (old)	Neutral; sells beacon service to both sides
O’Cahan	Pass of Ashes, far west	None	Isolationist; speaks to lowlanders only through Aeler outcasts

The Mac Tern – O’Creagh feud has outlasted every lowland king. Each has a cairn for every generation lost. No wergild has ever settled it; no marriage has ever bridged it. The Lady of Tor keeps the peace by reminding both that a Viterran judge would hang them all.

Faction Clocks (Campaign Engines)

- **The Viterran Yoke [6]** – Lowland crown’s creeping control. Advances when a chief accepts a Viterran title, the party enforces lowland law, or a garrison is established. Retreats when a tax collector is sent home empty (or headless) or a claim is exposed as fraud. On full: a Queen’s Justiciar arrives with a circuit court; lowland law becomes default.
- **Tor’s Hold [6]** – Lady Morwen’s personal authority. Advances when she wins a moot, brokers peace, or gains an ally. Retreats when she loses a feud or a client clan defects. On 0: she is deposed; civil war follows.
- **Ancestral Grudge [8]** – The dead’s patience. Advances when oaths are broken, wergild unpaid, or cairns defiled. On full: a cairn-wight (see *Witnessed Prey*) rises and demands blood.
- **The Forge Ledger [6]** – Khaz-Vurim’s economic leverage. Advances when they secure toll contracts, sell iron, or gain a clan’s debt. On full: they can close a pass to enforce terms.
- **The Deep Road [8]** – Aeler outcasts’ secret ambition. Advances as they survey, bribe, or blast. On full: construction begins on a dwarf under-way that would destroy several clan cairns.
- **Mac Tern’s Revenge [6]** – Advances when Mac Tern suffers an insult or loses cattle. On full: they launch a devastating raid.
- **O’Creagh’s Patience [6]** – Retreats when O’Creagh is wronged. When it hits 0, they strike without warning.

Wergild Price Table (Quick Reference)

Blood Prices (in cattle, unless noted)

Insult (spoken)	1 cow
Stolen sheep	3 cows
Broken betrothal	5 cows + a horse
Wounding	7–15 cows (by severity)
Killing a clansman	21 cows + a public apology
Killing a chief	42 cows + a hostage

The Hollow's Cairn (Legendary Site)

Hidden in the high mist, a ninth stone circle with no clan markings. The dead do not vote here; they *listen*. Once per arc, a character may climb the cairn and ask one question of the Hollow. The answer is always a price.

Mechanics: Spirit + Resolve (DV 6). Success: the GM answers truthfully (one sentence). Failure: the character gains the Condition *Marked by the Hollow* (the GM may spend 2 SB to have a Debt-Walker appear).

Starting Hooks

- **The Wolf Road wakes:** Viterran tax men are asking which passes you used. The clans are counting your steps.
- **The Bride-Price Default:** A Mac Tern groom cannot pay the wergild for an O'Creagh bride. The bride has fled to the Pass of Ashes. Retrieve her – or pay her price yourself.
- **The Toll-Master's Ledger:** Khaz-Vurim has doubled tolls on the Steps. A clan chief suspects they are skimming to fund the Deep Road. Infiltrate the counting-house and copy the ledger.
- **The Cairn that Weeps:** A shepherd reports that a cairn on Three-Fires Ridge is weeping water that tastes of salt. The dead are agitated. Find out why before the clan blames a rival.

Faction Turn Cheat Sheet

Between sessions, roll 1d6 for each major faction. Write one sentence of fallout and adjust the relevant clock.

Roll	Progress	Clock Change
1–2	Setback	–1 segment (min 0)
3–4	Stalled	No change
5–6	Advance	+1 segment

Example: Mac Tern raided O'Creagh's cattle (**Mac Tern's Revenge** +1). The Viterran factor raised tariffs (**The Viterran Yoke** +1). Khaz-Vurim surveyed a new pass (**The Deep Road** +1).

Prominent NPCs of Ubral

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Lady Morwen	Clan-chief of the Grey Tor	Keep the old oaths and resist Viterran encroachment	She lost a hand to a Viterran knight; her iron hook has a built-in bell.
Hearth-Aunt Brigid	Keeper of guest-right (commoner exemplar)	Protect her household and settle feuds before blood is spilled	She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to.
Councillor Gethin	Elder of the Council of Cairns	Preserve the wergild system and the memory of the dead	He speaks once a year; his sentences take a full season to deliver.
Oath-Singer Liliás	Verse-weaver and feud mediator	Turn vengeance into cattle, not corpses	Her tongue is forked—she can praise and curse in the same breath.
Vent-Prior Orla	Aeler outcast leader of Khaz-Vurim	Build a new under-way through Ubral, linking mountains to lowlands	She carries a bell that rings once for each miner she left behind.
Sister Niamh	Healer of the Cairn-Keeper of the Grey Palm (Temple of Light)	Run a free hospice at Grey Tor without angering the old gods	She asks no payment, but she writes every patient’s name on a slate that never fills.

Names of Ubral

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Gethin	Morwen	ap Cairn	<i>the Grey</i>
Bran	Brigid	ferch Tor	<i>Oath-Sworn</i>
Drystan	Liliás	mac Tern	<i>the Stone-Foot</i>
Eilian	Niamh	O’Ruarc	<i>Hollow-Tongue</i>
Padraig	Siorcha	Mac Gowan	<i>the Unbroken</i>

Tegid	Ailbhe	O’Creagh	Ash-Finger
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Spades — Places

2. **Sheepwalk Ledge** — Goat path with room for one honest lie at a time. ‘[THRESHOLD]’
The lie must be small—a false weight, a borrowed name. Tell it twice and the ledge crumbles. A Viterran spy learned that the hard way.
 3. **Warden’s Cairn** — Windy tor; signal-fire basket and dry cache; eyes of the hills. ‘[WATCH]’
The cache holds a single arrow. Light it with the fire, and the message is war. The arrow is fletched with eagle feathers — a clan’s highest oath.
 4. **Wergild Ford** — Flat stones, deep pools, table rock for counting silver. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[TRADE]’
The table rock is smooth as glass. Blood washes off; lies do not. The water remembers every price ever paid here.
 5. **Droppers’ Bridge** — Stone span rigged to fall; pins already loosened. ‘[TRAP]’ *The pins are greased with mutton fat. The bridge knows who paid for the grease. Its fall has ended three feuds and started two.*
 6. **Scree-Ladder** — Climbing to a notch; red rags mark safe steps through danger. ‘[TRAVEL]’
The rags are old clan banners. Step where they wave, not where they lie flat. One rag is white — that marks a traitor’s grave.
 7. **Moot Hollow** — Ring of standing stones; voices carry and won’t quite stop. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[OATH]’
The stones have ears. Speak a false oath here, and every cairn will know. The dead vote by how the mist moves.
 8. **Reiver’s Gate** — Between boulders; cart-ruts vanish into heather’s memory. ‘[STEALTH]’
The gate has no lintel. Above it, ravens nest in a skull. The ravens are the clan’s spies.
 9. **Khaz-Vurim Steps** — Dwarf-cut switchbacks with iron mile studs; toll and toil. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’
The studs are cold iron. Touch them, and the mountain knows your weight. Aeler outcasts maintain the toll — they accept stories as often as coin.
 10. **Grey Tor Fort** — Earthen rampart, timber crown, smoky cook pits. ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *The cook pits have been burning for three hundred years. The ash is deep enough to bury a secret — and more than one Viterran scout.*
- J **Black Broom Bog** — Stepping-logs; wrong one drinks you into silence. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[FEAR]’
The logs are painted with warding runes. One is unpainted — that one is the quick way. The bog exhales names of the drowned.
- Q **Bride’s Causey** — Raised road to a valley kirk; ribbons hang like warnings. ‘[SOCIAL]’
The ribbons are from wedding gowns — cut short when the groom fell in a feud. The kirk is neutral ground, but the path is not.
- K **Three-Fires Ridge** — Watchposts that see Viterra and Vhasia both; news travels fast. ‘[WATCH]’
The fires are layered: birch for peace, pine for raid, oak for invasion. A fourth fire — yew — means the Hollow walks.
- A **Pass of Ashes** — When snow closes here, the upland becomes an island. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[DEATH]’
The ash is from old sacrifices. The pass remembers every offering. The last sacrifice was a Viterran herald. His voice is still in the wind.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Hearth-Aunt** — Holds guest-cup and house’s temper; hospitality as power. *She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to. Her hospitality has ended more feuds than swords.*
3. **Hill Guide** — Thorn-staff and ten quiet shortcuts; the land as a map. *He taps each stone before stepping. The stones talk to him. He learned the tongue from an Aeler outcast who went deaf and learned to listen with his feet.*
4. **Feud-Broker** — Knows the weight of a life in cattle and coin; peace as trade. *His ledger is a row of tally sticks. Each notch is a death—or a birth. He has notched both sides of the same feud for forty years.*
5. **Reiver Band** — Light on tack, heavy on nerve, laughing in the rain. *They wear no colors. Their horses answer to whistles, not names. They raid Viterran supply trains and leave heather sprigs as signatures.*
6. **Fire Warden** — Braziers speak faster than riders; warning as weapon. *She can light a signal with a single word. The word is a dead man’s name. The dead man was a Viterran knight who burned her village.*
7. **Wergild Counter** — Keeps tallies, ends grudges, starts others; law as math. *His abacus beads are sheep knuckles. He clicks them in his sleep. His grandmother taught him; she learned from an Aeler vent-prior.*
8. **Dwarf Warden (Aeler Outcast)** — Khaz-Vurim road; toll first, friendship later. *Her hammer has a chip where she cracked a liar’s skull. She never fixed it. She came to the surface for the sky — and stayed for the feuds.*
9. **Oath-Singer** — Verses bind hands and open gates; word as iron. *Her tongue is forked—she can praise and curse in the same breath. Her songs are older than the Viterran crown.*
10. **Lowland Factor** — Buying iron blooms, selling trouble; coin as catalyst. *He carries two ledgers. One is for the clans. One is for the tax man. The third ledger is in his head; it lists every bribe he has ever taken.*
- J **Bride-Carrier** — Peaceweaver walking bloodlines with a knife and a smile. *Her knife has a wooden blade. The threat is real. She has walked between warring clans nine times. The ninth was a Viterran lord who wanted a wife. He got a treaty instead.*
- Q **Lady of Tor** — Clan-chief in cloak and mail; her nod is winter or spring. *She lost a hand to a Viterran knight. Her iron hook has a built-in bell. The bell rings when she lies. It has never rung.*
- K **Council of Cairns** — Greybeards and granite wills; they do not hurry. *They have sentenced men to exile. The sentences take a year to deliver. The exile always knows before they speak.*
- A **Stone-Speaker** — Aeler outcast envoy whose word moves roads and rates. *He carries a tuning fork. Strike it, and the mountain answers. He has not seen his homeland in sixty years. He calls the mist his ceiling now.*

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Upland Mist** — Hear horns but not edges; navigation by sound and instinct. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[STEALTH]’ *The horns are calling a muster. Which clan? You will know when they arrive. The mist smells of wet wool and old iron.*
3. **Feud Rekindled** — Cousin spits on guest-law; knives wake from sleep. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The spit lands at your feet. The insult is now yours to answer. The cousin’s father was*

killed in a cattle raid thirty years ago. He has been waiting.

4. **Bridge Dropped** — Pursuers fall... and the route with them; passage becomes peril. ‘[TRAP]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The bridge was cut from the far side. Someone expected you. The cut ropes smell of dwarf-made pitch — a signature of the Aeler outcasts.*
5. **Black-Rent Demand** — “Privateering on land”; pay or be “escorted.” ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The escort has a noose. Choose your words carefully. The man collecting is a Viterran factor with a royal warrant. The warrant is a forgery. No one will admit it.*
6. **Wergild Breach** — Silver short by a head; tempers long by a spear’s length. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The bereaved clan has a new widow. She is sharpening a blade. The missing silver was paid in lowland coin — debased, clipped, and worthless. The insult is not the shortfall; it is the contempt.*
7. **Snow-Squall** — Seals the notch; tents turn to coffins if you dally. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The snow is tinged grey—ash from the Pass. Someone burned an offering. The offering was a Viterran tax ledger. The gods accepted.*
8. **Dwarf Toll Hike** — At the Steps; papers right, purses wrong; law costs coin. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The warden quotes a rate from a book that wasn’t there yesterday. The book was written by an Aeler outcast who lost his sense of humour but not his arithmetic.*
9. **Cattle Scatter** — Bells ringing downslope; the cover story runs with the herd. ‘[STEALTH]’ ‘[DISASTER]’ *The bells are yours. The herd is not. The real owner is a clan chief with a long memory and three sons with sharp swords.*
10. **False Alarm** — Watch-fire beacons ridge to ridge; levies seize the road. ‘[WATCH]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The fire was lit by a child. Or a spy. The levy doesn’t care. The spy is a Viterran agent. The child is his nephew.*
- J **Bride-Theft** — A wedding becomes a war-party; you are caught between both. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The bride’s veil is on the ground. The groom’s own kin drew first blood. The bride was promised to a neighbouring clan. She chose her own groom. Now three clans want her head — and her hand.*
- Q **Royal Incursion** — Neighbor’s “lawful” arrests in the uplands; flags and chains. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The flags are Viterran. The chains are new. The prisoners are children. The crime is not paying a tax that was never law. The clans are calling the muster.*
- K **Clan Muster** — Horns call men from steadings to spears; all traffic stops. ‘[WATCH]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The muster stone is black with old blood. The new blood will be red. The last muster was forty years ago, to drive out a Viterran garrison. The garrison’s bones are under the sheepwalk.*
- A **Hill-Fall** — Rain liquefies a slope; trail, proof, and bodies slide together. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *The mud is warm. Something underneath is still breathing. The slide exposed a mass grave — clan warriors who fell in a forgotten feud. Their ghosts are counting the wergild still owed.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Guest-Token** — One hearth owes food, bed, and steel at dawn. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The token is a knucklebone from a feast. The host’s name is carved on it. Break it, and the obligation ends. The host will not thank you.*
3. **Guide’s Braid** — Lawful passage on named sheepwalks (once). ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The braid is woven from horsehair and a promise. Unravel it to return. The promise was made to a hill*

guide who died last winter. His ghost still checks the knots.

4. **Ford Remission** — Cross Wergild Ford free for a season; water as ally. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The remission is a white stone. Skip it across the ford to pay. The stone was taken from a Viterran courthouse. The law has not found it yet.*
5. **Feud-Charter** — Two clans sheath blades until the next harvest. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[OATH]’ *The charter is a broken spear. Each clan keeps a half. The spear was used to kill a Viterran tax collector. His family still wants it back.*
6. **Bloom Allotment** — Claim on a week’s iron from a hill bloomery. ‘[TRADE]’ *The bloomery is a woman’s name. She decides how much you get. She is an Aeler outcast’s granddaughter. Her iron is harder than any lowlander’s steel.*
7. **Watch-Code** — Today’s beacon order from Three-Fires Ridge. ‘[WATCH]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The code is a sequence of smoke puffs. Read it, and the hills will watch for you. The code changes weekly. The fire wardens burn the old codes — the smoke carries the memory.*
8. **Pass-Ring** — Dwarf road priority for one train of carts. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The ring is iron. Wear it on your off hand. The Aeler outcasts who made it stamped their names inside. One name is scratched out — the smith was killed in a feud. The ring still works.*
9. **Bride-Escrow** — Hold the purse; both sides must humor you. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The purse is a leather bag. The coins inside are from a dead man’s hoard. The dead man was a Viterran lord who tried to tax the clans. His ghost asks for his money back.*
10. **Shelter Writ** — Grey Tor opens its gates during storm or pursuit. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The writ is a raven feather. Burn it to claim shelter. The raven was a clan spy. His memory still watches the gates.*
- J **Oath-Bracelet** — One binding vow ends cleanly, witnessed. ‘[OATH]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *The bracelet is silver. The clasp is a wolf’s head. Bite it to break the oath. The wolf’s head was a seal of a Viterran king. The oath was sworn under duress. The bracelet remembers.*
- Q **Council Audience** — The Cairns hear you alone; precedent sticks like stone. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The audience is held at midnight. The stones glow when they agree. The last audience exiled a clan chief. He is still walking the passes, looking for a cairn that will forgive him.*
- K **Road Commission** — Collect tolls on a stretch of pass (for now). ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[TRADE]’ *The commission is a wooden staff. Plant it at the toll gate. The staff was carved from a gallows tree. The last toll-keeper was hanged. The staff still creaks.*
- A **Stone-Clause** — Temporary exception to dwarf toll or law, sealed. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[OATH]’ *The clause is a single rune. Carve it on the toll post, and the mountain will honor it — once. The rune was taught to the clans by an Aeler outcast who wanted to see a Viterran knight pay double.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (oaths/rights/tokens) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **stone and spear** motifs—cairns that watch, voices that echo, and oaths that cut deeper than steel.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Guest-Law:** Breaking hospitality stains a name worse than breaking a sword. Guest-right tokens guarantee shelter, but abuse invites a blood feud. A Viterran lord who broke guest-law at Grey Tor had his name struck from the Council's cairn. His own clan disowned him.
- **Wergild System:** Every injury has a price in cattle or coin. Wergild counters keep tallies that outlive the injured; debts pass to kin. The lowland courts have no equivalent; they imprison the poor and hang the desperate. The clans consider that barbaric.
- **Dwarf Toll Roads:** Khaz-Vurim gates charge for passage, but their roads are sure and swift. Pass-rings grant priority, but dwarf law is strict. The Aeler outcasts who run the tolls are exiles — they fled the Deep Vaults because they could not abide the counting. Now they count for the clans, and they are gentle with the weary.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Bone Keeper** — Varnek Karn. *The accountant of ancestral wergild; the witness to every blood price.*
 - **The Iron Crown** — Mykkiel. *The law of the lowlands, cold and distant; the clans honour it by breaking it.*
 - **The Grey Mare** — The Traveler. *The rider who never tires; the path that leads home through the mist.*
 - **The Forge Father (Aeler outcast cult)** — The Sealed Gate. *The fire that shapes iron; the exile who builds a new hearth.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a hospice near the Pass of Ashes, tending to the wounded of both sides of the Great Feud. A renegade Sister has hidden a Hollowed in a cairn, trying to discharge a blood-debt by feeding the Hollow memories of Viterran tax collectors. The clans do not know whether to thank her or burn her.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends appears in the palm of every third corpse pulled from a hill-fall. Take it, and the dead will give you their last breath — but the coin will taste of peat smoke and regret.
- **The Grey Wanderer's Grimoire:** Ubral psions are called "Stone-Listeners." They press their foreheads to cairns and hear the names of everyone who has touched that stone. The Lady of Tor employs three; they have not spoken aloud in a decade.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Pass of Ashes is a Class II Anchor — the spirits of Viterran knights who froze to death in a blizzard still march there, looking for a way home. Saikou Ira left a silver mirror at the summit. The mirror shows the knights their own corpses. They have not advanced since.
- **The Ninth:** In any Ubral scene, the ninth stone in a cairn is always warm. Touch it, and you will remember an oath you never swore. Those who touch the ninth stone three times are said to become a cairn themselves — silent, still, and waiting for the next hand. The Aeler outcasts say the ninth stone is a door to the Deep Vaults they fled. They do not touch it.

Ubral Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Cairn:** Crumble a crust at the base of a standing stone. Ignore the first *Upland Mist* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'

- **Knot the Guest-Cup:** Tie a single knot in the handle of a drinking cup. Cancel *Feud Rekindled* or take −1 die on your next hospitality roll (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Ford:** Whisper a dead enemy’s name into the Wergild Ford. Gain +1 Effect when collecting from their kin this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Lady of Tor. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **clan guards or reiver scouts**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **watch-fires or hill guides**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or feud-kin**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable weather**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Hill guide or clan chief** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **mist or bridge collapse**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **reiver band or feud-kin** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **clan warriors, reivers, or dwarf wardens** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** **The situation fundamentally changes — feud declared/bridge falls/snow closes pass.**
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant **campaign/front clock** by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Lady of Tor, Council of Cairns, or Stone-Speaker** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically — **mist thickens/bridge drops/hill falls**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice — **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Ubral (Stone & Oath):** Cairns shift position, voices echo from empty air, oaths bind mid-speech.

- **Ubral (Hill Law):** Paths reroute without warning, tolls increase mid-journey, guest-rights expire.
- **Ubral (Feud Culture):** Insults are overheard, weapons appear in sheaths, kin arrive unsummoned.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Navigation):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Bog Mist*.
- **Cut the Bridge (Presence + Command):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a **Pass-Ring** is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Squall (Resolve + Survival):** On a hit in *Snow-Squall*, you pick who finds shelter; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Stone & Spear)

- **The Wolf-Road Captain (reiver-king on a piebald mare)** — *Phases:* Ride-Through → Torch the Fold → Laugh in Rain. *Cracks:* present a **Watch-Code** or **Guide's Braid** to reduce his effect; strike a truce with a season's cattle.
- **The Bride-Thief of Black Broom (mask of bog-rush)** — *Phases:* Switch the Bride → Bog Embrace → Nettle Oath. *Cracks:* play a **Bride-Charter** to freeze blades; a **Well-Blessing** nulls one bog move.
- **Stone Auditor of Khaz-Vurim (Aeler outcast toll-magistrate)** — *Phases:* Double the Toll → Weigh the Lie → Seal the Switchback. *Cracks:* present two of {**Pass-Ring**, **Stamped Load-List**, **Named Sponsor**} to downgrade his authority.
- **The Oath-Eater Wight (cairn-bound revenant)** — *Phases:* Take the Word → Cold of Cairn → Bind Witness. *Cracks:* **Oath-Bracelet** or a skald's stanza spoken over bread and blood cancels one move; repay an ancestral wergild.
- **Grey-Tor Hedge-Witch (heather crown, ash staff)** — *Phases:* Weather-Turn → Hag-Stone Sight → Bind the Gate. *Cracks:* gift a **Bloom Allotment** or a winter's salt; a **Council Audience** compels parley.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- **Sheepwalk Ledge Trial** — Speak one honest lie to pass. On success, set Position one step safer for the next border scene; on failure, start *Kin Arrive*.
- **Wergild Ford Weighing** — Cast silver on the table-rock. If paid in full, clear 1 *Feud-Smoke*; if short, *Wergild Breach* enters play.
- **Pass of Ashes Vigil** — Hold a fire through the night storm. Success grants **Shelter Writ**; a miss summons the *Oath-Eater Wight* at weak strength.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Oath Dial (Honor ↔ Cunning):** Track how the party navigates Ubral norms.
 - *Honor High:* +1 Position when invoking guest-right, keeping truce, or paying wergild promptly; first ambush/raid action each session starts one step worse.

- *Cunning High*: +1 Effect on raids, evasions, and border tricks; first formal parley or oath-bound request each session starts one step worse.
- Center the dial by restoring stolen cattle, hosting an enemy well, or submitting to a cairn ruling.
- **Feud Math (fast settlement)**: Lay three markers: **Blood, Beasts, Blame**.
 1. Make a single *Parley/Command/Study* roll per side. On a hit, move one marker to your side; great Effect moves two.
 2. Win any two to settle: *Blood* = oath/hostage, *Beasts* = wergild in cattle/coin, *Blame* = public apology/verse.
 3. Miss: mark *Feud-Smoke* [4]. At 4, the losing side names a lawful target (bridge, herd, guide).
- **Guest-Right Procedure**:
 - Present a **Guest-Token** (or bread and salt). Host must choose: *Shelter*, *Escort at Dawn*, or *Neutral Meal*.
 - Breaking it creates *Blood-Oath* [6] against the violator; any Ubral ally may spend 1 *◊totickittwice*.
 - Abiding it clears 1 tick from *Feud-Smoke* and grants +1d to the next social action in that steading.
- **Watchfire Net (ridge signals)**:
 - Two clocks: *Beat the Beacons* vs *Ridge Aflame* (size by highest rank in your seed).
 - Choose a lane each exchange: *Low Fold* (slow, stealth), *Sheepwalk* (tricky, quick), *Road* (fast, obvious).
 - Advantage: Low Fold▷Road (conceal), Road▷Sheepwalk (speed), Sheepwalk▷Low Fold (shortcuts).
 - *False Alarm (1 SB)*: light or douse a misleading brazier; shift one segment between the two clocks.
- **Reiver Ride (mounted chase)**:
 - Track *Remounts* (3): each push for speed trades 1 remount for +1d or +1 Effect. At 0, gain *Blown Mounts* condition.
 - *Hag-Stone Cut*: pass a known gap (Sheepwalk Ledge, Droppers’ Bridge) to force pursuers to roll or fall behind.
- **Khaz-Vurim Protocol (Aeler Outcast Rules)**:
 - Present any two: **Pass-Ring, Stamped Load-List, Named Sponsor**. Two = safe passage; one = pay toll + scrutiny; none = delay and search.
 - *Stone-Clause* may override one dwarf law once; afterwards start *Ledger Notice* [3] with the wardens (prices rise, patience falls).
 - *Tally Truth*: you may substitute exact weights/measures for charm or coin to improve Position by one step with dwarves.
 - Aeler outcast smiths accept stories as payment for small repairs — the story must be about a betrayal. They are collecting evidence for a case they will never bring.
- **Bride-Peace Interlude**:
 - Play a **Bride-Charter** to suspend violence at a scene. Everyone sheaths—or earns *Song*

Shame [4]. When it fills, a skald memorializes the insult (ongoing -1d with that clan).

- **Start-of-Scene Omens (1d6):**

1. *Clear Ridge*: first signal test gains +1d.
2. *Lowing Herd*: +1d to tracking or herding; -1d to stealth near cattle.
3. *Wet Stone*: climbs start one step worse; mending gear is easier (free repair tick).
4. *Old Verse Remembered*: first oath/plea gains +1d if spoken in rhyme.
5. *Border Drums*: Viterra patrols near; papers safer, raiding harsher.
6. *Dwarf Toll Day*: prices firm; any $\diamond$ *tied to roads counts double value at the Steps*.

- **Plug-in SB Conversions (Ubral Flavor):**

- 1 SB → *Mud and Heather*: footing worsens; next physical action -1d or mark *Winded*.
- 2 SB → *Kin Arrive*: add a rival cousin/ally who changes the ask or splits the pot.
- 3+ SB → *Cairn Decrees*: a standing stone “speaks” (witnesses recall the law); swap one held $\diamond$ *for a less right until you make amends*.

- **Reputation Echoes:**

- *Guest-Faithful*: once/session downgrade a social backlash inside a steading; next time you refuse hospitality, mark *Feud-Smoke* +1.
- *Reiver-Favored*: +1 Effect to seize cattle/contraband on the move; city gates start one step worse Position.
- *Stone-Friend*: +1d with dwarf wardens on roads; any false measure triggers *Ledger Notice* +1.

Patronage & Power

In Ubral, power flows through clan bonds, guest-right, and the careful balance of honor and iron. Clan chiefs maintain authority through wergild, moots, and the respect of their people, while the Aeler outcasts of Khaz-Vurim wield influence through their control of mountain passes and forges. Law is personal and passed down through generations, with each oath and debt creating a web of obligation that can last centuries. The Viterran crown claims suzerainty; the clans call that claim “the ink of thieves.”

For the GM: Patronage in Ubral revolves around hospitality, protection, and the resolution of feuds. Rewards often take the form of tokens, charters, or safe passage that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this, use the faction clocks, let rival clans issue conflicting protections, and remember the Aeler outcasts — they are exiles, not tourists. They will help a clan for a story, but they will never forget a slight.

In Ubral, your word is your bond, and your bond determines whether you walk in peace or peril. The lowlands write their laws in ink; Ubral carves them in stone. The ink fades. The stone remembers.

Chapter 21

Silkstrand

City of Bridges & Dyewater. Silkstrand is strung across canals and arches, a place where every bridge is a ledger line and every current carries rumor. The dyes that stain its waters never wash out, and neither do the bargains struck in shadow. Merchants rise and fall with the Exchange, bravos carve reputations on the planks of Three-Queens Bridge, and curses cling to the very cloth that leaves the looms.

21.1 Silkstrand — “City of Bridges & Ledgers”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Every bridge is a contract. Every current carries coin.*

The Matron (Elite): “In this city, every bridge is a contract and every current carries coin. The bargains struck in our shadows never quite fade from memory, and the waters remember every handshake.”

Bobbin-Runner (Commoner): “I can cross this city faster than any grown-up, and I know which planks creak and which merchants lie. The bridges remember every step, and the canals carry more secrets than fish.”

Genre / Mood: Mercantile noir, Renaissance urban fantasy, late-medieval finance.

Starting Location: Three-Queens Bridge, crowded with market stalls, its stones worn smooth by centuries of footsteps. A Guildmistress with ink-stained fingers offers a customs waiver. “The Exchange boils today,” she says. “And something in the canals remembers your scent. Bring me three bolts of untaxed crimson before the closing bell, or the Archivolt will find your name in a dead notary’s ledger.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Silkstrand is a city strung across canals and arches, a place where every bridge is a contract and every current carries rumor. The silk looms never sleep, the Exchange never closes, and the Archivolt's notaries seal fates with a drop of wax. Merchants rise and fall with the tide of the market, bravos carve reputations on the planks of Three-Queens Bridge, and the city's underworld runs on whispers and borrowed keys. The Matron rules from her palazzo stairs with velvet and iron, but the city itself belongs to silk, silver, and shadow.

What you notice first: The clash of water against ancient stone. The constant rumble of cart wheels on bridge planks. The way every handshake lingers a heartbeat too long — as if both parties are checking for hidden clauses.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never name a rival while crossing a bridge at night. The water remembers, and the curse you send may come back wrapped around your own throat.

Regional Mood: Bridges and Ledgers

Here, fortune is written in ink and sealed in wax. Silkstrand is not lawless — it is **layered**. Above the tide lies the world of guild charters, notarial seals, and the Matron's velvet justice. Below the bridges, in the weeping arches and the midnight boat lanes, a quieter economy runs on whispers, borrowed keys, and the careful omission of names. The city's bravos duel for reputation on Three-Queens Bridge while factors bribe clerks in the Archivolt. Every alliance is a knot that can be pulled loose. Every fortune is a thread that can be cut.

Prominent NPCs of Silkstrand

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Matrona Lucia	The Matron, ruler of Silkstrand	Keep the guilds balanced and the treasury full	She has never raised her voice. The city learned to fear her silences.
Guildmistress Xara She can tell your guild by the stain on your cuff; she never forgets a color.	Head of the Silk	Dye Guilds	Secure the red dye monopoly
Niccolò	Archivolt notary	"Fix" missing recitals for a fee	His inkwell contains a single drop of his own blood. He renews it each spring.

Ravel	Night-boat smuggler	Move cargo that cannot be named	His boat has no name. The canal would remember it, and memory is a kind of tax.
Sister Chiara	Healer of the Weavers of Mercy (The Silk-Shrouded) (Temple of Light)	Run a hospice near the Salt Gate	She asks no payment, but she records every patient’s name in a ledger that never dries.
Captain Borso	Condottieri watch captain	Keep the peace between guilds	He wears a mask on feast days; no one has seen his face in seven years.

Names of Silkstrand

Inspired by the mercantile republics of the southern coast: liquid vowels, soft endings, and surnames that recall a bridge, a canal, or a trade.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Lorenzo	Lucia	da Ponte	<i>the Bridge-Wise</i>
Niccolò	Xara	Canaletti	<i>the Unseen</i>
Borso	Chiara	del Forno	<i>Bobbin-Foot</i>
Marco	Fiammetta	Riva	<i>the Silent</i>
Tommaso	Oria	Selci	<i>Red-Handed</i>
Andrea	Zilia	Molin	<i>Ash-Thread</i>

(Bridge/Canal/Market) Three-Queens Bridge with stacked stalls; Archivolt arcade of notaries; Salt Gate quay with customs.

Spades — Places

2. **Three-Queens Bridge** — Stacked market stalls; cells under arches, reputations made and broken. *The cells are for debtors. The walls are washed with canal water so no one forgets the smell.* ‘[TRADE]’
3. **The Archivolt** — Arcaded street of notaries, seals, and quiet knives. *The notaries write in lemon juice. Heat reveals the truth — or a facsimile.* ‘[LAW]’
4. **Silk Exchange** — Floor with chalk circles and clappers for opening bids. *The clappers are whale ribs. The bids echo, and sometimes the echo answers.* ‘[TRADE]’

5. **Salt Gate Quay** — Rope booms, chalk tallies, tired eyes; customs and coin. *The chalk is mixed with ground bone. A false tally writes itself in a dead hand.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
6. **Palazzo della Matrona** — Ruling seat with private river stairs; velvet and iron. *The Matrona’s barge is rowed by debtors who have repaid in years, not coin.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
7. **Spindle Tower** — Creaking windlass-lifts and posted rates; heights and hazards. *The lift operator has a bell. He rings it once for every passenger who didn’t pay.* ‘[LABOR]’
8. **Ropewalk Sheds** — Arrow-straight; bruisers hired by the yard, muscle for hire. *The rope-walkers never look back. They say a rope remembers who pulled it last.* ‘[LABOR]’
9. **Old Arsenal** — Free Company’s barracks now; arms and ambitions stored. *The arsenal’s bell rings at odd hours. No one admits ringing it.* ‘[MILITARY]’
10. **Exchange Coffee House** — Where merchants insure cargo and spread rumors. *The coffee is thick as mud. The policy rates change with the wind.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
- J **Flood-Stairs** — Bronze flood marks, bell rope ready when the Strand runs wild. *The flood marks go up to nine. The ninth step is underwater — always.* ‘[WEATHER]’
- Q **Basilica of Azerin** — Weaver-saint; confraternity rooms hum with vows. *The saint’s icon has one eye. The other was traded for the secret of indigo.* ‘[FAITH]’
- K **Debtors’ Arcade** — Row of pawn shops and loan banks; interest rates carved on the pillars. *The pillars are scored with tally marks. The oldest ones are from three centuries ago.* ‘[DEBT]’
- A **The Unwritten Canal** — A buried waterway that appears only in the lowest tides. *It leads to a vault where contracts are kept that were never meant to be fulfilled.* ‘[MYSTERY]’

(**Guild/Factor/Crown**) Bobbin-runner child with feet sure on parapets; foreign factor seeking warehouse and friend at customs.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Bobbin-Runner** — Child with sure feet on parapets, rumors in pocket. *She ties a knot in her apron string for every secret she carries. The apron is nearly solid knots.* ‘[STEALTH]’
3. **Mulberry Steward** — Counting leaves; desperate for pickers, quick with coin. *His left hand is missing two fingers — lost to a cocoon-rot curse. He calls it a bargain.* ‘[LABOR]’
4. **Foreign Factor** — Seeking warehouse and friend at customs; connections for sale. *He carries three ledgers. One for the Matron, one for the Archivolt, one for himself.* ‘[TRADE]’
5. **Guildmistress** — Silk Dye guilds’ hands stained, permits tighter than purse strings. *She can tell your guild by the stain on your cuff. She never forgets a color.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
6. **Bridge Bailiff** — Rents stalls, sells gossip by the breath; power in position. *He rings a small bell before each announcement. The tone tells you if it’s truth or theater.* ‘[LAW]’
7. **Archivolt Notary** — “Fixes” missing recitals — for a donation; law as service. *His inkwell contains a single drop of his own blood. He renews it each spring.* ‘[LAW]’
8. **Watch Captain** — Condotta to three lords; passwords change with the wind. *He wears a mask on feast days. No one has seen his face in seven years.* ‘[MILITARY]’
9. **Exchange Caller** — A clap can still a thousand voices; auction master. *He lost his voice to a curse. Now he claps in a language only the bids understand.* ‘[TRADE]’
10. **Insurance Broker** — Writes policies on cargo, lives, and sometimes conspiracies. *His quill is a stiletto. He has used it as both.* ‘[FINANCE]’

- J **Night-Boat Smuggler** — “Ravel,” silent oar, louder favors; shadows for coin. *His boat has no name. The canal would remember it, and memory is a kind of tax.* ‘[STEALTH]’
- Q **The Matron** — Patient, velvet, iron; the city’s thread pulled through her hands. *She has never raised her voice. The city learned to fear her silences.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- K **Lame King’s Envoy** — Velvet boots; claims certain alleys “protected.” *His cane is hollow. Inside is a letter of marque that expired a decade ago.* ‘[POLITICS]’
- A **Saint of Warps** — If real: sees curses braided in cloth; holy unraveler. *Her eyes are milk-white. She sees not the cloth, but the threads of obligation within.* ‘[FAITH]’

(**Flood/Interdict/Riot**) Flood siren with gates lowering — move crates or kiss them goodbye; quarantine flag at the dyeworks sealing a district; Loom strike over unpaid wages.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Flood Siren** — Gates lowering; move crates or kiss them goodbye to tide. *The gate-keeper’s palm is marked with a bell. Cross it with silver to hurry.* ‘[WEATHER]’
 3. **Quarantine Flag** — A district sealed; your cargo implicated. *The flag is dyed with lamp-black and something else — something that smells of graves.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
 4. **Loom Strike** — Weavers idle over wage disputes; streets fill with idle frames. *The striking weavers wear red threads around their wrists. They will not speak first.* ‘[LABOR]’
 5. **Seal Counterfeit** — Discovered at Archivolt; all contracts frozen. *The forged seal is warm. The real one is cold. Touch both to know which is which.* ‘[LAW]’
 6. **Bridge Riot** — A dropped stall blocks lanes; tempers boil faster than vats. *The riot started over a missed bell-ring. Or a stolen bolt. Or a look.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
 7. **Condottieri Flip** — Colors change; watchwords shift, escorts vanish. *The captain’s new banner is stitched with thread from his old captain’s shroud.* ‘[MILITARY]’
 8. **Insurance Fraud** — A warehouse burns; the policy is a forgery. *The broker has fled. His ledgers are full of ships that never sailed.* ‘[FINANCE]’
 9. **Coin Clipping** — Light silver floods the market; the Exchange closes. *The clippings were melted into a statue of the Matron. She is not amused.* ‘[TRADE]’
 10. **Salt-Tax Doubled** — At Salt Gate; boats stack three deep, bribes flow. *The tax collector wears a mask. Beneath it, his face is a salt-caked skull.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- J **Duel Challenge** — Booked on Three-Queens Bridge; you’re named as seconds. *The challenge is written on silk. Burn it to refuse — and lose face forever.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
- Q **Exchange Corner** — Rivals hoard raw silk; prices go vertical. *The cornering merchant has a ledger bound in human skin. The names inside are his competitors.* ‘[TRADE]’
- K **Saint’s Procession** — Closes half the wards; ignore at peril, faith walks the streets. *The icon weeps dyewater. The faithful collect it in silver cups.* ‘[FAITH]’
- A **Curse Awakened** — In canals: no route reaches the address you seek. *The water is still. Your reflection is gone. You are still here — for now.* ‘[DEATH]’

(**Permit/Seat/Escort**) Bridge token for peak-hour cart crossing free; Exchange floor pass; Matron’s seal for a single contract.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Bridge Token** — One peak-hour cart crossing free; traffic as currency. *The token is a bronze coin with a hole in the center. The hole is the toll.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
3. **Exchange Pass** — Day pass to trade without sponsor; freedom in paper. *The pass is stamped with a spider. The spider’s legs are the signatures of three guilds.* ‘[TRADE]’
4. **Watergate Priority** — Skip one flood closure when it matters; tide waits for none. *The priority token is a dried eel skin. Show it, and the gate-keeper spits but stands aside.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
5. **Notarial Indulgence** — Retrofit a missing recital; past deals stand. *The indulgence is written in lemon juice. Heat it to see the terms.* ‘[LAW]’
6. **Warehouse Seal** — From Matron’s office; rivals legally shut out. *The seal is a brass bell. Ring it once to claim the space.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
7. **Ropewalk Credit** — Hire crews before you have coin; muscle on credit. *The credit is a knotted rope. Cut a knot for each favor called.* ‘[LABOR]’
8. **Arsenal Key** — One night’s issue for retinue; arms in trusted hands. *The key is a finger bone. The lock is a gauntleted fist.* ‘[MILITARY]’
9. **Insurance Policy (Blank)** — Insure one cargo against any loss; the policy pays in silver. *The policy is a prayer. The prayer is a contract. The contract is a bet.* ‘[FINANCE]’
10. **Condotta Rider** — City watch escorts through any ward, once. *The rider’s horse has iron shoes. The sparks tell him who to watch.* ‘[MILITARY]’
- J **Matron’s Audience** — Private whisper becomes policy; velvet commands. *The Matron’s ear is a bell. Speak into it, and the city listens — once.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- Q **Tax-Farm Share** — On Three-Queens stalls for a season; profit in peddlers. *The share is a tally stick. Break it in half to claim your portion.* ‘[FINANCE]’
- K **Golden Thread** — Temporary charter to set tolls on a named canal. *The thread is real gold. It will not break — but it will stretch.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- A **The Unwritten Contract** — A blank parchment signed by a dead notary. Fill it in. *The notary’s ghost will enforce it. The ghost has a sense of humor.* ‘[MAGIC]’

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (permits, passes, seals) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **silk and water** motifs — threads that bind, currents that remember, bargains that stain the ledger.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Duel Etiquette:** Duels fought on bridges draw crowds eager to wager on blood. Refusing stains a name worse than losing. The winner may claim the loser’s bridge token (if any) as a trophy.
- **Canal Omens:** Canals run strange colors at dawn; red foretells riots, blue brings calm, black means a curse has awakened. A successful Wits + Lore test (DV 3) allows a character to interpret the omen and gain +1 die on the next roll to avoid or exploit the coming event.

- **Matron’s Seal:** Any contract bearing her seal is law — but the Matron is known to rescind seals without warning, leaving debts tangled. A seal may be challenged by producing an older Matron’s seal; the older one always holds.
- **Exchange Volatility Clock [6]:** Tracks market instability. Each time a major cargo is seized, a trade route is cut, or a merchant defaults, tick the clock. At 3: prices of all goods increase by 1 Supply. At 6: a panic hits — the Exchange closes for 1d3 days, and all outstanding contracts are voided unless witnessed by the Matron.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Ledger Saint** — The Witness. *Every transaction is a prayer. Every signature is a confession.*
 - **The Unbroken Seal** — Mykkiel. *Contracts are sacred. To break one is to break the city.*
 - **The Tide Father** — Khemesh. *The canal’s hunger; the interest on a loan never repaid.*
 - **The Lantern Bearer** — The Traveler. *The light that guides lost ships — and lost debtors.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Saint Lazarus of the Unfinished Ledger (The Witness):** The Archivolt notaries keep a sealed archive of *unwritten contracts* — promises that were never stamped. The Order of the Witness claims that reading even one of these binds the reader to fulfil it. The Matron has never opened the archive. The Red Clerk has, and his inkwell is now a skull.
- **Saint Fina of the Dyed Veil (Isoka):** The Basilica of Azerin has a side chapel dedicated to the *Shedding Saint*, whose mosaic shows a silkworm breaking its cocoon. Pilgrims who leave a confession there wake the next morning having forgotten one sin — but also one kindness they received. The Guildmistress permits the chapel because the offerings keep the silk guilds wealthy.
- **The Weavers of Mercy (The Silk-Shrouded):** A hospice near the Salt Gate is run by grey-robed healers who ask no payment. They are tolerated because they treat wounded condottieri for free, but the Black Purse faction suspects they also erase debts — ledgers left near their doors have been found blank. The Order’s rule: “You do not pay back. You pay forward. But woe to the one who strikes a healer.”
- **The Ledger of Unbroken Promises (The Syndicate Seal):** A small but influential order of notaries based in the Archivolt. They adjudicate disputes over contracts, cargo claims, and bridge tolls. Their judgments are always delivered in triplicate, and they accept no bribes — only binding oaths. Those who lie before a Covenant judge find that their next three shipments are impounded.
- **The Ninth:** In any Silkstrand scene, the ninth bridge crossed in a day leads somewhere unexpected. The wise stop at eight and take a boat. Those who cross the ninth are said to hear a faint laugh from the water — and their contracts are never quite fulfilled.

Silkstrand Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Canal:** Toss a crust into the water before crossing a new bridge. Ignore the first *Bridge Riot* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

- **Knot the Thread:** Tie a single knot in a scrap of silk. Cancel *Seal Counterfeit* or take −1 die on your next negotiation (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Water:** Whisper a debtor’s name into the canal at dawn. Gain +1 Effect when collecting from them this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Archivolt. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **city watch or rival merchants**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **crowds or bridge traffic**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or customs**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Bridge bailiff or guildmaster** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **crowd movement or flood**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival merchant or hired bravo** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **condottieri, smugglers, or guild enforcers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes — **flood hits/contract voided/duel declared**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **The Matron, Watch Captain, or Guildmistress** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically — **flood rises/bridge collapses/procession blocks streets**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice — **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Silkstrand (Bridges & Trade):** Bridge planks shift underfoot, bargains restructure mid-speech, coins change hands without touch.

- **Silkstrand (Canals):** Water levels rise without warning, gondolas block routes, a sudden fog hides a rival’s approach.
- **Silkstrand (Duel Culture):** Challenges are issued mid-conversation, seconds appear from the crowd, honor prices rise with each breath.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Stealth):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Fog Bank*.
- **Cut the Bridge (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a bridge token is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Flood (Resolve + Athletics):** On a hit in *Flood Siren*, you pick who keeps their footing; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Corseted Ledger (cursed accounting bound in silk)** — *Phases:* Friendly Audit → Retroactive Debts → Names as Collateral. *Cracks:* burn one forged seal in public; settle a rival’s debt at cost; wash the book on Flood-Stairs at high bell.
- **Archivolt Ragman (collector of “missing recitals”)** — *Phases:* Quiet Inserts → Paper Hunts → Bridge Vetoes. *Cracks:* win a duel for precedent; expose a double-entry altar; break his pen with the Matron’s Seal.
- **The Tide of Unpaid Interest (a walking loan)** — *Phases:* Grace Period → Collection → Foreclosure. *Cracks:* pay in stories; find the original debtor; renegotiate the contract under a neutral bridge.

Patronage & Power

In Silkstrand, power flows through commerce, connections, and the careful weaving of influence. The Matron maintains control through a web of guilds, factors, and condottieri, each bound by contracts and customs that shift like the tides. Merchants rise and fall with the Exchange, while the city’s bravos and smugglers operate in the spaces between law and profit.

For the GM: Patronage in Silkstrand revolves around access — to bridges, to warehouses, to the Exchange floor itself. Rewards often take the form of permits, seals, or safe passage that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, tokens, contracts) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival guilds issue conflicting charters, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the bridges, markets, and Exchange as arenas for social contests, where reputation and connections determine success.

In Silkstrand, your word is your bond, and your bond determines whether you rise or drown.

Chapter 22

The Ways Between

Spiritways & Veilways. Between Death and Dreams lies a country of crossings. Roads remember promises; milestones remember names you never spoke. The Ways Between do not measure miles—they measure choices. Walk softly, pay what the path asks, and mind which version of you arrives.

22.1 The Ways Between — Obishaal, the Realm of Dreams and Death

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Every dream is a door. Every door is a judgment. The dead dream forever; the living borrow their sleep.*

The Wayfinder (Elite): “I exist only in the moment of choice, the breath between one path and another. Obishaal is not a place—it is a *state*. To guide here is to understand that every dream leads somewhere, but only the virtuous know which somewhere is worth the waking.”

Lost Pilgrim (Commoner): “The dead don’t leave. They just change addresses. Obishaal is their new neighborhood, and the rent is paid in virtue. If you’re lucky, you’ll only visit. If you’re not... you’ll find yourself climbing stairs that never end, and every landing offers a bargain you can’t refuse.”

Genre / Mood: Dream-death metaphysical, virtue-based ascent, temptation and fall, folk-surrealism.

Starting Location: A crossroad shrine of black glass stones, where travelers meet their reflections coming the other way. The shrine is silent except for the soft hum of the stones. A Backwards Pilgrim stands at the crossroads, facing the direction you came from. “The Thirteenth Stone speaks,” they say. “But the path chooses who arrives. What did you bury on the road here? The stones can smell it. And in Obishaal, every buried thing dreams of waking.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Ways Between is a transit way, the eternal crossroads through Obishaal, the element of Dreams and Death, the eighth element after Fire, Life, Air, Fortune, Earth, Fate, Water, Dreams/Death. It is the realm where the settled dead go not to oblivion but to an *ideal afterlife*—a dream that reflects the life they lived. A farmer dreams of endless harvest; a warrior dreams of eternal battle; a merchant dreams of ledgers that never close. These dreams are real, and they are paradise or prisons.

The living may enter the Ways through thresholds of sleep, near-death, or deliberate ritual. Once inside, they find a landscape that shifts with their own psyche—but also with the weight of their choices. **To ascend** through the layers of Obishaal, a traveler must demonstrate *virtue*: honesty, courage, mercy, self-sacrifice. **To fall** is to yield to *vice*: greed, cowardice, cruelty, despair. Each layer is a test, and each test is a dream that tempts you to fail.

At the very bottom, pressed into the silt of the deepest dream, lies **Ikasha**, She Who Sleeps. Her sisters Inaea and Isoka imprisoned her there eons ago, for Ikasha dreamed of summoning and confronting the Clockwork Monad—a confrontation that, in their judgment, would unmake reality. Now Ikasha dreams fitfully, and her nightmares seep upward, infecting the layers above. Sometimes a traveler who falls far enough can hear her voice, offering escape in exchange for service—a service that would free her.

Between the layers drift the dead who have not yet found their final dream. They are the *Unsettled*, and they will trade memories, secrets, and virtues for a chance to ascend—or to pull you down with them.

What you notice first: The air tastes of copper and old keys. Your footsteps echo half a beat too late. The waystones are warm—and they pulse like hearts.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never answer a question asked by a reflection. The answer will bind you to the path you did not choose.

Regional Mood: The Dream That Remembers

Here, the dream is not a thing—it is a witness. It remembers every promise made at a deathbed, every lie told to a dying ear, every virtue you failed to keep. Obishaal does not forgive, but it does not forget either. It offers passage in exchange for truth. The longer you stay, the more the dream learns about you. By the time you reach your destination, you may find that the destination knows you better than you know yourself. Some travelers never leave. They become dream-echoes, their faces pressed into the glass of a forgotten dream, their names still warm on the lips of the next pilgrim.

(Path/Crossing/Threshold) Mist-shrouded ford where water runs uphill; footsteps echo backwards; bone-lit corridor where shadows walk the walls.

Spades — Places (Dream Layers)

2. **Mist-Ford of First Doubt** — Water runs uphill; footsteps echo backwards through time. '[THRESHOLD]' *The ford shows you wading through your own past. Do not look down at the water.*
3. **Bone Corridor of Unfinished Business** — Shadows walk the walls but never touch the floor; light as memory. '[DEATH]' *The bones are from those who chose vice and fell. They*

shift when you blink.

4. **Threshold Arch of Virtue** — Shows a reflection as someone you might have been; the past as a mirror. '[TRUTH]' *The reflection has a scar you never got. It asks how you avoided it.*
5. **Spiral Path of Recursion** — Ascends but returns to the same stone marker; the journey as meditation. '[MAGIC]' *Each loop, the stone moves closer to the center. Or you do.*
6. **Promise Bridge of the Unsettled** — Cross with a vow and it remembers your debt; an oath as a toll. '[OATH]' *The bridge's planks are old letters. Read one, and you may owe the writer.*
7. **Crossroads of the Ninth Choice** — All four paths lead to the same destination, but different tomorrows. '[THRESHOLD]' *The center stone is warm. A coin placed there will vanish—or be accepted.*
8. **Stone Circle of Forgotten Villages** — Marks where a village used to be; the houses are now constellations. '[DEATH]' *The stars are too close. You can touch them. They crumble like ash.*
9. **Memory Tunnel of the Dying** — Hear the thoughts of those who passed here; the past as an echo. '[MEMORY]' *The thoughts are in a language you almost understand. One word is your name.*
10. **Fossil Stairs of Ascension** — Each step is an eye that watches your ascent; the climb as scrutiny. '[FEAR]' *The eyes belong to those who fell here. They blink in sequence.*
- J **Waystation of the Virtuous** — The keeper trades in unfinished conversations; words as currency. '[SOCIAL]' *The keeper has no face. It wears the faces of those who paused too long.*
- Q **Junction of Vice and Virtue** — Paths physically collide; you must choose which reality to follow. '[THRESHOLD]' *The collision sounds like breaking glass. The glass reforms into a door.*
- K **Long Mile of Temptation** — The road stretches differently for each traveler; distance as perception. '[MAGIC]' *You are the only one walking. The others are already at the end.*
- A **The Thirteenth Stone — Ikasha's Seal** — Where the path reveals its true destination; truth as revelation. '[TRUTH]' *The stone whispers. The whisper is a promise you made to yourself and broke. Beneath it, the stone is warm—and dreaming.*

(Wayfarer/Spirit/Dream-walker) Lost pilgrim who thinks they're going home but forgot where; toll-taker accepting payment in forgotten memories.

Hearts — Travelers & Guides

2. **Lost Pilgrim** — Thinks they're going home but forgot where; destination as a memory. '[TRAVEL]' *Their pack is full of stones. Each stone is a forgotten promise.*
3. **Toll-Taker (Virtue Assessor)** — Accepts payment in virtues you didn't know you had. '[SOCIAL]' *Their scales weigh truth and echo. A balanced scale means you pass—for now.*
4. **Wayward Guide** — Directions technically correct, morally questionable. '[TRAVEL]' *They point with a broken compass. The needle spins, but the path is true.*
5. **Dream-Merchant** — Carries a sack of nightmares and one perfect dream for sale. '[MAGIC]' *The perfect dream is their own. They are selling it because they cannot wake up.*
6. **Child-Ghost of Unfinished Life** — Knows shortcuts but charges in riddles; wisdom as a puzzle. '[DEATH]' *The riddles have no answer—only a choice. Choose wrong, and you*

become a child.

7. **Wounded Walker (Vice-Bound)** — Bleeding metaphor; their pain grows thorns along the path. '[FEAR]' *The thorns have faces. Each face is someone they failed to save.*
8. **Map-Merchant of Impossible Dreams** — Selling maps to places that don't exist yet; the future as a commodity. '[TRUTH]' *The maps change as you watch. The destination is always one page ahead.*
9. **Guide-Dog (Ancestral Spirit)** — Made of shadow and starlight; follows those who walk with purpose. '[SPIRIT]' *It never barks. It whines when you are about to make a mistake.*
10. **Backwards Pilgrim (Dream-Echo)** — Moving through time; their steps erase what just happened. '[MEMORY]' *They are walking toward their birth. Every step, they forget something.*
- J **Soul-Ferryman** — Carries the luggage of the living; a burden as a service. '[DEATH]' *The luggage is full of things you never said. The ferryman knows them all.*
- Q **Road's Child (Dream-Kin)** — Born where paths crossed, raised by waymarks; navigation as instinct. '[TRAVEL]' *They have no navel. They were never born—they simply began.*
- K **Dead-Road Keeper** — Ensures proper passage for those who should not walk. '[DEATH]' *Their lantern burns a cold blue. The flame does not flicker.*
- A **The Wayfinder (Dream Avatar)** — Exists only in the moment a choice is made; a decision as an entity. '[LEGEND]' *They are every guide you ever needed. They are also every road you refused.*

(Veil-Thin/Dream-Bleed/Wayward) Path loops back to show your funeral preparations; reality thins—you see the dreams of sleeping travelers; Ikasha's nightmare bleeds into the upper layers.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Funeral Loop** — The path shows your funeral preparations; death as a destination. '[DEATH]' '[FEAR]' *The mourners are people you have not met yet. They seem to know you well.*
3. **Reality Thins (Ikasha's Dream Bleed)** — You see the dreams of sleeping travelers; the boundary as a veil. '[MAGIC]' *A dreamer mutters your name. They are dreaming of a choice you will make tomorrow.*
4. **Waymark Lies (Vice's Test)** — Points the wrong way; trust leads to places that never were. '[TRUTH]' *The waymark has a crack. Through the crack, you see a path you should have taken.*
5. **Dream-Bleed** — Waking memories become someone else's nightmares. '[MEMORY]' '[FEAR]' *You remember a childhood fear that was not yours. It still terrifies you.*
6. **Toll Demanded (Virtue Payment)** — Currency you did not know you carried; payment as a revelation. '[SOCIAL]' '[DEBT]' *The toll is a secret you told a dead person. They are now standing behind you.*
7. **Path Split (Virtue vs. Vice)** — Each version of you remembers differently; identity as a choice. '[MAGIC]' *One you is smiling. One you is weeping. One you is already walking away.*
8. **Gravity Shifts (Guilt's Weight)** — Emotional weight grows physically heavy; a burden as physics. '[WEATHER]' *Your pack feels heavier. Inside is a regret you forgot you carried.*

9. **Time-Sickness (Dream Chronology)** — You arrive before you left; paradox shadows follow. '[MAGIC]' *Your past self waves at you. Do not wave back.*
10. **Truth Payment (Ikasha's Price)** — The road remembers your lies and demands truth as payment. '[TRUTH]' '[DEBT]' *The lie is carved on a stone. The stone is warm. It knows your temperature.*
- J **Crossroads Judgment (Virtue Audit)** — The path you chose judges the ones you did not; decision as karma. '[TRUTH]' '[SOCIAL]' *A ghost of the road not taken asks why. You have one sentence to answer.*
- Q **Memory-Thief (Unsettled Dead)** — A rest stop keeper pays in counterfeit recollections. '[MEMORY]' '[SOCIAL]' *The memory is almost right. The color of the sky is wrong.*
- K **Forbidden Path (Ikasha's Descent)** — Opens only for those already lost; loss as a key. '[DEATH]' *The path smells of old tears. You taste salt on your lips.*
- A **Convergence (Ikasha's Waking)** — All travelers arrive together, none recall how; arrival as a mystery. '[MAGIC]' '[LEGEND]' *You recognize everyone. You have never seen any of them before. The air tastes of honey and rust. Ikasha is dreaming of you.*

(True Name/Safe Passage/Waywisdom) Waymark that always points toward your next important choice; a token of passage that the road recognizes as belonging.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Choice Compass (Virtue's Needle)** — Always points toward your next important choice. '[TRAVEL]' *The needle is a splinter of the Thirteenth Stone. It hums when you are near a decision.*
3. **Passage Token (Dream-Marked)** — The road recognizes you as one who belongs. '[SOCIAL]' *The token is a braid of your own hair. You do not remember cutting it.*
4. **Dream-Catcher** — Filters nightmares from your rest; sleep as a sanctuary. '[MAGIC]' *The catcher is woven from old promises. It smells of lavender and regret.*
5. **Truth-Compass (Ikasha's Fragment)** — Points to what you most need to know, not what you want. '[TRUTH]' *The compass has no needle. The housing spins until you speak a truth.*
6. **Memory-Anchor** — Keeps you from losing yourself on deeper paths. '[MEMORY]' *The anchor is a river stone. Your name is carved on it in a language you have never seen.*
7. **Safe Haven (Virtue's Rest)** — A guaranteed rest stop without complication. '[TRAVEL]' *The haven is a dry arch. The arch is a doorframe with no door.*
8. **Guide-Light (Virtue's Beacon)** — Burns the color of your truest intention; purpose as a beacon. '[SOCIAL]' *The light is blue. Blue means you are honest. Red means you are not.*
9. **Path-Cutter (Dream Shears)** — Cuts distance through metaphor, not space. '[MAGIC]' *The cutter is a pair of shears. Cut a memory, and the road between here and there vanishes.*
10. **Debt-Clearing (Virtue's Mercy)** — The road forgives one obligation you thought you owed. '[DEBT]' *The obligation was to a dead person. They are no longer dead on this path.*
- J **Crossroads Boon** — Choose among three paths, each exactly where you need to be. '[LEGEND]' *The paths are labeled: Regret, Forgive, Forget. Choose carefully.*
- Q **Way-Wisdom (Dream-Logic)** — Understand the language of paths and signs for one journey. '[TRAVEL]' *The waystones whisper. They are complaining about the last traveler. It*

was you.

- K **Grace Passage (Virtue's Shield)** — Walk safely through any dangerous crossing for one night. '[TRAVEL]' *The grace is a bell. Ring it, and the road will pretend not to see you.*
- A **Road's Name (Ikasha's True Name)** — Call the path by its true name and command its nature. '[LEGEND]' *The name is a single syllable. Speaking it will change the road—and you.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (true names/safe passages/waywisdom) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **dream-road** motifs—reflections that lie, paths that judge, destinations that choose the traveler. Also, the presence of an Ace hints that Ikasha's dream is particularly close.

Additional Features

- **Dream-Logic Navigation:** Any Ace introduces a metaphysical requirement (a sacrifice, a taboo, an exchange) that must be satisfied to pass. Name it at the table; the road will enforce it.
- **Reflection Points:** Face cards (J, Q, K) show alternate selves or unlived choices. Treat them as temporary NPCs or scene tags that can help, hinder, or tempt.
- **Memory Currency:** Diamonds may be traded for knowledge or safe passage as if they were memories. Describe the memory paid; the path (or its keeper) pays in kind.
- **Virtue and Vice Clocks:** Each character in Obishaal tracks a small personal **Virtue** [3] and **Vice** [3] clock. Virtue advances when they act with honesty, courage, mercy, or self-sacrifice. Vice advances when they act with greed, cowardice, cruelty, or despair. When one clock fills, the character **ascends** (Virtue) to a higher layer of Obishaal or **falls** (Vice) to a lower one. Ascension offers a boon; falling offers a temptation (a cursed gift from the layer's vice-spirit). The clocks reset after each layer transition. Reaching the bottom (Vice filled in the deepest layer) allows Ikasha to speak directly to the character.
- **Ikasha's Whisper (Patron Intervention):** When a character falls to the lowest layer (or deliberately seeks her out), they may hear Ikasha's voice. She offers a *Fragment of Freedom*: +2 dice to any roll involving escape, secrecy, or breaking bonds, but each use marks 1 **Obligation to Ikasha** and advances a **Waking Dream** [6] clock. When that clock fills, Ikasha uses the character as a vessel to attempt an escape—a campaign-level event.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Unnamed Guide** — The Traveler. *The road that appears only when you are lost.*
 - **The Mirror Listener** — The Witness. *The reflection that tells you what you need to hear, never what you want.*
 - **The Threshold Child** — The Sealed Gate. *The one who was never born, who guards the places where paths end.*
 - **The Echo King** — The Ninth. *The voice that answers when you speak to the empty road.*

- **The Dreamer Below** — Ikasha (imprisoned). *She who sleeps and dreams of waking. Her whispers are bargains; her freedom is a promise.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord know the Ways Between as the Cord’s shadow. A lost Hollowed wanders here, its thread trailing into the mist. Follow it, and you may find a Sister who cut herself free—and who now tends Ikasha’s dream.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** Saikou Ira’s silver mirror shows the Ways Between as a tangled knot of unfulfilled obligations. He has walked three paths here. He will not speak of the fourth, where he glimpsed Ikasha’s face.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends lies at every crossroads. Pick it up, and the road will offer you a shortcut—but the coin will reappear in your pocket at the next junction, heavier. In Obishaal, the coin is warm and pulses like a heartbeat.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Psions call the Ways Between “the Stair.” They climb it in their dreams, trading memories for glimpses of paths not yet walked. Some never wake. The Grey Wanderer claims that the Stair is Ikasha’s spine.
- **The Ninth:** On any path in the Ways Between, the ninth step you take in a straight line will land on a threshold you did not see. The wise take eight steps, then pause to look around. In Obishaal, the ninth step is always a dream of falling.

Ways Between Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Stones:** Crumble a crust at the base of a waystone. Ignore the first *Waymark Lies* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Path:** Tie a single knot in a piece of string and hang it from a milestone. Cancel *Path Split* or take –1 die on your next navigation roll (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Crossroads:** Whisper a dead traveler’s name into the center stone. Gain +1 Effect when bargaining with a Toll-Taker this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Wayfinder. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **path keepers** or **wayward spirits**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **travelers** or **memory echoes**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers** or **reflection points**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favorable path alignment**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** Toll-taker or wayward guide becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **path shift** or **reality thinning**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **memory-thief** or **forbidden path entity** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.

- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **wayward spirits, path entities, or alternate selves** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **path loops/time shifts/reality fractures**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **The Wayfinder, Dead-Road Keeper, or Road's Child** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **reality thins/paths converge/time loops**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Obishaal (Dream-Logic):** Paths rearrange without warning, reflections speak unbidden, destinations shift mid-journey. A character may hear Ikasha's whisper as a free omen (the GM may spend 1 SB to make it a false omen).
- **Obishaal (Memory Currency):** Memories become tangible, forgotten knowledge resurfaces, past and present blur. Trading a memory here may also tick the *Virtue* or *Vice* clock depending on the memory's nature.
- **Obishaal (Virtue and Vice):** Decisions echo forward, alternate selves appear, paths judge moral weight. The GM may spend SB to force a character to test a virtue (e.g., "Resist the temptation to lie") or to offer a vice that ticks their Vice clock.

Path-Moves & Procedures (Optional Depth)

Weighing of Steps (Travel Move) When the company enters a liminal path (Mist-Ford, Bone Corridor, etc.), choose one:

- **Pay the Toll:** Each PC names a small truth or a fond memory (GM: 1 SB banked, +1 Position on navigation).
- **Refuse the Toll:** +1d on Speed, but start a **Way-Debt** [4] clock.
- **Bargain the Toll:** Trade a *Diamond* reward as if it were a memory (see Memory Exchange below); cancel one imminent *Club* card in this scene.

When **Way-Debt** fills, trigger *Crossroads Judgment* at the next junction.

Reflection Duel (Social/Moral Test) When confronted by an alternate self or *Reflection Point*, state what that self wants from you and roll your best social action.

- **Success:** Gain a *Guide-Light* tag for the scene and clear 1 tick from **Paths Decide**.

- **Mixed:** Trade places for one exchange or take a **Condition: Disoriented**.
- **Miss:** The reflection walks away with one of your *Diamonds* (GM picks the most narratively apt).

Memory Exchange (Rates & Risks)	Memory Offered	Buys You	Sid
	A childhood smell, a forgotten nickname	+1 Position on one crossing	A f for
	A first failure or small betrayal	Cancel one minor Complication	Yo ogr
	A true fear you have never spoken	<i>Guide-Light</i> or <i>Way-Cord</i> -like effect	A c nig
	The details of a kept promise	<i>Safe Passage</i> for the party	An mis
	The meaning behind a scar	Convert one <i>Club</i> into <i>Trace</i> only	Th unt
	A perfect day (all details)	Treat the next <i>Heart</i> face as an ally	Sta the

Exchange Rule: If you pay the same *kind* of memory twice in a journey, start **Hollowing** [4]. When it fills, you gain the *Backwards Pilgrim* tag until you reclaim what was lost.

Way-Keys & Taboos (d6)

1. **Speak Last:** Only the final word said at a gate is true; others are “practice.” First speakers take –1d on their next test.
2. **Step Odd:** Crossings require an odd number of steps; even counts loop you back one scene.
3. **Name Nothing:** True names wake *Name-Theft*; use titles or lose a *Diamond*.
4. **Wet Iron:** A drop of water on iron cancels one glamour once per scene.
5. **Back Gift:** Leave something behind to go forward; refuse and tick **Way-Debt**.
6. **Answer Bent:** Answer a waystone’s question with a metaphor, not a fact, or trigger *Truth Payment*.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Archivist of Unmade Roads (cloak stitched from surveyor’s cords)** — *Phases:* Receipts of Refusal → Stay of Journey → Unfiled Options. *Cracks:* a **Choice Compass** reveals the true path; a **Debt-Clearing** voids his claim.
- **The Toll-Matriarch Beneath the Bridge (many hands, one voice like wet stone)** — *Phases:* Truth Payment → Debt-Clearing → Forbidden Path. *Cracks:* a **Passage Token** marks you as belonging; a **Road’s Name** commands her to stand aside.
- **The Wayfinder’s Shadow (your silhouette, two steps ahead)** — *Phases:* Crossroads Judgment → Guide-Light → Haste Mark. *Cracks:* a **Memory-Anchor** keeps you grounded; a **Grace Passage** slips past its gaze.
- **Ikasha’s Nightmare (Dream-Eater)** — Appears only in the deepest layer. *Phases:* Whispers → Temptation → Consumption. *Cracks:* a **Virtue** filled clock can be spent to reject the nightmare; a memory of true self-sacrifice (cost 1 permanent Bond) banishes it entirely.

Encounter Seeds (quick hooks)

- **The Promise Bridge's Receipt:** An old vow you never spoke was logged here. To cross, define when you would have sworn it—and to whom.
- **Thirteenth Stone Auction:** The stone sells three possible endings. Each bidder is you from a different failure.
- **Bone Corridor Choir:** Shadows sing a name wrong by one letter. Correct it and gain *Truth-Compass*; ignore it and start **Name-Theft**.
- **Ikasha's Finger Bone:** A character finds a bone that pulses with dream-light. If they hold it while sleeping, they can speak to Ikasha directly—but each time, the **Waking Dream** clock ticks.

Extensions (Plug-in)

Choice Dial (Resolve ↔ Drift) Track the party's footing between firm intent and wandering.

- *Resolve High:* +1 Position on *Path Split* tests; the first *Dream-Bleed* each session hits harder (start at 2).
- *Drift High:* +1 Effect when bargaining with way-entities; the first *Truth Payment* each session costs a cherished *detail*.
- Center the Dial by naming aloud the next choice *and* why you might refuse it; clear 1 tick from **Way-Debt**.

Counter-Seal (once/scene, if justified) Break a single metaphysical instruction (taboo, key, or omen) by presenting a memory in symbol form (a token, a letter, a sketch). Gain +1d on that crossing; the GM banks 1 SB as a *Marked Consequence* to spend when reflections return.

Start-of-Scene Murmurs (1d6)

1. *Second Sunrise:* light arrives twice; your first missed navigation roll becomes a mixed success.
2. *Name Draft:* the air steals a syllable; your next lie sounds true once.
3. *Echo Debt:* your footprints owe a step—skip a square or tick **Way-Debt** +1.
4. *Pale Bell:* time hiccups; the first *Club* can be delayed until the end of the scene.
5. *Traveler's Chorus:* distant voices agree with you; +1d on appeals to path entities.
6. *Hollow Weather:* rain that does not wet; conditions look dire but impose no penalties this scene.

Plug-in SB Conversions (Obishaal Flavor)

- 1 SB → *Footprint Vote:* your tracks choose a different direction; increase DV by 1 on any roll that relies on following a trail.
- 2 SB → *Echo of Refusal:* a choice you avoided manifests as a minor obstacle (a locked gate, a forgotten toll). If the choice involved a vice, also tick the Vice clock of the character who refused.
- 3+ SB → *Threshold Cracks:* the path fractures; gain a temporary **Path-Cutter** effect but start **Convergence** [4] (all travelers you have met will arrive together at the next junction). Additionally, Ikasha's dream seeps through the cracks; each character hears a single word of her voice.

Cross-Regional Conversions (Using Diamonds Across the Map)

- *Valewood*: **Road's Name** may count as a *Valeheart Clause* once if spoken under leaves; doing so creates **Court Tithe** [2].
- *Mistlands*: **Grace Passage** functions as *Pall Indulgence* over one levee crown at night; ring a bell afterward or start **Witchlight Count**.
- *Vhasia*: **Way-Wisdom** can be presented as “pilgrim right” to bypass one *Interdict* barrier; begin a **Parlement Divided** tick.
- *Viterra*: **Passage Token** can be notarized into a temporary *Ferry Priority*; on use, advance **Border-Lace**.
- *Ubral*: **Memory-Anchor** counts as a *Guest-Token* at one hearth if you recount a family road-tale.
- *Silkstrand*: **Path-Cutter** doubles as a night-boat route once; spend 1 favor with a smuggler or trigger *Seal Counterfeit*.
- *Linn*: **Choice Compass** acts as a *Pilot's Token* in a reed-maze if you pay a name to the water.
- *Theona*: **Crossroads Boon** allows counting “eight-and-one” to cross an *Uncounted Bridge* safely once.

Patronage & Power

In Obishaal, power flows through understanding the metaphysical nature of dreams, the ability to navigate virtue and vice, and the careful management of obligations to the dead and to Ikasha herself. The true authorities are those who know the True Names of dream-layers, can mediate between the living and the Unsettled, and understand the currency of virtue.

For the GM: Patronage in Obishaal revolves around guidance, safe passage, and the ability to navigate moral tests. Rewards often take the form of dream-tokens, fragments of Ikasha's memory, or knowledge of a layer's True Name. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (compasses, anchors, bells) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided by the dream itself.
- Let rival guides (Virtue vs. Vice) issue conflicting directions, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the crossroads, waystations, and dream-layers as arenas for moral contests, where a single act of mercy can ascend you—and a single act of cruelty can damn you.

In Obishaal, your virtue is your power, and your power determines whether you wake or sleep forever.

Chapter 23

The Wilds

Roads, Ruins, and Weather. Between towns and treaties lies the patience of the land. Old roads remember armies; cairns remember names no book keeps. Law thins to trail-marks and favors, and the weather keeps its own counsel. Walk soft, read the wind, and bargain with whatever still listens.

23.1 The Wilds — “Roads, Ruins, and Weather”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The land walks when you don’t watch it, and the roads remember who bled on them.*

Claimant Chief (Elite): “These lands answer not to charters but to those who can read their signs and respect their moods. Authority here is earned one campfire at a time, by proving you understand the difference between claiming and belonging.”

Forager Child (Commoner): “The wilds don’t need your roads or your rules – they got their own ways of keeping score. Follow the cairns if you want to live, and always leave something behind to thank the land for letting you pass. Every hill hides a secret, and every hollow breathes.”

Genre / Mood: Hexcrawl wanderlust, ruin-haunted silence, weather as character.

Starting Location: A shelter hollow carved into a fallen giant’s ribcage, moss glowing faintly under starlight. A Forager Child offers a route-song: “The Bad Ground shifts, and the weather walks behind it. Sing with me, or walk alone.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Between towns and treaties lies the patience of the land. Old roads remember armies; cairns remember names no book keeps. In the Wilds, law thins to trail-marks and favors, and the weather keeps its own counsel. This is the country of the hexcrawl: a patchwork of hidden valleys, forgotten ruins, beast lairs, and the bones of failed settlements. No single authority rules here—instead, the land itself is the ledger, and every crossing writes a new line. Walk soft, read the wind, bargain with whatever still listens, and keep one eye on the horizon. The next hex may hold water, treasure, or teeth.

What you notice first: The silence after a bird stops singing. The way a cairn seems to have shifted since you passed it last. The smell of rain on dry stone, even when the sky is clear.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never sleep in a hollow that has soot on the ceiling without adding your own to the fire. The land knows the difference between a guest and a thief.

The Unfinished Map

The Wilds are not a route—they are a grid of secrets. Each day's march opens a new page. Some hexes are empty: water, fuel, a safe place to sleep. Others hold lairs, ruins, shrines, or the remnants of old wars. The GM should key a handful of interesting places in advance, then let the cards populate the space between. Draw a card for each new leg; let the suit and rank whisper what you find. The land does not repeat itself, but it echoes.

(Crossing/Lookout/Old Road) Crossing point with ford/ice-span/stepping logs/dune saddle/reef shelf; lookout knoll with wind-carved marker; old road trace with cairns half-eaten by terrain.

Spades — Places (Hex Terrain)

2. **Crossing Point** — Ford, ice-span, stepping logs, dune saddle, reef shelf. *The crossing has a price: a stone, a story, or a moment of silence. The water hums when it's satisfied.*
3. **Lookout Knoll** — Tor, cliff, dune, ridge with wind-carved marker. *From here, you can see three hexes in clear weather—and one that shouldn't exist, flickering like a heat-shaped lie.*
4. **Old Road** — Trace with cairns and switchbacks half-eaten by terrain. *The cobbles are worn smooth by ghosts. They whisper directions at dusk. The directions are always true, but never complete.*
5. **Shelter Hollow** — Overhang, cave, root cellar; soot says “used lately.” *The soot is layered in thin, greasy rings. Someone has been coming here for a very long time. The hollow smells of wet fur and old secrets.*
6. **Water Source** — Spring, seep, fog net, snow pan, guarded by thorns or stone. *The water tastes of iron and old bargains. Drink deep, but leave a coin—copper for a safe draw, silver for a question answered.*
7. **Windbreak** — Rock ribs, lee of pines, reed-wall berm. *The windbreak smells of woodsmoke and wool. Someone camped here last night. Their fire is still warm.*

8. **Ruined Outpost** — Watchstack, wayside shrine, marker pile. *The ruin’s flagstones are warm, as if a great beast sleeps beneath them. The air tastes of rust and thyme.*
9. **Bad Ground** — Sinkhole, bog crust, crevasse, loess slump. *The ground breathes—a slow, deep inhalation that lifts your heels. Step lightly or it will swallow you.*
10. **Gate Gully** — Pinch point between bluffs, dunes, or ice hummocks. *The gully has a name carved in the rock. The name changes every season. Carve yours, and you may never leave.*
- J **Boundary Row** — Totems, standing stones, prayer flags bent by weather. *The flags are faded. The last prayer was for rain—and it still hasn’t come. The totems have grown moss in the shape of faces.*
- Q **Worksite** — Abandoned mine, quarry, logging camp, salt pan. *The tools are scattered, but none are rusted. Whoever left did not plan to return—or has not yet finished.*
- K **Signal Height** — Old fire-pit or mirror stand; smoke stains linger. *Light the fire, and someone will answer. Whether they are friend or foe is your risk. The smoke always smells of your childhood.*
- A **Trail Nexus** — Migratory, pack, or contraband paths knot here. *Three trails meet, but only two are on any map. The third belongs to the dead. Their footprints point the wrong way.*

(Guide/Warden/Caravan) Forager child with truer maps than yours; guide with three routes and one price (changes daily).

Hearts — People & Factions (Hex Denizens)

2. **Forager Child** — Goat-herd or berry-picker with truer maps than yours. *Their map is drawn on a scrap of bark. It shows a path that disappears at a standing stone. The stone is not on any other map.*
3. **Guide** — Three routes and one price (changes daily); navigation as negotiation. *Their price is never coin. It is a favor, a secret, or a night’s watch. They will not tell you which until you arrive.*
4. **Warden Patrol** — Local badges, local laws, local patience; order as familiarity. *Their badge is a chipped sunburst. They serve a crown that no longer exists. The crown does not pay them. The land does.*
5. **Caravan Crew** — Drovers, porters, yarn-post hands trading speed for coin. *They know every shortcut and every ambush. They will share both—for a price. Their silence is purchased in stories.*
6. **Pilgrims** — Bound for a tucked-away shrine or stone; faith as a destination. *Their shrine has no name. The stone there is warm, and it answers questions poorly. It prefers to ask them.*
7. **Poachers** — Know every snare and shortcut; survival as expertise. *They wear the teeth of game wardens as necklaces. The game wardens are still alive. They are saving for a full set.*
8. **Hermit-Healer** — Dogs, geese, and opinions about weather; wisdom as isolation. *Their poultices smell of grave-moss. They work anyway. The dogs do not bark at strangers—they judge them.*
9. **Prospectors** — Salt, amber, iron, fungus; chasing rumors and glint. *Their claim is marked with a knot of red thread. Cross it, and they will shoot. The thread glows when a stranger’s foot touches it.*
10. **War-Band** — Reavers or “escorts,” depending on your purse; violence as commerce. *Their*

banner is a painted skull. The paint is from a dead comrade's blood. They add a finger bone to the standard after every contract.

J Monster-Hunter — Rite-keeper wearing yesterday's trophies; death as livelihood. *Their trophy is still warm. The monster's mate is close behind. They are not running—they are leading.*

Q Quartermaster — Ledgers first, hospitality second; supply as authority. *Their ledger is written in a code only they understand. The code is their life story. The margins are full of regrets.*

K Claimant Chief — Papers and spears to match; legitimacy as force. *Their papers are stained with water and blood. Both are still wet. The water came from a spring they poisoned. The blood from the spring's keeper.*

A The Stranger — Spirit-touched nomad or emissary; rules bend near them. *They have no shadow. The ground does not remember their footprints. Their voice echoes twice—once for them, once for the land.*

(Weather/Doubleback/Prowlers) Weather turn with heat snap/cold snap/fog/dust; double-back with tracks that loop; prowlers shadow with wolves/jackals/ghouls.

Clubs — Complications/Threats (Hex Hazards)

2. **Weather Turn** — Heat snap, cold snap, fog, dust; plans sag like wet leather. *The wind changes direction three times in an hour. Someone is watching. The air tastes of a season that hasn't come yet.*

3. **Doubleback** — Tracks loop; the navigator swears the land moved underfoot. *Your own footprints face you. They were made yesterday—or tomorrow. The toes point toward a future you have not chosen.*

4. **Prowlers Shadow** — Wolves, jackals, ghouls, seals, ravens by night; hunt as a company. *Their eyes reflect no light. Their teeth do. They are patient. They have been following since the last hex. You are only now noticing.*

5. **Route Blocked** — Deadfall, rockfall, dune shift, ice heave; the path as an obstacle. *The blockage was placed. The toolmarks are fresh. Whoever cleared this path did not want you to follow—or wanted you to take the other way.*

6. **Quarantine Sign** — Camp fever; wardens sniff your packs for death. *The sign is a ribbon tied in a figure-eight. Do not cross it. The ribbon is damp. It was tied recently. The wardens are still nearby.*

7. **Territorial Beast** — Charge, stampede, or swarm; your choice of which is wrong. *The beast's lair is nearby. You can smell it—old blood and older musk. The ground is warm. You are standing on its pantry.*

8. **Elemental Front** — Grassfire, peat-burn, canopy flare, blowing spindrift. *The fire moves against the wind. The wind is lying. The smoke writes a word in a language you almost understand. It is a warning.*

9. **Paper vs Spear** — Jurisdiction fight in the wilds stalls your day; law as argument. *Two officials, one road. Both have seals. Neither will show them. The seals are warm. They have been used recently—on death warrants.*

10. **Supply Pinch** — Water, fuel, or feed low; pick what starves first. *Your canteen is full. The*

water is from a source that dried up last year. You do not remember filling it. Someone did.

J **Pursuit** — Hunters or avengers follow; signs say “close.” *The tracks are one hour old. They are gaining. The hunters do not need to sleep. They have not slept for three days. Neither have you.*

Q **Bad Omen** — Will-lights, taboo day, saint bells silent; locals refuse to move. *The omen is written in bird droppings on a milestone. It is still accurate. The birds are watching. They are waiting for you to ignore it.*

K **General Alarm** — Levy, muster, evacuation; all tracks become checkpoints. *The alarm horn is cracked. It sounds like a scream. The scream is a name. The name is yours.*

A **Catastrophe** — Flood, whiteout, sandstorm, lahar; clocks jump like frightened deer. *The catastrophe has a name. The land remembers it. The land is shouting it now. The sound is the same as a heartbeat. Yours.*

(Cache/Pass/Favor) Cache token for hidden food or fuel stash; right-of-way pass recognized by a named trail; warden’s favor with an escort letter.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage (Hex Discoveries)

2. **Cache Token** — Key to a hidden food or fuel stash (once); preparation as power. *The token is a knucklebone. The stash is marked with a cairn that has one stone missing. The missing stone is the token.*

3. **Right-of-Pass** — Recognized marker for a named trail or crossing. *The marker is a notch carved in a milestone. The notch is shaped like a bird. The bird is an owl. The owl watches at dusk.*

4. **Warden’s Favor** — Escort letter; “they’re with us” as a shield. *The letter is stamped with a bell. The bell’s clapper is missing. The absence of sound is the signature.*

5. **Weather Window** — Good forecast and a narrow gate to use it. *The window is a single hour at dawn. The birds will tell you when. They will stop singing. That is the signal.*

6. **Water Deed** — Lawful draw at a scarce source; necessity as a right. *The deed is a clay cup. Break it, and the spring will flow—once. The cup’s shards can be traded for another deed. There are nine shards.*

7. **Route Song** — A map scrap that actually works; knowledge as navigation. *The song has eight verses. The ninth is humming. The humming is the sound of the road itself. It changes with the weather.*

8. **Remount Hire** — Fresh legs or hulls waiting at a post; speed as a service. *The remounts have no names. They answer to whistles and bribes. They remember every rider. They do not forgive cruelty.*

9. **Truce Cord** — Taboo exemption at a site (one scene); peace as a thread. *The cord is braided from wool and ash. Burn it to invoke the truce. The ash must be from the same fire that warmed the truce.*

10. **Toll Waiver** — A ferry, bridge, or reef gate honors this chit; passage as paper. *The chit is a dried leaf. The toll-keeper will not touch it. They will nod and wave you through. They will not speak.*

J **Rescue Debt** — Locals owe you (or you owe them); trade for labor or intel. *The debt is carved on a tally stick. Break it when the favor is done. The stick will not burn. It will only*

splinter.

- Q Private Audience** — A keeper, shrine-warden, or spirit of the place hears you alone. *The audience is held at midnight. The spirit wears your face. It asks only one question. You will answer truthfully.*
- K Road Commission** — Temporary authority over a stretch of wilds. *The commission is a whistle. Blow it, and the land will listen—once. The whistle is carved from a bone that was never alive.*
- A Earth's Exception** — One temporary rule-bend (cross during a storm, pass uncounted, beasts ignore you). *The exception is a secret. The land will forget it as soon as you use it. You will remember it every night for a year.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (cache/pass/favor) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, add a lingering omen of the land (a smell on the wind, a sound that carries too far, tracks that shift) that you can echo in later scenes.

Travel at a Glance (Fast Loose)

A journey through the Wilds is a series of choices, not a checklist. Before each leg (a day, a stretch of road, a single hex), the party picks two priorities from **Speed**, **Stealth**, **Safety**, **Survey**. Those become your edge; the others become vulnerabilities. The GM then frames a single roll based on the terrain and the weather's mood (see *Weather Whims*, below). Success means you find what you sought; a mixed result trades progress for a cost; a miss throws a complication from the *Clubs* table onto the path.

Weather Whims (d6, one per leg)

1. *Glass-clear* – long sight, easy navigation. +1 to Survey actions.
2. *Low fog* – stealth advantage, speed suffers. +1 to Stealth, –1 to Speed.
3. *Trickle rain* – tracks wash, cold bites. First navigation or tracking roll at –1 die.
4. *Dry cold / heat* – resources drain faster. Mark +1 supply strain at end of leg.
5. *Shifting wind* – smoke and scent lie. Reroll one die on a weather-related check, but the GM may bank 1 SB.
6. *Omen sky* (aurora, sun-dog, three moons) – the land is listening. The GM may ask one player to answer a single question about the party's future.

Making Camp When you stop, choose one *boon* and accept one *risk*:

- **Boon:** heal a piece of gear; clear 1 Fatigue; scout tomorrow's weather; share a story with a road spirit (gain a *Truce Cord*).
- **Risk:** thin shelter (next weather hits harder); smoky fire (attracts prowlers); exposed approach (ambush more likely); hungry neighbors (locals or beasts appear).

A road spirit’s favour requires a small offering—a pinch of salt, a dropped coin, a whispered truth. Be polite.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord use certain shelter hollows as waystations. A renegade Sister has hidden a Hollowed in a ruined outpost; the child has not moved in weeks.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** Old Roads are Class II Anchor sites—ghosts of imperial surveyors still measure the miles. Saikou Ira would leave a silver coin at every milestone.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends lies at the bottom of every spring. Take it, and the water will never run dry—but the spring will remember your face.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Wilds psions are called “Stone-Listeners.” They hear the memory of old trails. Claimant chiefs pay well for their services—and dispose of those who hear too much.
- **The Ninth:** In any Wilds scene, the ninth cairn you pass in a day will be warm. Leave an offering, or the path will forget you.

Wilderness Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Cairn:** Crumble a crust at a boundary stone. Ignore the first *Bad Ground* penalty.
- **Knot the Trail:** Tie a single knot in a piece of grass at a crossing. Cancel *Doubleback* or take –1 die on your next navigation roll (your choice).
- **Name to the Spring:** Whisper a dead traveler’s name into a water source. Gain +1 Effect when foraging this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the land.

Patronage & Power

In the Wilds, power flows through knowledge of the land, the ability to navigate without formal authority, and the careful cultivation of local relationships. True authority comes from understanding weather patterns, reading tracks, and maintaining the favor of both human inhabitants and the spirits of place. Those who can provide safe passage, find water in dry times, or mediate between conflicting claims hold the most influence.

For the GM: Patronage in the Wilds revolves around practical knowledge, local customs, and the ability to provide essential services like navigation, shelter, and supply. Rewards often take the form of tokens, passes, and local knowledge that can be leveraged into greater safety and efficiency. To emphasise the hexcrawl feel:

- Key 6–10 interesting hexes before the session, then use the generator to fill the rest.
- Let the party discover new routes, short cuts, and hidden lairs through successful scouting or lucky finds.
- Use the *Roads Move*, *Weather Wakes*, and *Local Resentment* clocks (from the hexcrawl procedures) to create a living, reactive wilderness—or simply let the cards speak.
- Offer Diamonds as “exploration rewards” that unlock new options (a cache token, a safe passage, a local ally).

In the Wilds, your skill is your standing, and your standing determines whether you survive or perish.

Terrain Stock (d20)

Roll or choose a striking detail to dress a hex.

1. Fresh ash on an old fire ring; prints circle *around* it.
2. Boundary totems toppled but re-stack themselves if watched politely.
3. Broken wagon with salt-vein crystals growing through spokes.
4. Singing culvert; echo names the boldest listener wrongly.
5. Weather bell hung in a pine; tolling swaps rain and wind.
6. Cairn with a copper coin balanced on edge; don't breathe hard.
7. Fence of antlers pointing uphill; follow and skip one *Bad Ground*.
8. Mummified pack-beast wearing a courier's braid; letter hums.
9. Pebble mosaic of an old levy call; stepping it summons wardens.
10. Fossil rib arch; shelter under it and dream of tomorrow's route.
11. Abandoned hunter's cache; choice of food or rumor, not both.
12. Mirror-puddle; shows last night's sky whatever the hour.
13. Rope bridge made of prayer knots; one is freshly cut.
14. Scare-stakes dressed in saltcloth; something big respects them.
15. Stone with bite-marks; taste iron and remember a shortcut.
16. Old road mile-post defaced into a saint; offerings still fresh.
17. Thistle patch buzzing with coin-flies; feed them copper for safe passage.
18. Fallen giant's footprint now a pond; frogs chant a route-song.
19. Soot writing on cliff: *Storm at Second Bell*. It's right.
20. Hollow tree full of carved names; the newest is yours.

Lair Seeds (One-Page Crawls)

d12 quick lair hooks. Each can be a single session's focus.

1. **Fen Clockworks** — Bog-gears turn under peat; each tooth a drowned oath.
2. **Dry River Gallery** — Petroglyphs re-arrange at dusk; wrong reading summons bramble knights.
3. **Ice-Well Vault** — Stairs drilled through permafrost; breath blooms frost-runes that answer questions badly.
4. **Sunken Forum** — Pillars knee-deep in silt; rust moths nest in the rostrum.
5. **Pilgrim Kilns** — Charcoal mounds hike on stilt roots at night; a hermit-healer bargains weather for charcoal.
6. **Hanging Salt Chapel** — White stalactites ring like bells; grave-eels coil in the font.
7. **Thorn Maze Mill** — Waterwheel turns without water; phase panthers pace the sluice.
8. **Brewer's Hollow** — Barrels of wind; decant a gale or drink a calm.
9. **Antler Archive** — Ledger carved on horn; theft awakens the cairn-wights' accountant.
10. **Black Lantern Mines** — Lantern-eyes nest like bats; light buys silence, darkness buys passage.
11. **Stormbone Spire** — Vertebrae tower; earth-sharks circle beneath like sharks in sand.
12. **Amber Orchard** — Trees fossilised mid-sway; trapped thunderflies grant *Weather Window*

when freed.

Wilderness Bestiary

A palette of strange creatures, each with *signs* (what you notice before it sees you) and a *hook* (how to engage or avoid).

- **Earth-Sharks** — Burrow beneath loess and tundra; dorsal ridges like plowshares. *Signs:* furrows that breathe; pebbles rattle. *Hook:* lure with drumbeats or goat bells.
- **Phase Panthers** — Shadow-striped cats that step between gusts. *Signs:* pawprints offset from themselves. *Hook:* mirrored water or bell-silver disrupts the blink.
- **Rust Moths** — Swarms that taste iron memory. *Signs:* lacework mail; pitted nails. *Hook:* feed them old keys; they ignore fresh steel.
- **Lichen-Bears** — Moss-matted ursines with rock-teeth. *Signs:* clawed bark with green scabs. *Hook:* smoke of juniper calms; salt enrages.
- **Wind Drakes** — Rib-thin sky-serpents that ride fronts. *Signs:* shed vanes; feathers like glass. *Hook:* whistle back the storm to ground them.
- **Ooze-Remnants** — Alchemical slough from an old field lab. *Signs:* boot-holes rounded smooth. *Hook:* wood ash firms them; vinegar makes them sprint.
- **Fell Harts** — Antlered shades that herd the living toward cliffs. *Signs:* hoofprints that don't compress soil. *Hook:* speak a hunter's apology while walking backward.
- **Cairn-Wights** — Stone-stack custodians; patient as frost. *Signs:* pebbles rearranged around your fire. *Hook:* rebuild the stack correctly; they serve until dawn.
- **Thundertusks** — Boars that store lightning in tusk-veins. *Signs:* fused sand beads; singed roots. *Hook:* ground your spear; throw shadow to draw the strike.
- **Lantern-Eyes** — Floating orbs of watchlight rumor; jealous of secrets. *Signs:* daylight in ravines at midnight. *Hook:* offer a whispered truth; they part like reeds.
- **Grave-Eels** — Burrow through barrow loam; taste names. *Signs:* sinking turf over old wars. *Hook:* sing lineage or throw false names to mislead.
- **Bramble Knights** — Empty helms grown through with thorn; patrol old borders. *Signs:* briar in boot-grease. *Hook:* present a hedge-blessing; they escort instead of impale.

Strange Finds (d10)

When you discover a hidden cache or an ancient hoard, roll or pick:

1. **Route-stones** that warm near true north.
2. **Weather-bell clapper** that tolls only for lightning.
3. **Trail-right knot** dyed in berry law; locals honour it once.
4. **Salt-vein pick** that cuts oozes like cloth.
5. **Glass feather**; break to call a wind drake for one pass.
6. **Ledger leaf** waterproofed with eel-fat; ink never runs, words drift.
7. **Thorn sigil** that bramble knights read as parley.
8. **Coin-fly cocoon**; hatch it for one honest guide to the nearest water.
9. **Bone flute** that calls earth-sharks to circle elsewhere.
10. **Lantern-eye husk**; squeeze for daylight the length of a camp prayer.

Omens & Signs

The land speaks. Use these when the party pauses or when the GM needs a portent.

Sky Signs (d8)

1. sun-dog
2. mare's tails
3. anvil cloud faces the wrong way
4. silent birds
5. far thunder without storm
6. moon with halo
7. ash scent on clear air
8. stars "shiver"

Ground Signs (d8)

1. cairn with new pebble
2. boot prints that end at rock
3. butchered game left neat
4. snapped twig at head height
5. ash under wet moss
6. ward-knot cut
7. trail beads on shrub
8. a single coin on a stone

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **wardens or local hunters**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **prowlers or caravan guards**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or claimants**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable weather**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Guide or warden patrol** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **weather shift or route blockage**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **war-band or territorial beast** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **wardens, war-bands, or prowlers** arrive.

- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **weather turns/catastrophe strikes/quarantine declared**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Claimant chief, quartermaster, or The Stranger** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **weather shifts/blockage clears/catastrophe hits**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Wilds (Weather):** Conditions shift without warning, storms arrive early, calm turns to chaos.
- **Wilds (Navigation):** Trails reroute mid-journey, landmarks disappear, guides demand additional payment.
- **Wilds (Local Customs):** Spirits demand tribute, territorial beasts become aggressive, local laws change with the terrain.

Fast reskin palette

Forest

swap dunes→deadfall, spindrift→canopy flare, prowlers→boar/wolves; water = spring/stream.

Desert

swap bog→salt pan, fog→dust, shelter = overhang/wadi; water = seep/fog net.

Tundra/Ice

swap dune shift→ice heave, fire→spindrift, boats→sleds; prowlers = bears/wolves.

Coast/Isles

crossings = reef shelves, prowlers = seals/raiders, alarms = harbor booms; fuel = driftwood.

Swamp/Fen

crossings = corduroy/log causeways, bad ground = peat crust, prowlers = gators/leeches.

Highlands

crossings = cols and scree traverses, alarms = beacon chains, prowlers = cats/eagles.

Chapter 24

Dungeons

Living Infrastructure. Beneath the surface, ancient places breathe with mechanical lungs and dream electric dreams. Dungeons are not merely ruins but living systems—vascular networks of stone and shadow where every corridor hums with purpose. The walls remember every footfall, the air carries whispers of forgotten conversations, and the very architecture shifts like a sleeper turning in bed.

24.1 Dungeon — “Living Infrastructure”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The walls remember. The echoes answer. The architecture chooses.*

Dungeon’s Creator (Elite): “I built more than walls and corridors – I crafted a living symphony of stone and shadow, where every passage breathes and every chamber remembers. The structure itself is the true inhabitant.”

Scholar-Prisoner (Commoner): “The walls here got a memory like old parchment – they remember every scream, every spell, every drop of blood spilled on the stones. And sometimes, when the air’s just right, they whisper it back to you. The dungeon listens. The question is whether it learns.”

Genre / Mood: Living architecture, ecological horror, sentient dungeon, community of exiles.

Starting Location: A spiral stairwell deep beneath a forgotten citadel, pulsing with a heartbeat not entirely mechanical. The steps hum underfoot. A Forgotten Custodian keys a door that wasn’t there yesterday. “The Heart Chamber hungers. Will you feed it – or be fed?”

Theme & Atmosphere

Beneath the surface, ancient places breathe with mechanical lungs and dream electric dreams. Dungeons are not merely ruins but living systems – vascular networks of stone and shadow where every corridor hums with purpose and every chamber holds its own hungry logic. The walls remember every footfall, the air carries whispers of forgotten conversations, and the very architecture shifts like a sleeper turning in bed. Here, the boundary between structure and organism blurs, and those who would plunder its secrets must first learn to speak its language of echoes, scents, and subtle pressures.

What you notice first: The wet stone smell of a place that sweats. The distant grinding of gears that should have seized centuries ago. The way your footsteps echo back with an extra beat – like someone is following, or catching up.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never ignore a door that opens when you're not looking. The dungeon is offering you a choice. Refuse, and the next door may not open at all.

The Living Hierarchy: Factions of the Deep

Dungeons are not empty. They host a fragile ecology of factions, each with its own relationship to the site's "consciousness." A site's dominant faction determines its mood; a dungeon ruled by *Custodians* may be melancholic and negotiable, while one overrun by *Awakened Organs* is actively predatory.

- **Custodians (Forgotten Caretakers)** – The original stewards, now half-mad or ghostly. They maintain the dungeon's rhythms (polishing thresholds, oiling traps) and may trade safe passage for a **memory** or a **promise**. *Clocks: CUSTODIAN PATIENCE [4], MAINTENANCE ROUNDS [6].*
- **Invaders (Plunderers & Refugees)** – Living interlopers: mercenary remnants, cult initiates, refugee families. They exploit the dungeon's resources while trying to avoid its attention. Their presence raises *Dungeon Awareness (Heat)*. *Clocks: INVADER DESPERATION [4], RIVAL CLAIM [6].*
- **Awakened Organs (The Dungeon's Will)** – Manifestations of the site's internal systems: the *Heart Chamber*, the *Digestive Array*, the *Ledger Lich*. They act as immune responses or as twisted echoes of the original purpose. *Clocks: ORGAN HUNGER [4], SYSTEM REBOOT [6].*
- **Wild Symbiotes (Echoes & Aberrations)** – Creatures that evolved within the living infrastructure: stone-wights, memory eels, gravity ticks. They are neither friendly nor hostile – they simply follow the dungeon's new rules. *Clocks: SWARM TIDE [4], SYMBIOTIC ACCORD [6].*

Most expeditions will feature two or three of these factions in uneasy balance. A dungeon with predatory *Awakened Organs* and desperate *Invaders* is a very different crawl than one haunted by melancholic *Custodians* and curious *Wild Symbiotes*.

Spades — Places

2. **Cracked Gallery** — Hairline faults veined with damp; grit ticks from the ceiling like a slow clock. '[OMEN]' *The ticking is a language. It is counting the number of intruders.*
3. **Sunken Vestibule** — Waist-deep water glazed with oil rainbows; cold leeches the knees, something brushes past. '[HAZARD]' *The water has a pulse. It is not yours.*
4. **Vaulted Refectory** — Tables laid for a meal gone to dust; goblets taste faintly of iron when breathed upon. '[MEMORY]' *The iron is blood – old, dried, and patient.*

5. **Spiral Stairwell** — Steps cupped by centuries; one cough ricochets down into a throat not your own. ‘[THRESHOLD]’ *The throat is the dungeon’s. The cough is an answer.*
6. **Collapsed Observatory** — Stars stare through ribs of broken dome; wind brings ash that smears like soot. ‘[MYSTERY]’ *The stars are not real. The dungeon remembers the sky and shows it wrong.*
7. **Armory Alcove** — Weapon shadows longer than the racks; a glass-front case fogs from the inside. ‘[OMEN]’ *The fog has a shape. The shape is a hand.*
8. **Chained Sanctuary** — Prayer-niches and iron hooks; stone bruised where something strained to leave. ‘[DEATH]’ *The chains are warm. Something wore them recently.*
9. **Mirror Hall** — Reflections lag by a heartbeat; one pane shows you older, another shows you missing. ‘[TRUTH]’ *The missing reflection is ahead of you. It will wait.*
10. **Garden of Stone** — Statues mid-breath; a chisel-mark still weeps dust as if freshly struck. ‘[TRAP]’ *The dust is from the statues. They are not statues. They are frozen.*
- J **Throne of Echoes** — A single block worn satin-smooth; sit and your name returns in a stranger’s verdict. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The verdict is from a trial you never attended. The jury is the dungeon.*
- Q **Vault of Whispers** — Books exhale when opened; vowels crawl up the spine and into the ear. ‘[MEMORY]’ *The books are not books. They are memory. They eat yours to grow.*
- K **Chamber of Seasons** — Air flips from pollen-sweet to knife-cold; breath ghosts, sweat beads, leaves skitter. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The seasons are the dungeon’s moods. Today it is spring. Tomorrow, winter without end.*
- A **The Heart Chamber** — Mortar smells like blood, light like fever; floor hums to your pulse then sets its own. ‘[BOSS]’ *The pulse is not your own after the third beat.*

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Forgotten Custodian** — Keys like teeth on a ring; polishes thresholds no one crosses. ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *He has forgotten why he polishes. The threshold remembers.*
3. **Scholar-Prisoner** — Ink-stained nails, hollow cheeks; knows which lies the walls prefer. ‘[KNOWLEDGE]’ *The walls prefer lies that are almost true. She tells them often.*
4. **Symbiotic Colony** — Many mouths, one hunger; bargains in warmth, hoards salt. ‘[CURIOSITY]’ *The mouths whisper in chorus. Their voices are the dungeon’s breath.*
5. **Cursed Noble** — Velvet rotted to lace; voice drags like chain, eyes beg for ending. ‘[TRAGEDY]’ *The curse is the dungeon’s favor. He has worn it too long.*
6. **Mercenary Remnant** — Dried mud, wet fear; map carved into forearm with a dinner knife. ‘[SURVIVAL]’ *The map is accurate – for now. The dungeon moves while he sleeps.*
7. **Bound Guardian** — Filigree of wards across stone skin; obeys the letter, hears the spirit. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The spirit is the dungeon’s. The letter is a suggestion.*
8. **Cult Initiate** — Pupil-widened zeal; speaks passwords like prayers, prayers like debts. ‘[MYSTERY]’ *The debt is to a god that does not answer. The dungeon answers instead.*
9. **Refugee Family** — Boot-scrapes under cots; clutch charms that grow warm when danger nears. ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *The charms are stones from the garden. The statues are their ancestors.*
10. **Merchant of Curiosities** — Breath like cloves and rust; sells certainty bottled and slightly

- used. ‘[TRADE]’ *The certainty is a lie. The bottle is genuine.*
- J **Ascended Vermin** — Crown of wire, court of nests; taxes crumbs, enforces with a thousand eyes. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The eyes are not all vermin. Some are the dungeon’s.*
- Q **Fallen Hero’s Shade** — Armor of frost, sword of grievance; wants one last right choice. ‘[TRAGEDY]’ *The right choice is the one that frees her. The dungeon disagrees.*
- K **Dungeon’s Creator** — Architect’s hands cracked with mortar; still moving rooms the way others move chess. ‘[LEGEND]’ *He does not remember the Heart Chamber. The Heart Chamber remembers him.*
- A **The Collective Consciousness** — Voices braided into one intention; your thoughts return carrying fingerprints. ‘[BOSS]’ *The fingerprints are yours. The thoughts are the dungeon’s.*

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Shifting Walls** — Mortar pops like knuckles; corridors narrow behind you with polite insistence. ‘[TRAP]’ *The insistence is the dungeon’s. It wants you to stay.*
 3. **Hungering Dark** — Wicks gutter blue; shadows lip the flame and swallow the heat first. ‘[FEAR]’ *The dark has weight. It leans.*
 4. **Memory Fog** — Cool on the gums, sweet on the tongue; you “recall” a door that never was. ‘[MEMORY]’ *The door is real. The memory is the dungeon’s.*
 5. **Gravity Wells** — Knees turn to iron; dropped coins smack floor like thrown knives. ‘[HAZARD]’ *The coins are the dungeon’s now. It will spend them later.*
 6. **Temporal Echoes** — Footfalls not yours keep pace; a conversation repeats with one word wrong. ‘[OMEN]’ *The wrong word is a clue. The clue is a trap.*
 7. **Corrosive Atmosphere** — Leather slimes, metal freckles; breathe shallow or taste copper. ‘[HAZARD]’ *The copper is blood. The blood is the dungeon’s offering.*
 8. **Phantom Locks** — Doors exist when watched sidelong; they prefer particular hands and hours. ‘[TRAP]’ *The hands are yours. The hours are the dungeon’s.*
 9. **Borrowed Time** — Hair whitens at the tips; hunger leaps ahead of the clock. ‘[PRESSURE]’ *The time will be returned. The interest is your memory.*
 10. **Infectious Transformation** — Fingertips grain to stone, pupils catch light like a cat’s; urges shift. ‘[TRANSFORMATION]’ *The urge is to stay. The garden needs new statues.*
- J **Reality Anchor Points** — Candles burn sideways, water beads uphill; spells itch in the teeth. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The itch is the dungeon laughing.*
- Q **The Dungeon’s Will** — Maps argue with themselves; paths rephrase your intentions. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The path is the dungeon’s intention. Your intention is a suggestion.*
- K **Cascading Failure** — A cracked lintel sighs and the far cistern answers; systems talk in groans. ‘[DISASTER]’ *The groans are a warning. The warning is too late.*
- A **The Price of Passage** — Each shortcut salts your tongue with loss; the house keeps its ledger. ‘[PRICE]’ *The ledger is the dungeon’s. The loss is yours.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Wayfinder Compass** — Needle twitches toward safety like a frightened animal; steadies if you hum. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The humming must be in tune with the dungeon’s breath. The breath*

changes.

3. **Key of Echoes** — Warms in the palm when a door remembers being opened. ‘[ACCESS]’
The door’s memory is not yours. It remembers a different key.
4. **Lantern of Clarity** — Light outlines hollows in the world; truths show up as clean edges.
‘[TRUTH]’ *The truths are sharp. They cut if you look too long.*
5. **Cloak of Passage** — Hem sips through stone or mist; leaves damp prints on the far side.
‘[STEALTH]’ *The prints are the dungeon’s. It will follow.*
6. **Tome of Convenient Knowledge** — Pages grow new margins; ink creeps to answer the question you’re afraid to ask. ‘[KNOWLEDGE]’ *The answer is a lie. The lie is useful.*
7. **Ration of Sustenance** — Bread that tastes like last winter; settles the stomach, quiets the shakes. ‘[SURVIVAL]’ *Last winter was in the dungeon. The bread was grown in the garden.*
8. **Focus Crystal** — Thrum matches your breath; thoughts align the way teeth fit. ‘[MAGIC]’
The breath is the dungeon’s after the third inhale.
9. **Token of Safe Return** — Thread around a wrist; tugs once when it’s time to flee. ‘[PROTECTION]’
The tug is the dungeon’s mercy. It does not offer twice.
10. **Map that Grows** — Charcoal blooms corridors as you walk; tiny figures drift where things currently are. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The figures are the dungeon’s. They are not always accurate.*
- J **Shield of Temporary Immunity** — Hazards strike sparks and spend themselves like rain on slate. ‘[PROTECTION]’ *The immunity is borrowed. The dungeon will ask for it back.*
- Q **Crown of Momentary Authority** — Creatures blink, recognize a crest they cannot name, and obey. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The crest is the dungeon’s. The obedience is a misunderstanding.*
- K **Forge of Quick Repair** — Heat like a heartbeat; fractured gear exhales and remembers its shape. ‘[CRAFT]’ *The memory is the dungeon’s. The gear will remember you, too.*
- A **The Dungeon’s Blessing** — A knack that lingers in the bones; doors like you now, as do certain hungers. ‘[BOON]’ *The hungers are the dungeon’s appetites. They like you very much.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (safeties/knowledge/immunities) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **living infrastructure** – walls shift, voices repeat your plans, light returns redder.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Living Infrastructure:** Fluids, heat, dust, and sound move like blood – follow the drafts, the drips, the echoes to find *organs*: cisterns, chimneys, nerve-halls.
- **Scent Ledger:** Track smells (ozone, wet lime, tallow, old wine); they foretell hazards and factions before you see them. A successful Wits + Survival (DV 3) reveals one hidden feature of the next chamber.
- **Echo Etiquette:** Some rooms reward whispers and punish shouts; others demand a spoken price to cross. Listen first. A character who spends a full exchange listening may ask one

yes/no question about the room’s “mood” (GM answers truthfully).

- **Community of Exiles:** The dungeon’s refugee factions (Invaders, Custodians) can be bartered with using **memories** or **secrets** instead of coin. A memory of warmth buys a night’s shelter; a secret about the surface buys a guide through a dangerous junction.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Foundation Stone** – The Sealed Gate. *The keystone that remembers every weight placed upon it.*
 - **The Echo-Singer** – The Witness. *The voice that repeats every promise whispered in the dark.*
 - **The Pressure Below** – Khemesh. *The slow hunger of stone, the patience of the deep.*
 - **The Circuit** – Clockwork Monad. *The dungeon’s dreaming nervous system, always optimizing, always watching.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord sometimes serve as custodians, using the dungeon’s memory to collect debts from the living. A renegade Sister hides in the Sunken Vestibule, trying to cut her cord from a bound guardian’s oath.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends appears in the Vault of Whispers. Take it, and the books will answer any question – but the coin will reappear in your pocket each dawn, heavier.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Dungeon psions are called “Echo-Readers.” They hear the whispers of past explorers and can reroute a corridor once per expedition by humming the right frequency.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Throne of Echoes is a Class III Anchor – the ghost of a judge who died mid-trial. Saikou Ira would leave a coin on the seat and ask for a verdict. The verdict is always a riddle.
- **The Ninth:** In any dungeon scene, the ninth door you open in a row will lead to a place that was not on your map. The wise open eight, then retrace their steps. Those who open the ninth find a shortcut – and a debt.

Dungeon Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Threshold:** Crumble a crust at the base of a door. Ignore the first *Shifting Walls* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Echo:** Tie a single knot in a piece of string and hang it from a lintel. Cancel *Temporal Echoes* or take –1 die on your next navigation roll (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Dark:** Whisper a dead explorer’s name into a shadow. Gain +1 Effect when searching for hidden passages this scene, but mark *Attention* from the dungeon. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **dungeon dwellers or factions**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **creatures or echoes**.

- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or spirits**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or resources**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **The dungeon’s will** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **shifting architecture**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **minor entity or faction member** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **dungeon entities or guardians** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes – **trap springs/route blocked/ally turns**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **The Dungeon’s Creator or Collective Consciousness** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically – **walls shift/floor collapses/air thickens**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice – **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Living Infrastructure (1–2 SB):** Corridors whisper your name, reflections blink slower, scent trails loop back.
- **Echo Etiquette (1–3 SB):** Shouts echo thrice, silence answers back, doors ask riddles.
- **Cascading Failure (1–2 SB):** One crack becomes many, water flows uphill, lights dim in sequence.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Survival):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Dust Cloud*.
- **Cut the Echo (Presence + Lore):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a Wayfinder Compass is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Collapse (Body + Athletics):** On a hit in *Cascading Failure*, you pick who escapes first; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Living Infrastructure)

- **The Miscount-King (Nine Errors)** – *Phases*: Bell-Lines Severed → Orchestrated Miscount → Shrine Coup. *Cracks*: re-tie a bell-line, expose a false count, survive a night at the forgotten bell.
- **The Drowned Counter (Spirit of the Ninth Tide)** – *Phases*: Waves Miscounted → Procession of Empty Shrines → Bell-Baptism of a Warden. *Cracks*: relic tide-bead, survivor testimony, the ninth bell refusing to ring.

Plug-in Expedition Layer

- **Universal Clocks (drop into any site):**
 - *Dungeon Awareness (Heat)* [10]: rises on loud actions, light spillage, blood, or haste. At 4/7/10, the Keeper may promote Clubs results one step.
 - *Structure Stress* [6/8]: ticks on blasts, overloading mechanisms, or ignored warnings; when full, trigger *Cascading Failure*.
 - *Expedition Supply*: three pooled tracks – *Light* [4], *Air* [4] (if sealed), *Load* [4] (fatigue/overburden). Each empty track worsens Position for relevant actions until refreshed.
- **Safe Route Tokens**: On a strong success mapping/scouting, issue a *Safe Route* token. Spend to bypass one known hazard in that segment or to negate a single “Position Lost” SB.
- **Retreat & Seal**: When withdrawing, a PC may *seal the way* (chalk, wedges, wards). Clear 1 Heat, but tick *Structure Stress* or spawn a *Phantom Lock* in that lane.

Interfaces & Entanglements (use what fits your campaign)

- **Surface Stakeholders**: *Scavenger Union*, *Shrinekeepers*, *Civic Factors*. Register finds to bank a *Finder’s Favor* – spend to reduce one sell-off DV; skipping registration adds a “Disputed Claim” tag to the haul.
- **Internal Politics**: *Custodians*, *Bound Guardians*, *Refugee Enclaves*. Parley with proper tokens (salt, names, warmth) to downgrade the next Clubs result in their turf.
- **Patron Hooks (optional):**
 - **The Sealed Gate**: Chalk lines cancel one intrusion for a scene; breaking them adds 1 Heat.
 - **Lunara**: Moon-silver reveals one hidden organ (cistern, nerve-hall); mark Exposure +1.
 - **The Traveler**: Waymarks let you finish one travel tick after a room clear.
 - **Varnek Karn**: Naming the dead here clears 1 *Awareness* but starts a *Ledger Attention* [4].
 - **Maelstraeus**: Trade salvage tags at “fair rate” once/expedition; skewed trades create a *Karmic Debt* [6].

Keys, Locks, & Doors (drop-in schema)

- **Door Attitudes**: *Literal* (wants the right key), *Courteous* (opens to the right words), *Hungry* (takes a toll), *Shy* (hates crowds), *Proud* (demands ceremony).
- **Key Types**: *Mechanical* (wards/picks), *Mnemonic* (password, name), *Somatic* (gesture, breath), *Affective* (emotion offered), *Sacrificial* (blood, time, memory).

- **Rule of Two:** Each important barrier recognizes two different key types; learning either grants +1 Effect to breach or parley with it.

Salvage, Haul, & Conversion

- **Salvage Tags:** *Stable* (safe to carry), *Volatile* (ticks Stress on jostle), *Bound* (linked to site), *Loud* (adds Heat when moved), *Forbidden* (attracts factions).
- **Convert on Exit (choose one):** trade haul for a *Map that Grows* upgrade, a *Pass-Key Writ* (one automatic door compliance), or *Market Credit* (reduce next sell-off complication).

Table Prompts (d6 each, fast prep)

Echo Questions

1. What does the room want?
2. Who set this alarm?
3. What was repaired last?
4. Where does the draft go?
5. What memory sticks here?
6. What price opens the way?

Find the Organ

1. Cistern (fluid)
2. Bell-shaft (signal)
3. Heat lung (thermal)
4. Nerve-hall (control)
5. Waste sluice (decay)
6. Relay shrine (intent)

Procedures at the Door (one-minute read-aloud checklist)

1. **Sense:** Name two smells; ask which grew stronger.
2. **Listen:** Offer one echo; ask what word returns wrong.
3. **Light:** Describe color/behavior; ask who steadies it (hum, prayer, silence).
4. **Count:** Beats, drips, or breaths – players may claim *Counting Etiquette* to shift Position safer once.
5. **Declare Price or Key:** Players state attitude + key type; on a hit, grant +1 Effect or a *Safe Route* token.

Plug-in SB Conversions (use with any dungeon)

- First 1 SB in a scene may become *Heat +1* instead of a narrative wrinkle (signal without immediate harm).
- Any 2 SB can instead tick *Structure Stress* and foreshadow *Cascading Failure* rather than spawn foes.
- On 3+ SB, offer a bargain: pay with *memory/gear/time* to halve the consequence and add *Price of Passage* [3].

Bosses & Lairs (Classic Crawl Feel, Fate’s Edge Framework)

Using Bosses Each boss runs on a **Phase Clock** and 2–3 **Lair Actions**. Tie them to the site’s *Dungeon Awareness (Heat)* and *Structure Stress*; as either rises, promote boss position/effect. Boss defeats should yield a Diamond-tier boon keyed to the lair.

Oculus Warden (many-eyed sentry)

A floating nerve-knot studded with glass eyes; lenses irise like gills.

- **Phase Clock:** [8] *Calibration* → *Overwatch* → *Lethal Focus* → *Blind Panic*
- **Moves:** *Disintegrate Signage* (erase waymarks), *Anti-magic Glare* (downgrade 1 magical effect this exchange), *Scry Ping* (advance Awareness +1).
- **Lair Actions (Mirror Hall / Vault of Whispers):**
 1. *Prismatic Sweep:* Split the party's positions (each PC steps one tier toward Controlled).
 2. *Echo False Order:* One PC hears an ally's command that was never given; test or waste an action.
 3. *Lens Flare:* Next ranged attack against the Warden loses 1 Effect unless the light source is doused.
- **Counters:** Smoke, darkness, reflective shields, calling shots on specific lenses (name a lens: cancel one Move this round).
- **Drop (Diamond):** *Crown of Momentary Authority* or *Lantern of Clarity*.

Digestive Array (cube-that-crawls)

A transparent, room-sized solvent held in grid tension; carries tools it cannot digest.

- **Phase Clock:** [6] *Probe* → *Enmesh* → *Dissolve*
- **Moves:** *Corrode* (apply COMPROMISED to metal/wood), *Engulf* (split group; trapped PC marks Fatigue or gear loss), *Clean Bones* (remove tags from fallen).
- **Lair Actions (Sunken Vestibule / Chained Sanctuary):**
 1. *Flood Gate Twitch:* Water level rises a step; footing worsens.
 2. *Sluice Pulse:* Pushes all creatures one range band.
 3. *Reagent Bloom:* Vapors add −1 die to breathy actions this round.
- **Counters:** Grates, cold cinders, base powders; lures with iron filings or salted meat (draw off for a scene).
- **Drop (Diamond):** *Forge of Quick Repair* salvage or *Ration of Sustenance* (3).

Ledger Lich (archivist revenant)

A curator bound by indices; hands of ink, breath of dust.

- **Phase Clock:** [8] *Citation* → *Injunction* → *Foreclosure* → *Redaction*
- **Moves:** *Name Forfeiture* (steal a declared tag until bell), *Writ of Seizure* (lock a Diamond or gear under spectral seal), *Errata* (retroactively worsen one PC's prior roll Outcome).
- **Lair Actions (Vault of Whispers / Deep Archive):**
 1. *Quiet Hours:* Casting/rites generate +1 SB or fail softly.
 2. *Reference Only:* Movement through stacks costs an action unless proper tokens are presented.
 3. *Cross-reference Collapse:* Bookshelves reconfigure; split the party.
- **Counters:** True names carved in quartz, burning a citation (sacrifice an *index* – a map, a ledger, a vow) to cancel one Move.
- **Drop (Diamond):** *Key of Echoes*, *Tome of Convenient Knowledge*.

Protocol Titan (stone sentinel)

A walking paragraph of law in granite; joints clock with tiny bells.

- **Phase Clock:** [6] *Challenge* → *Adjudicate* → *Execute*
- **Moves:** *Ward Stomp* (shockwave; prone or position –), *Clause Capture* (binds a PC to a declared rule), *Countermeasure* (reflect mundane force).
- **Lair Actions (Measure Vault / Throne of Echoes):**
 1. *Bell of Standing:* Only those who declare an intent may act this round.
 2. *Weigh Deceit:* The largest lie in the scene takes Harm 1 (Stress).
 3. *Seal Turned:* A door the party used closes and locks under new terms.
- **Counters:** Present certified measures, exploit contradictions, or swear a binding minor oath (shift boss Position –).
- **Drop (Diamond):** *The Under-Seal Clause* (local), *Key-Writ*.

Mimetic Colony (door-that-eats)

An ecosystem of impostor hinges, handles, chests, and carpets.

- **Phase Clock:** [6] *Invitation* → *Adhesion* → *Ingestion*
- **Moves:** *Stickfast* (immobilize limb/gear), *Swallow Noise* (negate assists), *Split & Flank*.
- **Lair Actions (Armory / Garden of Stone):**
 1. *Everything's a Mouth:* First interacted object bites.
 2. *False Safe:* Creates a "short rest" that actually advances Heat +2.
 3. *Chew Through:* Destroys one rung/bridge segment.
- **Counters:** Iron spikes, chalk lines, bait boxes; fire/acid cause the colony to fragment (treat as minions).
- **Drop (Diamond):** *Cloak of Passage*, *Token of Safe Return*.

Sluice Dragon (steam & acid wyrm)

A heat lung grown proud; scales are boiler plates, breath a flash-boil scream.

- **Phase Clock:** [10] *Banked Heat* → *Pressure Rise* → *Vent Fury* → *Rupture*
- **Moves:** *Scalding Cone*, *Vacuum Lurch* (pull PCs), *Steam Blind* (Position –).
- **Lair Actions (Heat Lungs / Cistern):**
 1. *Valve Spin:* Change terrain tags (Dry/Wet/Boiling).
 2. *Gauge Pop:* Structure Stress +1; cracks form.
 3. *Pressure Shadow:* The dragon gains +1 Effect for one exchange.
- **Counters:** Chill the room (dump cistern), bleed valves (two actions), or bait with metal ingots.
- **Drop (Diamond):** *Forge of Quick Repair*, *Shield of Temporary Immunity*.

Crawl Procedures (Quick, Crunchy Options)

- **Short Rest (10 minutes):** Clear Fatigue 1 *or* refresh one spent tool; advance *Dungeon Awareness* +1 and roll once on *Ambient Signs* (below).

- **Secure Camp (1 hour, defensible):** Clear Fatigue 2 and one *Condition* (not Harm); *Structure Stress* +1d2 from barricading/heat, Awareness +2 unless *Sealed*.
- **Search a Room (5 minutes):** On success, gain 1 *Safe Route* token or a *Map that Grows* tick; on miss, trigger a *Door Attitude* complication.
- **Light, Air, Load:** Track three pooled clocks [4] (see Plug-in Expedition Layer). Empty tracks worsen Position until restored.

Wandering Signs & Encounters (d12)

1. Whisper returns one word wrong; nearest door adopts a *Hungry* attitude.
2. Drip changes rhythm; nearby *Gravity Well* awakens.
3. Custodian chalk erased and redrawn *behind* you.
4. A stack exhales: *Memory Fog* for one exchange.
5. Pilfer-vermin court demands toll (crumbs, salt, or gossip).
6. Bound Guardian patrol, willing to debate terms (papers help).
7. Refugee child with a *Key of Echoes* that hates you.
8. Floor warms; *Heat Lung* cycling – steam hazard next room.
9. Echo sermon on "proper doors"; ignoring it adds Heat +1.
10. Sloshing in walls; *Digestive Array* scouts with a filament.
11. A mirror shows your gear two items lighter – choose which or mark Fatigue 1.
12. Stone hymn – sing along to cancel first SB this scene, or suffer *Hungering Dark* pulse.

Classic Traps, Living-Site Style (pick 1–2 tags)

- **Pressure Mosaic** (Artful, Loud): Floor pattern asks for a dance step; wrong beat drops spears from *ceiling*, not floor.
- **Breath Tax** (Subtle, Lingering): Room meters exhalations; excess vents sleeping gas; counting etiquette downgrades risk.
- **Magi-Siphon Grate** (Hungry, Magnetic): Drains charges from tools/wards; feeding it a *Focus Crystal* buys safe passage.
- **Echo Latch** (Riddle, Social): Door opens to a truth spoken softly; lies trigger *Phantom Locks*.

Treasure & Upgrade Hooks (d8 hoard seeds)

1. Cage of *tame echoes* – store a sentence for later; release as perfect mimicry.
2. *Map that Grows* (upgraded): shows *organs* (cistern/nerve-hall) when rubbed with tallow.
3. *Wayfinder Compass* attuned: hum a note to swap "nearest exit" with "nearest objective."
4. *Key-ring of Attitudes*: once each – *Courteous*, *Hungry*, *Proud*.
5. Bottle of *stolen seasons*: pour to set room to *pollen-sweet* or *knife-cold* for one scene.
6. *Token of Safe Return* (party-wide) that tugs twice when the *Heart Pressure* hits threshold.
7. A ledger page signed by the *Dungeon's Creator* – treat one barrier as if you are expected.
8. *Lantern of Clarity* mantle: once/session, reveals the *Price of Passage* without paying it.

Boss Build Template (one-minute prep)

1. **Name & Nature:** What organ of the dungeon is this boss the face of?

2. **Phase Clock:** 6/8/10 with 2–4 titled phases.
3. **Three Moves:** One space-control, one resource-tax, one identity/knowledge twist.
4. **Two Lair Actions:** Environmental toggles keyed to this lair.
5. **Counters:** A courtesy, a tool, a sacrifice. (Players should be able to *learn* these.)
6. **Drop:** A Diamond (from §24.1) or bespoke boon tied to the organ.

Dungeon Boss: The Heart Itself (set-piece)

A chamber of ribs and lintels; mortar smells like blood, light like fever.

- **Phase Clock:** [10] *Palpate* → *Synchronize* → *Pacemaker* → *Arrest*
- **Moves:** *Syncopate* (force actions to resolve off-beat; assist dice misfire), *Tachycardia* (Heat +2, Structure Stress +1), *Backflow* (reverse one clock tick on *Floorplan Loops*, but split the party).
- **Lair Actions:**
 1. *Valve Close:* Seal exits; require a "Somatic" or "Affective" key to reopen.
 2. *Adrenal Surge:* The Heart acts twice next round unless fed a secret *all PCs share*.
- **Counters:** Speak the dungeon’s *true purpose* (as inferred via organs), vent a heat lung, or sacrifice mapped ground (tear up a *Safe Route*).
- **Victory States:** *Stabilize* (site becomes safer; Awareness clears to 0), *Pacify* (gain *Dungeon’s Blessing*), or *Slay* (collapse risk; Structure Stress +2 across the level).

Patronage & Power

The true dungeon is not a place but a process – a slow alchemy that transforms intruders into something the structure can understand or consume. Every chamber is a test, every corridor a negotiation, and every inhabitant a symptom of the site’s deeper hungers. The wise explorer learns to read the dungeon’s moods in the way light falls, the way echoes return, and the way the very air seems to lean toward certain passages. Here, knowledge is not power but currency, and the smart adventurer knows when to pay with memory, when to pay with blood, and when to simply walk away.

For the GM: Dungeon authority is not hierarchical – it is ecological. The Custodians maintain, the Invaders exploit, the Organs react, and the Symbiotes adapt. Players gain leverage by understanding these relationships and offering what each faction lacks: memories for Custodians, safe passage for Invaders, sacrifice for Organs, curiosity for Symbiotes. Emphasise that the dungeon learns. Repeated tactics become less effective; kindness to one faction may anger another. The dungeon is not a monster – it is a neighbourhood.

World Travel Gateway and Routes

How to use this table:

When the party arrives at a gateway, ask: *Do you have the required leverage?* If yes, they may pass with Improved Position or reduced DV.

If not, they must negotiate (social roll), bribe (pay Measures), or find a smuggler’s alternative (additional clock).

Table 24.1: Gateways and Routes of the Known World

Gateway	Location (Region)	Controls Route
Kassamira Port	Kahfagia (Titan’s Throat)	Entry to Amaranthine from southern seas
Titan’s Throat (strait)	Between Kahfagia and Akilan	The only deep-water passage from the sea
Ecktoria Capital Port	Ecktoria (northern Amaranthine)	Grain and imperial trade routes
Silkstrand (river port)	Acasia (Silkstrand)	Acasian rivers, overland to Valewood and beyond
Marcott (Belworth estuary)	Vhasia (border with Viterra)	Cross-river trade and ferries
Fairport (Dolmis coast)	Viterra	Dolmis shipping and grain exports
Tarlington Falls	Viterra (Belworth River)	Portage and bridge crossing between V
Thepyrgos (harbour boom)	Thepyrgos (southern peninsula)	Gateway to the Astroegro Straits and I
High-Mist Pass	Aelerian Mountains (north)	Passage between Acasia/Vhasia and the
Payden’s Port	Mistlands (western levee)	Entry to the Mistlands from the Aeler j
Thin Shore (shadow corridor)	Valewood (east coast)	North–south coastal route skirting the
Green Gate	Aelinnel (Aevrossa coast)	Sea-arch to the fey courts and phasing
Ubral Passes (e.g., Vurim Pass)	Ubral (highlands)	Routes between Viterra, Vhasia, and th
Thing-holm	Linn (island in the Yloka delta)	Moot and harbour for Linn raiders and
Foedus Stone	Vilikari-Ykrul frontier (steppe edge)	Renewal of treaties and safe passage be

Table 24.2: Major Sea Lanes (Abstract Clocks)

Sea Lane	Route	Typical Clock Size	Primary Hazards
Amaranthine Coastway	Kahfagia → Ecktoria → Acasia → Vhasia → Viterra	6 segments	Gale, cold tine, h booms
Astroegro Straits	Thepyrgos Dolmis Amaranthine	8 segments	Strong rents, w synod tions
Dolmis Circuits	Fairport Theona Ubral Aelinnel Zakov	8 segments	Reefs, j tide-spin
Aberderrin Sea	Linnstad Mistlands Valewood coast	10 segments	Ice, squalls,
Monsoon Coast	Taharka Dhahara (Port Shed) Ayokha Sihai	6–8 segments	Monsoon shifts, vateers, mazes

Many Diamonds listed above can be earned as quest rewards, bought with Strings, or discovered as treasure in dungeons (e.g., a *lantern writ* in a Mistland barrow).

“The road is a ledger. Every gate is a clause. Pay the toll, or pay the interest.” — The Grey Wanderer

Part VI

Appendices

Chapter 25

Quick Reference Cards

To be printed and kept at the table.

Core Travel Procedure (1 card)

Draw ♠+♥+♣+♦ from destination/authority decks. Highest rank sets clock (2–5=4, 6–10=6, J/Q/K=8, A=10). On success advance, on failure mark delay/debt/diversion.

Story Beat Menus

See the full tables in the Travel & Navigation chapter. The GM may choose complications by region or use the universal menu.

Gateways & Control Points

Refer to the table in *Travel & Navigation*. Each gate requires a specific ♦ for lawful priority.

Weather Engine (Wilds)

Roll d12: 1 Glass-Clear, 2 Haze, 3 Trickle Rain, 4 Downpour, 5 Thunderhead, 6 Cold Snap, 7 Heat Snap, 8 Ground Fog, 9 Spindrift/Dust, 10 Shifting Wind, 11 Front Line, 12 Catspaw Omen.